

the catalan



EVERYMAN CHESS Alex Raetsky & Maxim Chetverik

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by Alex Raetsky &
Maxim Chetverik

EVERYMAN CHESS

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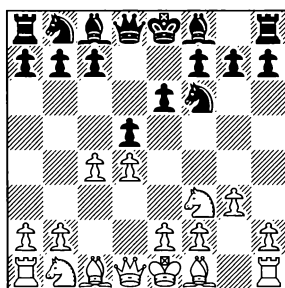
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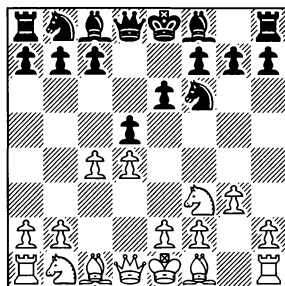
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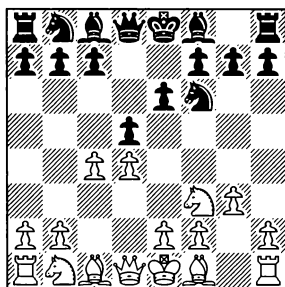
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This book is dedicated to the Catalan bishop. Thank you for everything!

INTRODUCTION



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♙f6 4 g3

Between the authors there exists almost a lifetime of dedication to the Catalan Opening. This positionally oriented opening fits our classical style perfectly and has brought us much pleasure in our chess careers. Therefore it is quite natural for us to write a book about this opening, and we have already done so in German. We should point out here that, rather than a translation, this is aimed at being a complementary work, with slightly different points of gravity. In some positions, where style is the main factor, we have chosen slightly different recommendations compared to the earlier book. Additionally, this edition is more up-to-date.

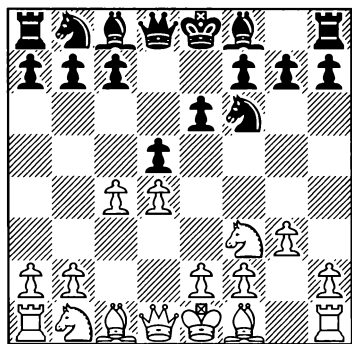
We have decided to use the move order 1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♙f6 4 g3 as a Catalan standard in these pages because in our experience this is more likely to be seen in practice than 1 d4 ♙f6 2 c4 e6 3 g3 d5 4 ♘f3, both leading to the same position:

(see following diagram)

This is the starting position of the Catalan. White could have played 4 ♙g2 instead of 4 ♘f3, but this will make a difference only in very few lines, mainly in Chapter 3 with 5 ♖a4+ after 4...dxc4.

The lines with 1 d4 ♙f6 2 c4 e6 3 g3 c5 and 1 d4 ♙f6 2 c4 e6 3 g3 ♙b4+ will not be

found in this book. After 3...c5 White has a choice between 4 ♘f3, going into the English Opening, or 4 d5, transposing to the Modern Benoni. After 3...♙b4+ the game will almost always transpose to the BogIndian Defence, where White would have played 3 ♘f3 instead of 3 g3.



The layout of the chapters in this book has been set out mainly according to importance, in a descending order. But we have also taken into consideration the natural branches of the move order. Therefore we have included slightly obscure lines with 4...c6 and 5...♙d6 in the Closed Catalan and 4...dxc4 5 ♖a4+ as Chapters 2 and 3 respectively.

You will find that some of the games in this book are those of the authors. Obviously

we are proud of our nicest wins but the main reason for their inclusion is that we feel we understand these games quite well. Not surprisingly, our losses also feature.

One of Alexander's most brilliant victories, against a strong Hungarian Grandmaster, did not find its way into the first draft of the book, but our friend Jacob Aagaard insisted that we include it, so here it is. It should serve as a warning of the power of the Catalan...

Raetsky-Varga

Zürich 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 dxc4 3 ♖f3 c6 4 g3 b5 5 ♙g2 ♙b7 6 0-0 e6 7 a4 a6 8 b3 cxb3 9 ♙xb3 ♖f6 10 ♙d1 ♖bd7 11 ♙e5 ♙b6 12 ♖c3 ♖xe5 13 dxe5 ♖d5

13...♖g4!? is also possible. White has compensation but it is not clear how much. The following lengthy – and by no means forced – fantasy line illustrates relevant themes: 14 ♖e4 ♖xe5 15 ♙f4 ♖c4 16 ♙ac1 ♖a5 17 ♙c3 ♙d8 18 ♙e3 ♙xd1+ 19 ♙xd1 c5! 20 ♙xc5 ♙c7 21 axb5 ♙xe4 22 ♙xe4 ♙xc5 23 ♙c1 ♙e7 24 ♙xc5+ ♙xc5 25 ♙xc5 axb5 26 ♙xb5 ♖c4 and Black maintains the balance.

14 ♙xd5!?

White parts with his good bishop to further the collective cause – namely the exploitation of Black's tardy kingside development.

14...exd5

14...cxd5 does not work because after 15 ♙e3 ♙c7 16 axb5 ♙e7 17 bxa6 ♙xa6 18 ♙a4+ ♙d7 19 ♙xd7+ ♙xd7 20 ♖a4 White wins the exchange.

15 axb5 axb5 16 ♙e3 ♙d8?

After this Black is, surprisingly, completely outplayed. The problem is the advance e2-e4. After the accurate 16...♙c5 17 ♙xc5 ♙xc5 18 ♙xa8+ ♙xa8 19 e4 d4! 20 ♖e2 d3! 21 ♙xd3 0-0 22 ♙d6 ♙c2 Black is doing fine.

17 ♙a7! ♙c7 18 e4! b4

Black cannot avoid the deadly opening of

the centre. After 18...dxe4 19 ♖xe4 ♙xe5 20 ♙d3 ♙d5 21 ♙e3 ♙e6 22 ♙b6! the end is fast approaching.

19 exd5! bxc3 20 d6 ♙d7 21 ♙c5! ♙xa1

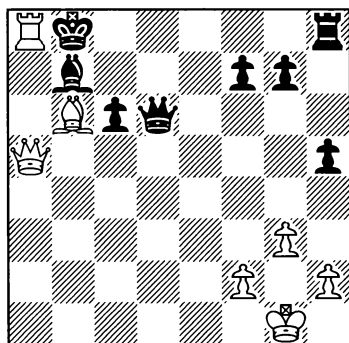
21...♙b8 22 ♙db1 g6 23 ♙a7 ♙g7 24 ♙xb7 ♙xb7 25 ♙xb7 ♙xb7 26 ♙xb7 0-0 27 f4 c2 28 ♙e3 ♙d8 29 ♙b2 and Black has a hopeless task – 29...f6 30 e6! ♙xd6 31 ♙b8+ and White wins.

22 ♙xa1 ♖d8 23 ♙xc3!?

Simple and safe, but 23 ♙b6+ ♖c8 24 ♙c7! is another way to end the game.

23...h5 24 ♙a7 ♖c8 25 ♙a5 ♖b8 26 ♙b6!?

This does win, but a more direct route is 26 ♙xb7+! ♙xb7 (26...♖xb7 27 ♙a7+ ♖c8 28 ♙a8 mate) 27 ♙d8+ ♙c8 28 ♙a7+ ♖b7 29 ♙b6+ ♖a8 30 d7! etc.
26...♙xd6 27 exd6 ♙xd6 28 ♙a8+!



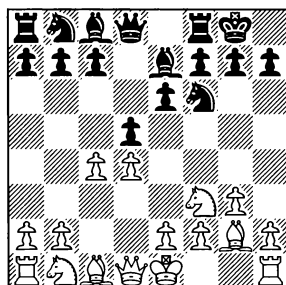
Winning a piece.

28...♙xa8 29 ♙a7+ ♖c8 30 ♙xa8+ ♖d7 31 ♙xh8 c5 32 ♙d8+ ♖c6 33 ♙xd6+ ♖xd6 34 ♖f1 ♖d5 35 ♖e2 g5 36 h3 g4 37 h4 1-0

The Catalan is a dangerous weapon for the positional player, and often we find ourselves enjoying a lasting advantage in the middlegame and endgame due to the strength of the Catalan bishop, or the weakness of c6 or c5 and so on. We hope you will enjoy many such advantages, and that you find this book useful.

CHAPTER ONE

Closed Catalan: 4...♙e7 5 ♙g2 0-0



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 ♙e7 5 ♙g2 0-0

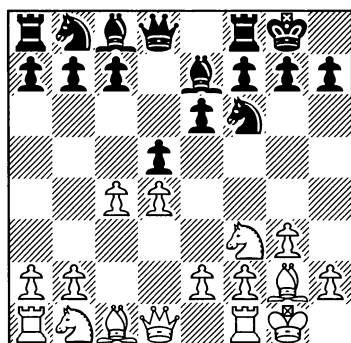
Black decides to address development (first the kingside, then the queenside – in real classical fashion) and not undertake any untimely action in the centre. This quite logical approach was always popular against the Catalan. In fact even before the birth of the opening we can find games with this set-up, one example being Blackburne-Baird, Leipzig 1884, where the game started 1 d4 d5 2 ♘f3 ♘f6 3 g3 e6 4 ♙g2 ♙e7 5 0-0 0-0 6 c4 c6 7 ♘c3 – a rather modern move order.

After 1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 ♙e7 5 ♙g2 0-0 the most common move is 6 0-0. Occasionally White plays 6 ♖c2 to reach a position from the semi-open Catalan, intending to secure an advantage by postponing castling. However, after 6 ♖c2 the d4-pawn becomes weaker and Black can challenge it immediately with 6...c5. Black then has a good game after 7 0-0 cxd4 8 ♘xd4 ♘c6 9 ♘xc6 bxc6, or 8...e5! (Game 1).

After 6 0-0 we get the basic closed Catalan position (from hereon referred to as the CC).

The CC is very similar to other closed openings. Now 6...b6 transposes to the Queen's Indian Defence, 6...c5 to the Tarasch Defence and 6...♘e4 followed by ...f7-f5 to the Stonewall variation of the Dutch

Defence. Obviously we cannot examine these openings here, but we do pay attention to the possible transpositions.



The arrangement of the theory in the CC can be awkward due to the number of move orders. For instance after 1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 ♙b4+ 5 ♙d2 ♙e7 6 ♙g2 0-0 7 0-0 ♘bd7 8 ♙f4 ♘h5 9 ♙c1 ♘hf6 we have a normal position in the CC with 6 0-0 ♘bd7. However, we will use the most popular routes.

Since the game Botvinnik-I.Rabinovich, St. Petersburg 1938 Black has used the plan with ...c7-c6 and ...b7-b5. This hits the c4-pawn and forces White to define the situation in the centre. In the case of an exchange on b5 and the opening of the c-file, the most

White can achieve is a slightly better position because the g2-bishop lacks bite. On the other hand, c4-c5 notably restricts Black's freedom, and after e2-e4 (and sometimes even e4-e5) White has the better prospects.

The main response to 6 0-0 is ...♘bd7. The plan with 6...c6, 7...b6 and 8...♙b7 (Game 2) has gone out of fashion because Black has serious problems after 8 ♖e5. Here Black can easily go wrong, for example 8...♜fd7 9 cxd5 cxd5 10 ♜xd5! or 8...♙b7 9 e4 ♜bd7? 10 ♜xc6! – in both cases White should win.

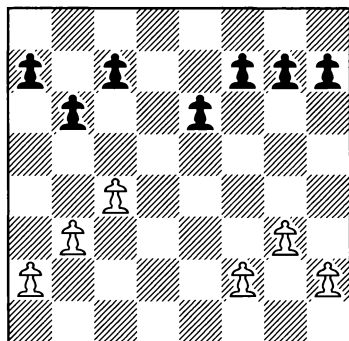
In the main line, with 8...♙b7 9 e4 dxc4 10 ♜xc4 ♙a6 11 b3, White has the initiative in the centre, while in the case of 6...c6 7 ♜c2 b6 8 ♜bd2 ♙b7 9 e4 ♜a6 White has more space.

The main gambit continuation in the CC is 6...♜bd7 7 ♜c3 dxc4 8 e4 (Game 3). There are various possibilities after 7 ♜c3 c6, which we examine in Games 4-6: 8 ♜b3 (Game 4), 8 ♜d3 (Game 5) and 8 b3 without ♜c2 (Game 6).

Game 7 is devoted to rare continuations in the 7 ♜c2 line. We have paid attention to Zagoryansky's plan with 7...c6 8 ♜d1 b6 9 a4! with the idea of a4-a5. Here Black must play with some accuracy in order to avoid trouble; Black seems to equalise after 9...♙a6 10 b3 ♜c8 11 a5 c5 12 axb6 ♜xb6 13 ♜a2 ♙b7 14 ♙a3 ♜fe8, as in Tratar-Atalik.

The main possibilities after 7 ♜c2 c6 are examined in Games 8-15. 8 ♙f4 (Games 8 & 9) allows Black to engineer a Stonewall position (8...♜h5 and 9...f5). In our opinion this appears to be the best option, but note that after 8...♜e4 9 ♜c3 (or 9 ♜bd2, 9 ♜fd2) the direct 9...f5 is no good in view of 10 ♜xe4 fxe4 11 ♜d2.

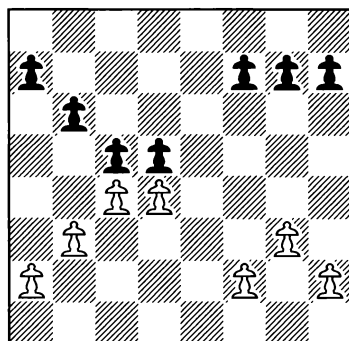
White's main plan in the CC is the advance e2-e4, when ...d5xe4 is not a popular reaction in modern international practice, being played mostly in games among amateurs. After ...c6-c5 and ...c5xd4 (or d4xc5) a prototypical pawn structure arises:



White has the pawn majority on the queenside, which provides a modest but stable advantage, especially in the endgame. In these positions it is not easy for Black to find counterplay and very often Black is forced to fight long and hard for a draw.

After 7 ♜c2 c6 8 ♜bd2 b6 9 e4 ♙a6 or 9...♙b7 White can grab space with e4-e5, and in such a situation White has kingside attacking chances (Game 12). Occasionally after e2-e4 the sides manoeuvre their pieces without altering the pawn structure, as in Game 13, where play continues 7 ♜c2 c6 8 ♜bd2 b6 9 b3 ♙b7 10 e4 ♜c8 11 ♙b2 ♜c7 12 ♜ad1 ♜fd8. Again, thanks to his space advantage, White's chances are slightly better.

Generally after e2-e4 Black prepares for and then advances ...c6-c5. The modern pawn structure in the CC arises after the exchange e4xd5 ...e6xd5:



With this confrontational pawn structure the current placement of the pieces and other tactical nuances are more important than strategic considerations. Black develops his light-squared bishop either to b7 (Game 13) or – more often – on a6 (Games 14 & 15). In the line starting with 7 ♖c2 c6 8 ♖bd2 b6 9 b3 ♖a6 White has a choice between 13 ♖f5, 13 ♖b2 and 13 ♖f1. The move order 10 ♖b2 ♖c8 11 e4 c5 12 exd5 exd5 13 ♖f5 is analysed in Game 15.

Game 1

H. Olafsson-E. Geller

Reykjavik 1986

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♖e7 5 ♖g2 0-0 6 ♖c2

The downside to this is Black's reply.
6...c5!

After 6...dxc4 7 ♖xc4 a6 there is a major difference between this and the Semi-Open variation in that White is not forced to castle yet, and can achieve a slight advantage with 8 ♖f4!, e.g. 8...♖d5 9 ♖c3 b5 10 ♖d3 ♖b7 11 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 12 0-0 ♖d7 13 ♖fd1 c5 14 e4 ♖b7 15 d5 exd5 16 exd5 ♖f6 17 ♖c2 ♖e8 18 h4 h6 19 ♖d2 ♖b6 20 ♖e4, when White was a shade better in Dorfman-Bönsch, Lvov 1984.

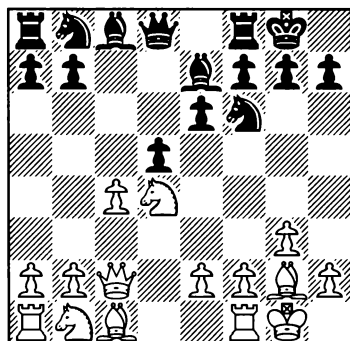
7 0-0

White needs to be careful even here. He could easily get himself into trouble: K. Grigorian-Vyzhmanavin, Pinsk 1986 continued 7 cxd5?! cxd4 8 ♖xd4 ♖xd5 9 ♖b3 ♖c6 10 ♖xc6 bxc6 11 e4 ♖b4 12 0-0 c5!, when White was behind in development and was therefore not suited by the open character of the position. After 13 ♖a3 ♖c6 14 ♖e3 ♖b8 15 ♖c3 ♖d4 16 ♖h1 ♖a6 17 ♖fd1 e5 18 b3 ♖c8 19 ♖a5 ♖b4 Black had a slight edge.

There is also 7 dxc5 ♖a5+ 8 ♖c3 dxc4 9 ♖d2 ♖xc5 10 ♖a4 ♖a5 11 ♖xc4 ♖d7, e.g. 12 ♖xb7 ♖b5! (an important zwischenzug as after 12...♖xa4? 13 ♖xa8 ♖bd7 14 ♖g2

♖e5 15 ♖f4 ♖h5 16 ♖e3 ♖c5 17 b4! ♖xb4 18 0-0 Black did not have enough compensation for the exchange in C. Horvath-Yu Shaoteng, Budapest 2000) 13 ♖h4 (13 ♖f4 e5! 14 ♖h4 ♖c6! 15 ♖xa8 ♖d4! gives Black a very strong attack) 13...♖d5 14 ♖e4 ♖c6! 15 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 with strong play for the pawn. Even worse here is 12 ♖c3?! ♖c8 13 ♖b3 ♖h5 14 ♖f4 ♖c6 15 0-0 h6 16 e4 ♖bd7 17 f3 a5! 18 g4 ♖e5 19 ♖g3 ♖xg3 20 hxg3 ♖e5 and Black's prospects were preferable in Korchnoi-Short, Lucerne 1989.

7...cxd4 8 ♖xd4



8...♖c6

Interesting is 8...e5!? 9 ♖f5 d4 10 ♖xe7+ ♖xe7 11 ♖g5 ♖c6 12 ♖d2 h6 13 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 14 c5 ♖f5 15 ♖a4 as in Zilberstein-A. Geller, Belgorod 1989. Now it is possible for Black to continue 15...♖g6 16 ♖c4 ♖e4 17 ♖d6 ♖xg2 18 ♖xg2 ♖e6 with reasonable chances. It is not clear that the d6-knight is well placed.

9 ♖xc6 bxc6 10 b3

White has also tried 10 ♖d1 ♖b6 11 ♖c3 ♖a6 12 ♖e3 ♖b7 13 cxd5 cxd5 14 ♖d4 but without much success. After 14...♖ac8 15 ♖b3 ♖c5 16 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 17 e3 ♖xd4 18 ♖xd4 ♖c5 19 ♖ad1 a5 20 ♖f1 ♖c6 21 h3 ♖b8 a draw was agreed in Gulko-Khalifman, Lucerne 1997.

10...a5

This looks like a luxury that offers Black nothing in terms of development. Serious

consideration should be given to the continuation 10...♔a6 11 ♖b2 ♜c8 12 e3 ♜b6 13 ♘d2 ♜f8 14 ♜fd1 ♘d7 15 ♜ac1 ♖b7 16 ♘f3 c5, when 17 ♘e5? ♘xe5 18 ♖xe5 d4! 19 exd4 ♖xg2 20 ♖xg2 f6 21 ♖f4 cxd4 22 ♜e4 e5 23 ♖d2 ♖a3 24 ♜b1 a5 was excellent for Black in Gulko-Karpov, Thessaloniki 1988. Instead Karpov gives 17 cxd5 exd5 18 ♜f5 ♘f6 19 ♘g5 with chances for both sides.

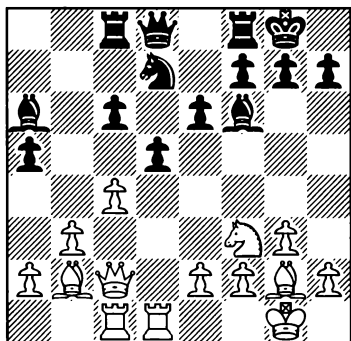
11 ♖b2

After 11 ♘c3 ♖a6 12 ♜d1 ♜c7 13 ♘a4 dxc4 14 bxc4 ♜ab8 15 ♖d2 e5 16 ♜ab1 ♜xb1 17 ♖xb1 ♘d7 Black – in control of the c5-square – was doing fine in Gulko-Hjartarsson, Linares 1989.

11...♖a6

An interesting alternative here is 11...a4!? 12 ♘d2 a3 13 ♖d4 (13 ♖c3?? d4 and the bishop is lost) 13...dxc4 14 e3 cxb3 15 ♘xb3 ♘d5 16 ♜fd1 ♜c7 17 e4 ♘f6 18 ♜c3 ♖a6 19 ♘c5 ♜f8 20 ♜ab1 when White had compensation for the pawn in Kengis-Gild. Garcia, Manila 1992 (whether there is more than enough is not completely clear).

12 ♘d2 ♘d7 13 ♜fd1 ♖f6 14 ♜ac1 ♜c8 15 ♘f3



15...♜e7

White is already a little better. After 15...♖xb2 16 ♜xb2 ♜b6 17 e4 ♘c5 18 ♜d4! dxc4 19 ♘e5 ♜f8 20 ♘xc4 ♜xd4 21 ♘xb6 ♜cd8 22 ♜xd4 ♜xd4 23 ♖f1 ♖xf1 24 ♖xf1 ♘xe4 25 ♜xc6 the endgame was slightly

unpleasant for Black in Kengis-Klovans, Riga 1987.

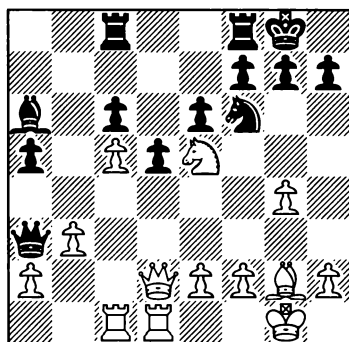
16 ♖xf6 ♘xf6

After 16...♜xf6 17 ♜d2! ♜d8 18 e4! White is better according to H.Olafsson.

17 ♘e5 ♖b7 18 ♜d2 ♜a3 19 c5 ♖a6

White has secured the queenside and is now free to start action on the kingside.

20 g4!



20...♜c7 21 g5 ♘d7 22 ♘xd7 ♜xd7 23 e4 d4 24 e5 ♖b5 25 ♖e4 d3 26 h4 a4

26...♜b4 looks safer, when after 27 ♜xb4 axb4 28 f3 f6 29 gxf6 gxf6 30 exf6 ♜xf6 31 ♖f2 ♜f4 32 ♖g1+ ♖f7 33 ♜g4 e5 34 ♖e3 h5 35 ♜g5 ♜xh4 36 ♜cg1 White has nothing special.

27 h5! axb3 28 axb3 ♜xb3 29 h6 g6?!

An improvement is 29...♜f8 30 hxg7 ♖xg7 31 ♜f4 d2 32 ♜f6+ ♖g8 33 ♜xd2! ♜a3! (not 33...♜xd2? 34 ♖xh7+! ♖xh7 35 ♜xf7+ ♖h8 36 g6 etc.) 34 ♜b1 ♜a4 and Black still has sufficient counterplay.

30 ♜f4 f5

Black loses in the event of 30...♜f8 31 ♜f6 ♖f8 32 ♖xg6!, when White comes crashing through: 32...♖e8 33 ♜h8+ ♖e7 34 ♜g7! ♜f8 35 ♜a1! and Black's party is over.

31 gxf6

White also has the better game after 31 exf6 ♜b2 32 ♜b1 ♜d4 33 ♜xb5! cxb5 34 ♜xd3. The following line is important: 34...♜a1+ 35 ♖g2 ♜xd3 36 ♜c7!! ♜f7 37 ♜c8+ ♜f8 38 ♜xe6+ ♖h8 39 ♜e7 ♜g8 40

♕xd3 and White is completely winning. He is threatening 41 f7 and after 40...b4 there is even 41 ♖g7+ ♙xg7 42 hxg7+ ♔g8 43 ♕c4 mate.

31... ♗d4 32 f3 ♕c4?

32... ♗d7 puts up some resistance, although 33 ♖g5 ♖b2 34 ♔h1! still gives White a strong attack.

33 ♖b1 1-0

After 33... ♖c2 there comes 34 f7! etc.

Game 2 Pigsov-Goldin Irkutsk 1986

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♖e7 5 ♕g2 0-0 6 0-0 c6

Black has some inventive alternatives:

6... ♖a6 7 ♖c3 c5 8 cxd5 exd5 is a Tarasch with the knight on a6 instead of c6, a feature that sees Black without any hold on d4. Rausis-Ponomarev, Enghien les Bains 1999 went 9 dxc5 ♖xc5 10 ♕e3 ♕g4 11 h3 ♕e6 12 ♖d4 ♗c8 13 ♗c1 a6 14 ♗c2 b5 15 a3 ♖d7 16 ♔h2 ♗fd8 17 ♗d2 ♖b7 18 ♖b1 ♖ce4 19 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 20 ♗d3 ♕d7 21 ♗fd1 with a slight edge for White.

6... ♖c6 7 ♖c2 ♖b4 8 ♖b3 dxc4 9 ♖xc4 b5!? is ambitious but weakening. Then 10 ♖b3 a5 11 ♖c3 ♗b8 12 ♕f4 a4 13 ♖d1 ♕b7 14 ♗c1 ♖bd5 15 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 was an edge for White in Kengis-Hertneck, Germany 2000. Here 9...b6 looks solid but is not too exciting for Black: 10 ♖c3 ♕a6 11 ♖b3 c5 12 dxc5 ♕xc5 13 ♖e5 ♗c8 14 ♕g5 ♖d4 15 ♕f4 ♖bd5 16 e3 ♖b4 17 ♗fd1 ♖xf4 18 gxf4 ♗c7 19 ♖c6 ♖c4 20 ♖c2 ♕xe3?! (20... ♖g4!? with an unclear game is better, with the following tactical justification: 21 b3?! ♖xe3 22 fxe3 ♖xf4 and Black has good counterplay; 21 ♖d4 improves) 21 fxe3 ♗xc6 22 ♗d4 ♖c5 23 ♕xc6 ♖xc6 24 ♖g2 ♖c7 25 ♗ad1 ♕b7 26 ♖b5 ♖b8 27 ♖d2 and White was on his way to winning in Rausis-Kulaots, Sweden 2000.

7 ♖c3

In the event of 7 ♖bd2 Black should transpose to the main lines with 7... ♖bd7. Instead Grivas-Papaioannou, Portaria 1996 continued with the unnecessary 7...b5, and after 8 cxb5 cxb5 9 ♖b3 a5 10 ♕f4 ♖a6 11 ♖e5 ♕b7 12 ♗c1 ♖b6 13 ♕g5 ♗fd8 14 e3 h6 15 ♕xf6 ♕xf6 16 f4 White had a slight lead.

7 ♖c2 can of course easily transpose to the main lines featured later in this chapter, but White's immediate action in the centre is of independent significance, e.g. 7...b6 8 ♖bd2 ♕b7 9 e4 ♖a6 10 a3 c5 11 e5 ♖d7 12 cxd5 ♕xd5 13 ♖d3 ♖c8 14 ♖e4 cxd4 15 ♖eg5 f5 16 exf6 ♖xf6 17 ♖xd4 ♕c4 18 ♖d1 ♖d8 19 ♕xa8 ♖xa8 20 ♖f3 ♖xf3 21 ♖gxf3 ♕xf1 22 ♖xf1 and White had the more comfortable ending in Karpov-Tal, Brussels 1987. An interesting alternative here is 11... ♖e4 12 ♖xe4 dxe4 13 ♖d2 cxd4 14 ♖xe4 ♖c7 15 ♕f4 ♖c5, when Damljanovic-Popchev, Yugoslavia 1997 saw the over the top 16 ♖f6+?! ♕xf6?! (preferable is 16...gxf6 17 exf6 ♕d6 18 ♖d1 ♔h8 with the better game for Black; it is difficult to see how White's pieces should succeed in attacking the black king) 17 exf6 ♖d8 18 ♕xb7 ♖xb7 19 fxg7 ♗e8 20 ♗fe1 f6, and now 21 ♖e4 ♖c5 22 ♖f3 would have maintained White's lead.

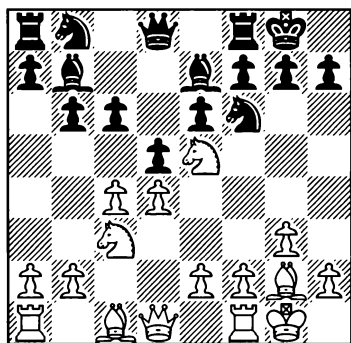
7...b6

Black is slightly worse – in traditional Catalan fashion – after 7...dxc4 8 ♖e5 ♖bd7 9 ♖xc4, e.g. 9... ♖b6 10 ♖e5 ♕d7 11 e4 c5 12 ♕e3 cxd4 13 ♕xd4 ♕e8 14 a4 ♖fd7 15 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 16 e5! ♖c5 17 b4! ♖b3 18 ♖xb3 ♖xd4 19 b5 and White had the freer game in Raetsky-Lemanczyk, Dusseldorf 2001.

8 ♖e5 ♕b7

Black can run into trouble with 8... ♖fd7?, when 9 cxd5 cxd5 10 ♖xd5! exd5 11 ♕xd5 ♖xe5 12 dxe5 ♕h3 13 ♕xa8 ♕xf1 14 ♖xf1 ♖d7 15 ♕d5 ♖xe5 16 e4 left White a clear pawn up in Chetverik-Laihonen, Nagykanizsa 1993.

8...♙a6 9 cxd5 (9 ♖a4!? b5 10 cxb5 cxb5 11 ♖xb5 ♖e8 12 ♖c3 ♖xa4 13 ♖xa4 ♙xe2 14 ♚e1 ♙b5 15 ♖c5 ♚e8 16 ♙e3 ♖fd7 17 a4 ♖xe5 18 axb5 ♖c4 19 b4 produced an edge for White in Tunik-Dautov, Moscow 1989) 9...cxd5 10 ♙f4 ♖fd7 (after 10...♙b7 11 ♚c1 ♖h5 12 ♙d2 ♖f6 13 ♖b5 ♖e8 14 ♖c2 f6 15 ♖d3 ♖c6 16 ♖f4 ♖d7 17 e4! favoured White in Smejkal-Bönsch, Germany 1998) 11 ♚c1 (11 ♖xd5?! exd5 12 ♙xd5 ♖xe5 13 dxe5? does not work this time due to 13...♙xe2!, when Black wins material) 11...♖xe5 12 ♙xe5 and White is a shade better.



9 e4! dxc4

Black loses a pawn after 9...♖bd7? 10 ♖xc6! ♙xc6 11 exd5 exd5 12 cxd5 ♙b7, when White has 13 d6! ♙xg2 14 dxe7 ♖xe7 15 ♙xg2 ♚fd8 16 ♖f3 ♚ac8 17 ♚d1 ♖b4 18 ♚b1 h6 19 ♙f4 ♖a5 20 d5, which was close to winning in Poluliahov-Dragomaretsky, Sochi 1996. Black was also rather quickly in a bad way in Korchnoi-Yusupov, Rotterdam 1988, finding himself clearly worse after 9...♖a6 10 ♙f4 dxc4 11 ♖xc4 b5 12 ♖e3 ♖d7 13 ♖g4 b4 14 ♖a4 ♖b6 15 ♙e3 ♖c4 16 ♚c1 ♖xe3 17 ♖xe3 ♚c8 18 e5! etc.

10 ♖xc4 ♙a6

The weakening of the queenside with 10...b5 seems risky. For example 11 ♖e3 b4 12 e5 bxc3 13 exf6 ♙xf6 14 bxc3 ♖d7 15 ♙a3 ♚e8 16 ♚b1 ♖b6 17 ♚e1 ♖c7 18 ♖g4 ♙e7 19 ♙xe7 ♚xe7 20 ♖e5 led to a clear

advantage for White in Ivanchuk-Dautov, Tashkent 1987.

11 b3 b5 12 ♖e3

Also possible is 12 ♖e5, after which the thematic 12...c5 results in superior prospects for White following 13 d5 b4 14 ♖e2 ♖c7 15 ♙b2 ♚d8 16 ♚e1. Instead 12...b4 looks a little suspicious (and greedy), as was demonstrated in Dizdar-Limbach, Hamburg 1993, which went 13 ♖e2 ♙xe2 14 ♖xe2 ♖xd4 15 ♙b2 ♖b6 16 ♚ac1 ♚d8 17 ♚c4!? with more than sufficient compensation. The subsequent 17...a5 18 ♖c2 ♚a6 19 ♖xf7!? ♙xf7 20 e5 ♖d5 21 ♖xh7, ♖f8 22 ♚g4 ♙e8 23 ♚xg7 ♖d8 24 ♙h3 c5 25 ♚d1 left White in the driving seat.

12...b4 13 ♖e2 ♖bd7

It is dangerous to take the pawn – 13...♙xe2 14 ♖xe2 ♖xd4 15 ♙b2 ♖b6 16 ♖c4 ♖b5 17 ♙xf6 gxf6 18 ♚ad1 a5 19 ♚fe1 a4 20 e5 and White had a strong attack in Smyslov-Guimard, Groningen 1946.

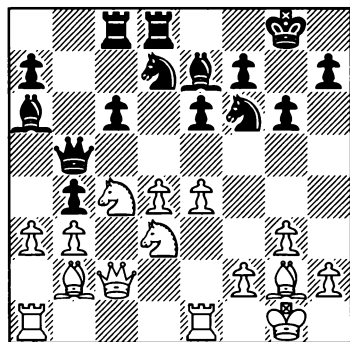
14 ♚e1 ♚c8 15 ♙b2 ♖a5 16 ♖f4 g6

16...c5 17 e5 ♖e8 18 d5 and Black is in trouble.

17 ♖d3 ♚fd8 18 ♖c4 ♖h5 19 ♖c2

Even the ending after 19 ♖xh5 ♖xh5 20 a3!? offers White the better prospects.

19...♖b5 20 a3



20...♖d5!?

Black has to try something. 20...bxa3 21 ♙xa3 c5 22 d5 gives White a clear lead.

21 axb4!

A strong yet logical move, allowing White to retain his structural advantage. 21 exd5! cxd5 22 ♖xb4 dxc4, on the other hand, is not clear.

21... ♖xb4 22 ♖xb4 ♗xb4 23 ♖ed1 ♖b8 24 ♖a4 ♖b7 25 ♖da1 ♗f8 26 ♖c3 ♗g7 27 e5!

The weakness of the d6-square is clearly felt.

27... ♗xc4

27... ♗f8 loses to 28 ♖d6! ♗xd6 29 exd6 ♗xd6 30 d5, when the dark squares look like a Swiss cheese.

28 bxc4 ♖c7 29 ♗a3 ♗f8 30 c5

30 ♗xf8 ♗xf8 31 ♖b4 ♖c8 32 ♖ab1 ♖d7 33 c5 should also win.

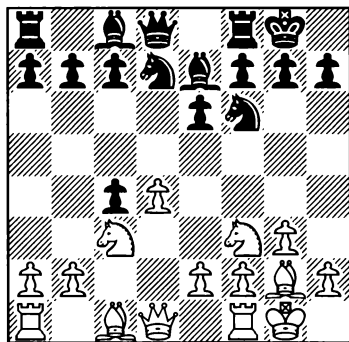
30... ♖cd7 31 ♗c1 ♗e7 32 h4 ♖c8 33 ♗e4 f5 34 exf6 ♗xf6 35 ♖b1 ♖c7 36 ♗f4 ♖d8 37 ♖b3 ♖xd4 38 ♖xd4 1-0

Game 3
Topalov-Kramnik
Linares 1997

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♗e7 5 ♗g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♖bd7 7 ♖c3!

This gambit line is no longer so 'hot' – thanks in part to what now develops.

7... dxc4!



The key to refuting a gambit is often in accepting the pawn(s).

8 e4 c6

One of several possibilities at this juncture.

ture.

8... ♖b6 9 ♖e2 c5 10 dxc5 ♗xc5 11 ♖e5 ♗d7 12 ♖d1 ♖e7 13 ♗g5 gives White a slight edge, this being transformed to a dangerous attack in Gretarsson-Bjornsson, Reykjavik 1999 after 13... h6 14 ♗xf6 gxf6 15 ♖g4 ♗g7 16 e5! f5 17 ♖f6 ♗c6 18 g4 ♖fd8 19 ♗xc6 bxc6 20 ♖h1.

8... c5 9 d5 exd5 10 exd5 ♖b6 11 ♖e5 ♗d6 12 f4 ♖e8 13 a4 a5 (13... ♗xe5 14 fxe5 ♖xe5 15 ♗f4 gives White a strong attack for the pawns; the lead in development is the most important factor here) 14 ♖b5 ♗f5 15 ♖e1 ♖g4 16 ♖xg4 ♖xe1 + 17 ♖xe1 ♗xg4 18 ♗d2 ♖e7 19 ♖xe7 ♗xe7 20 d6 ♗f6 21 ♗xb7 ♖b8 22 ♗c6 ♗xb2 23 ♖e1 was an edge for White in Petursson-Dutreeuw, San Bernadino 1989.

8... a6!? is an interesting option, Black trying to hang on to the pawn. 9 a4 ♖b8 10 a5 b5 11 axb6 cxb6 12 ♗f4 ♖a8 13 ♖d2 b5 14 ♖xb5 ♖b6 15 ♗c7 ♖d7 16 ♗xb6 ♖xb5 17 ♗a5 is good for White according to Volzhin, so Kramnik-Lputian, Wijk aan Zee 2000 went 11... ♖xb6 12 ♖e2 ♗b7 13 ♖d1 ♗b4 14 ♖e5 a5! (making way for ... ♗a6 in case of ♖xc4 and improving on 14... ♖e7, which gives White the chance to win a tempo and claim an advantage with 15 ♗g5! h6 16 ♗xf6 ♖xf6 17 ♖xc4 ♖xc4 18 ♖xc4 ♖e7 19 e5 ♗xg2 20 ♗xg2, as in Volzhin-Neveerov, Dubai 2001) 15 ♖a2 ♖a8 16 ♗g5?! (16 ♗f4! looks like an improvement) 16... ♗e7 and now 17 ♖xc4? ♗a6 18 b3 a4 19 ♗xf6 axb3 20 ♖g4 ♗xf6 21 ♖xb6 cxb6 22 e5 ♗e7 resulted in a clear advantage for Black. Kramnik gives the lesser evil 17 ♖c3, when the strongest is 17... ♖fd7! 18 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 19 ♗e3 a4 with the better game for Black.

9 a4 e5!?

An interesting, fresh try. Older games contribute the following knowledge:

9... a5 10 ♖e2 ♖b6 11 ♖d1 ♗b4 12 ♖e5 ♖e7 13 ♗e3 ♗d7 14 ♖xc4 ♖xc4 15 ♖xc4 and now Black went wrong in Botvinnik-Em.Lasker, Moscow 1936 with 15... b5?! 16

♖e2 ♙ab8?!, when 17 axb5 cxb5 18 e5 ♜e8 19 d5! proved rather inconvenient for the defender. After the improvement 15...e5 16 dxe5 ♜g4 17 ♙d4 ♙e6 18 ♖e2 ♙c5 White has 19 ♜d5!? cxd5 20 exd5 ♙xd4 21 ♙xd4 ♙f5 22 ♙e1, with sufficient compensation for the piece to claim a lead.

9...b6 10 ♖e2 and now 10...♙a6 11 ♜d1 ♖c8 12 d5!? exd5 13 exd5 ♙e8 14 dxc6 ♜c5 15 ♜b5 ♜d3 16 ♙xd3! cxd3 17 ♖xd3 furnished White with compensation for the exchange in I.Zaitsev-Lukacs, Dubna 1979, while 10...a5 11 ♜d1 ♙a6 12 ♙f4 ♙e8 13 ♜d2 ♜f8 14 ♜xc4 ♜g6 15 ♙e3 should be better for White, which was the case in Ivanchuk-Dreev, Tallinn 1986 after 15...♜d5!? 16 e5 ♙c8 17 ♙ac1 ♜e3 18 fxe3 b5 19 ♜a3 ♖b6 20 ♙f1 etc.

10 dxe5 ♜g4 11 ♙f4 ♖a5 12 e6

After 12 ♖d4 ♙d8 13 ♖xc4 ♜dxe5 14 ♜xe5 ♜xe5 15 ♖b3 b6 16 ♜d5 cxd5 17 ♙xe5 ♙a6 18 ♙fe1 d4 Black has the better chances.

12...fxe6

12...♜de5 13 ♜xe5 ♜xe5 14 exf7+ ♙xf7 15 ♜d5 cxd5 16 ♙xe5 dxe4 17 ♙c3 ♖a6 18 ♙xe4 ♙f5 19 ♙xf5 ♙xf5 20 ♖g4 ♙f7 eventually led to equality in Ignatiev-Yagupov, St. Petersburg 1998.

13 ♖e2

Later Topalov tried to improve on his play in the main game, still without proving an advantage – Topalov-Kasparov, Sarajevo 2000 went 13 e5 ♜dxe5 14 ♜xe5 ♜xe5 15 ♖h5 ♙d6! 16 ♜e4 ♙f5 17 ♖e8+ ♙f8 18 ♖h5 ♙f5 and a draw was agreed.

13...♜ge5 14 ♜d4 ♜d3!

The e6-pawn is of lesser importance than the placement of the pieces.

15 ♜xe6 ♙f6 16 ♙c7

16 ♜c7? loses to 16...♜xf4 17 ♖xc4+ ♜h8 18 ♜xa8 ♜e5 19 ♖b3 ♜xg2 20 ♜xg2 ♜f3 21 ♙fd1 ♖h5 and Black has a winning attack.

16...♖b4

All of this was – oddly enough – played

again later the same year. Perhaps White did not know of this game?

17 ♜d4

After 17 ♜f4 ♖xb2 18 ♖xb2 ♜xb2 19 e5 ♙h6, as in Maherramzade-Kacheishvili, Baku 1997, White has compensation after 20 ♙ab1 ♜d3 21 ♜xd3 cxd3 22 ♜e4, but better is 17...♜7e5! with a strong position for Black.

17...♙c5 18 ♜c2 ♖xb2 19 ♜d1 ♖b3

The black queen will survive, leaving White's minor pieces looking very odd indeed. Topalov clearly must have overlooked something.

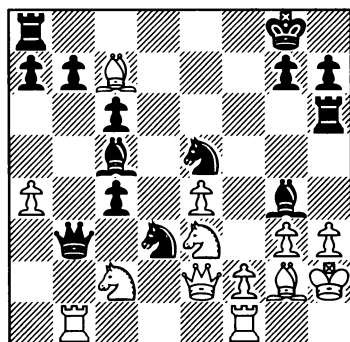
20 ♜de3 ♜7e5 21 h3 ♙e6 22 ♜h2

22 ♙xe5 ♜xe5 23 ♙ab1 ♖xa4 24 ♙xb7 ♖a6 gives Black a clear advantage.

22...♙h6 23 ♙ab1?!

23 f4 ♜g4+ 24 ♜xg4 ♙xg4 25 ♖xg4 ♖xc2 26 h4 improves, although Black is ahead after 26...♙f8.

23...♙g4!



A key tactic.

24 ♜xg4

24 ♖d2 ♙xh3+! 25 ♙xh3 ♜f3+ wins for Black, while 24 f3 loses to 24...♜xf3+! 25 ♙xf3 ♙xh3 with a deadly attack after 26 ♜g2 ♖c3! etc.

24...♜xg4+ 25 ♖xg4 ♖xc2 26 ♖g5

26 f4 runs into 26...♜f2! 27 ♖f3 ♙xh3+ 28 ♙xh3 ♜g4+ 29 ♜h1 ♖h2 mate.

26...♜xf2! 27 ♜xf2

27 ♖xc5 again meets with 27...♙xh3+, now with a twist after 28 ♜g1 ♙h1+! 29

♙xh1 ♘h3 mate.

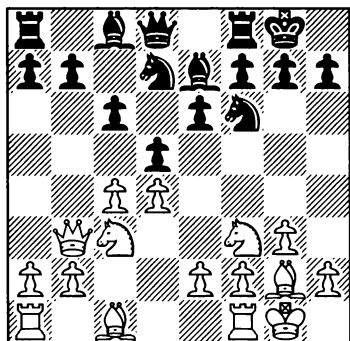
27... ♖xf2 28 ♖f1 ♗d4 29 ♖e5 ♗d7 30 ♗c1 ♗e6 31 ♖xg7 ♗xg7 32 ♗g5+ ♖g6 33 ♗xc5 ♗d6 0-1

Game 4

Romanishin-Ribli

Polanica Zdroj 1993

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 ♖e7 5 ♖g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♘bd7 7 ♘c3 c6 8 ♗b3



8...b6

Black has two main alternatives:

8... ♗b6 appears inadequate. White was a little better in Korchnoi-S.Polgar, Munich 2000 after 9 ♗d1 ♗xb3 10 axb3 b6 11 e4 ♖b7 12 e5 ♘e8 13 ♖g5 ♖xg5 14 ♘xg5 h6 15 ♘h3 ♘c7 16 ♘f4 a5 17 h4 ♖a6 18 ♖ac1 ♖ac8 19 cxd5 cxd5 20 ♗d2.

But 8... ♘b6!? looks sound. Then 9 c5 ♘bd7 10 ♗c2 b6 11 b4 a5 12 b5 ♖b7 13 cxb6 cxb5 14 ♘xb5 ♗xb6 15 ♖b1 ♖fc8 16 ♗d3 ♖a6 17 a4 ♖b4 18 ♖d2 ♖xb5 19 axb5 ♖c4 gave Black the initiative in Martynov-Sherbakov, Taby 1991. This leaves 9 cxd5 cxd5, when an interesting idea is 10 ♗d1!? with the point that after 10... ♖d7 11 ♘e5 ♖c8 12 ♖f4 White is a little better. Instead Chetverik-O.Kozlov, Pecs 1996 went 10 ♘e5 ♘fd7! (the knight on b6 is the better placed of the two) 11 e4 ♘xe5 12 dxe5 d4 13 ♗d1 ♖c5 14 ♘b5 ♖d7 15 a4 a6 and now White should have played 16 ♘d6 ♖xd6 17

exd6 e5 18 a5 ♘c8 19 ♗xb7 ♘xd6 20 ♗d5, with chances for both sides.

9 ♖f4

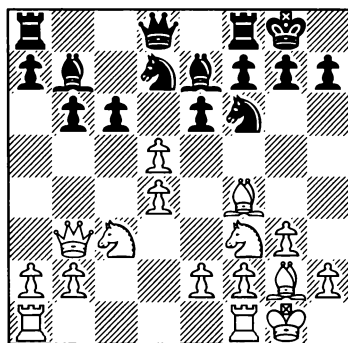
Also good is 9 ♖g5 ♖b7 10 ♖fd1 a5 11 cxd5 cxd5 12 ♖ac1 with the more comfortable game for White. After the subsequent 12... ♘e4 13 ♖xe7 ♗xe7 14 ♘d2 ♘ef6 15 e3 ♖fc8 16 a3 ♖a6 17 ♘b5 ♖xc1 18 ♖xc1 ♖c8 19 ♖xc8+ ♖xc8 20 ♗c2 ♖a6 21 ♖f1 White still had an edge in Tukmakov-Chernin, Lvov 1990.

9...♖b7

Black has a couple of alternatives. 9... ♖a6 10 cxd5 cxd5 11 ♘b5! ♖xb5 12 ♗xb5 gives White a lasting edge with the two bishops, e.g. 12...a6 13 ♗c6 ♖c8 14 ♗a4 ♖a8 15 ♖fc1 b5 16 ♗c2 ♖c8 17 ♖c7 ♗e8 18 ♗d2 ♘b8 19 ♘e5, Markowski-Filippov, Koszalin 1999.

9...a5!? 10 ♖fd1 ♖a6 11 cxd5 ♘xd5! sees Black keep his options open, 12 ♘e5 ♘xe5 13 ♖xe5 a4 14 ♗c2 a3 offering good counterplay according to Kasimdzanov.

10 cxd5



White has also tried 10 ♖ac1 dxc4 11 ♗xc4 ♘d5 12 ♘e5, when the natural 12... ♘xe5 results in an unclear game after 13 ♖xe5 ♖g5 14 e3 ♖xe3! 15 fxe3 ♘xe3 16 ♗e2 ♘xf1 17 ♘xf1 f6 18 ♖f4 ♗d7 (Ulibin & Tiviakov). In Ulibin-Tiviakov, Kastellanata 1998 Black opted for the dubious 12...b5?! but soon suffered: 13 ♗d3 ♘xe5 14 ♖xe5 ♗b6 15 ♘e4 f6 16 ♖f4 ♖ad8 17 ♖d2 ♖c8 18 ♘c5 a5 19 ♖fd1 ♗h8 20 ♗a3! b4 21 ♗a4

♖b5 22 ♖xb5 cxb5 23 ♜b3 a4 24 ♜a5 ♙d7 25 ♜c6 ♙xc6 26 ♜xc6 and life was not easy for the defender.

10...cxd5

10...exd5 11 ♖ad1 ♜e8 12 e4!? ♜xe4 13 ♜xe4 dxe4 14 ♜e5 ♜xe5 15 dxe5 ♖c8 16 ♙xe4 ♙f8 17 ♜d2 c5 18 ♙xb7 ♖xb7 19 ♜fd1 ♜e7 20 h4 ♜c8 21 ♜d5 ♖xd5 22 ♜xd5 was a little better for White in Rashkovsky-Goloshchapov, Ekaterinburg 1999 in view of the domination of the d-file.

10...♜xd5 11 ♜xd5 exd5 12 ♜ac1 c5 13 ♜fd1 ♜c8 14 h4 cxd4 was played in Chetverik-Hajnal, Gyula 1999. Now 15 ♜xd4 ♜c5 16 ♖f3 gives White a slight plus due to the superior pieces and the isolated d-pawn. If possible the queen will go to g4, and in the event of 16...♖d7 White can consider 17 ♜h2! with the idea of 18 ♙h3.

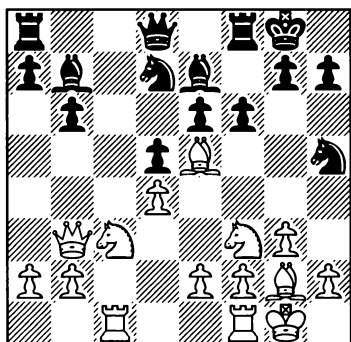
11 ♜ac1

11 ♜b5!? is interesting, after which 11...a6?! is risky thanks to 12 ♜d6!, when White gets the two bishops. Tiviakov gives 11...♜e8 12 ♜ac1 a6 13 ♜c3 with an even game, or 13 ♜c7 g5 14 ♜xa8 gxf4 15 ♜xb6 ♜xb6 16 gxf4 with unclear play.

11...♜h5

After 11...♜e8 White achieves a slight edge with 12 ♜c2 ♜d6 13 ♜fc1 ♜c4 14 ♜d2 ♜xd2 15 ♙xd2, when an invasion down the c-file is imminent.

12 ♙e5 f6



13 ♙c7!?

A very exciting piece sacrifice. White gets two pawns and free access to the queenside in return for the bishop. Meanwhile the knight remains stuck on h5. The alternative is 13 ♙f4!? ♜xf4 14 gxf4 f5 15 ♜b5 ♙f6 16 ♜c7 ♜b8 17 ♜fc1 a6 18 ♜a7! with an attack on the queenside (Romanishin).

13...♖xc7 14 ♜xd5 ♖d6

White gets an extra possibility after 14...♖d8, when 15 ♜xe7+ transposes and 15 ♜c7!? offers a hell of a ride: 15...♜c5 16 ♜xc5! bxc5 17 ♖xb7 ♜b8 18 ♖xa7 ♖c8! 19 ♜d5 ♙d6 20 ♖e7! exd5 21 ♖xd6 and White will probably have the better chances in the endgame after 21...♖d8 22 ♖xc5 ♜xb2 23 ♖xc8 ♜xc8 24 e3 as all the pawns are on one flank and Black has problems with the knight on h5.

15 ♜xe7+ ♖xe7 16 ♜c7 ♙d5 17 ♖b5 ♜fd8

17...♖ad8 18 ♜xa7 ♖d6 19 ♜c1, with ♜cc7 to follow, also looks dangerous for Black.

18 e4 ♙xe4

Worth considering was 18...a6 19 ♖e2 ♙xa2! (19...♖d6 20 ♜fc1 ♙xa2 21 e5! looks dangerous) 20 ♜a1 ♙b3 21 ♖e3 ♖b4 22 ♖c3 ♖xc3 23 ♜xc3 e5 24 ♜xb3 exd4 with approximately even chances in the endgame, although White might argue otherwise.

19 ♖xh5 ♖d6

19...♜dc8 is strongly met with 20 ♜e5! ♜xc7 21 ♙xe4 fxe5 22 ♖xh7+ ♜f8 23 ♙xa8 exd4 24 ♖d1 and Black's king is walking on thin ice.

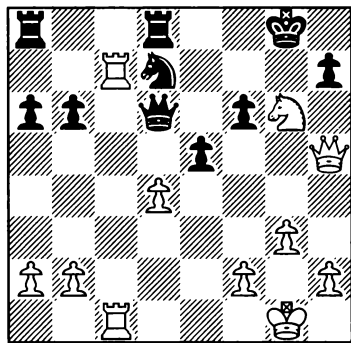
20 ♜fc1 a6 21 ♜h4 ♙xg2 22 ♜xg2 e5?!

It was necessary to take the pawn with 22...♖xd4, and after 23 ♜f4 play 23...♖e4, when White has compensation. Perhaps 24 ♜1c4!? is the best chance to fight for the initiative.

23 ♜h4 g6?

23...exd4 24 ♜f5 ♖e5 puts up more resistance, although White has 25 ♜xg7! ♜xg7 26 ♜xd7+ ♜xd7 27 ♖g4+ ♜h8 28 ♖xd7 with a near decisive lead.

24 ♖xg6!



Stripping away the defences.

24...hxg6 25 ♖xg6+ ♖h8

After 25...♖f8 26 ♖1c6 ♖e7 27 ♖xd7! the last line of defence falls.

26 dxe5 1-0

Game 5
Gleizerov-Barua
Kolkata 2002

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♖e7 5
 ♖g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♖bd7 7 ♖c3 c6 8 ♖d3

A patent of the Russian Grandmaster.

8...b6 9 ♖d1

This seems to give White the best chances for an edge. Now the queen will not be unprotected after e2-e4. Alternatives:

9 cxd5 cxd5 10 ♖f4 a6 11 a4 ♖b7 12 ♖fc1 ♖c8 13 ♖d2 ♖h5 14 ♖e3 ♖d6 15 f3 ♖hf6 16 ♖f2 ♖e7 17 ♖h3 ♖fd8 18 ♖e1 ♖b8 19 ♖ac1 ♖c6 resulted in a balanced game in Ivanchuk-A.Petrosian, Lvov 1988.

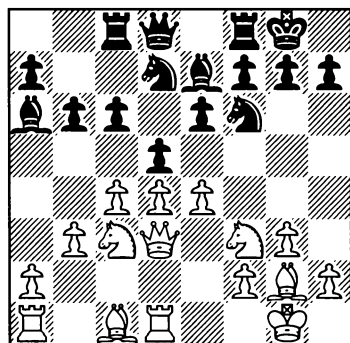
9 e4 ♖a6 10 b3 dxc4 11 bxc4 e5!? and now 12 ♖d1 seems to be rather harmless. One game continued 12...♖c7 13 dxe5 ♖xe5 14 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 15 ♖f4 ♖e6 16 ♖d5!? cxd5 17 exd5 ♖d7 18 d6 ♖ad8 19 ♖c2 ♖b7 20 dxe7 ♖xe7 21 ♖e1 ♖d7 22 ♖ad1 ♖c8 23 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 24 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 25 ♖g5 ♖c6 26 ♖xf6 and a draw was agreed in Flear-Dizdar, Montpellier 1998. Instead Vaganian-Mueller, Germany 1995 continued 12 dxe5 ♖g4 13

♖f4 ♖c5 14 ♖xd8 ♖fxd8 15 h3 ♖h6 16 ♖fd1 ♖xc4 17 ♖d4 ♖ac8 18 ♖xh6 gxh6 19 ♖f5 ♖f8 20 ♖d6 ♖xd6 21 exd6 ♖d3 22 ♖d2 ♖xd6 23 ♖ad1 with a clear advantage to White. Here the brutal 13...g5!? is more appropriate, e.g. 14 ♖xg5 (14 ♖ad1!? 14...♖xg5 15 ♖xg5 ♖xg5 16 ♖xd7 ♖xe5 17 ♖f5 ♖g7 with an unclear situation in which White has interests on the kingside while Black is looking to the centre and to the queenside.

9...♖a6 10 b3 ♖c8

Black could also choose to develop the other rook. An interesting choice is 10...♖c8 11 ♖f4 ♖d8 12 e4 b5 13 cxb5 cxb5 14 ♖ac1 b4 15 ♖xd5! (forced) 15...exd5 (15...♖xc1 16 ♖xe7+ ♖f8 17 ♖xc1 ♖xd3 18 ♖c6 ♖dc8 19 ♖d6+ ♖e8 20 ♖d2 leaves White with good compensation for the exchange; Black will have difficulties freeing himself) 16 ♖xc8 ♖xd3 17 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 18 ♖xd3 ♖xe4 (18...dxe4 19 ♖e1 ♖e8 20 ♖e3 favours White) 19 ♖e5 ♖df6 20 ♖c6 ♖f8, Ulibin-Vaulin, Bydgoszcz 2000, and now 21 ♖b8!? gives White a modest plus.

11 e4



11...c5

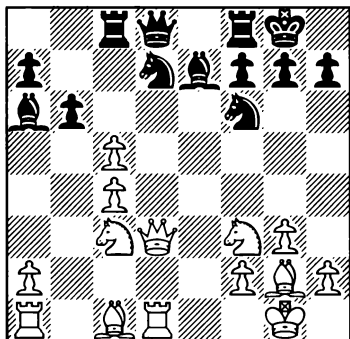
11...♖c7 is best met with 12 ♖f4 ♖b7 13 e5 ♖e8 14 a4 ♖b8 15 ♖g5 ♖xg5 16 ♖xg5 g6 17 g4 with bright prospects on the kingside, Yevseev-Azarov, Minsk 2000.

12 exd5 exd5 13 dxc5

13 ♖b2 dxc4 14 bxc4 cxd4 15 ♖b5 ♖c5

16 ♖xd4 ♖xd4 17 ♜fxd4 ♙xb5 18 cxb5 ♜a4 19 ♜f5 ♜fe8 20 ♙d4 ♙c5 21 ♜ac1 gave White a fantastic advantage in Romanishin-Ciric, Dortmund 1976. As in so many positions in the Catalan, Black has a big problem with the c6-square.

13...dxc4 14 bxc4



14...♜xc5?!

Preferable is 14...♜xc5 15 ♖f1 ♖e8 (15...♜fd7?) 16 ♜b5 ♜ce4 17 ♜fd4 ♙c5 18 ♙b2, when 18...♜d8 should limit White to a slight advantage. Worse is 18...♖e5? 19 ♖e2 ♙xb5 20 cxb5 ♜cd8 21 ♜c6 ♜xd1+ 22 ♜xd1 ♖f5 23 ♙d4, when Black was struggling a little in Gleizerov-Perez, Malaga 2001.

15 ♜b5 ♙xb5 16 cxb5 ♜d5 17 ♜d4 ♜e5

After 17...♜c5 18 ♖c4 ♜fe4 19 ♙e3 ♙f6 20 ♙f3! White stands clearly better according to Gleizerov. The main idea behind ♙f3 is, of course, to protect the rook. Now ♜f5 and ♜c6 are threats, and Black will probably have to give up his second bishop.

18 ♖c3

18 ♖e2? would be a slip as after 18...♙c5!! Black assumes the initiative.

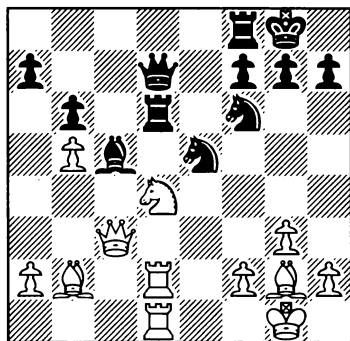
18...♙c5 19 ♙b2!

Forced. 19 ♙e3? ♜fg4! 20 ♙xd5 ♖xd5 21 ♖b3 ♖e4 22 ♖b1 ♖a8 gives Black a sensational attack, and 19 ♙xd5? ♖xd5 20 ♙e3 ♙xd4 21 ♙xd4 ♜f3+ 22 ♖f1 ♜hx2+ 23 ♖g1 ♜f3+ 24 ♖f1 ♜xd4 25 ♖xd4 ♖h1+ 26 ♖e2 ♜e8+ looks deadly.

19...♙d6 20 ♜d2 ♖d7

20...♜d5 fails to 21 ♙xd5! ♜xd5 22 ♜c6! ♜xd2 23 ♜xd8 ♙d4 (only move) 24 ♖xd2 ♜f3+ 25 ♖g2 ♜xd2 26 ♙xd4 ♜xd8 27 ♜c1 with a wonderful ending.

21 ♜ad1



21...♖g4

21...♜d5? 22 ♙xd5! ♜xd5 23 ♜b3 and White wins material. 21...♜d8 22 ♜b3! is also very uncomfortable.

22 h3!

This leads by force to a highly favourable ending.

22...♙xd4 23 hxg4 ♙xc3 24 ♙xc3 ♜xd2 25 ♜xd2 ♜exg4 26 ♙c6 h5 27 f3 ♜e3 28 ♙xf6 gxf6 29 ♜d7

White has all the chances.

29...♖g7 30 ♜xa7 ♜d8 31 ♜d7!

The minor piece endgame is winning, and the attack on f7 cannot be allowed.

31...♜xd7 32 ♙xd7 ♜c4 33 ♖f2 ♖f8 34 ♙h3!

The h5-pawn is the target of this bishop manoeuvre.

34...♖e7 35 ♙f1 ♜a3 36 f4 ♖d6 37 ♙e2 ♖c5 38 ♙xh5 ♜xb5 39 ♙xf7 ♖d4 40 ♖f3 ♜d6 41 ♙b3 f5 42 g4

White does not hesitate in creating a decisive passed pawn. An important point to notice here is that a8 is a light square, so White does not risk having a pawn + bishop versus king scenario in which he cannot win.

42...fxg4+ 43 ♖xg4 b5 44 ♖g5 b4 45 ♖g6 ♜e4

Black also loses after 45... ♖e4 46 f5! ♜xf5 47 ♖c2+ etc.

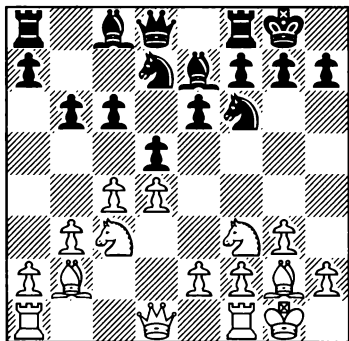
46 ♖c2 ♜c5 47 f5 ♖e5 48 f6 ♜d7 49 f7 ♜d6 50 ♗g7 ♖e7 51 ♖f5 1-0

Game 6

Korchnoi-Nogueiras

Moscow 1994

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 ♖e7 5 ♗g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♜bd7 7 ♜c3 c6 8 b3 b6 9 ♖b2



9... ♖a6

Black's main alternative is, not surprisingly, 9... ♖b7, when White has tried a few moves:

10 ♖c2 might be best, transposing to 7 ♖c2 c6 8 b3 b6 9 ♖b2 ♖b7 10 ♜c3 (see Game 10).

10 ♜c1 ♜e4!? 11 ♜xe4 dxe4 12 ♜e5 f5 13 ♖c2 ♜xe5 14 dxe5 c5 15 ♜cd1 ♖c7 was a draw in Szabo-Spassky, Palma de Mallorca 1969, probably because the position offers little promise of progress for either player.

Stojanovic-Jovcic, Tivat 1995 went 10 ♜e5 ♜xe5 11 dxe5 ♜d7 12 cxd5 cxd5 13 e4 d4!? (a logical temporary pawn sacrifice, designed to close out the g2-bishop) 14 ♖xd4 ♖c5 15 ♖d1 ♜xe5 16 ♖h5 ♜g6 17 ♜fd1 ♖e7 18 ♜a4 ♖a3 19 ♖xa3 ♖xa3 with another draw.

10 ♖d3 c5 11 cxd5 exd5 12 ♜ad1 ♜e8 13 dxc5 bxc5 14 ♜g5 ♜b6 15 e4!? and now

15... ♜fd7! is good, when 16 ♜xf7!? ♜xf7 17 exd5 is unclear. The alternatives are worse, e.g. 15...d4!? 16 e5! dxc3 17 ♖c2! with a very dangerous position for Black. And 15...h6!? 16 ♜xf7! ♜xf7 17 e5 ♖g8 (17... ♜e4 18 e6+! ♜xe6 19 ♜xe4 is not something Black will survive, an important line being 19...dxe4 20 ♖e2! ♖d5 21 ♖xe4 ♜f7 22 ♖h5+ ♖g8 23 ♜xd5! and Black can resign as mate is coming) 18 exf6 ♖xf6 19 ♖a3 was a clear lead for White in Tisdall-Chernushevich, Hallsdall 1996.

10 a4!?

A highly original approach, gaining space on the queenside. The alternative is 10 ♜d2, when Black has two main moves.

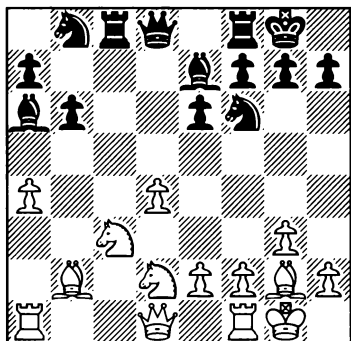
Ehlvest-Nogueiras, New Delhi 2000 went 10...b5 11 c5 (11 cxb5 cxb5 12 a3 ♜c8 13 b4 ♜b6 14 ♜b3 ♜c4 15 ♖c1 ♜d7 16 ♜a2 ♖b7 17 ♜xb5 a6 18 ♜c3 was enough for an edge in Korchnoi-Lputian, Sarajevo 1998) 11...b4 12 ♜a4 ♖b5 13 ♜e1 ♖c7 14 ♖c2 e5 15 e4!? dxe4 16 ♜xe4 exd4 17 ♖xd4 ♜fe8 18 ♜ac1 ♜ad8 19 ♜b2 and White's extra territory afforded him more room for manoeuvre and therefore the superior prospects.

10...♜c8 11 e4 dxe4 (11...c5 12 exd5 cxd4 13 dxe6 fxe6 14 ♜ce4 slightly favoured White in Tregubov-Fomichenko, Krasnodar 1999) 12 ♜cx4 (12 ♜dxe4!? b5! 13 ♜e1 bxc4 14 ♖e2 ♖a5 was pleasant for Black in Cifuentes-Gomez, Terrasa 1995) 12...♜xe4 13 ♜xe4 ♜f6 14 ♖c2 ♜xe4 15 ♖xe4 h6 16 ♜ad1 ♖f6 17 ♖e2 ♜e8 18 ♖f3 ♖b7 19 h4 ♜c7 20 ♜fe1 and White was slightly better in Kaidanov-Cifuentes, Andorra 1991.

10...dxc4

Black is not forced to take the pawn but it seems to be the best option. After 10...♜c8 11 ♜d2 ♜e8 12 e4 ♜f8 13 ♜e1 ♖b7 14 a5 bxa5 15 c5 ♖c7 16 e5 ♜d6d7 17 ♜e2 ♖a6 18 ♖c3 f5 19 h4 ♖b5 20 ♖xa5 ♖b7 21 ♜f4 ♜b8 22 ♖c2 White had the advantage in Poluliahov-Akhmadeev, St. Petersburg 1999.

11 bxc4 ♖xc4 12 ♜d2 ♖a6 13 ♖xc6 ♜c8 14 ♖g2 ♜b8!

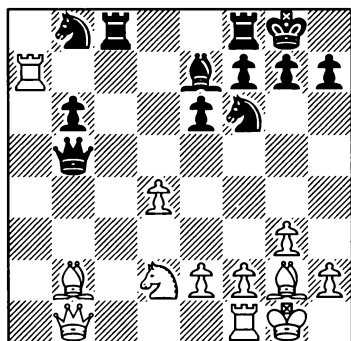


The knight is transferred to a square with a future, at the same time vacating a square for the queen – and, in turn, the king's rook. Black should not be worse here.

15 ♖b5 ♜d7 16 ♜b1!? ♙xb5?!

After this White always has the advantage of bishop versus knight. 16...♖c6!? looks like an improvement. After 17 ♖c4 ♖xd4 18 ♖e5 ♖xe2+ 19 ♖h1 ♜d2 20 ♖c6 ♙xc6!? 21 ♙xc6 ♖g4 Black has strong compensation for the exchange in the form of a direct attack on the enemy king. White is forced to play 22 ♜e4 ♜xb2 23 ♜xg4, with chances for both sides.

17 axb5 ♜xb5 18 ♙xa7



18...♜xe2?

Essentially a piece sacrifice. 18...♙d6 19 e3 ♖c6 20 ♙a2 gives White a modest but enduring advantage. The passed pawn is more a weakness than a strength.

19 ♙c1 ♖c6

Forced. After 19...♙d6 20 ♙f3 ♙xc1 21 ♙xe2 ♙xb1 22 ♙xb1 ♖c6 23 ♙a4 White is close to winning.

20 ♙xc6 ♙xc6 21 ♙xe7 ♙fc8 22 ♖b3 h5 23 ♙a7?!

White should play 23 ♙e3!? ♖d5 24 ♙a7 ♙c2 25 ♙e1 ♜d3 26 ♖a1 ♖xe3 27 ♖xc2 ♖xc2 28 ♙c1 ♙c3 29 ♙b7 with decent chances of success.

23...h4

Black needs to create some insecurity around his opponent's king, but this is not the only way. After 23...♙c2 24 ♙a3 ♖g4 25 ♜e1 (25 ♜d1 ♜xd1 26 ♙xd1 ♙xf2 27 ♙d2 ♙f3! and Black is still fighting) 25...♜xe1 26 ♙xe1 ♙xf2 27 ♙c1 ♙cc2! 28 ♙xc2 ♙xc2 there are still some drawing chances.

24 ♙f4 ♖d5 25 ♙e1 ♙g4 26 ♜d1 ♜xd1 27 ♙xd1 ♙c3 28 ♙b1 ♙d3

28...♖xf4 29 gxf4 ♙f3 30 ♙b7 ♙c6 31 ♙c1 ♙d6 also offered stubborn resistance.

29 ♙a2 ♙cc3 30 ♙ab2 h3?!

30...♖xf4 31 gxf4 ♙f3 was necessary according to Nogueiras.

31 ♖f1 ♖xf4 32 gxf4 ♙f3?

A blunder. After 32...♖h7 33 ♖e1 ♖g6 White still needs to solve some technical problems before he can write 1-0 on the scoresheet.

33 ♖c1! 1-0

Game 7 Chiburdanidze-Vaganian Biel 1994

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♙e7 5 ♙g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♖bd7 7 ♜c2 c6

This slow build-up is the main line, and the way the position should be played. However, there are two notable alternatives.

7...c5 8 cxd5 ♖xd5 9 ♖c3 ♖xc3 (9...♖b4 10 ♜b3 b6 11 ♙d1 ♖c6 12 d5! favours White, and in Adianto-Dao Thien Hai, Istanbul 2000 the subsequent continuation 12...♖a5 13 ♜c2 exd5 14 ♖xd5 ♙b7 15

♖h3 ♘b8 16 ♘f6+ ♖xf6 17 ♜xd8 ♖xd8 18 ♖f5 h6 19 b4!? cxb4 20 ♖b2 ♘bc6 21 ♜e4 ♘e7 22 ♖h7+ ♘h8 23 ♜g4 f6 24 ♖d3 ♘ac6 25 ♜e4 f5 26 ♜e6 saw Black come under heavy attack) 10 bxc3 cxd4 11 cxd4 ♘b6 12 ♖f4 ♘d5 13 ♜ac1 ♖d7 14 ♘e5 ♖b5 15 ♜b2 ♖a6 16 ♜fd1 with a healthy development lead for White in Allen-Soloveychik, Canberra 1999. There followed 16... ♜c8 17 ♜xc8 ♜xc8 18 ♜c1 ♜d8 19 ♖d2 ♖d6 20 ♘c4 ♖c7 21 e4 ♘b6 22 ♘e3, and White's stronger centre and more attractively posted pieces combined to form an advantage.

7...b6 weakens the c6-square and gives White the advantage after 8 cxd5!, when Black has two unpleasant recaptures. In the case of 8... ♘xd5 9 ♘c3 ♖b7 10 ♘d5 exd5 11 ♜d1 ♘f6 12 ♘e5 White has a slight but stable advantage. The knight would like to go to f4 and exert pressure on d5. Karpov-Spassky, Riga 1975 continued 12...c5 13 dxc5 ♖xc5 14 ♘d3 ♖d6 15 ♖f4 ♜e8 16 e3 ♘e4 17 ♖xd6 ♜xd6 18 ♘f4 ♜ac8 19 ♜a4, when White's advantage had increased.

8...exd5 9 ♜c6 ♖a6 10 ♘c3 ♜c8 (10... ♜e8?! 11 ♘e5 ♜b8 12 ♜a4 ♖b7 13 ♘d7 ♘d7 14 ♘d5 and White was a pawn up for nothing in Raetsky-Renner, Apolda 1993) 11 ♜a4 ♘b8 12 ♖h3 ♜e8 13 ♜c2! (13 ♖xc8 ♜xa4 14 ♘xa4 ♖xe2 15 ♜e1 ♖xf3 16 ♖b7 is less clear) 13... ♜d8 14 ♖f4 ♖d6 15 ♖e5 and Black will have considerable problems getting his pieces into the game.

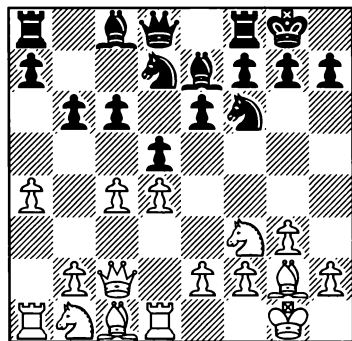
8 ♜d1 b6

Black has little chance of equalising with 8...b5. Then White has no use for the c-file, so best is 9 c5, when Rashkovsky-Farago, Sochi 1980 went 9... ♘e4 10 a4 ♖a6 11 axb5 ♖xb5 12 ♘a3 a6 13 ♘e1 f5 14 ♘d3 ♖f6 15 ♘f4 ♜e8 16 f3 ♘g5 17 h4 ♘f7 18 e4 g6 19 e5 ♖g7 20 ♖d2 ♜e7 21 ♘xb5 axb5 22 ♘d3 with an advantage for White, who had more space and access to the f4-square (which might prove problematic for Black on e6).

8... ♘e4 9 b3 f5 is an interesting idea. Of

course Black must accept the exchange of the dark-squared bishops. Ara Minasian-Lputian, Yerevan 2000 continued 10 ♖a3 ♖xa3 11 ♘xa3 f4 12 ♘b1 g5!? 13 ♘c3 g4 14 ♘h4 ♘g5 (14... ♘xf2!? 15 ♜f1 fxg3 16 hxg3 ♘h3+ 17 ♘h2 followed by e2-e4 looks promising for White) 15 e4 ♘f6 16 exd5 exd5 17 cxd5 cxd5 with chances for both sides. In this kind of position Black obviously hopes that he will achieve something on the kingside, and he has reasonable chances of doing so. White, for his part, will be looking to quickly invade the queenside.

9 a4!?



White is putting immediate pressure on the queenside. Consequently Black should now be careful how he develops.

9... ♖a6

Inferior is 9... ♖b7?! due to 10 a5!, with the threat of a5-a6. In Zagorjansky-Bonch-Osmolovsky, Moscow 1949 White emerged with the better game after 10...bxa5 11 c5 ♘e4 12 ♘bd2 f5 13 ♘b3 ♖a6 14 ♘xa5 ♖b5 15 b4 ♜e8 16 ♘e5 ♜c8 17 f3 ♘ef6 18 ♘b7.

10 b3 ♜c8!

Black needs to build up his ...c6-c5 push with some care. After 10...c5 11 ♘c3 dxc4 12 bxc4 ♖xc4 13 dxc5 ♖xc5 14 ♘e5 ♘xe5!? 15 ♜xd8 ♜axd8 16 ♖b2 there is compensation for the queen, but not much. It seems to us that White still has slightly superior long-term prospects because Black has no obvious

point of attack on which to concentrate. Note that here 11...♖c8? is too late compared with the main game as now White has 12 ♖b5! dxc4 13 bxc4 cxd4 14 ♖fxd4 and Black has the usual problems with the c6-square, e.g. 14...♖d5?! 15 ♗b3 ♖c5 16 ♗b1 ♖f6 17 ♖f4 ♗e8 18 ♖xa7 ♖d8 19 ♖ac6 and White was on his way to the full point in Pigusov-Tavadian, Irkutsk 1983.

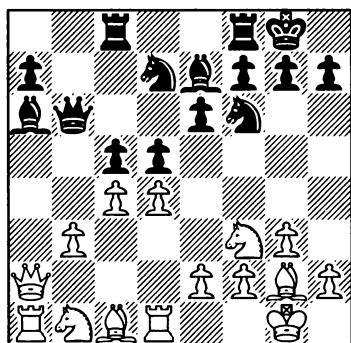
11 a5

11 ♖c3 throws a pawn away.

11...c5!

Black is finally fully prepared.

12 axb6 ♗xb6 13 ♗a2



13...♗b7

The strange looking 13...♖b8 14 ♖f4 ♖d6 was played in Korchnoi-Spraggett, Wijk aan Zee 1985. Now White could try 15 b4!? ♖xf4 16 bxc5 ♗c7 17 gxf4 ♖xc4 18 ♗d2 when the control over e5 and the weak a-pawn, together with his own protected passed pawn, secure a lead.

14 ♖a3 ♖e4

Also possible is 14...♗fe8 15 ♖bd2 cxd4 16 ♖xe7 ♗xe7 17 ♗xa7 e5, as in Tratar-Atalik, Nova Gorica 1999. Black should never get into trouble here, and Atalik earned approximate equality after 18 ♗xb6 ♖xb6 19 ♖a7 ♗cc7 20 c5!? ♗xc5 21 ♖xe5 ♖c8 22 ♖d3 ♗c3 23 ♖a4 ♖xe2 24 ♖xd4 g5 25 ♖b4 ♖e7 26 ♖f1 ♖e6 27 ♖d3 ♗c5.

15 e3 ♖f6 16 ♖b2 dxc4 17 bxc4 ♖b8 18 ♖c3

On 18 ♖bd2 Black has the interesting 18...♖xf2!?, leading to equality after 19 ♖xf2 ♖xf3 20 ♖xf3 ♗xb2 21 ♗xb2 ♖xb2 22 ♖xa7 ♖d8.

18...♖a8

18...♖xf2?? now loses to 19 ♖a4! etc.

19 ♖xe4

19 ♖ab1 might well leave White ahead, Black needing to improve on 19...♗xb2!? 20 ♗xb2! (20 ♖xb2 ♖xc3 21 ♗a1 ♖xb2 22 ♗xb2 ♖xd1 23 ♗d2 ♖xe3 24 fxe3 ♖d8 gives Black good counterplay) 20...♖xb2 21 ♖xe4 ♖c2 22 ♖xf6+ ♖xf6 23 dxc5 ♖xc4 24 ♖dc1, when the c-pawn is annoying for Black.

19...♖xe4 20 ♖c3

20 ♖e5 leads to equality – 20...♖xe5 21 dxe5 ♖xg2 22 ♖xg2 ♗b7+ 23 ♖g1 ♖b6 and the knight is no worse than the bishop.

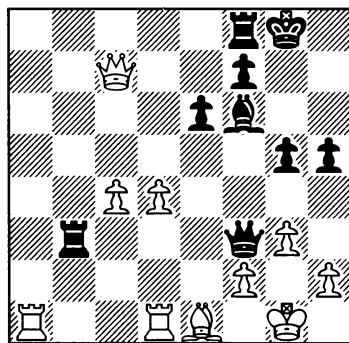
20...♗b7

Also possible is 20...cxd4!? 21 exd4 ♗c6 22 ♖e5 ♖xe5 23 ♖xe4 ♖f3+ 24 ♖xf3 ♗xf3 with equality.

21 ♗xa7

21 ♖e1 ♖xg2 22 ♖xg2 cxd4 23 exd4 ♗b3 is fine for Black.

21...♖xf3 22 ♖xf3 ♗xf3 23 ♗xd7 h5 24 ♗c7 ♖b3 25 ♖e1 cxd4 26 exd4 g5!?



Black is trying to generate something interesting.

27 ♖db1

27 ♖ab1? ♖xd4! is not what White wants. **27...♖xd4 28 ♖xb3 ♗xb3 29 ♖a5 ♖f6**

30 ♖b5 ♖d1 31 ♖a5 ♖f3 32 ♖d2 ♖a8
33 ♖xg5+!

White correctly goes for the draw before he gets mated.

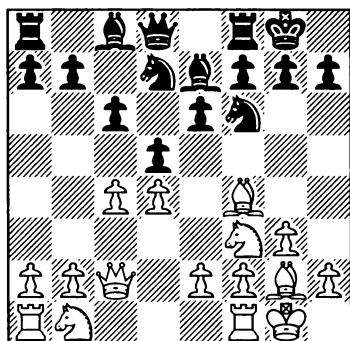
33... ♖xg5 34 ♖xg5+ ♖h7 35 ♖h6+
♖g8 36 ♖g5+ ½-½

Game 8

Kengis-M. Gurevich

Jurmala 1985

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♖e7 5
♗g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♖bd2 7 ♖c2 c6 8 ♖f4!?



This development of the bishop does not guarantee an advantage but is nonetheless a sound and practical alternative to b2-b3, which can be seen in Games 10-15.

8...b6

8...a5 9 ♖bd2 ♖h5 10 ♖e3 a4 11 ♖fd1
♖a5 12 ♖g5 f6 13 ♖e3 ♖d6 14 ♖e1 f5 15
♖df3 ♖a6 16 ♖ac1 gives White a slight edge. Khalifman-I.Sokolov, Rogatska Slatina 1991 saw this increase in value after 16... ♖xc4?! 17 ♖xc4 dxc4 18 ♖xc4 ♖b6 19 ♖cc1 a3 20 b3 ♖d5 21 ♖d2 ♖b4 22 ♖xb4 ♖xb4 23 ♖d3 ♖e7 24 ♖fe5, with a dominating position.

In the event of 8... ♖h5, little is achieved by assuming that this is a normal Stonewall and playing 9 ♖c1. Bareev-Balashov, Elista 1996 went 9...f5 (9... ♖hf6!? with a repetition is also sensible, but perhaps 10 b3 was the idea) 10 b3 g5 11 e3 g4 12 ♖e5 ♖xe5 13 dxe5 ♖g7 14 ♖c3 h5 15 ♖b2 h4 16 ♖ad1

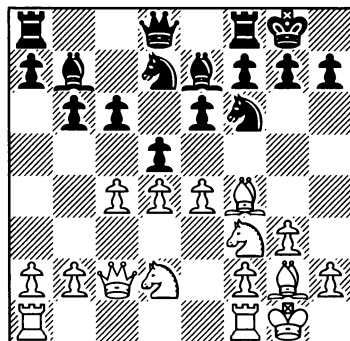
♖e8 17 f3 hxc3 18 hxc3 ♖g6 19 ♖e2 ♖d7 20 ♖f4 ♖g5 21 ♖f2 ♖f7 22 ♖h1 ♖h8 with a balanced game.

9 ♖d2! f5 10 b4 g5 11 a4 g4 12 ♖e1 ♖b6 13 ♖a3 dxc4 14 e3 e5 15 dxe5 ♖xa4!? 16 ♖xc4 is a shade preferable for White, while Black was in trouble in Kurajica-Flear, Las Palmas 1993 after 15... ♖e6?! 16 a5 ♖d5 17 ♖xc4 ♖xb4 18 ♖xb4 ♖xb4 19 ♖d3 ♖e7 20 ♖fd1 etc.

9 ♖bd2

Harmless is 9 cxd5 cxd5, e.g. 10 ♖c1 ♖b7 11 ♖c3 ♖c8 12 ♖d1 ♖e8 13 ♖c2 g5 14 ♖d2 ♖d6 15 ♖ac1 f6 16 ♖e1 f5 17 ♖d3 ♖e8 18 ♖b1 ♖xc2 19 ♖xc2 ♖b8, Andersson-Bareev, Ubeda 1997. After the second pair of rooks is exchanged Black is by no means worse.

9...♖b7 10 e4



10...♖c8

The immediate 10...c5!? is possible, e.g. 11 exd5 exd5 12 ♖fe1 ♖c8 13 ♖f5!? dxc4 14 ♖xc4 g6 15 ♖h3, which was seen in D.Gurevich-Browne, Key West 1994. Now Black should have played 15...cxd4 16 ♖d6 ♖xd6 17 ♖xd6 ♖e8 18 ♖xd4 ♖xg2 19 ♖xg2 ♖c5 with equality (Browne).

11 ♖ad1

White also achieves very little from closing the position. After 11 e5 ♖e8 12 h4 h6 13 cxd5 cxd5 14 ♖d3 ♖c7 15 ♖e3 ♖a6 16 ♖fb1 ♖c2!? 17 ♖e1 ♖f5 18 ♖df3 ♖c7 19 ♖c1 ♖fd8 20 ♖c2 ♖e8 21 ♖ac1 ♖f8 the position was complicated but no worse for

Black in Stohl-San Segundo, Moscow 1994.

11...c5 12 exd5 exd5 13 ♖b1

13 ♜fe1 ♜e8 14 ♜f5 g6 15 ♜h3 dxc4 16 ♜xc4 cxd4 also gives Black a good game, particularly after 17 ♜ce5?! ♜xe5 18 ♜xe5 d3 19 ♜h6 ♜c5 20 h3 ♜xf3 21 ♜xf3 ♜xe5! 22 ♜xe5 ♜d4 as in Kaidanov-Vaganian, Armenia 1994, when Black had a strong attack on the dark squares as well as a dangerous passed pawn. All in all this is way too much for an exchange.

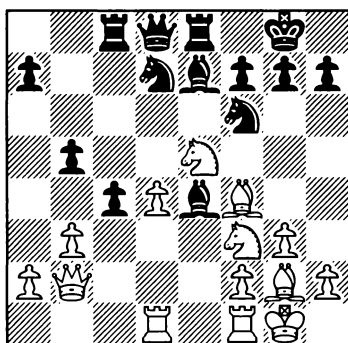
13...♜e8

Also fine is 13...dxc4 14 ♜xc4 ♜e4 15 ♜a1 cxd4 16 ♜d6 ♜xd6 17 ♜xd6 ♜e8 18 ♜xd4 with roughly even chances (Kengis).

14 b3 dxc4 15 ♜xc4 ♜e4 16 ♜b2 b5

16...♜d5 17 ♜d6 ♜f6, with unclear play, is a sound alternative.

17 ♜ce5 c4



An alternative is 17...♜b6!? 18 ♜fe1 ♜b7 19 ♜h4 ♜xg2 20 ♜xg2 ♜xe5 21 ♜xe5 cxd4 22 ♜xd4 with a draw.

18 ♜xf7!

White enters the spirit of wild tactics. After 18 bxc4 bxc4 19 ♜xf7 Black has the attractive alternative 19...♜b6! 20 ♜xb6 axb6 21 ♜d6 ♜xd6 22 ♜xd6 c3 etc.

18...c3 19 ♜e2 ♜b6

19...♜xf3?? 20 ♜e6! and White wins due to the threat of ♜h6+ and smothered mate.

20 ♜7e5 ♜a3 21 ♜h3 ♜a8

21...c2!? 22 ♜xd7 cxd1♜ 23 ♜xd1 ♜xf3 24 ♜xf3 ♜xd7 25 ♜xd7 ♜c6 26 ♜xc6 ♜xc6

27 d5 ♜c2 28 d6 with unclear play was an interesting idea. But Black is happy with the half point.

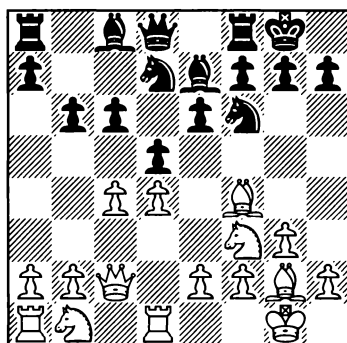
22 ♜c2 ♜e4 23 ♜e2 ½-½

Game 9

Dautov-Tiviakov

Venlo 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 ♜e7 5 ♜g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♜bd7 7 ♜c2 c6 8 ♜f4 b6 9 ♜d1



9...♜b7

Here this is sounder than 9...♜a6, as now White would have different options:

10 b3 ♜c8 11 ♜c3 dxc4 12 ♜d2 b5!? 13 bxc4 bxc4 14 ♜a4 ♜b5 15 ♜xb5 cxb5 16 ♜xb5 ♜b6 17 ♜xb6 ♜xb6 presented Black with interesting counterplay in Delchev-Beliavsky, Moscow 2001.

10 ♜e5! uses the posting of the bishop on f4 creatively. After 10...♜c8 11 ♜c3 Black has tried a couple of moves. 11...♜b7 12 b3 ♜a8 13 e4 h6 14 ♜xd7 ♜xd7 15 e5 ♜e8 16 ♜f1 ♜c7 17 a4 ♜b7 18 ♜e2 favoured White in Burmakin-Graf, Ohrid 2001. It is not clear where Black will find genuine counterplay; a lack of breathing space is a problem.

Wojtkiewicz-Zubarev, Moscow 2002 went 11...♜xc4 12 ♜xc4 dxc4 13 ♜e4 h5 14 ♜d6 ♜xd6 15 ♜xd6 ♜d8 16 a4 with an advantage for White. The two bishops are clearly stronger than the knights.

10 ♖c3 dxc4

Also possible is 10...♞c8. Then after 11 ♖e5 ♖h5 12 ♟d2 ♖hf6 13 e4 c5 Black has good counterplay. In Fridman-Yusupov, Essen 2002 a draw was agreed after 14 exd5 cxd4 15 ♖c6 ♟xc6 16 dxc6 ♖e5 17 ♖b5 ♖xc6 18 ♟f4 ♞d7 19 ♞ac1 ♟c5 20 ♟xc6 ♞xc6 21 ♟e5 ♞e7 22 ♟xd4.

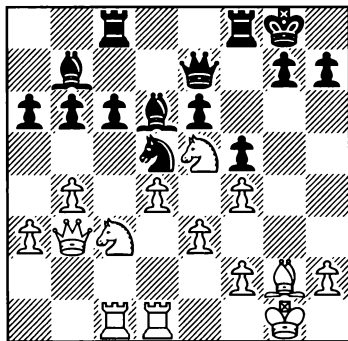
Now the strongest approach appears to be the slow 11 b3, e.g. 11...♖h5 12 ♟c1 f5 13 ♟b2 ♟d6 14 e3 ♖hf6 15 ♖e2 ♖e4 16 ♖f4 ♞e7 17 ♖e5! ♖xe5 18 dxe5 ♟b8 19 a4 with a pleasant game for White in Marin-Pogorelov, Andorra 1994.

11 ♖d2 ♖h5 12 ♖xc4 ♖xf4 13 gxf4 ♞c7 14 e3 ♞ac8 15 ♞ab1

In Lautier-Tiviakov, Mondariz 2000 White played 15 ♞ac1 ♖f6 16 a3 ♖d5 17 ♖e5 ♟d6 18 ♞a4 ♖xc3 19 ♞xc3 ♟xe5 20 fxe5 f6 21 f4 ♟a8 22 b4 ♞f7 23 ♞c2 ♞h5 24 ♞d2 fxe5 25 dxe5 and achieved lasting pressure.

15...♖f6 16 b4 ♖d5 17 a3 f5!?

17...♖xc3 18 ♞xc3 c5 19 dxc5 ♟xg2 20 ♟xg2 bxc5 21 b5 gives White a long lasting advantage due to the strong knight and the potential passed pawn, which will soon come to b6.

18 ♖e5 ♟d6 19 ♞bc1 ♞e7 20 ♞a4 a6 21 ♞b3**21...g5!**

Black needs to create counterplay, otherwise White will have all the fun.

22 fxg5

22 ♖xd5 cxd5 23 ♞d3 g4 with equality.

22...♟xe5 23 dxe5 ♞xg5 24 ♟h1 ♟h8 25 f4 ♞h5 26 ♖xd5 cxd5 27 ♞b2 ♞g8

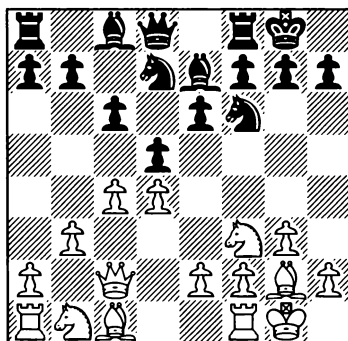
Black might solve his problems both easier and quicker with 27...b5!? 28 ♞f2 ♞c4, when White has to search for an advantage.

28 ♞g1 ♞xc1 29 ♞xc1 ♞c8 30 ♞xc8+ ♟xc8 31 h3

31 ♞d4 ♞e2 32 h3 ♞b5 33 a4 ♞c6 and Black maintains equality.

31...♞e8 32 ♞c2 ♞d7 33 ♞f2 ♞d8 34 ♟h2 ♟d7 35 ♟f3 a5 36 ♞e1 ♟g8 37 ♟h5 ♟f8 38 ♟f3 ♟e8 39 bxa5 bxa5 40 ♞c3 ½-½

Game 10
Kozul-Lputian
Lucerne 1997

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♟e7 5 ♟g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♖bd7 7 ♞c2 c6 8 b3

The main system in the Closed Catalan. White is in no hurry and slowly builds up his forces.

8...b6

The same goes for Black – the queen's bishop needs to find a route into the game. However, there are interesting alternatives.

8...♖e4 9 ♞d1 (9 ♖fd2 ♖xd2 10 ♖xd2 f5 11 ♟b2 ♞e8 12 ♖f3 ♞h5 13 ♞c1 ♖f6 14 ♟a3 gave White a slight plus in Paunovic-Piankov, Burgos 2001) 9...b6 10 ♖e1 ♖d6 11 ♖d2 ♟b7 12 ♟b2 ♞c8 13 ♖d3 c5 14

dx5 bxc5 15 cxd5 exd5 16 ♖f4 ♖f6 17 ♖ac1 d4 18 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 19 ♖c4 ♖d5 20 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 21 e3 ♖f6 22 e4 ♖e6 23 f4 and White had the better game in Poluliahov-Telnov, Tomsk 2001.

8...b5 9 c5! (opening the c-file makes little sense with the queen on c2) 9...♗e4 (this seems to be too time consuming) 10 ♖b2 a5 11 ♗e5 ♗xe5 12 ♖xe4 f5 (12...dxe4 13 dxe5 e3? 14 fxe3 is perhaps a slight advantage for White; the knight has a freer game than the bishop on c8) 13 ♖g2 ♗g4 14 ♖d2 f4 15 h3 ♖h6 16 ♖f3 f3g3 17 f3g3 ♖f5 18 ♗e5! and White is better. V.Mikhalevsky-Rechlis, Israel 1999 saw White continue with the weaker 15 ♖ae1?, when 15...f3g3 16 h3g3 ♖e8 17 ♖f3 ♖h5 18 ♖xg4 ♖xg4 19 ♖f3 ♖h3 20 ♗e5 ♖f5 21 g4 ♖xe5 22 dxe5 ♖xg4+ led to a draw. Instead of 9...♗e4 the encounter A.Petrosian-Bischoff, Germany 1999 went 9...a5 10 ♖bd2 b4 11 e4 ♖a6 12 ♖e1 ♗e8 13 e5 ♖c7 14 h4 and White had the superior prospects. There followed 14...♖b5 15 ♖b2 ♖e8 16 ♖f1 ♖b8 17 ♗e3 ♖a7 18 ♗g5 ♖f8 19 f4 ♖c8 20 ♖f1 h6 21 ♖f3 ♖d7 22 f5 with a menacing attack.

9 ♖b2

9 ♖c3 is premature in view of 9...♖a6, when the c-pawn is genuinely hanging. After 10 ♖d2 b5 11 ♖d1 ♖b8 12 e3 bxc4 13 bxc4 ♖a5 14 ♖b3 ♖c7 15 c5 e5 16 e4 dxe4 17 ♖xe4 ♖d5 18 dxe5 ♗xe5 19 ♖b2 ♖fe8 20 ♖d4 ♖f8 Black had solved his opening problems in Bernard-Sosonko, France 1999.

9...♖a6

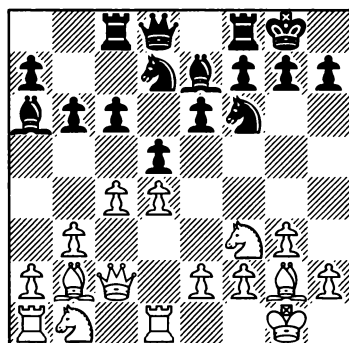
Black needs to place the bishop on a6 if he wants to see ♖fd1. After 9...♖b7 10 ♖c3 ♖c8 White has two attractive alternatives to the standard 11 ♖fd1.

11 ♖ad1 ♖c7 12 e4 ♗xe4 13 ♗xe4 dxe4 14 ♖xe4 c5 15 d5 ♖f6 (15...♖f6 16 ♖c2 exd5 17 ♖e5! ♖d8 18 ♗g5 g6 19 h4 gave White a strong attack in Geller-Ciric, Oberhausen 1961) 16 ♖c2 exd5 17 cxd5 and now Hausner-Kotan, Prague 2000 went 17...♖d6 18 ♖c1 b5 19 ♖f4 ♖b6 20 ♖fe1 ♖ce8 21 d6

♖xe1+ 22 ♖xe1 h6 23 h4 ♖d8 24 h5 with an advantage to White thanks to the d-pawn and the better king. Black's lot was much worse in Smejkal-Padevski, Smederevska Palanka 1971, when 17...♖xb2 soon got him into trouble: 18 ♖xb2 ♖cd8 19 d6 ♖b8 20 ♖h4! g6? 21 ♖fe1 f6 22 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 23 ♖e7 ♖c6 24 ♖e2 ♗e5 25 ♖c7! ♖a8 26 f4 ♖f7 27 ♖e7 1-0.

Vokac-Hrtanek, Karvina 2001 saw White play the immediate 11 e4 dxe4 12 ♗xe4. Then 12...c5 13 ♖xf6+ ♖xf6 14 ♗g5 ♖xg5 15 ♖xb7 ♖c7 16 ♖e4! g6 17 d5 exd5 18 cxd5 ♖f6 19 d6! is a good illustration of the kind of problems Black can quickly run into, Black avoiding trouble with 12...♗xe4 13 ♖xe4 ♖f6 14 ♖c2 c5 15 dxc5 ♖e4 (15...♖xc5?? 16 ♗g5! and Black can resign) 16 ♖c3 ♖xc5 17 ♖fe1 ♖a8 18 ♗e5 ♖xg2 19 ♖xg2 ♖e7 20 ♖f3 when White had a slight plus. Again it is the c6-square that is Black's main problem here.

10 ♖d1 ♖c8



11 ♖c3?!

The stronger 11 ♖bd2 leads to play along the lines of Game 14.

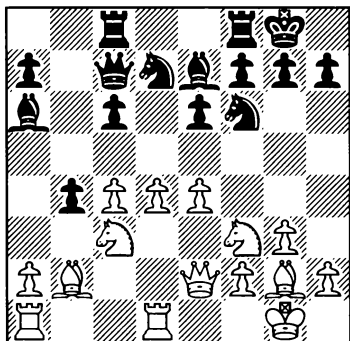
11...♖c7

An alternative is 11...dxc4! 12 ♗e5 cxb3 13 axb3 ♖b8, when Lputian prefers Black. Perhaps this is a bit optimistic, but Black is clearly okay.

12 e4

It might be time for 12 cxd5 cxd5 13 ♖ac1

♖b8 with complete equality.
12...dxc4 13 ♖e2 b5 14 bxc4 b4!



White clearly has some problems here.
15 ♖b1?!

Necessary is 15 ♖a4 when, after 15... ♖a5 16 a3! b3 17 ♖c3 ♖fd8, it is difficult to say who is better and why.

15...♖b6 16 ♖bd2 ♖a4 17 ♖ab1 c5!

White's centre collapses. Black's control over the dark squares affords him the lead.

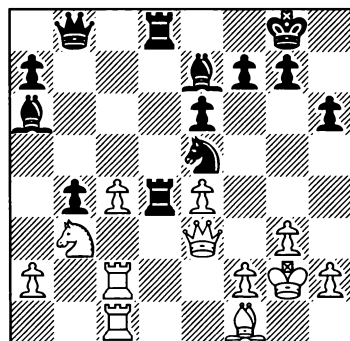
18 ♖dc1 ♖fd8 19 dxc5 ♖xb2

19... ♖d7 20 ♖a1 ♖dxc5 favours Black.

20 ♖xb2 ♖xc5 21 ♖bc2 ♖d7 22 ♖b3 ♖c7 23 ♖fd4 ♖e5 24 ♖f1 ♖d7 25 ♖b5 ♖b8 26 ♖e3 ♖cd8 27 ♖g2 h6

27... ♖xc4!? 28 ♖xc4 ♖xb5 29 ♖xb5 ♖xb5 30 ♖c7 a6 is stronger, when White has very little compensation for the pawn.

28 ♖5d4 ♖xd4!



Black completely annihilates the enemy's

defence of the light squares.

29 ♖xd4 ♖c5 30 ♖d1 ♖d6

The accurate move. After 30... ♖b6 White has 31 ♖xe6!!, escaping with a draw (31 ♖cd2?! ♖xc4 leaves White in big trouble), e.g. 31... ♖xe3 (31... ♖xd1 32 ♖xc5 is far from clear) 32 ♖xd8+ ♖h7 33 ♖f8+ ♖g8 34 ♖e6+! with a draw by repetition.

31 ♖cd2 ♖b6 32 f4 ♖xc4 33 ♖xc4 ♖xc4

Black has definite compensation for the exchange, with two strong bishops against a poorly placed rook and a pinned knight.

34 ♖h3 a5 35 e5 ♖a6 36 ♖e4 ♖b7 37 ♖e3 a4 38 f5?!

White is getting desperate. A better try is 38 g4!? a3 39 f5 with counterplay.

38...exf5 39 e6 ♖e4 40 exf7+ ♖xf7 41 ♖e2 g5!

White's king is in much more trouble than its opposite number.

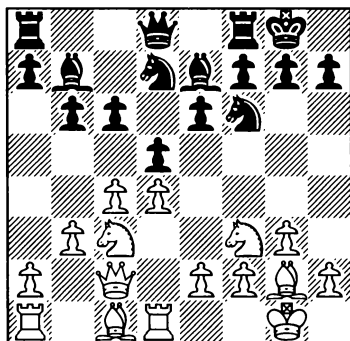
42 g4 ♖xd4 43 ♖c4+ ♖d5 44 ♖xd4 fxg4+ 0-1

Game 11

Beliaevsky-Mitkov

Panormo 2001

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♖e7 5 ♖g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♖bd7 7 ♖c2 c6 8 b3 b6 9 ♖d1 ♖b7 10 ♖c3



10...♖c8

Also possible is 10...c5!?, e.g. 11 cxd5 exd5

12 dxc5 ♖xc5 13 ♖b2 ♜c8 14 e3 ♜e8 15 ♜f5 ♜e7 16 ♜ac1 ♞f8 17 ♞d4 g6 18 ♜g5 ♖xd4 19 exd4 ♜g7 20 ♖f1 h6 21 ♜d2 ♞h7 and Black was no worse in Salov-Bauer, Enghiens-les-Bains 1999.

11 e4 dxe4

Following up ...♖b7 with 11...♖a6 looks illogical, and after 12 ♖f4 dxc4 13 ♞d2 c5 14 d5 White is able to generate an initiative. Korchnoi-M.Gurevich, Antwerp 1995 continued 14...e5 15 ♖g5, when Korchnoi gives 15...♞xd5 16 ♞xd5 ♖xg5 17 ♞f3! ♖b5 18 ♖h3 ♖c6 19 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 20 ♞xe5 ♖e6 21 ♞xc4 as a shade preferable for White. In Odendahl-Tiviakov, Dieren 2001 Black elected to capture on d5, but 14...exd5 15 e5 caused problems: 15...d4 (15...♞g4 16 ♞xd5 ♞gxe5 17 ♞xc4 ♖xc4 18 bxc4 gives White good control over the light squares and ample compensation) 16 exf6 ♖xf6 17 ♞ce4 c3 18 ♞c4 ♖e7 19 ♞xc3! g5 (19...dxc3? 20 ♖h3 ♖b5 21 ♞e5 and White wins) 20 ♜f5! gxf4 21 ♞d5 ♜e8 22 ♖e4 and Black was under pressure.

11...c5 12 exd5 exd5 13 ♖b2 dxc4 14 d5! gives White the advantage. The point is that 14...cxb3 15 axb3 ♖d6 opens the way for 16 ♜xa7. Sulava-Ferretti, Verona 1998 went 14...♖d6 15 bxc4 ♞e5 16 ♞e4 ♜e8 17 ♞xd6 ♞xf3+ 18 ♖xf3 ♜xd6 19 ♜d3 ♜cd8 20 a4 ♜f8 21 a5 ♜d6 22 axb6 axb6 23 ♖e1 ♜xe1+ 24 ♜xe1, although White had all the chances.

12 ♞g5

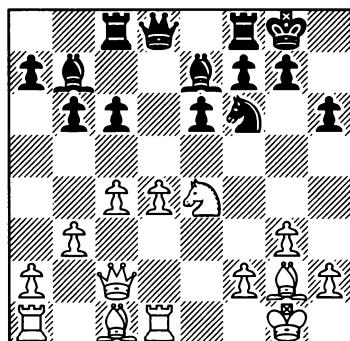
White wants to establish a knight on e4. Another possibility is 12 ♞xe4, when 12...♞xe4 13 ♜xe4 ♜c7 14 ♖f4 ♖d6 15 ♖xd6 ♜xd6 16 c5! ♜c7 17 ♜ac1 ♜fd8 18 ♜e1 ♖a6 19 a4 ♜b8 20 b4 bxc5 21 dxc5 ♞f6 22 ♜e5 ♜xd1+ 23 ♜xd1 ♜c8 24 ♞d4 was very nice for White Jo.Horvath-Krizsany, Paks 1996. A year later Black improved in Cvitan-Borgo, Porto San Giorgio 1997, 12...c5 13 ♞xf6+ ♖xf6 14 ♞g5 ♖xg5 15 ♖xb7 ♜c7 16 dxc5 ♖xc1 17 ♜axc1 bxc5 18 ♖g2 ♜e7 19 ♜d2 ♞f6 20 ♜cd1 g6 21 ♜c3 h5 22 h3 ♜fc8 23 f4 ♜d7 24 ♜xd7

♞xd7 25 ♖f3 providing White with a modest lead. In this position Black has problems getting the knight to d4, which is the only good square available. Nevertheless Black should be able to hold with accurate play.

12...h6

12...c5 13 dxc5 ♖xc5 14 ♞gxe4 ♞xe4 15 ♞xe4 favours White.

13 ♞gxe4 ♞xe4 14 ♞xe4 ♞f6



15 c5!

A thematic solution. The d5-square is not so important. Instead White has control over d6 and Black's queenside is under a bind. Less troubling for Black is 15 ♖e3 ♜c7 16 ♜d2 ♜d7 17 ♞xf6+ ♖xf6 18 ♜ad1 ♜e7 19 c5 ♜fd8 20 a4 e5 21 dxe5 ♜xd2 22 ♜xd2 ♜xe5 23 h4 ♜xd2 24 ♜xd2 bxc5 25 ♜a5, Sulava-Inkirov, Nice 2001, with the smallest of edges for White – if anything.

15...♞d5

15...♞xe4 16 ♖xe4 bxc5 17 dxc5 ♜c7 18 ♖b2 ♜cd8 19 a3 gives White a slight but enduring advantage in view of the c6-pawn and, in turn, the bishop on b7.

16 a3 a5 17 ♖f1 ♜c7 18 ♖d2 ♜fd8 19 b4 axb4 20 ♖xb4 ♜a8?!

20...♞xb4!? is necessary, when 21 axb4 ♜a8 limits White's lead.

21 cxb6!

Now White occupies the c5-square and starts pushing his a-pawn – a perfect reward for his game-plan.

21...♖xb6 22 ♖xe7 ♞xe7 23 ♞c5 ♖c8

24 a4

White is close to being strategically winning.

24... ♖a5

24... ♖d5 25 ♖db1 ♗c7 26 ♖b3 ♖a6 27 ♖xa6 ♖xa6 28 ♖c5 ♖a7 29 a5! and the a-pawn makes progress. The main point is that 29... ♖xa5 30 ♖xa5 ♗xa5 31 ♖b7 ♗c7 32 ♖xd8 ♗xd8 33 ♗xc6 is decisive.

25 ♖b3 ♖ad5 26 a5 ♗a7 27 a6 ♖d7 28 ♖c4

As we can see, Black should still have tried to get rid of the bishops.

28... ♖d6 29 ♖c5 ♖c8 30 ♗b2 ♖d5

Belavsky gives 30... ♖f5 31 ♖b7! ♖xb7 32 axb7 ♗b8 33 ♖a8 and White wins.

31 ♖db1!

This time White should refrain from 31 ♖b7? as 31... ♖xb7 32 axb7 ♗b6 33 ♖db1 ♗xb2 34 ♖xb2 ♖b8 is less clear.

31... ♖c7 32 ♗b8!

The blockade of the pawn is removed, and with it the last line of defence.

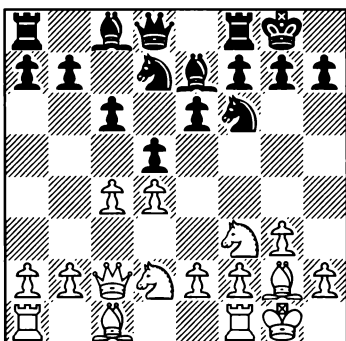
32... ♗xb8 33 ♖xb8 ♖xd4 34 a7 ♖xc4 35 ♖a6! ♖xa6 36 ♖xa6 ♖c1+ 37 ♖g2 1-0

Game 12

Comas Fabrego-Nogueiras

Havana 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♖e7 5 ♖g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♖bd7 7 ♗c2 c6 8 ♖bd2



In this game White elects to execute a

quick central expansion with e2-e4 while simultaneously monitoring the c4-pawn.

8...b6

8...b5 9 c5 should be to White's advantage, this version being even better than with 8 b3, which is quite useless here. Black has tried a couple of responses.

9... ♗c7 10 ♖b3 e5?! 11 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 12 ♖f4 ♖fg4 13 e4! dxe4 14 ♖xe4 f6 (14...f5 15 ♖g2 ♖f6 16 ♖ae1 is nice for White) 15 dxe5 fxe5 16 ♖xh7+ ♖h8 17 ♖d2 ♖e6 was the course of Botvinnik-I.Rabinovich, Leningrad 1938, when 18 f3 ♖f6 19 ♖f5 ♖c4 20 ♖d3 ♖e6 21 ♖a5 would have gained White a free pawn.

In the event of 9...a5 10 e4 Black should play 10...dxe4 rather than drop back to e8. For example in Damljanovic-Semkov, Saint John 1988 Black was too cramped after 10... ♖e8 11 e5, creating breathing space with 11...f6 12 exf6 gxf6 13 ♖e1 ♖g7 failing to improve his chances: 14 a4 b4 15 ♖b3 ♖e8 16 ♖h6 ♖f8 17 ♖h4 ♗d7 18 ♖e3 ♖d8 19 ♖ae1 ♗f7 20 ♖xg7 ♗xg7 21 f4 ♖d7 22 ♖h3 and White was doing very well. Returning to 10...dxe4, Gulko-Campora, Biel 1987 continued 11 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 12 ♗xe4 ♖a6 13 ♖e1 ♖e8 14 h4 ♖f6 15 ♗c2 ♖d5 16 a4 b4 17 ♖e5 ♗c7?! 18 ♖e4 g6 19 h5 ♖f6 20 hxg6 hxg6 21 ♖xg6! fxg6 22 ♗xg6+ ♖f8 23 ♖e4 ♖e7?! (23... ♖xe5 was the last try) 24 ♖g5 ♖f8 25 ♖f4! and White won. Gulko gives 17... ♖f6 as the improvement in an anyway difficult position. He believes that after 18 ♖f1 ♖xe5 19 ♖xe5 White has a small but enduring advantage. It is often the case in the Catalan that the enduring nature of White's positive stock is the more significant factor from a practical point of view.

9 e4 ♖b7

This seems wrong here. After 9... ♖a6 10 e5 ♖e8 11 ♖e1 ♖c8 12 ♖f1 ♖c7 13 b3 dxc4 14 ♖xc4 ♖d5 15 ♗e4! White was better in Cifuentes-Flear, Polanica Zdroj 1992, which continued 15...b5 16 ♖e3 ♖e8 17 h4 ♖f8 18 ♖xd5! cxd5 19 ♗g4 ♖c6 20 h5 f5 21 exf6

12 xf6 22 d2 d6 23 a3 d7 24 d3 and Black's future was getting darker thanks to the lack of play and White's presence in the centre and prospects of a kingside offensive.

9... dxe4 10 dxe4 b7 is solid but passive. Black needs to pay special attention to the possibility of the clamping c4-c5 , as in the previous main game. Raetsky-Whiteley, Capelle la Grande 1997 went 11 d1 dxe4 12 xe4 f6 13 c2 c8 14 f4 d6 15 xd6 xd6 16 c5 c7 17 ac1 fd8 18 e5 d7 19 cxb6 xb6 20 d4 c7 21 a4 and White was on top. In Krasenkow-Azmaiparashvili, Groningen 1997 White must have been in the driving seat after 11... c8 12 xf6+ xf6 13 c5 , but the subsequent 13... d5 14 g5 f6 15 d2 bxc5 16 dxc5 e5 17 b4 a5 18 bxa5 d8 19 d4 f5 20 d3 f6 21 ab1 e4 22 d5 a6 23 b6! ? was unclear...

10 e5 e8 11 b3

11 cxd5 is an alternative. Then 11... cxd5 is a somewhat passive option – where is the knight going from e8 ? Sargissian-Rivas, Ubeda 2001 continued 12 e1 c8 13 a4 a5 14 f1 a6 15 h4 d3 16 g5 h6 17 xe7 xe7 18 ac1 d7 19 e3 b5 20 d1 a6 21 ec3 xc3 22 xc3 db8 23 g4 g6 24 d2 g7 25 f4 and White had more territory, chances to break through on the kingside and control of the only open file. Black does better to follow the example set in Buhmann-Vaganian, Germany 2000, when 11... exd5 ? 12 e1 d7 13 f1 d6 14 d3 g6 15 h4 c5 generated sufficient counterplay, 16 d4 cxd4 17 h6 e8 18 d2 dxc5 19 xd4 d7 20 dxe6 dxe6 resulting in a double-edged game.

11... d7

After 11... c8 12 b2 c5 13 ac1 cxd4 14 xd4 Black was struggling in Hertneck-Stangl, Austria 1997. There followed 14... c7 15 fe1 b8 16 b1 d7 17 a3 a8 18 b4 dxc4 19 xb7 xb7 20 dxc4 d5 21 d3 fd8 22 b5 and White dominated proceedings.

12 b2 c5 13 fe1 b8 14 dxc5 xc5

14... xc5 15 d5 g6 16 ac1 favours White. Black has no active plan and ... dxc4 exposes both d6 and f6 to the white knights.

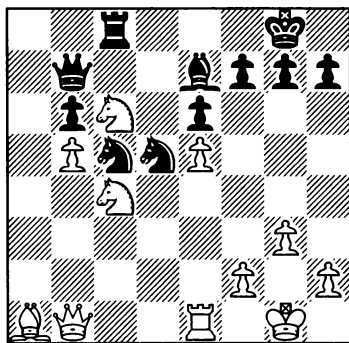
15 d4 a5! ?

Perhaps 15... dxc4! ? makes life easier for Black, e.g. 16 d6 e8 17 dxe7+ xe7 18 xb7 xb7 19 dxc4 and Black stands no worse.

16 a3 c8 17 b4 axb4 18 axb4 d7 19 b5 xa1 20 xa1 d5

Also possible is 20... c5 21 b3 dxc4 22 dxc4 gxg2 23 gxg2 d5 24 d6 when the knights are of equal worth. Black will probably play ... d7-b8 very soon in order to address White's outpost.

21 b1 dxc4 22 xb7 xb7 23 dxc4 d5 24 d6



24... a8 25 c2 f8 26 d4

White would be worse after 26 d6? ! xd6 27 exd6 d7 28 e5 f6 29 d4 xd6 because the bishop is not very effective and the knight on c6 is basically out of play.

26... d7 27 a1 xa1+ 28 xa1 c5 $\frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{2}$

Game 13

Raetsky-Landenbergue

Scul 2001

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 f3 f6 4 g3 e7 5 g2 0-0 6 0-0 bd7 7 c2 c6 8 bd2

b6 9 b3 ♖b7 10 e4

White needs to get going. After 10 ♖b2 c5 11 ♖ac1 ♖c8 12 ♖b1 dxc4 13 ♖xc4 cxd4 14 ♖xd4 ♖xg2 15 ♖xg2 a6 16 ♖e3 ♖xc1 17 ♖xc1 ♖a8+ 18 f3 ♖c8 Black had solved all his problems in Chiburdanidze-P.Nicolic, Linares 1988.

10... ♖c8 11 ♖b2 ♖c7

11...dxe4 12 ♖xe4 transposes to 8 b3 b6 9 ♖b2 ♖b7 10 ♖c3 ♖c8 11 e4 dxe4 12 ♖xe4, covered in Game 10, note to Black's 9th move.

11...c5 12 exd5 exd5 13 dxc5 dxc4 14 b4!? was the interesting course of Lindgren-Rasmussen, Budapest 2000, when Black went astray with 14...♖a6?! 15 c6! c3 (15...♖xc6 16 ♖d4 ♖c7 17 b5! is the problem) 16 ♖xc3 ♖b8 17 ♖d4! ♖xf1 18 ♖xf1 and White had more than enough compensation for the exchange – 18...♖e8 19 ♖e3 ♖a6? 20 ♖d1! ♖xb4 21 ♖c4 b5 22 ♖xb5 ♖b6 23 ♖xf6 gxf6 24 ♖d5 proved decisive. Black should play 14...bxc5 15 b5 ♖c7 16 ♖xc4, although White has a very pleasant structural advantage. The alternative 13...♖xc5 14 ♖g5 g6 15 ♖c3!? h6 16 ♖h3 seems to help White. Indeed in Wilhelmi-Lau, Germany 2000 White emerged from 13...♖xc5 14 ♖ad1 ♖e8 15 ♖f5 ♖c7 16 ♖d4 a6 17 cxd5 g6 18 ♖b1 ♖xd5 19 ♖e4 ♖f8 20 ♖fe1 b5 21 a3 b4 22 ♖c1 with the better game.

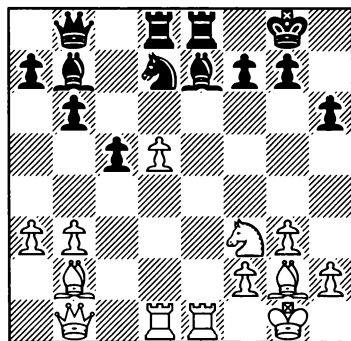
Instead of the trade on c5 White has an interesting idea in 13 ♖fd1 dxc4 14 ♖xc4 b5 15 d5!?, when Wojtkiewicz-Shabalov, USA 2000 continued with multiple exchanges: 15...♖xd5 16 ♖ce5 ♖7f6 17 ♖g5 h6 18 ♖exf7 ♖xf7 19 ♖xf7 ♖xf7 20 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 21 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 22 ♖d1 ♖d4 23 ♖f5+ ♖g8 24 ♖xd5+ and a draw was agreed as White had failed to prove an advantage.

12 ♖ad1 ♖fd8 13 ♖fe1 ♖b8 14 ♖b1

An interesting alternative was the ambitious 14 h4 h6 15 e5 ♖e8 16 c5!? bxc5 17 ♖a3 ♖c7 18 dxc5 a5 19 g4 ♖a7 20 g5 ♖b5 21 ♖b2 ♖xc5 22 ♖d3 ♖a6 23 gxh6 ♖c7 24 ♖b1 gxh6 25 ♖d4 where White has com-

pensation for the pawn through his active play, Vaulin-Dobrovolsky, Harkany, 1994.

14...h6 15 a3 dxe4 16 ♖xe4 c5 17 d5!? exd5 18 ♖c3!? ♖e8 19 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 20 cxd5 ♖cd8

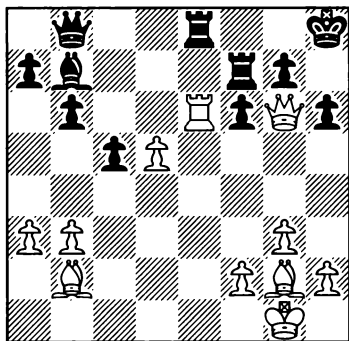
**21 ♖xe7!?**

Entertaining stuff. The idea is to enhance the power of the dark-squared bishop. With 21 ♖f5 ♖f6 22 ♖xe8+ ♖xe8 23 ♖c1 White guarantees a modest plus.

21... ♖xe7 22 ♖h4 ♖e2!

Black has to be very careful here. The following variations help demonstrate what lurks in the shadows. 22...♖ee8?! 23 ♖f5 f6 (23...♖e5 24 f4 looks dangerous) 24 ♖xh6+! gxh6 25 ♖g6+ ♖f8 (25...♖h8 26 ♖xh6+ ♖g8 27 ♖g6+ ♖h8 28 ♖h3! ♖d6 29 ♖xd7 and White wins) 26 d6! ♖xg2 27 ♖c1! and Black is savagely mated.

22...f6!? is preferable, when 23 ♖f5 ♖f7 offers Black solid defensive prospects on the kingside. An interesting approach is 24 ♖e4!? ♖f8 25 ♖g4 ♖h7 26 ♖h5 ♖c7 27 ♖e4 with a strong attack, while there is also 24 ♖e1, e.g. 24...♖f8 25 ♖e7+ ♖h8 (25...♖xe7? loses instantly to 26 ♖xe7 ♖xd5 27 ♖xf6! gxf6 28 ♖f5 and Black is soon mated) 26 ♖g6+ ♖xg6 (after 26...♖g8 White is not obliged to go for the repetition) 27 ♖xg6 ♖e8 (27...♖g8 28 ♖e4 looks dangerous, although after 28...♖f8 29 ♖h7 ♖e7 30 ♖xf6 gxf6 31 ♖h8+ ♖f7 32 ♖h7+ White has only a draw) 28 ♖e6!?

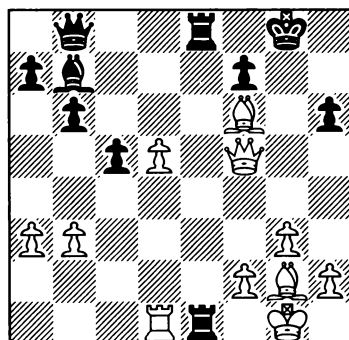


28...♖f7?? loses to 29 ♖e4 ♗g8 30 ♖xf6 in view of 30...♖xe4 31 ♖f8+ ♗xf8 32 ♗xg7 mate, which leaves 28...♖xe6 (28...♖ce7!?) 29 dxe6 ♖e7 30 ♖xf6! ♗d6! (30...gxf6? 31 ♗xf6+ ♗g7 32 e7 and White wins) 31 ♖xb7 (31 ♖xe7?? ♗d1+ 32 ♖f1 ♗f3 and suddenly it is Black who wins) 31...♖xb7 32 e7 ♗d1+ 33 ♗g2 ♗d5+ 34 f3 ♗d2+ 35 ♗h3 ♖xe7 36 ♖xe7 ♗d7+ with a drawn ending.

23 ♖f5 ♖f6?

This allows a combination that is not too difficult to find. Consequently Black should play 23...♖xb2 24 ♗xb2 ♗e5 25 ♗xe5 ♖xe5 26 ♖e1 or 23...♖e5! 24 f4 ♖xg2+! 25 ♗xg2 ♖g6 26 ♗e4! (26 ♖xg7? ♖xd5 27 ♖xd5 ♗d8! and Black wins) 26...♗a8 27 ♖e3, in both cases with a slight edge for White.

24 ♖xh6+! gxh6 25 ♖xf6 ♖de8 26 ♗f5 ♖e1+



27 ♖f1!!

The surprising point. After 27 ♖xe1 ♖xe1+ 28 ♖f1 ♗d6! the position is less clear, but now the king can no longer escape via e8. 27...♖c8

27...♖d6 28 ♗g4+ ♗f8 29 ♗g7 mate (e8 is not available).

28 ♗h5 ♗d6 29 ♖xe1 ♖xe1 30 ♗xh6 ♗xf6 31 ♗xf6 ♖h3

31...♖a6 32 d6 ♖xf1 33 h4 also wins smoothly for White.

32 ♗g5+ 1-0

Game 14

Marin-Berescu

Iasi 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 ♖e7 5 ♖g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♖bd7 7 ♗c2 c6 8 ♖bd2 b6 9 b3 ♖a6 10 ♖d1

10 e4 ♖c8 11 ♖e1 is a different approach, against which Black should have sufficient resources. 11...c5 12 exd5 exd5 13 ♖a3 ♖e8 14 cxd5 ♖xd5 15 ♗f5 ♖f6 16 dxc5 ♖xc5 17 ♖xc5 ♖xc5 simply equalised in Tosic-Kosic, Trebinje 2001, but 16...g6! 17 ♗h3 ♖xc5 18 ♖xc5 ♖xc5 19 ♖xe8+ ♗xe8 20 ♖e1 ♗d8 21 ♗h4 ♖c3! is unclear according to Kosic. Black seems fine in this position. Also possible is 14...cxd4! 15 ♖xe7 ♖xc2 16 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 17 ♖ec1 ♖dc8 when Black, again, looks no worse. Perhaps White could consider 18 ♖c4! ♖xc1+ 19 ♖xc1 b5 20 ♖xd4 bxc4 21 ♖c6 ♗f8 22 bxc4 with a complex struggle ahead.

10...♖c8

10...b5 led to a slight advantage for White in Filippov-Liang Chong, Shengjang 1999 after 11 c5 b4 12 e4! ♖xe4 13 ♖xe4 dxe4 14 ♗xe4 ♖xc5 15 ♗c2 ♖d7 16 ♖e5 ♖xe5 17 dxe5 ♗c7 18 ♗xc6 ♗xc6 19 ♖xc6 ♖ac8 20 ♖e4 ♖b5 21 ♖e3.

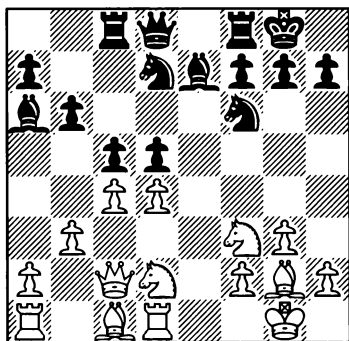
10...c5 11 e4 dxc4 12 ♖xc4 cxd4 13 ♖xd4 ♖c8 14 e5 ♖d5 15 ♗b2! secures White a small plus. Black, as always, has problems with the light squares. Poluljahov-Feigin, Kakhovka 1997 went 15...♖xc4 16 bxc4

♙xc4 17 ♜xd5! exd5 18 ♜f5 ♜b4 19 ♙xd5 ♜c3 20 ♜e2 ♜c7 21 ♜b2 ♜xb2 22 ♜xb2 ♜c5 23 ♜d6 ♜c6 24 ♙ad1 and White was firmly in control.

11 e4 c5

11... ♜c7 12 e5 ♜e8 13 ♜f1 ♜b8 14 ♜g5 ♜xg5 15 ♜xg5 g6 16 f4! is clearly better for White according to Beliavsky.

12 exd5 exd5



This is an important position for the CC. White has more than one option.

13 ♜b2

13 ♜f5 g6 (13... ♜e8 14 ♜b2 transposes to 13 ♜b2 ♜e8 14 ♜f5) 14 ♜h3 ♜c7 15 ♜b2 ♜c8 16 ♜h6 ♜g4 17 ♜f4 ♜df6 18 ♜e5 cxd4 19 ♜xd4 ♜d6 20 cxd5 ♜h5 21 ♜e4 ♜xe5 22 ♜xe5 ♜c7 was unclear in Beshukov-Fomichenko, Krasnodar 1999.

Particularly interesting is Sulava's 13 ♜f1!?, when Sulava-Atalik, Cappelle la Grande 2000 continued 13... cxd4 14 ♜xd4 b5 (14... ♜c5?! is too optimistic – 15 ♜e3 dxc4 16 ♜c6 sees White generate an initiative, Luther offering an example in the line 16... ♜c7 17 ♜xc4 ♜g4? 18 ♜f4! ♜xf2 19 ♜xf2 ♜xf2+ 20 ♜xf2 etc.) 15 ♜e3 bxc4 16 ♜xd5 ♜xd5 17 ♜xd5 cxb3 18 ♜xb3 ♜c5?! 19 ♜f3 ♜f6 20 ♜a3 ♜a5 21 ♜ab1! ♜xd4 22 ♜xd4 ♜e2 23 ♜xe2 ♜xa3 24 ♜e7! ♜h8 25 ♜xf7 with a poor position for Black. Stohl offers the improvement 18... ♜c5!, with the following instructive line: 19 ♜e6! ♜xf2+ 20 ♜g2 fxe6 21 ♜xe6+ ♜h8 22 ♜xd7 ♜d4! 23

♜xd8 ♜cxd8 24 ♜g5 ♜b8 25 ♜d1 ♜f2+ 26 ♜h3 ♜xa1 27 ♜xa1 ♜f1+ 28 ♜g4 ♜e2+ 29 ♜h4 ♜xh2+ 30 ♜h3 ♜b5! with a balanced game.

In Delchev-L.B.Hansen, Istanbul, 2000 Black chose the alternative capture: (13 ♜f1) 13... dxc4 14 d5 ♜e8 15 bxc4 ♜d6 16 ♜e3 ♜e8 17 ♜f1 b5 18 ♜b1 bxc4 19 ♜a4 ♜b7 20 ♜d2 ♜a8 21 ♜a5 ♜b6 22 ♜c2 ♜c8 23 ♜e5 and White was doing well. Stohl prefers 14... cxb3 15 axb3 ♜xf1 16 ♜xf1 ♜c7, although he still likes White after 17 ♜f4 ♜d6 18 ♜xd6 ♜xd6 19 ♜xa7 ♜a8 (19... ♜xd5? 20 ♜c4 ♜7f6 21 ♜g5 g6 22 ♜xd5 ♜xd5 23 ♜e4 ♜b8 24 ♜d7 ♜b4 25 ♜c3 and White wins) 20 ♜xa8 ♜xa8 21 ♜h4 g6 22 ♜g2.

13... cxd4

Black's alternatives have had mixed fortunes.

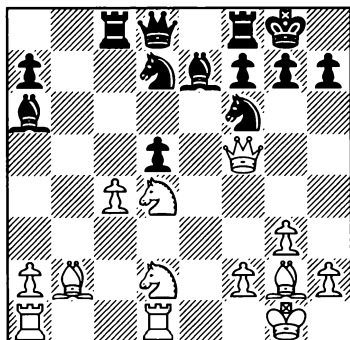
13... dxc4 14 d5! cxb3 15 axb3 ♜e2 16 ♜e1 ♜b5 17 ♜h4 ♜e8 18 ♜xa7 ♜d6 19 ♜aa1 ♜e5 20 ♜c4 ♜xc4 21 bxc4 ♜d7 22 ♜f3 left White slightly better in Cvitan-Godena, Geneve 1996.

After 13... b5?! 14 cxd5 c4 White used to respond with 15 bxc4, but stronger is 15 ♜e5!, when 15... ♜xd5? 16 ♜xf7! ♜a5 does not work for Black (as it normally does) because the b5-pawn obstructs the queen. Instead 16... ♜b4 17 ♜xd8 ♜xc2 18 ♜c6 leads to a clear advantage for White. This leaves the lesser evil 15... ♜b6! 16 ♜c6 ♜c7 17 bxc4 bxc4 18 ♜e4 ♜fxd5 19 ♜xe7+ ♜xe7 20 ♜c5 when White's outlook is the brighter, with strong knight on c5. Ernst-Aagaard, Groningen 1998 continued 14... ♜b7 15 ♜g5 h6 16 d6 ♜xg2 17 dxe7 ♜xe7 18 ♜xg2 hxg5 19 ♜d3 c4 20 bxc4 bxc4 21 ♜xc4 ♜b4 22 ♜dc1 ♜xc4 23 ♜xc4 ♜xb2 24 ♜ab1 ♜d2 25 ♜c2 ♜a5 26 ♜b5 ♜e1 27 ♜e2 ♜a1 and a draw was agreed. However, White has an improvement in 15 ♜d3! c4 16 bxc4 bxc4 17 ♜xc4 ♜xd5 18 ♜fd2 with advantage. It would appear that 13... b5 is inadequate.

13... ♜e8 14 ♜f5 g6 15 ♜h3 ♜f8 (15... b5?! is poor due to 16 ♜g5! with the threat of

♙xd5, the subsequent 16...♘f8 17 dxc5 bxc4 18 bxc4 ♙xc5 19 cxd5 ♙xf2+ 20 ♖h1 ♙c2 21 ♙xf6 ♖xf6 22 ♘de4 being good for White) 16 cxd5 ♙e2 17 ♙e1 ♘xd5 18 ♙ac1 with a complicated struggle ahead.

14 ♙xd4 b5 15 ♖f5 bxc4 16 bxc4



16...g6!

An important move. Black has been through a lot of suffering in this position.

16...♖b6?! 17 ♙ab1 dxc4 18 ♘e4! g6 19 ♘xf6+ ♘xf6 20 ♖f3 ♙fe8 21 ♘c6 ♖xc6 22 ♖xc6 ♙xc6 23 ♙xc6 ♙c8 24 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 25 ♙e4 offers White good winning chances.

16...♙xc4?! 17 ♘xc4 ♙xc4 18 ♙xd5 g6 19 ♖g5 ♘xd5 20 ♖xd5 ♘b6 21 ♘f5! gx f5 22 ♖e5 ♙f6 23 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 24 ♙xf6 was seen in Nielsen-Danielsen, Randers 1996, White eventually converting this favourable ending.

16...♘b6?! 17 cxd5 ♘a4 (17...♘bxd5 is met with 18 ♘e6! fxe6 19 ♖xe6+ ♖h8 20 ♖xa6 and White is a pawn up for nothing) 18 ♙ab1 ♘b2 19 ♙xb2 ♙c5 20 ♘c6 ♙d6 21 ♘e4 ♘e4 22 ♙xe4 g6 23 ♖f3 f5 24 ♙d3 ♙xd3 25 ♙xd3 f4 26 g4 ♙ce8 27 ♙e2 and White was on his way to the full point in Sorokin-Hoffman, Villa Martelli 1997.

17 ♖g5?!

This proves to be too risky as Black easily obtains compensation for the exchange. Sulaeva proposes the following line as a possible improvement: 17 ♖h3 dxc4 18 ♙c3 ♘c5 19 ♘c6 ♙xc6! 20 ♙xc6 ♘d3 21 ♘e4 ♖b6! 22 ♖g2! ♘g4! 23 ♙ab1 ♖xc6 24 ♘f6+ ♖xf6 25

♙xf6 ♙xf6 with an assessment of 'unclear' – as usual, further tests are required.

17...dxc4 18 ♘c6 ♙xc6 19 ♙xc6 ♖b6 20 ♙xd7 ♖xb2 21 ♙ab1 ♖a3

21...♖d4 is even stronger according to Marin. After 22 ♘f3 ♖xf2+ 23 ♖xf2 ♘e4+ 24 ♖g2 ♘g5 25 ♘g5 ♙g5 26 ♙d6 ♙c8 Black has all the chances, while 22 ♖a5 ♙c5 23 ♖xa6 ♖xf2+ 24 ♖h1 ♘e4! leaves White's king in serious trouble.

22 ♙b5 ♘e4?

A tactical error. Black would have been fine after 22...c3! 23 ♘c4 ♖c5 24 ♖xc5 ♙xc5 25 ♙dc1 ♙xb5 26 ♙xb5 ♘e4 27 ♘e3 ♙d8, retaining the passed pawn and with excellent compensation for the exchange.

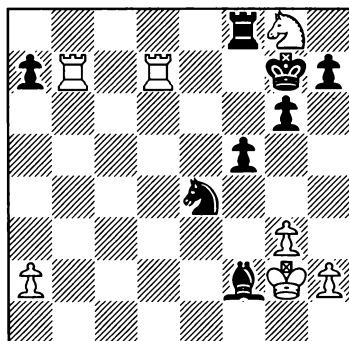
23 ♘xc4 ♖f3 24 ♖e3 ♖xe3 25 ♘xe3 ♙xb5 26 ♘d5! ♙c5 27 ♙xb5 ♙xf2+

27...♘xf2 28 ♙c1 ♙d4 29 ♙c4 and wins.

28 ♖g2 f5?

After the more precise 28...h5 White still remains well on top after 29 ♙b7 ♙c5 30 ♘e7+ ♖g7 31 ♘c6.

29 ♙b7 ♙f7 30 ♘e7+ ♖g7 31 ♙dd7 ♙f8 32 ♘g8+! 1-0



Game 15

Raetsky-Gattenloehner

Winterthur 2002

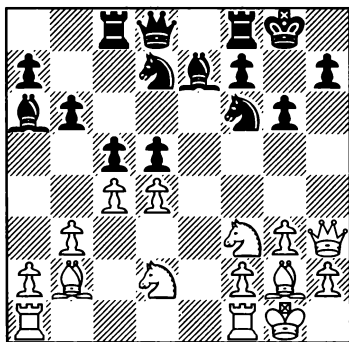
1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 ♙e7 5 ♙g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♘bd7 7 ♖c2 c6 8 ♘bd2 b6 9 b3 ♙a6 10 ♙b2 ♙c8 11 e4 c5

In Kasparov-Huss, Zürich (simul) 1987, 11...♙c7 12 ♙fe1 ♙b8 13 ♙ac1 ♙fd8 14 ♙b1 h6 15 a3 ♙b7 16 e5 ♙e8 17 cxd5! cxd5 18 ♙f1 earned White an advantage, albeit nothing spectacular. However, this soon snowballed, and after 18...♙xc1 19 ♙xc1 ♙c8 20 b4 ♙xc1 21 ♙xc1 ♙c8 22 b5 ♙c3 23 a4 g5?! 24 h3 ♙f8 25 ♙b2 ♙c8 26 ♙d3 White was clearly better.

12 exd5 exd5 13 ♙f5!?

13 ♙fd1 transposes to the previous game. An alternative is 13 ♙fe1, when Lobron-Knaak, Germany 1998 continued 13...cxd4 14 ♙xd4 b5 15 ♙ad1 ♙c5 16 ♙f5 ♙b6 17 ♙e7+ ♙xe7 18 ♙xe7 bxc4 19 bxc4 dxc4 20 ♙e4 c3 21 ♙xc3 ♙xe4 22 ♙xe4 ♙f6 23 ♙f3 ♙c5 24 ♙e3 ♙fe8 25 ♙d2, with a slight edge for White.

13...g6 14 ♙h3



14...cxd4

Black plans a knight manoeuvre. 14...h5 15 ♙fe1 cxd4 16 ♙xd4 ♙c5 was played in Raetsky-D.Frolov, Smolensk 2000, but this looks rather risky for Black. There followed 17 ♙f5! gxf5 18 ♙xe7! ♙xe7 19 ♙h4! ♙c6 (19...♙cd7 20 ♙g5+ ♙h7 21 ♙xf5+ ♙h6 22 ♙f4+ ♙g6 23 ♙f3 ♙e4 24 ♙e1 f5 25 ♙h3 and Black is in for a rough ride) 20 ♙g5+ ♙h7 21 ♙xf5+ ♙g8 22 ♙g5+ ♙h7 and a draw was agreed, but 23 cxd5 ♙d6 24 b4! gives White a strong attack.

In Rustemov-Nikolenko, Moscow 1999 Black followed 14...♙c7 15 dxc5 with the

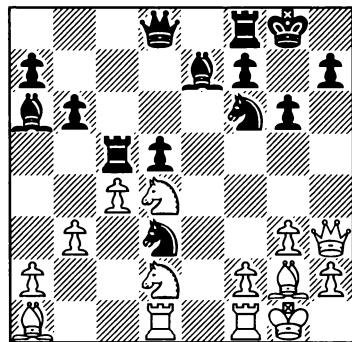
faulty 15...bxc5?, finding himself a pawn down for nothing after 16 ♙g5 d4 17 ♙e6! fxe6 18 ♙xe6+ ♙g7 19 ♙xa6. Gelfand-Sorokin, Sochi 1986 went 15...♙xc5 16 ♙h6 ♙e8 17 ♙e5 ♙d7 18 ♙h3 ♙e6 19 ♙fe1 dxc4 20 ♙xe6 fxe6 21 ♙e4 ♙b7 22 ♙fg5 ♙xe4 23 ♙xe4 cxb3 24 axb3 and White had a formidable attack.

15 ♙xd4 ♙c5 16 ♙ad1 ♙d3

Kochiev-Shaposhnikov, St. Petersburg 1996 is worth a look: 16...♙e8 17 ♙2f3 ♙ce4 18 ♙e5 ♙c7 19 ♙e6! ♙d6 (19...fxe6 20 ♙xe6+ ♙g7 21 ♙f7+ ♙h8 [21...♙h6 22 ♙g4+] 22 ♙xe4 ♙f8 23 ♙xd5! ♙xd5 24 ♙f7+ ♙g8 25 ♙h6 mate) 20 ♙xf7! ♙xf7 21 ♙xe4 ♙xe4 22 ♙xd5 ♙xd5 23 cxd5 and White was winning.

16...h5 17 ♙2f3 ♙ce4 18 ♙e5 ♙e8 19 ♙xe4 was the course of Razuvaev-Lputian, Frunze 1979, when 19...dxe4! met with 20 ♙f5! gxf5 21 ♙xf5 ♙c5 22 b4 ♙c7 23 ♙d6! ♙c8 24 ♙g5+ ♙h7 25 ♙d7! ♙xd7 26 ♙xd7 ♙xd7 27 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 28 ♙xf6 ♙xc4 29 ♙e7 1-0. Razuvaev gives 19...♙xe4 20 ♙fe1 with an attack for White.

17 ♙a1 ♙c5



18 ♙xd5!!

A surprising move. Usually White does not surrender this bishop if he can help it, yet here he does not even bother to recapture on d5. In fact this was home preparation. In a previous game 18 f4? was played, but with little success. After 18...dxc4! 19 ♙c6 ♙xc6!

20 xc6 c7 21 g2? (21 f3 c3 22 e4 xe4 23 xe4 c2 is better) 21... c5+ 22 h1 g4 Black was winning in Raetsky-Filippov, Smolensk 2000.

The contrasting 18 h1! ? e8 19 a3 f8 20 b4 c7 21 b5 also looks nice for White, but is of less relevance considering the effectiveness of the text.

18... xd5 19 e4!

The key idea. White simply wants to regain the knight for free.

19... f6

19... b4 20 h6! e5 21 f5! gxf5 22 xe5 f6 23 g5! and Black is mated, while 19... xc4 20 bxc4 xc4 21 h6! e5 22 f5! works in the same way.

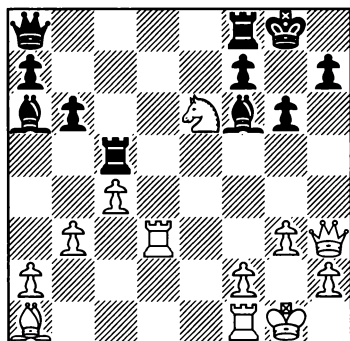
20 xf6+?

An inaccuracy. The game could have been decided with 20 xc5! xc5 (20... bxc5 21 c6 d6 22 xe7+ xe7 23 xd3 and Black must resign) 21 c6 c7 22 xe7+ xe7 23 h4! , when White wins as follows: 23... g7 24 fe1 e6 25 d7! xd7 26 xf6+ h6 27 h4 mate.

20... xf6 21 xd3 a8

Black does not have any compensation on the light squares. After 21... b7 22 fd1 e7 23 c3 h5 24 f1 c5 25 b5 xc3 26 xc3 White is a pawn up.

22 e6! ?



22... h5

Only move. After 22... fxe6 23 xe6+ g7 24 d7+ White wins.

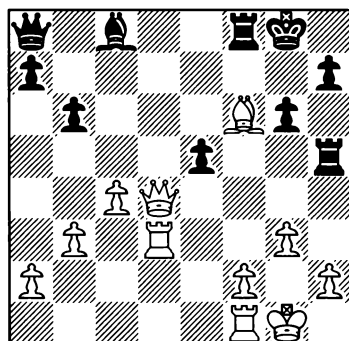
23 g4

Also strong is 23 xf8! ? hx3 24 xf6 c6 25 d8 xf6 26 e6+ xd8 27 xd8 , with good winning chances in the endgame.

23... c8 24 xf6 fxe6

24... xe6 25 f3 xf3 26 xf3 gives White excellent winning chances in the shape of a pawn and a powerfully posted bishop.

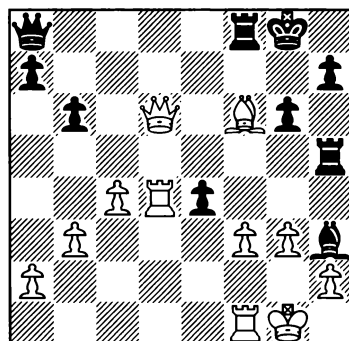
25 d4 e5



26 d6!

Not 26 xe5? h3 , when White is close to being worse.

26... h3 27 f3! e4 28 d4



28... e3?

A blunder. If 28... f7 Black is struggling, but while 29 g4 c5 30 fd1 exf3 31 we6 f2+ 32 xf2 c8 33 g3 g2+ 34 h4 favours White, there remains work to do.

29 we7 1-0

Summary

The evaluation of the gambit continuation 6...♞bd7 7 ♞c3 dxc4 8 e4 (Game 3) has changed during the last decade. Earlier Black defended with 8...♞b6, 8...c6 9 a4 a5 or 9...b6, but White has a strong initiative in the centre in all of these lines. Now Black has discovered 8...c6 9 a4 e5!? 10 dxe5 ♞g4 11 ♟f4 ♞a5. Another modern idea is action on the queenside with 8...a6 9 a4 ♞b8 10 a5 b5, but this variation needs more practice before a safe conclusion can be made.

After 7 ♞c3 c6 White seldom develops his queen on b3, often being forced to exchange on d5, when Black usually equalises quite comfortably. It seems to us that 8 ♞d3 has more going for it than 8 ♞b3. However, after 8...b6 White should not hurry with 9 e4 because 9...♟a6 10 b3 dxc4 11 bxc4 e5 is nice for Black. On the other hand, recent victories by GM Gleizerov have shown that after 9 ♞d1 ♟a6 10 b3 ♞c8 11 e4 Black has problems.

In the case of the move order 7 ♞c3 c6 8 b3 b6 9 ♟b2 ♟a6 (Game 6), then 10 ♞d2, with the standard idea of e2-e4, deserves attention. Indeed White's chances look preferable. Another interesting idea is 10 a4, although with 10...dxc4 11 bxc4 ♟xc4 12 ♞d2 ♟a6 13 ♟xc6 Black can equalise with accurate defence.

After 7 ♞c2 c6 8 ♟f4 b6 the standard plan 9 ♞bd2 ♟b7 10 e4 (Game 8) does not give White any advantage as the bishop is not well placed on f4 after ...c6-c5. Perhaps White should play 9 ♞d1 ♟a6 10 ♞e5, or 9...♟b7 10 ♞c3 dxc4 11 ♞d2 (Game 9).

In the event of e2-e4 the reply ...d5xe4 is unpopular. If Black is late with the freeing advance ...c6-c5 White can himself push with c4-c5 (Game 11), which is in fact quite effective.

The advance e4-e5 is still relevant (Game 12). After 7 ♞c2 c6 8 ♞bd2 b6 9 e4 ♟a6 this plan promises White the better chances, although in the case of 9...♟b7 10 e5 ♞e8 11 b3 ♞c7 12 ♟b2 c5 the bishop is well placed on b7 and the position is about equal. After 11 cxd5 cxd5 White is slightly better but instead of 11...cxd5 the alternative 11...exd5 looks more promising for Black, whose intention is to play ...♞e8-c7-e6 and prepare counterplay involving ...c6-c5.

In the CC the most popular position arises after 7 ♞c2 c6 8 ♞bd2 b6 9 b3 ♟a6:

Recent practice has demonstrated that 10 ♞d1 does not lead to an advantage for White. In the complex struggle Black has sufficient resources with which to oppose White's activity in the centre and on the kingside (Game 14). On the other hand, after 10 ♟b2 ♞c8 11 e4 c5 12 exd5 exd5 13 ♞f5!? White has a genuine initiative, and we do not see how Black can equalise.

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♞f3 ♞f6 4 g3 ♟e7 5 ♟g2 0-0 6 0-0

6 ♞c2 c5 – *Game 1*

6...♞bd7

6...c6 7 ♞c3 b6 8 ♞e5 – *Game 2*

7 ♞c2

7 ♞c3

7...dxc4 – *Game 3*

7...c6: 8 ♞b3 – *Game 4*; 8 ♞d3 – *Game 5*; 8 b3 – *Game 6*

7...c6 8 ♞bd2

8 ♞d1 b6 9 a4 – *Game 7*

8 ♟f4 b6: 9 ♞bd2 – *Game 8*; 9 ♞d1 – *Game 9*

8 b3 b6: 9 ♟b2 ♟a6 10 ♞d1 ♞c8 11 ♞c3 – *Game 10*; 9 ♞d1 ♟b7 10 ♞c3 – *Game 11*

8...b6

9 e4 – *Game 12*

9 b3 ♟a6

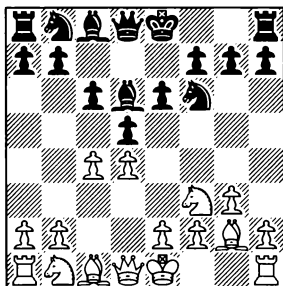
9...♟b7 – *Game 13*

10 ♞d1 – *Game 14*

10 ♟b2 – *Game 15*

CHAPTER TWO

4...c6 5 ♖g2 ♘d6



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 c6 5 ♙g2 ♙d6

This system resembles the Closed Catalan (4...♙e7 5 ♙g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♘bd7). However, in contrast to the positions with ...♙e7, Black can concentrate his efforts on the major plan of expansion with ...e6-e5. This approach enjoyed some popularity in the 1920s, when Catalan theory was in its infancy. Particularly noteworthy is the encounter Reti-Bogoljubov (Game 16) when, after transposition, a key position was reached in which Black attempted in vain to steer the game to Dutch Stonewall territory. After a correct move order such a transposition is indeed possible, but the Dutch Defence is outside the scope of this book.

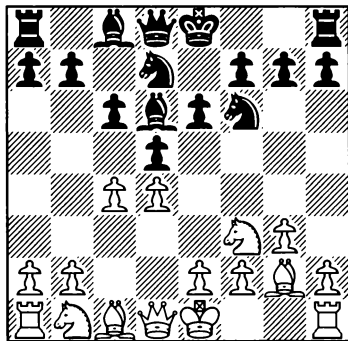
After 6 0-0 ♘bd7 White occasionally sacrifices the c4-pawn with 7 ♘c3, when his initiative more or less compensates the modest investment. However, most of the time White prefers to avoid this possibility, opting instead to continue 7 b3, 7 ♖c2 or 7 ♘bd2.

The 'tabia' occurs after 6 0-0 ♘bd7 7 ♖c2 0-0 8 ♘bd2, and since Bogoljubov-Joss, Zürich 1934 it has been known that the immediate advance 8...e5 is premature here. After 9 cxd5 ♘xd5! 10 ♘c4 Black has serious problems (Panov-Makogonov – see the notes to Game 17), while after the stronger

9...cxd5 10 dxe5 ♘xe5 11 ♘xe5 ♙xe5 12 ♘f3 the minuses of the isolated pawn are not quite compensated by Black's freer development. Therefore Black's best strategy is to prepare ...e6-e5 with 8...♖e7 or 8...♞e8 (often these moves simply transpose).

Game 16 Reti-Bogoljubov New York 1924

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 c6 5 ♙g2 ♙d6 6 0-0 ♘bd7



7 b3

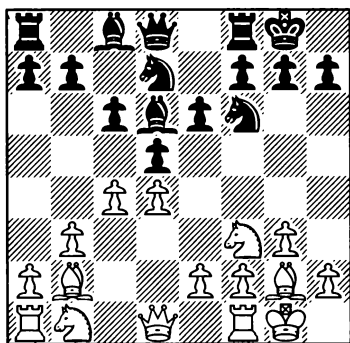
The alternative is 7 ♘c3 dxc4 8 ♖c2 (dubious is 8 e4! e5 9 dxe5 ♘xe5 10 ♘xe5 ♙xe5 11 ♖xd8+ ♙xd8 12 ♞d1+ ♙c7 Chet-

verik-Jurcisin, Presov, 1999. White doesn't have full compensation for the pawn deficit in this endgame.) 8...0-0 9 ♖d1 ♜e7 10 ♖g5 h6 11 ♖xf6 ♜xf6 12 ♜d2 e5, as in Lputian-Arencibia, Biel 1993, which continued 13 d5! cxd5 14 ♜xd5 ♜xd5 15 ♖xd5 c3 16 ♜xc3 ♖g4 17 ♜c4 ♖ac8 18 ♜e3 ♖b8 19 ♜e4 with a slight edge for White (more active).

7...0-0

Early play in the centre with 7...b6 8 ♖b2 c5?! is not to be recommended. In Chetverik-Hajek, Bratislava 2000 White won after 9 cxd5 exd5 10 dxc5 bxc5? 11 e4! ♖e7 12 e5 ♖a6 13 exf6, so Black should prefer 10...♜xc5 11 ♜c3 ♖b7 12 b4, when White has a useful lead in development in this isolated d-pawn position.

8 ♖b2



8...♜e8

Black can transpose to the Dutch Defence with 8...♜e4 9 ♜bd2 f5.

9 ♜bd2

White can prevent ...e6-e5 with 9 ♜e5 ♜c7 10 f4 b6 11 ♜d2 ♖b7 12 e4, as in Euwe-Davidson, Amsterdam 1924, when White took action in the centre and was rewarded with a pull after 12...dxe4 13 ♜xe4 ♜xe4 14 ♖xe4 ♜f6 15 ♖g2 c5 16 d5 exd5 17 cxd5.

9...♜e4?!

Lokvenc-Stolz, Haque 1928 went 9...e5 10 cxd5 cxd5 11 dxe5 ♜xe5 12 ♜xe5 ♖xe5 13

♖xe5 ♜xe5 14 ♜f3 ♜e8 15 ♜d4 ♖e6 16 ♜d3 ♜d7 17 ♖ac1 ♖ac8 18 ♜b5 and Black's isolated pawn left him a little worse. Black can also try 9...b6 10 ♜c2 ♖b7 11 e4 e5 with a mix of systems. Sämisch-Rellstab, Swinemunde 1930 continued 12 dxe5 ♜xe5 13 ♖ad1! ♜c7 14 exd5 cxd5 15 ♜d4 a6 16 ♜f5 ♖f8 17 ♜f3 ♜ed7 with chances for both sides. However, 13 ♜xe5 ♖xe5 14 ♖xe5 ♜xe5 15 f4 ♜e8 16 e5 ♜g4 17 ♜d3 improves, gaining space and thus putting White on top.

10 ♜xe4 dxe4 11 ♜e5 f5 12 f3!

White opens up the position while Black's queenside remains undeveloped.

12...exf3

12...♜xe5 has also been tried. Koller-Wiechmann, Germany 1994 went 13 dxe5 ♖c5+ 14 ♖h1 exf3 15 ♖xf3 ♜e7 16 ♖d3 (Black cannot liberate the queen's bishop) 16...♖b6 17 ♜d2 ♖d8 18 ♖d1 ♖xd3 19 ♜xd3 with a huge advantage for White.

13 ♖xf3 ♜c7 14 ♜xd7! ♖xd7 15 e4 e5

15...fxe4 16 ♖xe4 g6 17 ♜d3 ♖g7 18 c5! ♖f8 19 d5+ e5 20 d6 ♜d8 21 ♜c4 is given by Tartakover, Black's position being critical. Black should play 15...♖f8 16 e5 ♖ad8 in order to facilitate development, although White still has the initiative after the move 17 ♜e2.

16 c5 ♖f8 17 ♜c2 exd4?!

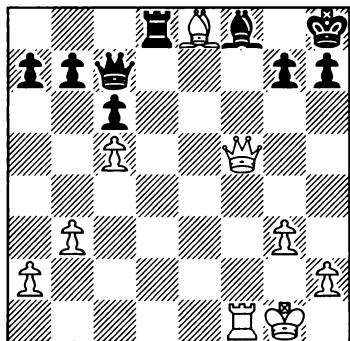
17...fxe4?! 18 ♖xe4 g6 19 ♖xg6! and White wins. 17...f4?! is interesting, keeping the position closed, 18 gxf4 exf4 19 ♖h1 leaving White a little better thanks to his presence in the centre and more breathing space for his forces.

18 exf5 ♖ad8 19 ♖h5! ♜e5 20 ♖xd4 ♖xf5?!

Black can also try 20...♖d5, when 21 ♜c4 ♖h8 22 ♖g4 sees White retain the extra material and the initiative, while 21...♖e6? loses to 22 fxe6 ♖xd4 23 ♖xf8+ ♖xf8 24 ♜h1 ♖xf5 ♖xf5 22 ♜xf5 ♖xd4 23 ♖f1! ♖d8

Alekhine gives 23...♜e7 24 ♖f7+ ♖h8 25

♙d5! ♖f6 26 ♜c8 and wins.
24 ♙f7+ ♜h8 25 ♙e8! 1-0



A famous final move.

Game 17
Panov-M.Makogonov
Kiev 1938

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 c6 5 ♙g2 ♙d6 6 0-0 ♖bd7 7 ♜c2 0-0 8 ♖bd2 e5?!

Too early. Another try is 8...b6 9 e4 (after the greedy 9 cxd5?! cxd5 10 ♜c6 ♜c7 11 ♜xa8 ♙a6 12 ♜xf8+ ♖xf8 White has two rooks for the queen but is behind in development) 9...dxe4 10 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 11 ♜xe4. Raetsky-J. Gunnarsson, Hafnarfjörður 1996 continued 11...♙b7 12 ♙f4 ♖f6 13 ♜e3 c5 14 ♙ad1 ♙xf4 15 ♜xf4 ♜e7 16 ♙fe1 cxd4 17 ♙xd4 ♙ac8 18 ♖e5 ♙xg2 19 ♜xg2 ♙fd8 20 ♙ed1 ♙xd4 21 ♜xd4, White possessing the d-file and a queenside pawn majority. Black's prospects failed to improve after 21...h6 22 a3 ♜b7+ 23 f3 b5 24 c5 ♖d5 25 b4 f6 26 ♖d3 ♜a6 27 ♖f4.

8...♜e7 presents White with a few choices:

9 ♙e1 b6 10 e4 ♖xe4 11 ♖xe4 dxe4 12 ♜xe4 ♙b7?! 13 ♙g5 ♜e8 14 ♙ae1 ♜c8 15 ♙h4! g6 was seen in A.Petrosian-Skembris, Dortmund 1992. Petrosian then recommends 16 ♙h6! ♙e8 17 ♖g5 with a menacing attack for White.

Perhaps 9 e4 is premature compared with

the previous line. The natural 9...dxe4 10 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 11 ♜xe4 e5 12 dxe5 ♖xe5 13 ♖g5 ♖g6 (13...g6!? is an interesting option) 14 ♜c2 h6 15 ♖e4 ♙f5 16 ♙e1 ♙fe8 17 ♙d2 ♙ad8 18 ♜b3 ♙e5 19 ♙b4 ♜c7 earned Black a decent game in Smyslov-Sehner, Farum 1986.

9 b3 is the quiet approach. Indeed in Razuvayev-Skatchkov, St. Petersburg 1997 this policy resulted in a steady lead for White after 9...b6 10 ♙b2 ♙b7 11 e4 dxe4 12 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 13 ♜xe4 ♙ad8 14 ♙ad1 ♖f6 15 ♜c2 thanks to Black's development problems. These were compounded after the subsequent 15...c5? 16 dxc5 ♙xf3 (16...♙xc5? 17 ♖g5) 17 cxd6 ♙xd1 18 ♜xh7+! ♖xh7 19 dxe7 ♙e2 20 exf8 ♜+ ♖xf8 21 ♙a1 ♙d2 22 ♙c3 ♙c2 23 ♙e5 ♖d7 24 ♙e4 ♙d2 25 ♙c3 and White was close to winning.

9 cxd5 ♖xd5?!

Or 9...cxd5 10 dxe5 ♖xe5 11 ♖xe5 ♙xe5 12 ♖f3 with an edge for White. Rogers-Handoko, Djakarta 1993 continued 12...♙d6 13 ♙d1 ♙e8 14 ♙g5 ♙e6 15 ♖d4 ♙e5 16 ♖xe6 fxe6 17 e4 h6 18 ♙xf6 ♜xf6 19 exd5 ♙ac8 20 ♜d3 ♙xb2 21 ♙ab1 exd5 22 ♙xd5+ ♜h8 23 ♙xb7 ♙cd8 24 ♜f3 and, although White had won a pawn, the opposite coloured bishops offered Black chances of saving the game.

10 ♖c4 ♜e7 11 e4

Also good is 11 ♖d6 ♜xd6 12 ♙d1 ♜e7 13 e4 ♖b4 14 ♜b3 ♖a6 15 ♙g5 when White has the bishop pair and an active position. In Bogoljubov-Joss, Zürich 1934 this proved significant after 15...♜e8 16 dxe5 ♖xe5 17 ♙d8 ♖xf3+ 18 ♙xf3 ♜e5 19 ♙xf8+ ♜xf8 20 ♙f4 ♜e6 21 ♜c3.

11...♙5b6

Panov gives 11...♖b4 12 ♜b3! exd4? 13 ♙g5! and Black has problems.

12 ♖xd6 ♜xd6 13 ♙d1

White had a healthy initiative for the pawn in Filipovic-Jerbic, Pula 1999 after 13 ♙e3 exd4 14 ♙xd4 ♙e8 15 ♙ad1 ♜e6 16 b3 ♜xe4 17 ♜b2. There followed 17...f6 18

♜de1 ♖g6 19 ♜h4 ♗f7 20 ♜f5 ♗f8 21 f4 ♜d5 22 ♗f2 g6 23 ♜xe8 ♗xe8 24 ♜e1 ♗f8 25 ♜xd5+ cxd5 26 ♜e7+ ♜f7 27 ♜xd5 and White regained the material with a winning position.

13...exd4 14 ♜f4 ♗e7 15 ♜xd4 ♜e8 16 ♜d6 ♗e6 17 a4 ♜f8

17...a5 18 ♜c7 f6 19 ♜ad1 does not help Black.

18 a5 ♜bd7 19 ♜ad1 f6

19...♜f6 20 ♜g5 ♗g4 21 f4 also favours White.

20 ♜f1! ♗f7 21 ♜c4 ♜e6 22 e5! ♜h8

22...fxe5? is poor in view of 23 ♜g5, while 22...♜xe5 loses: 23 ♜xe5 fxe5 24 ♜g5 ♗g6 25 ♗xg6 hxg6 26 ♜d8 etc. After 22...♗g6 23 ♗xg6 hxg6 24 ♜xe6+ ♗xe6 25 ♜a3 Black's cramped position will soon fall apart.

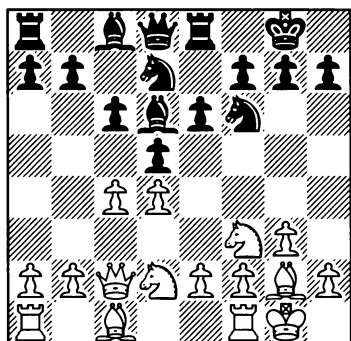
23 ♖g4! ♜df8

Or 23...♜xe5 24 ♜xe5 fxe5 25 ♜xe5 ♗g8 26 ♜h4 and wins.

24 exf6 ♗xf6 25 ♜e5 b5 26 ♜a2 c5 27 ♜d5 ♜a6 28 ♜h4 g5 29 ♜h6 ♗g7 30 ♜xf8 ♜xf8 31 ♜f7+ 1-0

Game 18
Orsag-Haba
Turnov 1996

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 c6 5 ♖g2 ♜d6 6 0-0 ♜bd7 7 ♗c2 0-0 8 ♜bd2 ♜e8



9 b3

9 e4 is good enough only for equality. For example Pirc-Bogoljubov, Bad Harzburg 1938 went 9...dxe4 10 ♜xe4 ♜xe4 11 ♗xe4 e5 12 ♜g5 f6 13 ♜d2 exd4 14 ♗xd4 ♜e5 15 ♜c3 c5 16 ♗d5+ ♜e6 17 ♗xb7 ♜b8 18 ♗e4 ♜xc4 19 b3 ♜b6 20 ♜ae1 ♗c7, and Black had solved his opening problems.

Alternatively 9 ♜d1 ♗e7 10 e4 ♜xe4 11 ♜xe4 dxe4 12 ♗xe4 e5 13 ♜g5! f6 14 ♜e3 exd4 15 ♗xe7 ♜xe7 16 ♜xd4 ♜c5 17 ♜e1 saw White maintain a modest lead in development in Ricardi-Panno, Florida 2001. An ending advantage resulted after 17...♜xe1+ 18 ♜xe1 ♜xd4 19 ♜xd4 ♜e5 20 b3 ♜g4 21 h3 ♜d7 22 f4 ♜f7 23 c5 ♜f8 24 ♜f2 in view of White's extra space.

9...e5

9...♗e7 10 ♜b2 e5 11 cxd5 ♜xd5 12 e4 ♜b4 13 ♗b1 b5?! 14 a3 ♜a6 15 b4 ♜b7 16 ♜b3 ♜ed8 17 ♗c2 ♜ab8 18 ♜ad1 favoured White in Raetsky-Budde, Cappelle la Grande 2001, Black's forces lacking co-ordination.

10 cxd5

Also possible is 10 dxe5 ♜xe5 11 ♜b2 ♜xf3+ 12 ♜xf3 dxc4 13 bxc4 ♗e7 14 e3 ♜g4 15 ♜d4 ♗d7 16 f3 ♜h3 17 e4 ♜c5 18 ♜ad1 ♜ad8 19 ♜h1, when Black has completed development and is ready to contest the centre. Note that 14...♜e4?! is dubious, as was demonstrated in Greenfeld-Zsu.Polgar, Pardubice 1994, 15 ♜ab1 c5 16 ♜fe1 ♜c7 17 ♜h4 ♜b8 18 ♜bd1 b5 19 cxb5 ♜xb5 20 ♜a1 ♜b6 21 ♜d5 leaving Black with numerous weaknesses (c5, for instance) and White the advantage.

10...cxd5

10...♜xd5?! is best avoided in view of 11 ♜c4 ♜c7 12 ♜fxe5 ♜xe5 13 dxe5 ♜xe5 14 ♜xe5 ♜xe5 15 ♜b2 when White has the bishop pair and central control. His initiative developed quickly in Nikcevic-Vencl, Arandjelovac 1990: 15...♜e8 16 e4 ♜f6 17 ♜ad1 ♗e7 18 h3 ♜e6 19 f4 ♜ad8 20 f5 ♜c8 21 e5 ♜d5 22 f6 with a huge advantage.

11 dxe5 ♜xe5 12 ♜b2 ♜c6

Also possible is 12...♜g4 13 ♜xe5 ♜xe5

14 ♖xe5 ♜xe5 15 ♜f3 ♞e7. Andersson-Cifuentes, Benidorm 1994 continued 16 ♜d4 ♞c8 17 ♜b2 ♞ec7 18 ♞ac1 h6 (Cifuentes gives 18...h5!?) 19 e3 a6 20 ♞fe1 ♜d7 21 f3 ♖e6 22 ♜f2 ♜d6 23 ♞xc7 ♜xc7 24 ♞e2. With ♞c2 White trades more pieces in order to step closer to an endgame that is favourable due to the isolated d-pawn.

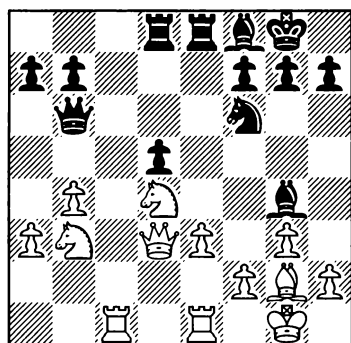
13 ♞fe1 ♖g4 14 a3 ♞c8 15 ♜d3 ♜e4 16 b4

Interesting is 16 ♜xd5 ♜xf2!? 17 ♜g5 ♜e5 18 ♖xe5 ♜xg5 19 ♖xd6 ♜e3 with a highly complicated position in which Black has a strong attack for the piece.

16...♖f8 17 e3 ♜b6?!

Better is 17...♜d6!? 18 ♞ac1 ♖f5.
18 ♞ac1

White can grab the pawn with 18 ♜xd5!? ♞cd8 19 ♜c4! as the g4-bishop is hanging.
18...♞cd8 19 ♖d4 ♜xd4 20 ♜xd4 ♜f6 21 ♜2b3



White is slightly better due to the control of c5.

21...a6 22 h3 ♖h5

Black enters the following complications as the more normal 22...♖e6 23 ♜c5 leads to a small but enduring advantage for White.

23 f4 h6 24 f5 ♜d6! 25 g4 ♖xg4 26 hxg4 ♜xg4 27 ♜f3 ♜g3

Black has attacking possibilities for the piece, but probably not enough.

28 ♜d2 ♖d6 29 ♞e2 ♜e5 30 ♜xe5 ♞xe5 31 ♜d4 ♞de8

Or 31...♞e4 32 ♜f1 ♞g4 33 ♜e1 and White consolidates.

32 ♜e1 ♜g4 33 ♞d1 ♞e4

Black can win one more pawn but at the cost of exchanging all the heavy pieces: 33...♞xe3 34 ♞xe3 ♞xe3 35 ♜xe3 ♜xd1+ 36 ♜f2 and the three pawns are no match for the minor piece, Black losing his attacking potential.

34 ♜f2?!

34 ♞d3 secures White the better game.

34...♜g5

Or 34...♞xe3 35 ♜f3!? ♞xf3 36 ♞xe8+ ♜h7 37 ♜xf3 ♜xf5 with a complex situation.

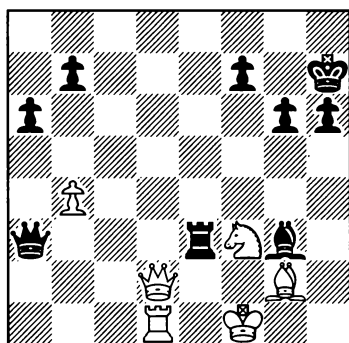
35 f6 g6 36 ♜f1 ♖g3 37 ♜f3 ♞xe3 38 ♞xe3?

Poor. White should go for 38 ♜xd5 ♜g4 39 ♖f3 ♜h3+ with equal chances.

38...♞xe3 39 ♜xd5 ♜xf6+ 40 ♜f3

Not 40 ♖f3? ♖e5 41 ♜g2 ♖xd4 42 ♞xd4 ♞xf3 and Black wins.

40...♜b2 41 ♜d8+ ♜h7 42 ♜d2 ♜xa3



Black now has more than adequate compensation the piece.

43 ♜d4 ♞e7 44 ♖d5 ♖d6 45 ♜f2 ♜h3+ 46 ♖g2 ♜g4 47 ♞d3?!

47 ♖f3 ♜f4 48 b5 offers better prospects for White than the game continuation.

47...♖xb4 48 ♖h3 ♜e4 49 ♞f3 ♜e1+ 50 ♜g2 ♜xf2+ 51 ♞xf2 ♖c3 52 ♞e2 ♞c7 53 ♞c2 b5 54 ♜f3 b4 55 ♖f1 a5 56 ♜b5 ♞c5 0-1

Summary

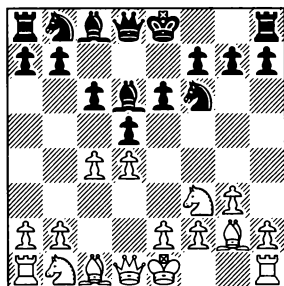
These examples indicate that in the ...♗d6 system it is not necessary for White to hurry with e2-e4 as this serves only to justify Black's own advance of the e-pawn, which appears to promise excellent equalising chances (for example 6 0-0 ♗bd7 7 ♜c2 0-0 8 ♗bd2 ♜e8 9 e4 dxe4 10 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 11 ♜e4 e5 with further simplifications that cancel out any White edge). A more promising strategy for White is to complete queenside development with b2-b3 and ♗b2. After 9 b3 e5 10 cxd5 cxd5 11 dxe5 ♗xe5 12 ♗b2 we again have a position with an isolated pawn, albeit an acceptable version for Black, who enjoys the better development and, in practice, tends to achieve equality.

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♗f3 ♗f6 4 g3 c6 5 ♖g2 ♗d6 (1) 6 0-0 ♗bd7 7 ♜c2

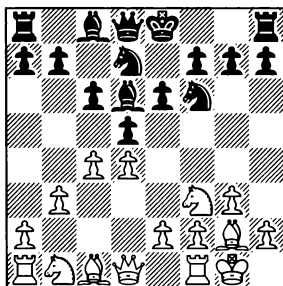
7 b3 (D) – Game 16

7...0-0 8 ♗bd2 (D)

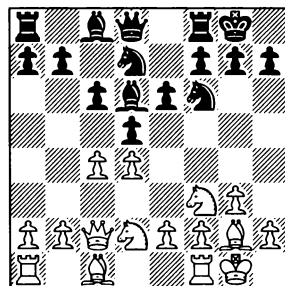
8...e5 – Game 17; 8...♜e8 – Game 18



5...♗d6



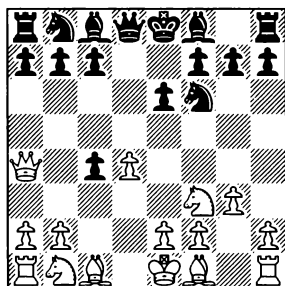
7 b3



8 ♗bd2

CHAPTER THREE

4...dxc4 5 ♖a4 +



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖a4+

After 4...dxc4 White can regain the pawn back immediately. This continuation was popular during the infancy of the Catalan. In particular world champions Capablanca, Alekhine (his two nice victories are shown in Games 22 & 25), Botvinnik and Smyslov played this line, but much has happened since. When White regains the pawn with the aid of the queen check he is also assisting Black's development. Moreover, the queen is subject to attack on c4 (mainly from ...b7-b5).

These days 5 ♖a4 is seen less often than 5 ♙g2, and is usually played by those looking for the kind of edge which brings with it little chance of losing. Not surprisingly the main adherent of 5 ♖a4+ is GM Ulf Andersson, a peace loving man with superb endgame technique.

1 d4 ♘f6 2 c4 e6 3 g3 d5 4 ♙g2 dxc4 5 ♖a4+ is the standard move order for this line from a theoretical perspective, but in reality ♘f3 is seen more often, and the variations where White tries to play without ♘g1-f3 are hardly relevant – 5 ♖a4+ ♙d7 6 ♖xc4 ♙c6 7 f3, for example, can never give White an advantage. After 1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖a4+ Black does have the extra

possibility of 5...♖d7 6 ♖xc4 ♖c6, but after 7 ♘bd2 ♖xc4 8 ♘xc4 White has a stable advantage.

In the event of 5...♘c6 6 ♖xc4 ♖d5 the position is acceptable for Black, but only in the line with ♘f3, of course, as otherwise the queen would be hanging. More attention should be paid to 5...c6 6 ♖xc4 b5, with a position that most often arises from the Slav after 1 d4 d5 2 c4 c6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 ♖c2 dxc4 5 ♖xc4 e6 6 g3 b5. Now after 7 ♖c2 ♙b7 8 ♙g2 ♘bd7 Black is trying to achieve ...c6-c5 as quickly as possible. If White allows this (Game 18) Black is afforded decent chances of equality, so preference should be for 9 ♘e5, preventing the immediate 9...c5 (Game 20).

After 5 ♖a4+ it is logical to play 5...♙d7 6 ♖xc4 ♙c6, after which Black develops his pieces (Game 21) or plays ...♙c6-d5 (with tempo), preparing the freeing advance ...c7-c5 (Game 22). Nevertheless, the main defence against 5 ♖a4+ is 5...♘bd7. It is impossible to clearly classify the variations based on concrete moves as there are so many transpositions. But what is possible is to pick out the different strategies. Insufficient for equality is the plan with ...e6-e5 (after 6 ♙g2 c6 7 ♖xc4 ♙d6 8 0-0 e5). And quite passive is 6...♙e7.

One idea for White is to hold back the capture on c4 and instead continue development with 6 ♖g2 (Game 23), although 6 ♖xc4 is the main continuation. Then 6...a6 (Games 24-26) is designed to harass White's queen with the help of ...b7-b5 and, in so doing, solve Black's main strategic problem – the development of the queen's bishop. White quickly drops back to c2 in Game 24 to prevent ...b7-b5, while in Games 25 & 26 Black is allowed to complete his main plan and push the b-pawn.

Black plays 5...c6

Game 19 Mednis-Prie Cannes 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♟f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖a4 + c6

5...♖d7 6 ♖xc4 ♖c6 7 ♟bd2 ♖xc4 8 ♟xc4 ♟b4 + 9 ♟d2 ♟xd2 + 10 ♟fxd2! ♟c6 11 e3 ♟b4 12 ♟e2 ♟d7 13 ♟g2 ♟c6 14 f3 left White in control of the centre in Botvinnik-Vidmar, Groningen 1946. There followed 14...♟d7 15 a3 ♟d5 16 e4 ♟5b6 17 ♟a5 ♟b5 + 18 ♟e3 0-0-0 19 ♖hc1 ♟b8 20 b3 ♟d7 21 ♟f1 ♟c6 22 ♟xc6 ♟xc6 23 a4 ♟e8 24 a5 ♟a8 25 a6 b6 26 b4 with a big edge.

After 5...♟c6 White should avoid 6 ♟e5? ♖d5 7 ♖g1 b5, when he stands clearly worse. Meanwhile, 6 ♟g2 transposes to 5 ♟g2 ♟c6 6 ♖a4. This leaves 6 ♖xc4 ♖d5 7 ♖d3, e.g. 7...♟b4 8 ♖d1 ♖e4!? 9 ♟a3 ♟d7 10 ♟g2 ♟c6 11 0-0 h6 12 ♟f4 ♟bd5 13 ♟d2 ♟xa3 14 bxa3 0-0 15 e3 ♖fd8 as in Kobalija-Dokuchaev, Majkop 1998, when White's weakened queenside pawns and Black's activity contributed to a balanced game. Another sensible line is 7...♖f5 8 ♖xf5 exf5 9 a3 ♟e6 10 e3 ♟a5 11 ♟bd2 ♟b3 12 ♟xb3 ♟xb3 13 ♟d3 g6 and Black was doing fine in Kura-jica-Zvjaginsev, Pula 1997. This status quo continued after the subsequent 14 ♟d2 a5 15 ♟e2 ♟d6 16 ♖hc1 ♟d5 17 ♟e5 c6 18 ♟c4

♟c7 19 b4 axb4 20 axb4 ♟d7.

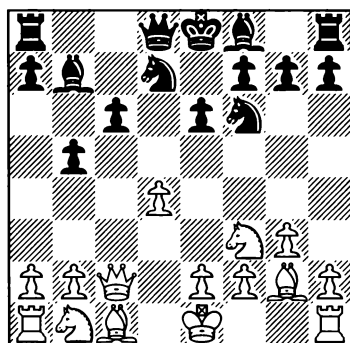
6 ♖xc4 b5 7 ♖c2

Abramovic-Maksimenko, Novi Sad 2000 went 7 ♖d3 ♟bd7 8 ♟g2 ♟b7 9 0-0 a6 10 a4 c5 11 axb5 ♟e4 12 ♖d1 axb5 13 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 14 ♟a3 b4 15 ♟c4 cxd4 16 ♟f4 ♖a6 17 b3 ♟c5 18 ♟xd4 ♟xg2 19 ♟xg2 0-0, Black completing development.

7...♟b7 8 ♟g2

Also possible is 8 ♟bd2 ♟bd7 9 e4 ♟e7 10 a3 c5!? 11 ♟xb5 0-0 with compensation according to M.Gurevich. In this line White can try to prevent the thematic ...c6-c5, a plan adopted in the encounter Gheorghiu-R.Bagirov, Bern 2001: 9 ♟b3 ♖b6 10 ♟g2 a5!? 11 ♟g5 a4 12 ♟bd2 c5 13 ♟xf6 ♟xf6 14 0-0 ♖c8 15 ♖ac1 ♟e7 16 dxc5. Now 16...♟xc5! 17 ♖b1 0-0 would have given Black the better chances due to the bishop pair and space on the queenside.

8...♟bd7



9 0-0

9 a4 c5!? 10 axb5 cxd4 11 0-0 ♟c5 12 ♟g5 ♖c8 13 ♟bd2 0-0 14 ♖d3 h6 15 ♟xf6 ♖xf6 16 ♟g5 ♖xg5 17 ♟xb7 ♖c7 was Timman-Lautier, Malmö 1999, with chances even after 18 ♟f3 ♟e5 19 ♟xe5 ♖xe5.

After 9 ♟c3 c5 White must avoid 10 ♟xb5? ♖a5 + 11 ♟c3 cxd4, when Black is winning. White fared better in Zagorskis-Vaisser, Lyon 1994: 10 0-0 b4 11 ♟a4 ♖c8 12 ♟xc5 ♟xc5 13 dxc5 ♟xc5 14 ♖a4 + ♟c6 15 ♖a6 0-0 16 ♟g5 ♟d5 17 ♖ac1 ♖b6 18

♖xb6 axb6 19 ♙xf6 gxf6 20 b3 with an equal endgame.

In Magerramov-Doroshkievich, Podolsk 1992 White produced an interesting pawn sacrifice aimed at generating an initiative: 9...a6 10 0-0 c5 11 ♙g5 ♜c8 12 d5!?, although after 12...exd5 13 ♘h4 h6 14 ♙xf6 ♘xf6 15 ♚ad1 ♜c7 16 ♘xd5 ♘xd5 17 ♙xd5 ♙xd5 18 e4 ♙e7 19 ♚xd5 ♖a8 20 ♘f5 0-0 21 ♚fd1 ♜e8 Black was okay.

9...c5 10 ♙e3

Another option is 10 a4 b4 11 ♙g5 ♜c8 12 dxc5 ♙xc5 13 ♖d3 0-0 14 ♘bd2 with a balanced game, a situation that is preferable from White's side of the board than 11 a5?! ♜c8 12 dxc5 ♙xc5 13 ♖d1 0-0 14 ♘bd2 ♖e7 15 ♘b3 ♚fd8 16 ♖e1 ♙d6 17 a6 ♙d5, when the advance of the a-pawn proved unsuccessful in A.Kulikov-Najer, St. Petersburg 2000. Black is better.

10...♜c8 11 dxc5 ♙xc5 12 ♙xc5 ♘xc5 13 ♘c3 b4 14 ♘b5 ♖b6 15 ♘bd4 0-0 16 a3 a5

Better is 16...♚fd8, e.g. 17 axb4? ♘ce4 with an initiative for Black.

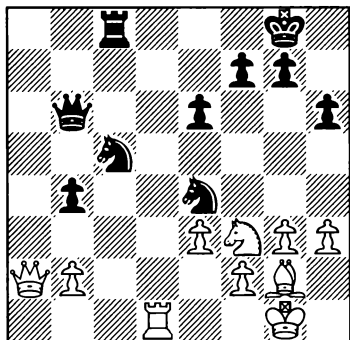
17 axb4 axb4 18 ♖c4 ♙xf3

18...♙d5 19 ♖b5 ♖xb5 20 ♘xb5 ♘b3 21 ♚a4 ♜c2 yields nothing for Black.

19 ♘xf3 ♘ce4 20 ♖b3

20 ♖d4 ♖xd4 21 ♘xd4 e5 22 ♘f3 ♜c2 23 ♘xe5 ♚xb2 is equal.

20...♚fd8 21 e3 h6 22 h3 ♘c5 23 ♖a2 ♘fe4 24 ♚ad1 ♚xd1 25 ♚xd1



25...♘xf2!?

An interesting piece sacrifice.

26 ♘xf2 ♘e4+ 27 ♙g1 ♖xe3+ 28 ♙h2 ♜c2 29 ♖a8+ ♙h7 30 ♚f1 ♙xg2+

Black forces the draw.

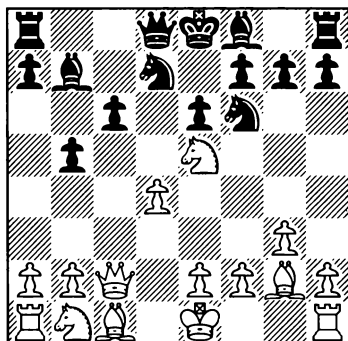
31 ♙xg2 ♖e2+ 32 ♙g1 ♖e3+ 33 ♙g2 ♖e2+ ½-½

Game 20

Raetsky-Sveshnikov

Kolontaev 1994

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖a4+ c6 6 ♖xc4 b5 7 ♖c2 ♙b7 8 ♙g2 ♘bd7 9 ♘e5



9...♖b6

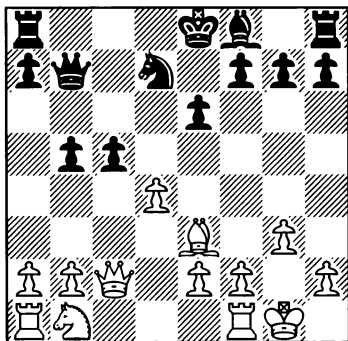
Another option is 9...♘xe5 10 dxe5 ♘d5! 11 0-0 ♙e7 12 ♚d1 ♖b8 13 ♘c3 0-0 14 ♘xd5 cxd5 15 e4 ♜c8 16 ♖e2 dxe4 17 ♙xe4 ♙xe4 18 ♖xe4 ♜c4! with a good game for Black in Volzhin-Ibragimov, Elista 2001, although 19 ♖f3 ♖e8 20 ♙e3 ♜c7 was agreed drawn. Note that it is important for Black to find (or be prepared with) 10...♘d5! as this is superior to 10...♘d7 11 0-0 ♖b6 12 a4, which featured in two Raetsky games. After 12...a6 13 axb5 axb5 14 ♙e3 ♖c7 15 ♚xa8+ ♙xa8 16 ♘c3 White had the initiative in Raetsky-Klingelhofer, Giessen 1994, and the further 16...♖b8 17 ♚a1 ♙e7 18 ♚a7 ♙d8? 19 ♘xb5 0-0 20 ♚xd7 cxb5? 21 ♙a7 saw White win. Raetsky-Volzhin, Hastings 1992/93 also favoured White after 12...c5 13

♙xb7 ♜xb7 14 axb5 ♜xc5 15 ♜c3 ♙e7 16 ♙f4 ♜g6 17 ♙e4 ♜xe4 18 ♜xe4 etc.

10 ♙e3

10 0-0 ♜xd4 (10...c5!? is interesting) 11 ♜xd7 ♜xd7 12 ♜d1 ♜c8 13 ♜c3 a6 14 ♙g5 with compensation for the pawn. White is well developed and ready for action.

10...c5 11 ♜xd7 ♜xd7 12 ♙xb7 ♜xb7 13 0-0



13...cxd4?!

13...♜c8 has also been played. Raetsky-Rausch, Biel 1997 continued 14 ♜c1 ♙e7 15 dxc5 ♜xc5 16 b4 ♙f6 17 ♜c3 ♜d7 18 ♜e4 ♜a6 19 ♙d4 0-0 with equality, while 17...♜a4 18 ♙e4 ♜a8! (18...♜a6? 19 ♜xb5! ♜xc1+ 20 ♜xc1 ♜xb5 21 ♜c8+ ♙d8 22 ♜xd8+) 19 ♜xb5! leads to a forced draw after 19...♜xe4 20 ♜xc8+ ♙e7 21 ♜c7+ ♙f8. Here 14...c4?! risks giving White a free hand in the centre. Raetsky-Tregubov, Krasnodar 1995 went 15 a4 a6 16 axb5 axb5 17 ♜c3 ♙b4 18 d5 exd5! (18...♙xc3 19 dxe6 fxe6 20 ♜xc3 0-0 and White has only a small advantage) 19 ♜a7 ♜c6 and White now changed gear and emerged with a clear advantage after 20 ♜ca1! ♙c5 21 ♜a6 ♜b6 22 ♙xc5 ♜xc5 23 ♙b7.

14 ♙xd4 ♜c8

After 14...e5 15 ♙e3 ♙e7 16 ♜d1 0-0 17 ♜f5 White has an action position.

15 ♜c3! b4

Again the push in the centre with 15...e5 is insufficient for equality – 16 ♙e3 ♙b4 17

♜e4 ♜xe4 18 ♜xe4 f5 19 a3 ♙e7 20 ♜c3 etc.

16 ♙e4 ♜xe4

Avoiding the exchange with 16...♜a6 gives White the better chances after 17 ♜d5 ♜c6 18 ♜ac1 ♜xc1 19 ♜xc1 ♜xc1+ 20 ♙g2.

17 ♜xe4 f5

17...♜c4?! runs into 18 ♙xg7! ♜g8 19 ♙xf8 ♜xe4 20 ♙d6 ♜xe2 21 ♜ac1 and White is well on top.

18 ♜g5 e5! 19 ♙xa7 ♙e7 20 ♙e3 h6 21 ♜f3 ♙f7

Completing development is the aim of Black's pawn sacrifice, resulting in an active game for Black.

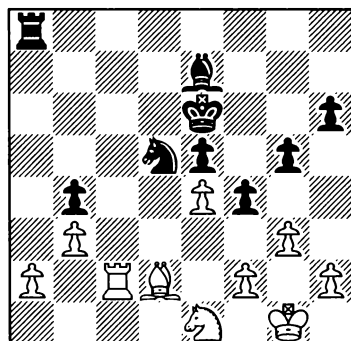
22 ♜fc1 g5 23 b3 f4 24 ♙d2 ♙e6 25 ♜xc8 ♜xc8 26 ♜c1 ♜a8 27 ♜c2

27 ♜c6+ ♙d5 28 ♜xh6 g4 29 ♜h7 ♙e6 and again Black has compensation, winning back one of the invested pawns with an aggressive stance.

27...♜f6 28 ♜e1

28 gxf4 gxf4 29 e3 promises White a small edge.

28...♜d5 29 e4



29...fxe3 30 ♙xe3 e4 31 ♙d4 ♙f6 32 ♜c6+ ♙d7 33 ♜c4

33 ♜xf6 ♜xf6 34 ♙xf6 ♜xa2 and, with a rook versus two minor pieces, Black has definite compensation. His king and rook are active and White's pieces lack co-ordination.

33...♜xa2 34 ♙xf6 ♜xf6 35 ♜c2 ♙b2 36 ♜xb4 ½-½

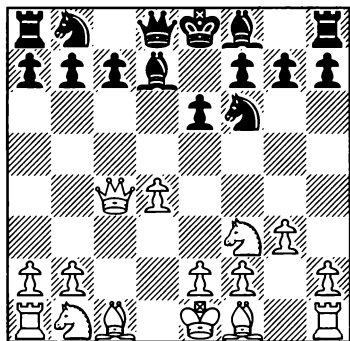
Black plays 5...♗d7

Game 21

Vila-Spassky

Castrop-Rauxel 1990

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♗f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♜a4+ ♗d7 6 ♜xc4



6...♗c6

6...c5 7 dxc5 ♗c6 transposes to 5 ♗g2 c5 6 ♜a4+ ♗d7 7 ♜xc4 ♗c6 8 dxc5 (see the notes to Game 76).

7 ♗g2 ♗bd7

Gleizerov-Akhmadeev, Kstovo 1997 went 7...♗e7 8 ♗c3 0-0 9 0-0 a6 10 ♜d3 b5 11 ♗g5 ♗bd7 12 a3 ♗b7 13 b4 h6 14 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 15 ♗e5 ♗xg2 16 ♗xg2 with the firm grip on c5 earning White the pleasant prospects.

8 ♗c3 ♗b6

Also possible is 8...♗e7 9 0-0 0-0 10 ♜d3 ♗d5 11 e4 ♗xc3 12 bxc3 f5 (12...♗c5 13 ♜e3 ♗xe4 is best avoided in view of 14 ♗e5!, regaining the pawn and keeping a plus) 13 exf5 exf5 14 ♗e1 ♗xg2 15 ♗xg2 ♗b6 16 a4 a5 17 ♗e1 ♗f7 with approximate equality in Zaichik-Shabalov, Philadelphia 2000.

9 ♜d3 ♗b4 10 ♗g5

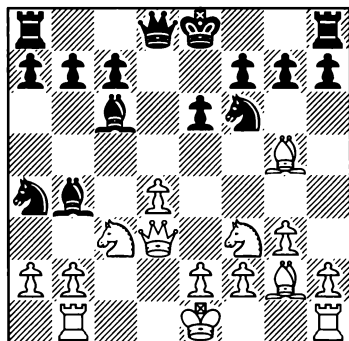
Petrov-Alekhine, Buenos Aires 1939 saw considerable trading during the next dozen or so moves: 10 0-0 0-0 11 ♜d1 h6 12 ♗e5 ♗xg2 13 ♗xg2 ♜e7 14 ♗e4 ♜ad8 15 ♗xf6+ ♜xf6 16 ♜f3 ♜xf3+ 17 ♗xf3 ♗c4 18 b3

♗a3 19 ♗b2 f6 20 ♗e1 ♗b5, and after 21 ♜ac1 ♗xe1 22 ♜xe1 ♗xd4 23 ♗xd4 ♜xd4 24 ♜xc7 ♗f7 the situation cleared and ended in an even ending.

10...♗a4

Forcing the exchange of the bishop with 10...h6 11 ♗xf6 ♜xf6 seems okay for Black. Indeed in Sosonko-Ligterink, Hilversum 1987 Black had a solid position with possibilities of healthy counterplay in the centre after 12 0-0 0-0 13 ♗e4 ♜e7 14 ♜ac1 ♗d7 15 a3 ♗d6 16 ♗c3 ♗xf3 17 ♗xf3 c6 18 ♗e4 ♗c7 19 b4 ♗b6 20 ♜fd1 ♜fd8.

11 ♜b1



11...♗d5?!

11...h6 is once again a sensible option, with 12 ♗xf6 ♜xf6 13 0-0 ♗xc3 14 bxc3 ♗a5 giving White central control, while the bishop pair helps Black's quest for equality.

12 ♗xf6 ♗b5

The recapture 12...gxf6 invites White to generate an initiative after 13 0-0 ♗xc3 14 bxc3 ♜a5 15 c4, although this might be preferable to the text.

13 ♜c2 ♜xa2 14 0-0 ♗xc3 15 ♗xg7 ♗g8

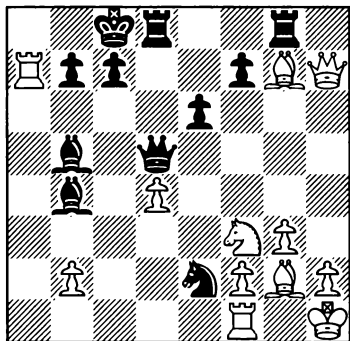
15...♗xb1 16 ♜xc7! ♗g8 17 ♗e5! ♗xg7 18 ♜xb7 a6 19 ♜xa8+ ♗e7 20 ♗c6 and White's attack against the bare king is very dangerous.

16 ♜a1 ♗xe2+ 17 ♗h1 ♗d5 18 ♜xh7 0-0-0?

18...♗xg7 19 ♜xg7 ♗c6 20 h4 is clearly

better for White, but Black is holding on.

19 ♖xa7



White has a decisive lead.

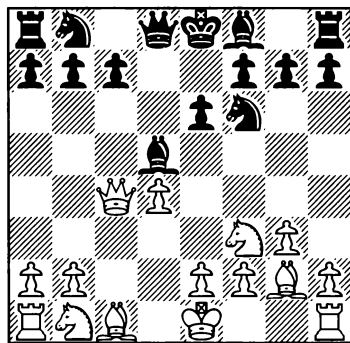
19...c6 20 ♖fa1

20 ♗e5 is clear-cut.

20...♗f5 21 ♗xf5 exf5 22 ♗f6 ♖de8 23 ♗e5 f4 24 ♗h3+ ♗e6 25 ♖a8+ 1-0

Game 22
Alekhine-Rabar
Munich 1942

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖a4+ ♗d7 6 ♗xc4 ♗c6 7 ♗g2 ♗d5



8 ♗d3

Other queen moves have been tried here. After 8 ♖a4+ ♗c6 9 ♗d1 e5!? 10 0-0 exd4 11 ♗xd4 ♗xd4 12 ♖xd4 ♗xg2 13 ♗xg2 ♗c5 the smoke begins to clear and Black faces no problems, e.g. 14 ♖b3 ♖a6 15 ♖c3

♗b6 16 ♗g5 ♖d7 17 ♖ad1 h6 18 ♗f4 0-0-0 with a level game.

8 ♗c2 ♖c6 (8...♗e4 9 ♗d1 transposes to 8 ♗d3 ♗e4 9 ♗d1) 9 ♖a4 ♗b4+ 10 ♖c3 ♖e4 11 0-0 saw White sacrifice a pawn for the initiative in S.Larsen-Thesing, Soro 1982. There followed 11...♗xc3 12 bxc3 ♖xc3 13 ♗c2 ♖e4 14 ♗a3 ♖d6 15 ♗xd6 ♗xd6 16 e4 ♖b4 17 ♗e2 ♗c6 18 d5 ♗d7 19 a3 ♖a6 20 e5 ♗e7 21 d6 cxd6 22 exd6 ♗xd6 23 ♖e5 and, despite being two pawns down, White's active play furnished him ample compensation.

8...c5

Andersson-Illescas, Pamplona 1997/98 is the way to play this line for Black: 8...♗e4 9 ♗d1 c5 10 ♖c3 ♗c6 11 0-0 ♖bd7 12 ♗e3 ♗e7 13 dxc5 (typical Andersson) 13...♗xc5 14 ♗xc5 ♖xc5 15 ♗xd8+ ♖xd8 16 ♖ac1 ♗e7 17 b4 ♖cd7 and the ending was level, although White was probably happy anyway!

9 ♖c3 ♗c6 10 0-0 ♖bd7 11 ♖d1

The more direct approach with 11 e4 promises White an edge, 11...cxd4 12 ♖xd4 ♖e5 13 ♗d1 ♗b6 14 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 15 ♖a4 giving White the bishop pair and the more active forces.

11...cxd4

With 11...♗b6 Black retains the tension in the centre for a while. Gereben-Szabo, Budapest 1948 continued 12 e4 cxd4 13 ♖xd4 ♗c5 14 ♗e3 ♖e5 15 ♗e2 ♖fg4 16 ♖xc6 ♗xe3 17 ♖xe5 ♗xf2+ 18 ♗h1 ♖xe5 19 ♖a4 ♖a5 20 ♗xf2 ♖xa4 21 ♗c5 and Black had a pawn but needed to address development, White's activity maintaining the balance.

12 ♖xd4 ♗xg2 13 ♗xg2 ♗e7 14 ♗f3!

The queen takes over the bishop's role on the long diagonal.

14...♗b6?

14...♗c8 also favours White after 15 ♖b3 ♖e5 16 ♗f4 ♖c6 17 ♗e3, although this improves on the game for Black. Now White sacrifices material to generate an initiative.

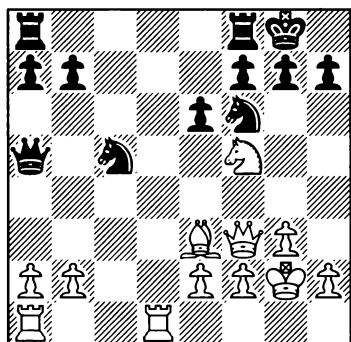
15 ♗e3! 0-0

15...♖xb2? 16 ♜cb5 highlights White's strategy. 15...♗e5 16 ♜db5 is also problematic for Black.

16 ♜f5 ♙c5

The continuation 16...♖d8 17 ♜xe7+ ♖xe7 18 ♖xb7 ♜fb8 19 ♖c7 ♖xb2 20 ♙d4 is given by Alekhine as being better for White.

17 ♜a4 ♖a5 18 ♜xc5 ♜xc5



19 ♜xg7!

A nice, traditional wrecking of the king-side from one of history's greatest attacking players.

19...♙xg7

19...♜ce4 20 b4! ♖e5 21 ♙f4 ♖b5 22 a4 (White really wants his bishop on the a1-h8 diagonal!) 22...♖xb4 23 ♙e5 is nice for White.

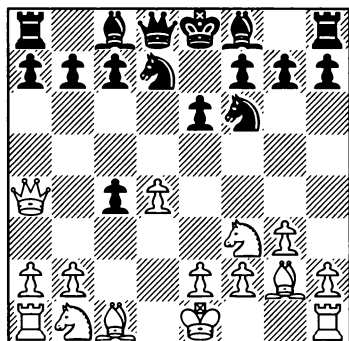
20 ♙d4! ♜ce4 21 ♖xe4 ♖f5 22 ♖xf5 exf5 23 ♜ac1 ♜fe8 24 ♜c7! ♜xe2 25 ♖xb7 ♙g6 26 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 27 ♜d6+! 1-0

In view of the continuation 27...♙g7 28 ♜dd7 ♜f8 29 ♙f3 ♜c2 30 ♜dc7 ♜d2 31 ♙e3.

Black plays 5...♜bd7

Game 23
Andersson-A.Sokolov
Bar 1997

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖a4+ ♜bd7 6 ♙g2



6...a6

Not the only possibility. After 6...c6 7 ♖xc4 ♙d6 8 0-0 e5 the break in the centre is not entirely satisfying for Black, e.g. 9 ♜c3 0-0 10 ♜d1 ♖e7 11 ♖b3 exd4 12 ♜xd4 ♙c5 13 h3 ♜e5 14 ♙g5 h6 15 ♙xf6 ♖xf6 16 ♜e4 ♖e7 17 ♜xc5 ♖xc5 18 ♜ac1 and White has a small advantage due to his lead in development. 6...♙e7 7 ♖xc4 0-0 8 0-0 a6 9 ♖c2 c5 10 ♜d1 ♜a7 11 e4 b6 12 ♜c3 ♙b7 13 d5 exd5 14 e5 ♜e8 15 ♜xd5 saw White seize the initiative in Lautier-Pinter, France 1993, when Black had to surrender his light-squared bishop – 15...♙xd5 16 ♜xd5 ♜c7 17 ♜d3 ♜e6 18 b3 ♖b8 19 ♙b2 ♜d8 20 ♜ad1 b5 21 h4 etc.

7 ♜c3 ♙e7

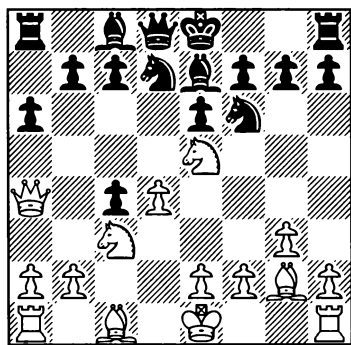
Again Black has other options:

7...c5 8 0-0 ♖b8 9 ♙f4 b5 10 ♖d1 ♖b6 11 d5 (Black keeps his pawn but now White attacks in the centre) 11...exd5 12 ♜xd5 ♜xd5 13 ♖xd5 ♙b7 14 ♖d2 ♙e7 15 a4 with compensation for the pawn in Speelman-Andersson, Hastings 1980/81. There followed 15...♜f6 16 ♖xd8+ ♙xd8 17 ♜fd1 ♜d5 18 axb5 ♜xf4 19 gxf4 ♖xb5 20 ♜e5 ♙xg2 21 ♙xg2 ♙c7 (21...♖xb2? is poor in view of 22 ♜xd8+!) 22 ♜xc4 ♙xf4 23 ♖xa6 0-0 and Black had finally castled. White won the pawn back but the game was equal. Also possible here is 8...cxd4 9 ♜xd4 ♖b6 10 ♜c2 ♙e7 11 ♖xc4 0-0, when Black addressed development and achieved a good

position after 12 b4 ♖e5 13 ♜b3 ♙d7 14 ♙e3 ♜c7 15 ♜ac1 ♙c6 16 ♙xc6 ♖xc6 17 ♙f4 ♜b6 in Lindberg-Jakovenko, Oropesa 2001.

7...♜b8 looks sensible. 8 ♜xc4 b5 9 ♜d3 ♙b7 10 0-0 c5 11 ♙f4 ♜c8 12 dxc5 ♙xc5 13 ♜ad1 0-0 14 ♖e5 and White was trying to generate an initiative in Andersson-Kasparov, Belgrade (6) 1985, which went 14...♙xg2 15 ♙xg2 ♖xe5 16 ♙xe5 ♙e7 17 ♜f3 ♜a5 18 ♜b7 ♜fe8 19 a3 b4 (securing a level game) 20 ♙xf6 gxf6 21 axb4 ♜xb4 22 ♜xb4 ♙xb4 23 ♖e4 ♙g7 24 ♖d6 with a draw. Returning to the 12th move, the more sophisticated 12...b4 has also been tried. In Mochalov-Sveshnikov, Minsk 2000 complications soon led to the arrival of the ending phase after 13 ♖a4 ♜a5 14 ♖b6 ♖xc5 15 ♖c4 ♜b5 16 ♖d6+ ♙xd6 17 ♜xb5+ axb5 18 ♙xd6 ♖fe4 19 ♙xc5 ♜xc5, when Black's activity was sufficient to maintain the balance: 20 ♜fc1 ♙e7 21 ♜xc5 ♖xc5 22 ♜c1 ♜c8 23 ♖e5 ♖a4 24 ♜xc8 ♙xc8 etc.

8 ♖e5



8...0-0

Another Andersson game went 8...♜b8 9 ♖xd7 (or 9 ♜xc4 c5 10 ♖xd7 ♜xd7 11 ♙f4 b5 12 ♜d3 c4 13 ♜c2 ♜b6 with counterplay for Black) 9...♜xd7 10 ♜xc4 b5 11 ♜d3 ♙b7 12 ♙xb7 ♜xb7 13 ♜f3 ♜b6 14 0-0 ♜c6 15 ♜xc6+ ♜xc6 and Black was well developed in Andersson-Hübner, Tilburg 1981, with White getting no chance to ex-

plot the c-file or the often weakened c5-square. Consequently 16 ♙g5 ♜c4! 17 e3 c5 18 ♙xf6 gxf6 19 dxc5 0-0 20 ♜ac1 ♜d8 21 ♖b1 ♜xc5 22 ♜xc5 ♙xc5 23 ♜c1 ♙b4 left Black with the superior ending.

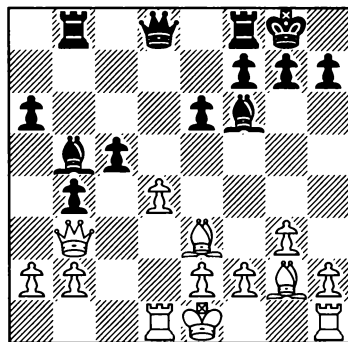
9 ♖xd7

9 ♖xc4 has also been played. Black was never in danger in the opening in Poluljahov-Zakharevich, St. Petersburg 2001, which went 9...c5 10 dxc5 ♙xc5 11 0-0 ♜b8 12 ♜d1 ♜c7 13 ♙f4 e5 14 ♙e3 b5 15 ♙xc5 ♖xc5 16 ♖e3 ♙b7 17 ♙xb7 ♜xb7 18 ♜c1 ♜d8 etc.

9...♙xd7 10 ♜xc4 b5 11 ♜b3 b4 12 ♖e4 ♙b5 13 ♖xf6+ ♙xf6 14 ♙e3

Also possible is the greedy 14 ♙xa8 ♜xa8 15 f3, although in the following lines Black obtains healthy compensation: 15...♙xd4 16 ♙e3 (16 ♜xb4 c5 17 ♜b3 e5 18 a4 ♙d7 is fine for Black as White still needs to complete development) 16...e5! 17 ♜c1 (White must be careful here, e.g. 17 ♙xd4 exd4 18 ♜xb4? ♜e8 19 0-0-0 c5! with the better chances for Black thanks to his busier pieces and White's insecure king) 17...c5 18 ♙xd4 exd4 19 ♜xc5 ♜e8 20 ♜xb5 (White returns the exchange and secures equality) 20...axb5 21 ♙f2 ♜a7! 22 ♜e1 ♜c5 etc. (A.Sokolov)

14...♜b8 15 ♜d1 c5!



Black temporarily sacrifices a pawn in order to activate his forces. Note that White's king is still in the centre.

16 dxc5 ♜a5 17 ♜d2 ♙a4 18 ♜c4 ♙c3!

Black continues to play with purpose.

19 0-0! ♖b5 20 ♜b3

20 ♜g4? is poor in view of 20...♙xd2 21 ♙xd2 ♜xa2 and White has lost a pawn for no compensation.

20...♙xd2

20...♙a4 21 ♜c4 ♖b5 with a repetition.

21 ♙xd2 ♙xe2 22 ♜c1

The passed pawn on the c-file gives White only a little compensation.

22...♜b5

22...♜c7 23 c6 a5 is more accurate, with an edge for Black.

23 c6 a5 24 ♙e3 a4 25 ♜c2 ♙d3 26 ♜d1 ♙c4 27 b3 axb3 28 axb3 ♙e2 29 ♜c2 ♜bc8 30 h3

Now it is difficult for Black to proceed.

30...♙e5 31 ♜b2 f6 32 ♙h2 ♙h5 33 ♜c5 ½-½

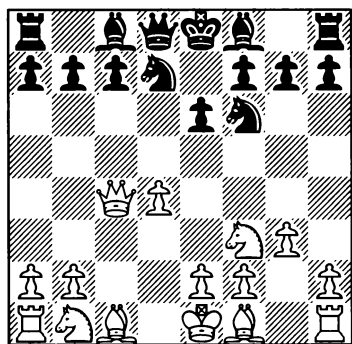
After 33...♜d3 34 ♜xd2 ♜xd2 35 ♙xd2 ♙f7 36 ♙xb4 ♙xb3 37 c7 ♙f7 38 ♙b7 ♙e6 the position is balanced.

Game 24

Hübner-Smyslov

Tilburg 1982

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♜a4+ ♙bd7 6 ♜xc4



6...a6

The immediate break in the centre with 6...c5 is also possible, bringing the game to a new junction. For example in Karpov-

Korchnoi, Moscow (8) 1974, Black developed fluidly and had no problems after 7 ♙g2 b6 8 0-0 ♙b7 9 ♙d1 a6 10 dxc5 ♙xc5 11 b4 ♙e7 12 ♙b2 b5 13 ♜d4 ♜c8 14 ♙bd2 0-0. Also possible here is 8 ♙e5 cxd4 9 ♙xf7! ♙xf7 10 ♙xa8 ♙c5 when White wins the exchange but lags behind in development, and must face Black's counterplay.

7 dxc5 ♙xc5 8 ♙g2 a6 (8...♜c7 9 ♙a3!? might favour White) 9 ♜b3 ♙a7 10 a4 and now the direct 10...b5 11 axb5 ♜b6 12 0-0 ♜xb5 13 ♜xb5 axb5 14 ♙xa7 ♙xa7 15 ♙c3 keeps White ahead in the development race and therefore earns him an edge. Chetverik-Vujosevic, Gyongyos 1997 instead continued 10...b6 11 0-0 ♙b7 12 ♙c3 ♜a8, when Black should be fine in the hedgehog position that results from 13 ♙h4 ♙xg2 14 ♙xg2 0-0 15 ♙e3 etc.

7 ♜c2 c5 8 ♙g2 b6

Grivas-Kourkounakis, Athens 1996 went 8...cxd4 9 ♙xd4 ♙b4+ 10 ♙d2 ♜e7 11 0-0 0-0 12 ♙d1 ♙b6 13 ♙xb4 ♜xb4 14 ♙c3 and Black had problems with queenside development.

9 ♙e5

G.Agzamov-Zaid, USSR 1984 demonstrated an interesting approach to the position: 9 dxc5 ♙xc5 10 ♙g5!? ♜b8 11 ♙c3 ♙b7 12 0-0 ♙xg2 13 ♙xg2 ♜c8 14 ♙d1 ♜b7+ 15 f3 0-0 16 ♙ce4 ♙xe4 17 ♙xe4 ♙e7 18 ♙d6 (after this exchange White has the superior minor piece) 18...♙xd6 19 ♜d6 ♜bc8 20 ♜d1 and White was better.

9...♙d5 10 ♙c3

The aggressive 10 ♙c6!? ♜c7 11 e4 is interesting. Zaitchik-A.Ivanov, Beltsy 1977 continued 11...♜xc6 12 exd5 exd5 13 ♙c3 ♙f6 14 ♙g5 cxd4 15 ♙xf6 dxc3 16 ♙xc3 and Black once again experienced development difficulties. There followed 16...♙e6 17 ♜e2 ♜b5 18 ♜e5 ♜c8 19 a4 ♜c4 20 ♙f1 ♜e4+ 21 ♜xe4 dxe4 22 ♙xa6, White winning back the pawn with advantage.

10...♙b7

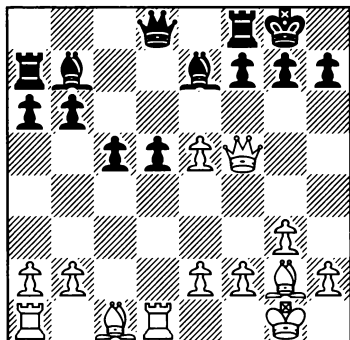
10...♙xe5 11 ♙xd5 exd5 12 dxe5 ♙e7 13

0-0 0-0 14 f4 and White has an initiative on the kingside.

11 ♖xd5 exd5 12 0-0 ♙e7 13 ♖d1 0-0 14 ♜f5

14 ♙f4 ♜c8 15 ♜f5 is more precise.

14...♖xe5 15 dxe5 ♖a7!



16 e6?!

White goes for the direct attack in the centre. Other tries don't promise an advantage, e.g. 16 ♜d3 ♜c7 17 ♙xd5 ♙xd5 18 ♜xd5 ♙d8 19 ♜b3 ♙xd1+ 20 ♜xd1 ♜xe5 with an equal game, or Šmyslov's 16 e3 g6 17 ♜f4 f6 18 e6 ♜c8, when Black frees himself successfully.

16...d4 17 ♙xb7 ♜xb7 18 e3 ♙f6 19 exd4 ♜e7! 20 ♙e3

20 exf7+ ♜xf7 21 ♜d3 ♜xd4! 22 ♜b3 c4 hands over the initiative to Black.

20...fxe6 21 ♜g4 h5! 22 ♜xh5

This is better than 22 ♜e4 cxd4 23 ♙xd4 ♙d7 24 ♜xe6+ ♙h8 25 ♜xd7 ♜xd7 26 ♙xf6 ♜e6 27 ♙d4 when White suffers on the light squares.

22...cxd4 23 ♜e2 ♜d5!

The centralization of the queen and Black's centre are more important features here than the a-pawn.

24 ♜xa6 b5 25 ♙e5 e5 26 ♙d2 ♖a8 27 ♜b4 ♖ea7 28 ♙e1

White should prefer the more adventurous 28 ♖ac1 ♖xa2 29 ♖c5 ♜f3 30 ♖dc1 ♜d3! 31 ♖xb5 ♙h7, although Black retains the initiative.

28...♖xa2 29 ♖ac1 ♖2a4 30 ♜c5 ♜xc5 31 ♖xc5 ♖a1 32 ♖cc1

32 ♖xa1 ♖xa1 33 ♙f1 d3 34 ♙d5 e4 35 f3 ♙xb2 36 fxe4 ♙c3 is poor for White.

32...♖xc1 33 ♖xc1 e4! 34 ♙f1 ♖a2 35 ♖b1 ♙f7 36 ♙b4 ♖a4 37 ♙d2 ♙e6 38 h4 ♙d5

Black has control of the centre and superior forces.

39 ♙e1 ♖a2 40 h5 d3 41 ♙c1 ♙d4 42 g4 b4 43 g5

43 ♙d2 ♙xb2 44 ♙xb4 doesn't work for White in view of 44...♙d4 45 ♙d2 ♙xf2+.

43...♖a8

The threat of ...♖h8 forces White into a hopeless rook ending.

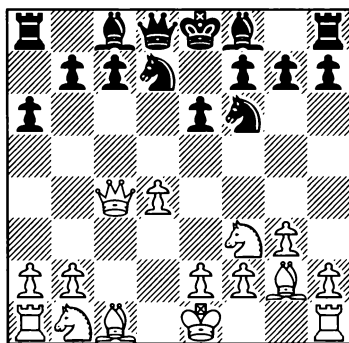
44 ♙e3 ♙xe3 45 fxe3 ♖h8 46 ♖a1 ♖xh5 47 ♖a7 g6 48 ♖a6 ♖h2 49 ♖xg6 ♖e2+ 50 ♙d1 ♖xe3 51 ♖g8 ♖g3 52 ♙d2 ♙c4 53 b3+ ♙xb3 54 g6 ♖g2+ 55 ♙e3 d2 56 ♖d8 ♙c2 57 ♖c8+ ♙d1 0-1

Game 25

Alekhine-Junge

Prague 1942

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖a4+ ♖bd7 6 ♜xc4 a6 7 ♙g2



7...b5

Also possible is 7...c5 8 dxc5 ♙xc5 9 ♜d3 b5!?, as played in Nogueiras-Marjanovic, Sarajevo 1985, which continued 10 ♙e5 ♖d5 11 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 12 ♖c3 ♖b4 13 ♜b1 ♙c6

14 0-0 ♖xg2 15 ♜xg2 0-0 16 a4 ♔d5 17 ♜d1 ♔xc3! (from here the rest is practically forced) 18 ♜xd8 ♔xb1 19 ♜xa8 ♜xa8 20 axb5 ♔a3! 21 bxa3 axb5 22 ♜b1 ♖xa3 23 ♖xa3 ♜xa3 and a draw was agreed.

8 ♜c6

8 ♜c2! is less ambitious. 8...c5 9 0-0 ♖b7 10 ♔c3 ♜c8 11 dxc5 ♖xc5 12 ♜b3 ♜b6 looked fine for Black in Skatchkov-Lastin, Nizhny Novgorod 1999. After 13 a4 b4 14 a5 ♜a7 15 ♔a4 ♖d5 16 ♜d1 ♜b7 17 ♔e1 ♖a7 18 ♖xd5 ♔xd5 19 ♔d3 h5 this unexpected pawn advance enabled Black to create an initiative: 20 ♔f4 ♔5f6 21 ♔b6 ♖xb6 22 axb6 h4 etc.

White delayed castling in Grabaczky-Krasenkov, Lubniewice 1998, so after 9 a4 ♖b7 10 dxc5 ♖xc5 11 axb5 axb5 12 ♜xa8 ♜xa8 13 ♔c3 0-0 Black was the first to complete development, seizing the initiative after 14 ♔xb5 ♖e4 15 ♜d1 ♔e5 16 0-0 ♜d8 17 ♜e1? ♔xf3+ 18 ♖xf3 ♖xf3 19 exf3 ♜xf3 20 ♔c3 ♜d3! 21 ♖f4 ♔g4 22 ♔e4 ♔xf2! 23 ♔xf2 ♜d1! with a decisive lead.

8...♜b8

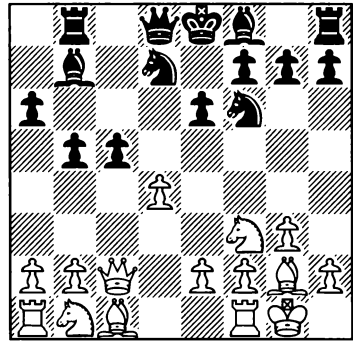
8...♜a7 is a bit awkward. 9 ♜c2 ♖b7 10 0-0 c5 11 a4 ♜a8 12 axb5 axb5 13 ♜xa7 ♜xa7 14 ♔a3 is given as slightly better for White by Neistadt as Black still needs to address his development. Pogorelov-Korneev, Albacete 2000 went instead 9 ♖f4 ♖b7 10 ♜c2 c5 11 dxc5 ♖xc5 12 0-0 0-0 13 ♔bd2 ♔d5 14 ♔b3 ♔xf4 15 gxf4 ♖b6 16 ♜fd1 ♜e7 17 ♜ac1 h6 18 ♔bd4 ♜c8 19 e3 ♔b8 with an unclear position in which Black has the bishop pair but White the more active pieces.

9 0-0

9 ♖g5 ♖b7 10 ♖xf6 ♖b4+ 11 ♔bd2 ♖xd2+ 12 ♔xd2 gxf6 13 ♜c3 c5 and White's king was stuck in the centre in Reschke-Meijers, Germany 2000. After 14 ♜hc1 c4 15 ♔e1 ♔b6 16 ♜d2 0-0 17 ♜f4 ♔h8 18 ♜h4 ♜g8 19 ♔f1 f5 20 ♜xd8 ♜gxh8 21 ♔e5 ♜xd4 22 ♔xf7+ ♔g7 23 ♖xb7 ♔xf7 24 ♖f3 ♜d2 25 ♜ab1 ♜bd8 Black entered the ending

the happier of the two.

9...♖b7 10 ♜c2 c5



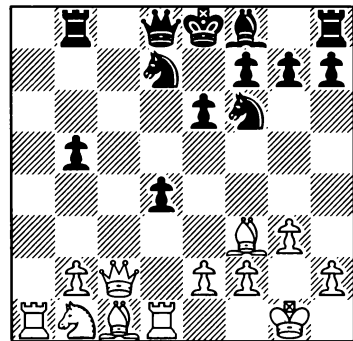
11 a4

11 ♔c3 ♜c8 transposes to 8 ♜c2 c5 9 0-0 ♖b7 10 ♔c3 ♜c8.

11...♖xf3?!

The decision to grab material is risky, leading Keres to suggest 11...♜c8 12 ♜b3 ♜b6 13 ♔a3 ♖c6 14 ♔e5 ♔xe5 15 dxe5 ♔d5 with counterplay.

12 ♖xf3 cxd4 13 axb5 axb5 14 ♜d1



14...♜b6

Other continuations are good for White, e.g. 14...♖c5 15 ♖f4 e5 16 ♖xe5 ♔xe5 17 ♜xc5, or 14...e5 15 e3! when the opening of the position is to White's benefit.

15 ♔d2 e5

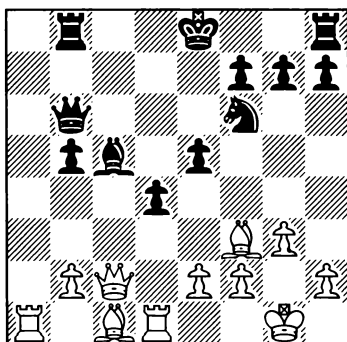
In the event of 15...♔e5 16 ♔b3 ♔xf3+ 17 exf3 White is in the driving seat. If Black tries to hold on to the d4-pawn he can get

into serious trouble, e.g. 17...♙d8 18 ♜xd4! ♙xd4 19 ♖a8+ ♕e7 20 ♙e3 and White is winning. 15...♙c5 16 ♜b3 presents White with compensation.

16 ♜b3 ♙c5?!

Better is 16...♙e7 17 e3 dxe3 18 ♙xe3 ♖e6, when 19 ♜a5! earns White compensation.

17 ♜xc5 ♙xc5?

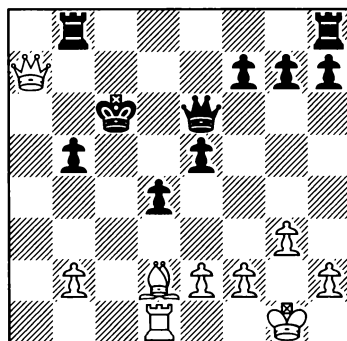


Inviting a brilliant reply. After the more circumspect 17...♖xc5 18 ♙c6+ ♜d7 19 ♖xc5 ♙xc5 20 ♖a5 White has only a modest edge.

18 ♖a6!! ♖xa6 19 ♖xc5 ♖e6 20 ♙c6+ ♜d7

Alekhine gives 20...♙d8 21 ♙d2 b4 22 ♖a1! ♜d7 23 ♙xd7 ♖xd7 24 ♖a7 and White is winning.

21 ♙xd7+ ♖xd7 22 ♖a7+ ♖c6 23 ♙d2!



Black's king is stranded.

23...♖hc8 24 e4! ♖b3 25 ♖a1! b4 26 ♖a6+ ♖b5 27 ♖a5+ ♖c6 28 ♖c5+ ♙d7 29 ♖a7+ 1-0

Black is mated.

Game 26

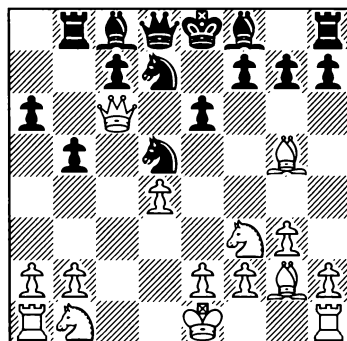
Cu.Hansen-Van Wely

Istanbul 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖a4+ ♜bd7 6 ♖xc4 a6 7 ♙g2 b5 8 ♖c6 ♖b8 9 ♙f4 ♜d5

Oll-Morozevich, Groningen 1997 went 9...♙b4+! 10 ♜bd2 (10 ♙d2 ♙c5!? is interesting, 11 dxc5 ♙b7 12 ♜e5 ♙xc6 13 ♜xc6 ♖c8 14 ♜a7 introducing a draw by repetition) 10...♙b7 11 ♖xc7 ♖xc7 12 ♙xc7 ♖c8 13 ♙f4 ♖c2 when, for the pawn sacrifice, Black has an active position. After 14 0-0 ♜d5 15 ♜b3! ♖xb2 16 ♙d2 ♜c3 17 ♙xc3 ♙xc3 18 ♖fc1 b4 Black was doing well as the game moved into an ending, with the bishop pair and a dangerous queenside majority. Morozevich evaluates 14 a3 ♙xd2+ 15 ♙xd2 ♖xb2 as unclear.

10 ♙g5



10...♙e7

Again 10...♙b4+! is possible. After 11 ♜bd2 ♜e7 12 ♙xe7 ♙xe7 13 ♖c1 White controls the c-file and has the better chances, but this is a lesser evil for Black than the eccentric 12...♙xe7?!, when Smyslov-S.Polgar, London 1996 left White better after

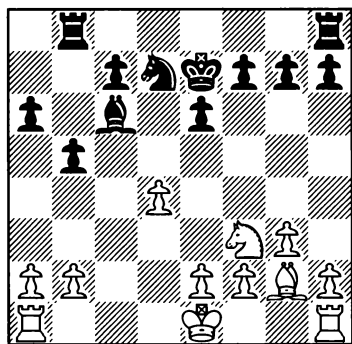
13 ♖c2 ♙b7 14 a3 ♙xd2+ 15 ♖xd2 f6 16 ♜c1 ♜c8 17 ♙b4+ ♙e8 18 0-0.

11 ♙xe7 ♖xe7 12 ♙c3 ♙b7

12...♙b4?! leads to wild complications: 13 ♖xc7! ♙c2+ 14 ♙d1! ♙xa1 15 ♙e5! ♖d8! 16 ♖xd8+ ♙xd8 17 ♙c6+ (better than 17 ♙xf7+ ♙e7 18 ♙xh8 b4 19 ♙a4 b3 and Black is doing fine) 17...♙c7 18 ♙xb8 and now Monin-Vul, Kecskemet 1992 went 18...♙xb8 19 ♙d2 ♙b6 20 ♜xa1 b4 21 ♙d1 ♜d8, when Black gets his pawn back after 22 e3 e5 but walks into the clever 23 b3 exd4 24 e4 (Vul) with the better prospects for White, whose knight will find a good outpost on d3. Illescas-Onischuk, Wijk aan Zee 1997 went 18...♙xb8 19 ♙d2 ♜d8 20 e3 e5, when Illescas proposes 21 ♜c1 with advantage to White, who keeps the extra pawn.

Also interesting is 12...♖b4!? 13 0-0 ♙xc3 14 bxc3 ♖d6 15 ♖xd6 cxd6, when the ending is okay for Black. Atalik-Li Wenliang, Beijing 1996 was agreed drawn after 16 a4 bxa4 17 ♜xa4 ♙e7 18 ♜fa1 ♙b2 19 e3 ♙b7 20 ♙e1 ♙xg2 21 ♙xg2 ♜c8 22 ♜xa6 ♜xc3 23 ♜6a2 ♜xa2 24 ♜xa2.

13 ♙xd5 ♙xc6 14 ♙xe7 ♙xe7



15 ♜c1

15 0-0 gives Black the opportunity to launch the c-pawn. Wojtkiewicz-Kaidanov, New York 1993 is a good example, when

15...♙xf3 16 ♙xf3 c5 17 dxc5 ♙xc5 18 ♜fc1 slightly favours White. The bishop is better than the knight, but Black's king is active near the centre. There followed 18...♜hc8 19 ♜c2 ♙d7 20 ♜ac1 ♙b6 21 ♜xc8 ♜xc8 22 ♜xc8 ♙xc8 23 ♙b7 ♙d6 24 ♙xa6 ♙d7 25 b3 ♙c6 26 a4 ♙b6 27 ♙xb5 ♙xb5 28 axb5 ♙xb5 29 ♙g2 ♙b4 30 ♙f3 ♙xb3 with a draw.

15...♙d5!?

Black also has 15...♙b6 16 0-0 ♜c8, e.g. 17 ♙d2 ♙xg2 18 ♙xg2 c5 19 dxc5 ♜xc5 20 ♙b3 ♜xc1 21 ♜xc1, when the knight is better on b3. Thanks to his control of the c-file White has the slightly better prospects. Gleizerov-Serper, Moscow 1992 proved less attractive for White after 17 ♙g5 ♙xg2 18 ♙xg2 ♙d6! 19 e3! when, if he had time for ♙e4, he would enjoy a solid advantage. However, 19...c5 20 dxc5 ♜d5! is enough for a small lead for Black.

16 ♜xc7 ♜hc8 17 ♜a7

17 ♜xc8 ♜xc8 18 ♙d2 ♙f6 and Black controls the light squares in the centre and has compensation for the pawn.

17...♜a8

Also possible is 17...♜c2!? 18 0-0 f6, again with compensation.

18 ♜xa8 ♙xa8 19 ♙d2 ♙f6 20 ♙e1

20 ♙g1 seems too slow. After 20...♜c4 21 ♙e5 ♜xd4+ 22 ♙e3 ♜d8 23 ♙xa8 ♜xa8 24 ♜c1 the idea is to generate activity but Black defends successfully with 24...♙d5+.

20...♙xg2 21 ♙xg2 ♜d8 22 e3 ♙e4+ 23 ♙e2 ♜c8

Black is very active.

24 ♙e1 ♜c1 25 ♙g1 f5 26 f3 ♙f6 27 ♙g2

Or 27 ♙d2 ♜a1 28 a3 ♙d5 with compensation.

27...♙d5 28 e4 fxe4 29 fxe4 ♙f6 30 ♙d3 ♜c4 31 ♙e5 ♜c2+ 32 ♙f3 ♙xg2 33 ♙xg2 ♙xe4 ½-½

Summary

After 5...c6 6 ♖xc4 b5 7 ♖c2 ♘b7 8 ♙g2 ♟bd7 the continuation 9 ♟e5 is the most interesting available to White, albeit one that offers nothing more than equality. Black has 9...♟xe5 10 dxe5 ♟d5!, closing the dangerous h1-a8 diagonal, but perhaps 9...♖b6 is even more precise, attacking the d4-pawn and renewing the threat of ...c6-c5.

There is also another defence that confirms 5 ♖a4+ lacks punch. After 5...♙d7 6 ♖xc4 ♙c6 7 ♙g2 the game Andersson-Illescas is perhaps the most exact advertisement: 7...♙d5 8 ♖d3 ♙e4 9 ♖d1 c5 10 ♟c3 ♙c6 etc.

Black can, step by step, equalize in the 5...♟bd7 variation. As is demonstrated in Game 24, Black should not fear 6 ♖xc4 a6 7 ♖c2 c5 8 ♙g2. Actually this is the position from the variation 5...c6 6 ♖xc4 b5 7 ♖c2 ♘b7 8 ♙g2 ♟bd7 with the extra tempo ...a7-a6 (as Black will play ...c6-c5 later in that line, but here do it in one go with ...c7-c5), which is therefore a definite improvement on a position considered fine for Black. It is interesting that the same position can occur after the main continuation 8 ♖c6 ♚b8 (after 9 0-0 ♘b7 10 ♖c2 c5). For Black it is enough to play ...♚b8-c8, which guarantees him an equal game. Therefore White most often aims to use the position of the queen on c6 for an attack on the weakened c7-square with 9 ♙f4.

Black can sacrifice a pawn in order to activate his pieces with 9...♙b4 (Morozevich). In Game 26, Hansen-Van Wely, we see that in the main line after 9...♟d5 10 ♙g5 ♙e7 11 ♙xe7 ♖xe7 the chances are approximately even.

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♟f3 ♟f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖a4+ ♟bd7

5...c6 6 ♖xc4 b5 7 ♖c2 ♘b7 8 ♙g2 ♟bd7 (D)

9 0-0 – Game 19; 9 ♟e5 – Game 20

5...♙d7 6 ♖xc4

6...c5 7 dxc5 ♙c6 8 ♙g2 – see Game 76 (Chapter 7)

6...♙c6 7 ♙g2 (D)

7...♟bd7 – Game 21; 7...♙d5 – Game 22

6 ♖xc4

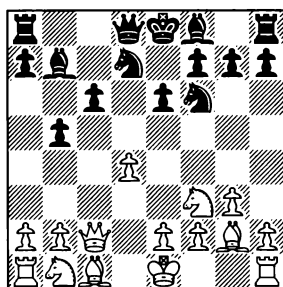
6 ♙g2 a6 7 ♟c3 – Game 23

6...a6 7 ♙g2

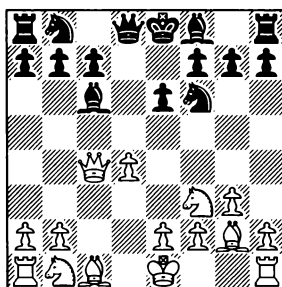
7 ♖c2 – Game 24

7...b5 8 ♖c6 ♚b8 (D)

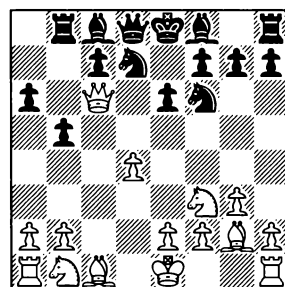
9 0-0 – Game 25; 9 ♙f4 – Game 26



8...♟bd7



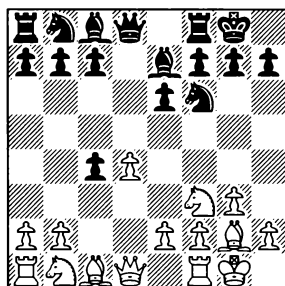
7 ♙g2



8...♚b8

CHAPTER FOUR

The Semi-Open Catalan: 4...dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♗f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♗g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0

In this chapter we consider the lines where Black simply completes development and refrains from defending the extra pawn on c4. This approach is the so-called Semi-Open Catalan (from now on the SC) and is one of the most popular systems. Here, as a rule, the game is less sharp than strategic in nature.

The position after 6 0-0 0-0 arises in the main via the move order 1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♗f6 4 g3 ♗e7 5 ♗g2 0-0 6 0-0 dxc4. But all roads lead to Rome and, once you are there, you look at the city rather than the route behind you.

Now 7 ♗bd2 allows Black to defend his extra pawn with 7...b5, which is not desirable for White, of course. 7 a4 prevents ...b7-b5 but in itself is not a useful developing move. The gambit continuation 7 ♗c3 was quite popular at the end of the eighties and during the beginning of the nineties, but over the last few years this interest has cooled down. After 7...♗c6 8 e3 it is not good for Black to play 8...♗d7 (Game 27). Black should prefer 8...♞b8 with the intention of ...b7-b5, or 8...♗d6 with ...e6-e5. Practice has proved that Black has good counter-chances here. Perhaps White has to pay attention to the sharp 8 e4 if he wants to keep this gambit line alive.

The 7 ♗a3 line is a very eccentric option which leads to sharp positions that can feature odd pawn structures. For example after 7...♗xa3 8 bxa3 White's queenside is destroyed. As compensation White has the bishop pair, a strong pawn centre and potential play on the semi-open b- and c-files. Nevertheless Black has different ways to neutralize White's initiative.

The continuation 7 ♗e5 looks quite natural. White attacks the c4-pawn and increases the pressure on the long diagonal. For a long time this variation was considered to be the most effective weapon against the SC. Then GM Kuzmin discovered an eccentric queen manoeuvre that begins with 7...♞d6. Now after 8 ♗xc4 ♞a6 the queen both vacates the d-file for the rook and protects b7. However, White can reach an advantage in numerous ways.

The old-fashioned 7...c5 has practically disappeared from modern practice. After 8 dxc5 White easily gets a slight but enduring edge. In fact in this line White can even generate a kingside offensive, e.g. 8...♗xc5 9 ♗c3 ♞c7 10 ♗xc4 ♗xf2 11 ♞xf2 ♞xc4 12 ♞xf6! gxf6 13 ♗h6 (Game 30).

In the game Gheorgiu-Robatsch, Helsinki 1972 the Austrian GM played the unbelievable 7...♗c6!? – Black returns the pawn and sees his queenside ruined in return for

slightly better development and pressure down the b-file. Here White has a major choice between 8 ♖xc6 bxc6 9 ♖xc6 ♗e8 10 ♖xe7 ♗xe7 11 ♗a4 (Game 31), 8 ♖xc6 bxc6 9 e3 (Game 32) and the more popular 8 ♖xc6 bxc6 9 ♖a3 (Games 33 & 34).

The main line these days is 7 ♗c2, with the obvious aim of restoring material equity. If Black tries to protect his extra pawn with ...b7-b5 he can quickly lose material after 8 a4 c6? 9 axb5 cxb5 10 ♖g5.

After 7 ♗c2 c5 White has a steady edge similar to that after 7 ♖e5 c5. The most common reply to 7 ♗c2 is 7...a6. Now White has to decide whether he wants to take on c4 immediately or first prevent ...b7-b5 with 8 a4. The 8 a4 line has, over time, become very popular. The defences 8...b6 and 8...♖bd7 have disappeared from recent practice, and even 8...♖c6 is seldom seen. After 9 ♗xc4 ♗d5 10 ♖bd2 ♗d8 11 e3 Black rehabilitated 11...♗d7 in Lahner-Michenka with tactics, replying to 12 ♖e5? ♖xe5 13 ♗c7 with 13...♖c6! etc. However, after the quiet 12 b3 Black's position is passive.

In the case of 8...c5 (Game 35) 9 ♖bd2 cxd4 10 ♖xc4 ♖c6 11 ♗d1 ♖d5 it is interesting to play 12 ♖d4, but it seems that this is not enough for an advantage. Instead White obtains the better prospects after 9 dxc5 ♖xc5 10 ♖bd2 ♖c6 11 ♖xc4 ♗e7 12 ♖fe5.

Today, after 8 a4, most players prefer 8...♗d7 to try to place the bishop on the long diagonal. White gets very little from exchanging this bishop with 9 ♖e5 ♖c6 10 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 because Black is well developed. After 8...♗d7 White should choose between 9 ♗d1 ♖c6 10 ♖c3 (Games 36 & 37) and 9 ♗c4 (Games 38-40).

The immediate 8 ♗xc4 permits Black's bishop to occupy the long diagonal after 8...b5 9 ♗c2 ♗b7. The drawback of this continuation from Black's point of view is the weakening of the queenside pawns. The main plan for Black here is the advance ...c7-c5. For example after 10 ♖g5 Black often

plays ...c7-c5 without any trouble. Such positions tend to be equal. This is why most players now prefer to develop the dark-squared bishop on f4 (Games 41 & 42) or d2 (Games 43-45). After 10 ♖f4 ♖d6 or 10 ♖d2 ♖d6 the further 11 ♖g5 makes more sense as it is difficult for Black to achieve ...c7-c5 (see the notes to Game 43). After 10 ♖f4 we consider 10...♖c6 in Game 41 and 10...♖d5 in Game 42. We discuss various possibilities for Black after 10 ♖d2 in Game 43, and various 11th moves for Black after 10 ♖d2 ♖e4 11 ♗c1 in Game 44. The main answer, the subtle manoeuvre 11...♗b7, is considered in Game 45.

Game 27

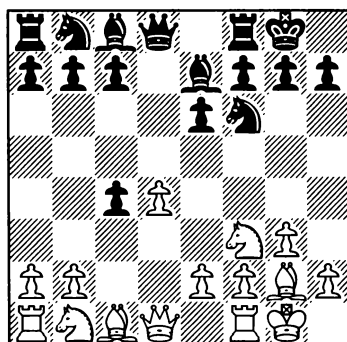
Wojtkiewicz-Dzhandzhgava

Hastings 1989/90

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♗e7 6 0-0

Another move is 6 ♖c3, one sample game going 6...0-0 7 ♖e5 c5 8 dxc5 ♗c7 9 ♖xc4 ♗xc5 10 ♗b3 ♖c6 11 ♖e3 ♖d4 12 ♖xd4 ♗xd4 13 0-0 ♗b8, when White had some pressure on the queenside in Gelfand-Speelman, Linares 1991, although Black managed to free himself in the event of 14 ♗fd1 ♗c5 15 ♗ac1 ♖d7 16 ♖e4 ♗b5 17 ♗d3 ♗fd8 18 ♖ed6 ♗a6 19 ♖e3 b5 20 ♗a3 ♗b6, with an equal middlegame position.

6...0-0



7 ♖c3

Also possible is 7 ♖bd2 b5 8 a4 c6 9 ♖e5 ♖d5 10 e4 ♖f6 11 d5 with a typical break in the centre in Kostic-Cvetkovic, Yugoslavia 1993. There followed 11... ♖c7! 12 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 13 dxc6 ♖xc6 14 axb5 ♖xb5 15 e5 ♖d5 16 ♖g4 ♖a6 17 ♖e4 ♖h8 18 ♖c3, when Black sacrificed the exchange and had a good position after 18... ♖xc3!? 19 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 20 bxc3 ♖b7.

The advance 7 a4 ♖c6 8 a5 looks harmless and Black shouldn't experience any problems. 8... ♖b8 9 ♖c2 ♖xd4 (9...b5!? is interesting, 10 axb6 axb6 11 ♖xc4 ♖b7 12 ♖c3 ♖a5 evaluated as equal by Kozul) 10 ♖xd4 ♖xd4 11 ♖e3 ♖d6! 12 ♖xa7 ♖a8 13 ♖e3 ♖d5 is pleasant for Black according to Kotronias. Nor does 12 ♖xc4 promise White more than equality after 12... ♖d5 13 ♖xa7 ♖a8 14 ♖d4 c5 15 ♖c3 b5!? 16 ♖xb5 ♖a6, when the situation is unclear.

7... ♖c6

7...c5 8 dxc5 ♖c6 9 ♖a4 ♖a5 10 ♖xc4 e5!? (10... ♖xc5 11 ♖xc5 ♖xc5 12 ♖g5 slightly favours White) 11 ♖e3 ♖e6 12 ♖a4 ♖xa4 13 ♖xa4 ♖d5 14 ♖d2 f5 was Scheeren-O.Rodriquez, Eindhoven 1986. It looks as if Black has compensation for the pawn, but with active play White managed to drum up an initiative with 15 e4! fxe4 16 ♖g5 ♖xg5 17 ♖xg5 h6 18 ♖e3 ♖xe3 19 fxe3 ♖xf1+ 20 ♖xf1 ♖xa2 21 ♖c3 ♖c4 22 ♖d1 ♖d8 23 ♖xd8+ ♖xd8 24 ♖xe4, with the superior ending (his knight is very good).

7... ♖bd7 transposes to 4... ♖e7 5 ♖g2 0-0 6 0-0 ♖bd7 7 ♖c3 dxc4.

8 e3

Also possible is 8 e4 ♖b8 9 ♖e3 (9 e5 ♖d5 10 ♖e4 gives White a space advantage and control of the important c5-square, inviting an assessment of unclear) 9...b5 10 a3 ♖a5 11 ♖c2 ♖b7 12 ♖ad1, when White is well developed and will soon be ready for action in the centre. Filippov-Kiriakov, Moscow 1995 continued 12...a6 13 d5 exd5 14 exd5 ♖b3 15 ♖e5 ♖e8 16 ♖c6 ♖xc6 17

dx6 and the bishop pair compensated for Black's extra pawn.

8... ♖d7?!

Black has other options.

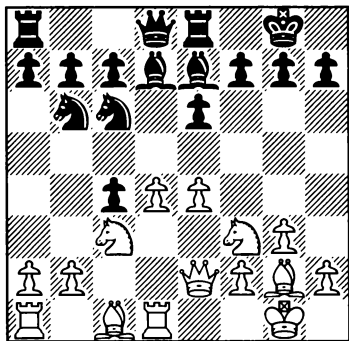
After 8... ♖b8 9 ♖a4 ♖b4?! 10 ♖xa7 ♖d7 11 ♖e5 White won back the pawn with a superior position in Gleizerov-Berzinsh, Berlin 1995. There followed 11... ♖fd5 12 ♖xb8! ♖xb8 13 ♖xd7 ♖a7 14 ♖xf8 ♖xf8 15 ♖xd5 exd5 16 ♖d2 and the rooks were stronger than the queen – 16...c6 17 a3 ♖d3 18 ♖c3 b5 19 ♖fd1 ♖d7 20 b3 h5 21 bxc4 dxc4 22 h4 ♖d6 23 e4 etc. Sorokin-Zarnicki, Buenos Aires 1995 went instead 9... ♖d7 10 ♖xc4 ♖a5 11 ♖e2 c5 12 dxc5 ♖xc5 13 ♖e5 ♖e8 14 ♖d1 ♖c7 15 ♖d3 ♖d6 16 e4 and White was in control: 16... ♖c4 17 ♖g5 ♖c6 18 ♖ac1 ♖a5? (18... ♖d7 19 b3 ♖a5 20 ♖f4 improves, with a plus for White) 19 h4? (after 19 ♖xf6 gxf6 20 ♖e1! b5 21 b3 ♖b4 22 ♖g4+ ♖h8 23 ♖f3 White obtains a winning position) 19... ♖e5 20 ♖d2 ♖a6 21 ♖xe5 with a draw.

8... ♖d6 9 ♖d2 e5 10 ♖xc4 exd4 11 exd4 ♖g4 12 ♖b3 (Kotronias gives 12 ♖a4 ♖xd4 13 ♖xd6 ♖xd6 14 ♖f4 ♖c5!? 15 ♖e3 ♖ad8 16 ♖xb7 ♖b6, when Black is doing well thanks to his well placed knight) 12... ♖xd4 13 ♖xb7 ♖f3! and now Lautier-Karpov, Dos Hermanas 1995 went 14 ♖a6? ♖b4 15 ♖e3 ♖xg2 16 ♖fd1 c5 17 ♖xd4 cxd4 18 ♖xg2 ♖c8 with an advantage to Black in view of the bishop and the somewhat exposed position of White's king. Additionally, the d-pawn is strong rather than weak in this position. Karpov proposes 14 ♖xf3! ♖b8 15 ♖xa7 ♖xf3+ 16 ♖g2 ♖d7! and Black forces the draw – 17 ♖xd6! ♖h4+ 18 gxh4 ♖g4+ etc.

9 ♖a4 e5 10 d5 ♖b4 11 ♖xe5 leads to complications after 11...a6 12 f4 ♖bxd5 13 ♖xc4 ♖xc3 14 bxc3 ♖c5 (Korchnoi) with an unclear position. Not good here is 12 ♖f3? ♖f5 13 ♖d4 ♖d3 14 ♖e1 ♖c5 15 e4 ♖bxd5! and Black won a pawn in Lautier-Korchnoi, Moscow 1994, when 16 ♖f5

♖xc3 17 bxc3 ♖g4 18 ♖e3 ♖xf2! was terrible for White.

9 ♗e2 ♖b6 10 ♖d1 ♖d7 11 e4 ♗e8



12 ♗e3

12 ♗f4! is worth a try.

12...♗f8 13 h4

White uses his space advantage to engineer an attack.

13...♗c8 14 ♗f4 a6 15 h5 h6 16 a3 f6

Black has no time to push the c-pawn immediately as 16...♖a5 17 ♖e5! c5 18 dxc5 ♗xc5 19 ♗g4! (Wojtkiewicz) is very promising for White.

17 e5 f5 18 ♖h4 ♖e7 19 g4! ♖bd5 20 ♗d2 ♗c6

After 20...♖xc3 21 bxc3 fxc4 22 ♗xc4 White still has a dangerous attack, although this looks better than what happens in the game.

21 gxf5 exf5 22 ♗xc4

White has won back the pawn and Black still hasn't completed development.

22...♖d8 23 ♖xd5! ♗xd5

23...♖xd5?! 24 ♗h3 loses the pawn on f5.

24 ♗xd5+ ♖xd5 25 ♗d3 f4 26 ♗f5!

In the ending White keeps the advantage.

26...♗xf5 27 ♖xf5 ♗f7 28 ♖h4 ♗e7

Another line goes 28...c5 29 dxc5 ♗xc5 30 ♗ac1 ♗b6 31 ♖g6 ♗e6 32 ♗g2 with advantage to White, the f4-pawn being vulnerable. Nevertheless, Black should go for this break at some point in order to undermine the support of the e5-pawn.

29 ♖g6 ♗g5 30 ♗g2 ♗e6 31 ♗f3 ♖d7

Or 31...♗f5 32 ♗e1! ♖d7 33 ♗e4 and f4 falls.

32 ♗e4 ♖ad8 33 ♗ac1

Now ...c7-c5 is no longer possible.

33...♗f7 34 ♗g1!

Directed against ...f4-f3.

34...♗f5 35 ♗g4 ♖d7 36 b4 c6 37 a4 f3

38 ♗xg5 hxg5 39 b5!

The final breakthrough.

39...axb5 40 axb5 ♗c7

40...cxb5 loses to 41 ♗c8 ♖df7 42 ♗c8+ ♖d7 43 e6+ etc.

41 ♗c5 ♗c8 42 bxc6 bxc6 43 ♗g1 ♖f4

44 ♗gc1 ♖f7 45 ♗xc6+ ♗xc6 46 ♗xc6+

1-0

White plays 7 ♖a3

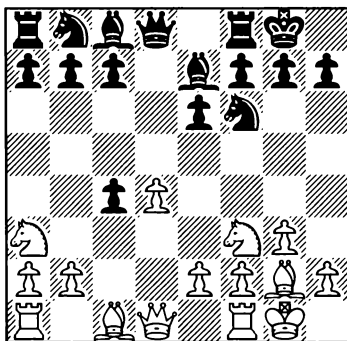
Game 28

Poluljahov-Nikolaev

Belorechensk 1988

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5

♗g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♖a3



7...♗xa3

Also possible is 7...c3 8 bxc3 c5, although this seems to help White consolidate the centre. Grabuzov-Vavra, Pardubice 1993 continued 9 ♖e5 ♖bd7 (9...♖d5 10 ♗b3 cxd4 11 cxd4 ♖c6 12 ♖xc6 bxc6 13 e4 ♖b6 14 ♗e3 is a shade preferable for White) 10 ♖ac4 ♖xe5 11 ♖xe5 ♗c7 12 ♗b3 ♖d8 13

♠f4 ♖h5 14 ♠e3 ♖f6 15 ♜fd1 and White's central control was enough for an edge.

Black also has 7...♠d7 8 ♖xc4 ♠c6 9 ♠f4 ♖bd7 10 ♜c1 ♠d5 11 ♖fe5 ♠xg2 12 ♖xg2 ♖xe5 13 ♠xe5 c5 (Krasenkow-Gagarin, USSR 1998) 14 ♠xf6 gxf6 15 dxc5 ♠xc5 16 e3 with a minimal advantage to White in view of Black's damaged structure.

7...c5 and now 8 ♖xc4 is a transposition from 7 ♖bd2 c5 8 ♖c4, Shtyrenkov-Mikulchik, Zlin 1995 continuing 8...♖c6 9 dxc5 ♠xc5 10 ♠f4 ♖d5 11 ♜c1!? ♖xf4 12 gxf4 ♜e7 13 ♖ce5 ♖b4 14 a3 ♖d5 15 e3 ♠b6 16 ♜b3 ♠d7 17 ♖xd7 ♜xd7 18 ♖e5 when, due to the Catalan pawn cluster with f2, e3 and f4, White had a firm grip on the centre. In Kozul-Ivanovic, Yugoslavia 1989 White took the other c-pawn: 8 dxc5 ♠xc5 9 ♖xc4 ♖c6 10 a3 a5 11 ♠g5 h6 12 ♜xd8 ♜xd8 13 ♠xf6 gxf6 14 ♜fd1 ♠d7 15 ♖fd2! and (again) Black's weakened pawns tipped the balance in White's favour, while White's more active forces are also significant.

8 bxa3 b5

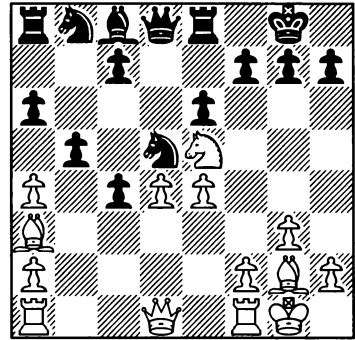
Another possibility is 8...♖d5 9 ♜c2 b5 10 ♜b1 a6 11 ♜d1 h6 12 ♖e5 ♠d7 13 a4 ♖c6 14 ♠a3 with compensation for the pawn in Kamsky-Gogoladze, Ivano-Frankovsk 1988. The earlier encounter Sveshnikov-Ubilava, USSR 1981 went 8...♖bd7 9 a4 a5 10 ♠a3 ♜e8 11 ♜c1 ♠a6!? (11...♖b6 12 ♖e5 ♠d7 13 ♠xb7 ♠xa4 14 ♜d2 and Black keeps the pawn but at the cost of damaging his own pawns, and White also has the bishop pair) 12 ♜xc4 ♖b6 13 ♜c5 ♠d7 14 ♖e5 ♖xa4 15 ♠xb7 ♖xc5 16 ♠xc5 ♠c8 17 ♖c6 ♜d7 18 ♖b8 ♜b5 19 ♠xa6 ♠xa6 20 ♖xa6 ♜xa6 21 ♜c2 and the bishop and superior formation left White on top.

9 a4

An interesting plan is 9 ♖g5!? c6 10 e4 h6 11 e5 ♖d5 12 ♖e4, White's knight exploiting the weakened dark squares in Black's camp. Kinsman-Stefansson, Stockholm 1993 saw White emerge from 12...f5 13 exf6 ♖xf6 14

♖xf6+ ♜xf6 15 ♠f4 ♜e7 16 a4 ♠b7 17 ♜e1 with definite compensation.

9...a6 10 ♠a3 ♜e8 11 ♖e5 ♖d5 12 e4



12...♖b6

In the event of 12...♖f6 White can sacrifice a piece with 13 ♖xf7!? ♖xf7 14 e5 ♖d5 15 ♜h5+ ♖g8 16 ♠e4 g6, when Krasenkow-Arbakov, Moscow 1989 witnessed 17 ♠xg6! hxg6 18 ♜xg6+ ♖h8 19 ♜fe1 ♖c3 (White's threat was ♠e4) 20 ♜e3 ♠b7 (20...♜d7 21 ♜h5+ ♖g7 22 ♜f3 ♖d5 23 g4! – Krasenkow – wins for White) 21 ♜xc3 ♖d7?! 22 ♜h6+ ♖g8 23 g4 ♜e7 24 ♜h3 with a dangerous attack. Black can improve with 21...♖c6!, forcing the draw: 22 ♜h6+ ♖g8 23 ♜g6+ ♖h8 etc. (Mitenkov). Note that Black must accept the second sacrifice, e.g. 17...♜e7?! 18 ♠xe7 ♜xe7 19 ♠e4 (also strong is 19 ♠xh7+!? ♜xh7 20 ♜e8+ ♖g7 21 ♜xc8 and Black's forces lack co-ordination) 19...♖c6 20 f4 ♜f7, Kuzmin-Anand, Frunze 1988. Then Anand gives 21 ♠xh7+! ♜xh7 22 ♜e8+ ♖g7 23 f5! ♠b7 24 f6+ ♖h6 25 f7 with a near decisive lead.

If this is not your style, then there is the quieter 13 ♜b1 ♠b7 14 ♜e1, after which Black must play precisely to maintain the balance. Gleizerov-Zhukhovitsky, USSR 1986 continued 14...♖c6 15 ♖xc4 ♜xd4 16 ♜c2 ♜xc4 (16...♜a7 17 ♖d2 is interesting) 17 ♜xc4 bxc4 18 ♠xb7 and now instead of 18...♖e5?! 19 ♜c1 ♜e8 20 f4 ♖c6 21 ♜bb1 a5 22 ♜xc4 ♖b4 23 ♠xb4 axb4 24 ♜xb4,

Black should have played 18...♗d4 19 e5 ♗d5 with chances for both sides. White has the bishop pair to compensate the two knights and the passed pawn on the c-file.

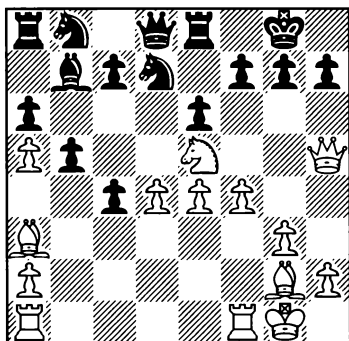
13 a5

An interesting option is 13 ♖h5!? f6 14 ♗g4 c6 15 a5 ♗a4.

13...♗d6d7 14 f4

But now the same manoeuvre is not to be recommended for White: 14 ♖h5?! ♗xe5 15 dxe5 ♖d3 16 ♖e7 (16 ♖c5 and the queen sacrifice 16...♗d7 17 ♖ad1 ♗xc5!? is good) 16...♖xe7 17 ♖ad1 c5 18 ♖xd3 cxd3 and Black has the better chances. The pawn phalanx is very strong.

14...♖b7 15 ♖h5



15...g6

15...♗xe5 16 fxe5 ♖xd4+ 17 ♖h1 wins a pawn for Black but the f-file is opened for attack.

16 ♖h6?

A poor move. White finds himself with the initiative after 16 ♖h3 ♗xe5 17 dxe5 ♖d4+ 18 ♖h1 ♖xe4 19 ♖ad1 ♖e3 20 ♖fe1 ♖xa3 21 ♖xe4.

16...♗f6?

16...♗xe5 17 dxe5 ♖d4+ 18 ♖h1 ♖xe4 19 ♖ad1 ♖xg2+ 20 ♖xg2 ♖e4+ 21 ♖h3 ♗c6 wins for Black.

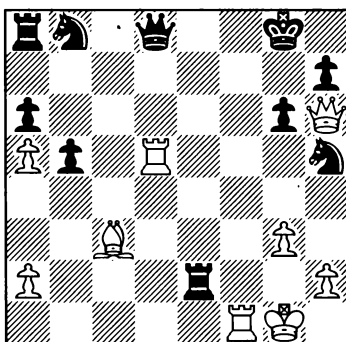
17 d5 c3

The capture 17...exd5 18 exd5 ♖xd5 19 ♖ad1 c6 20 ♖b2 simply creates attacking chances for White.

18 ♖b4 exd5 19 exd5 ♖xd5 20 ♖xc3 ♖xg2 21 ♗g4!

21 ♖xg2 ♖d5+ 22 ♖f3 is a more quiet approach, the dark-squared bishop promising White good chances. Nevertheless, White's attack in the game looks formidable.

21...♗h5 22 ♖ad1! ♖d5 23 f5! ♖e2 24 ♗e3 c6 25 fxg6 fxg6 26 ♗xd5 cxd5 27 ♖xd5



27...♗d7??

The only route is 27...♖e8 28 ♖xh5 ♖e3+ 29 ♖xe3 ♖xe3, when White keeps an advantage in the endgame due to his more active forces after 30 ♖c5 ♗d7 31 ♖c7 ♗e5 32 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 33 ♖ff7 ♖c8 34 ♖xh7 ♖xc7 35 ♖xc7 b4 36 ♖c6 ♖xa5 37 ♖xg6+ ♖f7 38 ♖g4 ♖xa2 39 ♖xb4 a5.

28 ♖xh5! ♖e7 29 ♖xg6+! 1-0

Game 29

Khalifman-Portisch

Reykjavik 1991

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♗f3 ♗f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♖e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♗a3 ♖xa3 8 bxa3 ♖d7

After 8...♗c6 9 ♖b2 V.Mikhalevsky-Pigusov, Ubeda 1997 went 9...♗d5 10 ♖c1 ♗b6 11 e4 ♖d7 12 ♖e1, when White's central control served as sufficient compensation for the pawn. There followed 12...♗e7 13 ♗e5 ♖b5 14 ♖h5 ♖e8 15 ♖h3 f5 16 ♖g5 h6 17 ♖h4 ♖f6 (17...♗g6 18 ♗xg6 ♖xg6 19

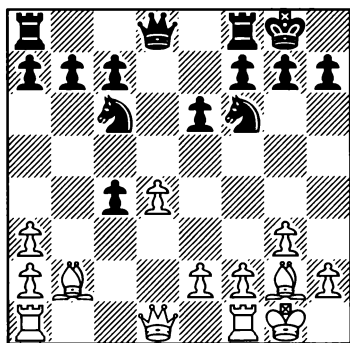
d5 is well balanced) 18 ♖g2 c6 19 d5!? cxd5 20 exd5 ♖exd5 21 ♖xc4 ♖xc4 22 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 23 ♖xc4 ♖xc4 24 ♖xc4 ♖c8 25 ♖b3 ♖f7 26 ♖xb7+ ♖d7, the smoke clearing to reveal a level ending.

Another path is 9...♖b8 10 ♖c2 b5 11 ♖ad1 when Korchnoi-O.Rodriguez, Barcelona 1992 continued 11...♖e7 (11...♖b7?! 12 ♖g5! h6 13 d5! ♖b4 14 axb4 hxg5 15 dxe6 ♖e7 16 exf7+ ♖xf7 17 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 18 ♖g6! left Black with weak pawns in Glek-Klovans, Tashkent 1987) 12 e4 ♖b7 13 ♖fe1 ♖g6 14 h4. White's latest thrust is quite typical. Having completed development and with control of the centre, White begins a kingside offensive: 14...♖e8 15 ♖h2 ♖e7 16 ♖e2 e5 17 h5 ♖f8 18 dxe5 ♖d6 19 ♖g4 h6 20 f4 with a menacing initiative.

9 ♖e5

Zaichik-Soffer, Rishon le Zion 1998 went 9 ♖c2 ♖c6, Black surrendering the c4-pawn to complete development. This policy proved successful after 10 ♖xc4 ♖bd7 11 ♖g5 ♖d5 12 ♖b4 b6 13 ♖fd1 h6 14 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 15 ♖ac1 ♖fc8 16 ♖b1 ♖b7 17 e4 ♖e7 18 ♖d3 ♖f8 19 d5 ♖d8 20 ♖b3 ♖ac8, when Black had a solid position.

9...♖c6 10 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 11 ♖b2



11...♖d5

11...♖d7?! looks wrong. Kozul-Kir.Georgiev, Sarajevo 2002 went 12 ♖a4 ♖xd4 13 ♖xc4 ♖ad8, when Georgiev proposes 14 ♖fd1 e5 15 e3 ♖e6 16 ♖xe6 ♖xe6

17 ♖xe5 for White, whose bishops dominate in this wide open position.

Another try is 11...♖d6!? 12 ♖c1 b5 13 e4 e5! 14 f4 ♖ad8! 15 d5 (15 fxe5 ♖xe5 16 ♖c2 ♖b6 favours Black, whose knight is heading for d3) 15...exf4 16 gxf4 ♖fe8. Here White's centre looks dominating, but White must keep his eyes peeled, e.g. 17 ♖h1 ♖xe4! 18 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 19 dxc6 ♖xc6 20 ♖f3 ♖d3 21 ♖g2 ♖g6 with the superior ending for Black. White was more circumspect in Alburt-Geller, New York 1990, albeit only for a few moves: 17 ♖c2 ♖e7 18 ♖f2 ♖g4 19 ♖g3 f5 20 ♖cd1 ♖b6+ and now 21 ♖d4? met with 21...♖g6! 22 ♖f3 h5! and Black assumed control because White was unable to hold on to the centre and his king was also susceptible to attack. Geller offers 21 ♖h1 as an improvement, when 21...♖e3!? 22 ♖f3 c3 23 ♖c1 ♖c5 24 ♖xg4 fxg4 25 ♖xg4 ♖g6 is unclear.

12 ♖b1

Glek-Klovans, Frunze 1988 went 12 ♖c1 ♖b6 13 e3 ♖d7 14 ♖c2 ♖ab8 15 ♖fd1 ♖e7 16 ♖f1 ♖a4 17 ♖b1, White uninterested in the exchange of queens as this would relieve some of the pressure. After 17...♖fd8 18 e4 ♖d6 19 ♖a1 f6 20 ♖e1 ♖c6 21 ♖h3 ♖f8 22 e5! fxe5 23 dxe5 ♖d2 24 ♖xe6+ ♖h8 25 ♖f1 ♖b5 26 ♖c3 ♖d3 the situation remained unclear.

12...♖b6

12...b5?! 13 e4 ♖b6, as in Krasenkow-Timoscenko, Tashkent 1987, appears dubious. Krasenkow analyses the following: 14 d5! ♖e7 15 ♖g4 ♖g6 16 dxe6 with the more pleasant game for White, or 14...exd5 15 exd5 ♖e7 16 d6 ♖xd6 17 ♖xd6 cxd6 18 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 19 ♖fd1 when Black has two pawns for the exchange but White's activity and Black's vulnerable pawns combine to favour the first player.

13 e3 ♖d6 14 ♖c2 ♖fd8 15 ♖fd1 ♖ab8 16 e4 e5! 17 d5

This is better than 17 dxe5?! ♖c5 18 e6 fxe6 19 ♖xd8+ ♖xd8 20 e5 ♖d4 21 ♖xd4

♙xd4 with an aggressive stance for Black.

17...♙d4! 18 ♖xd4 exd4 19 ♙xd4 c6

The greedy looking 19...♙xa3 20 e5 ♙c5 is an option.

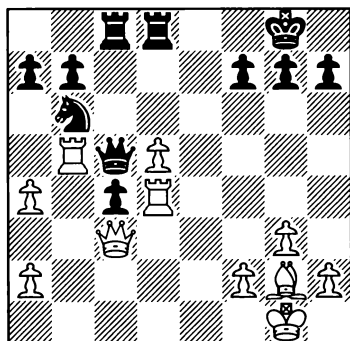
20 a4 ♙c5

20...cxd5 21 exd5 g6 22 a5 ♙c5 23 ♙c3 ♙xd5 24 ♙xc4 ♙xc4 25 ♙xc4 was seen in Krasenkow-Flear, Paris 1990, the Catalan bishop affording White the lead.

21 ♙c3 cxd5

21...♙xa4 22 ♙xc4 ♙xc4 23 ♙xc4 ♙b6 24 dxc6 ♙xc4 25 c7 ♙dc8 26 cxb8 ♙ ♙xb8 (Korpić-Gyimesi, Balatonbereny 1992) leads to a similar minor piece endgame, with the better prospects for White.

22 exd5 ♙bc8 23 ♙b5



23...♙e7?!

23...♙xa4 24 ♙xc5 ♙xc5 25 ♙dxc4 ♙xc5 26 ♙xc5 ♙xa2 and a draw was agreed in Nesis-Andonov, Correspondence 1997.

24 a5 ♙a4 25 ♙c2 ♙e1+ 26 ♙f1 ♙c3 27 ♙xb7 ♙xd5 28 ♙xc4

With 28 ♙d1! ♙e5 (28...♙xa5? loses to 29 ♙f5!) 29 ♙xc4 White keeps an advantage.

28...♙e3!?

Black has to try something. The straightforward 28...♙xc4 29 ♙xc4 ♙xa5 30 ♙a6 leads to a very difficult ending.

29 fxe3 ♙xc4 30 ♙xc4 ♙xe3+ 31 ♙g2 ♙d2+ 32 ♙h3 ♙h6+ 33 ♙h4? ½-½

Inviting Black to force perpetual check. However, with the following amazing king march White could have kept the piece and

retained excellent winning chances: 33 ♙g4! ♙g6+ 34 ♙f3 ♙f6+ 35 ♙e4 g6 36 ♙d3 ♙f5+ 37 ♙d4 ♙f6+ 38 ♙c5 ♙e5+ 39 ♙c6 ♙f6+ 40 ♙c7 ♙e7+ 41 ♙b8 ♙d8+ 42 ♙xa7 ♙xa5+ 43 ♙a6 ♙c5+ 44 ♙a8 etc.

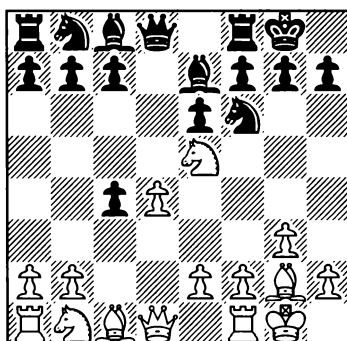
White plays 7 ♙e5

Game 30

Psakhis-Stefansson

Winnipeg 1997

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♙f3 ♙f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♙e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♙e5



7...c5

Another option is the rather unorthodox 7...♙d6 8 ♙xc4 ♙a6. Tukmakov-G.Kuzmin, Tallinn 1998 continued 9 ♙b3 ♙d8 10 ♙c3 ♙c6 (10...♙xd4? 11 ♙b5 ♙d7 12 ♙e5 and Black loses the exchange) 11 e3 ♙a5 12 ♙xa5 ♙xa5 13 ♙d2 ♙b6 14 ♙c2 ♙d7 15 b4 ♙c6 16 ♙a4 ♙xa4 17 ♙xa4 e5 18 ♙c3 e4 19 ♙fc1 ♙e6 20 ♙c2 ♙d6 21 b5 ♙e8 22 ♙d2 h5 23 h3 a6 24 a4 and White had the initiative.

8 dxc5 ♙xc5

It appears that Black's queen is awkwardly placed after 8...♙c7 9 ♙xc4 ♙xc5, as was demonstrated in Pinter-Kallai, Hungary 1988: 10 b3 ♙d8 11 ♙bd2 ♙c6 12 ♙b2 ♙b8 13 ♙c1 with a definite lead for White. This increased after 13...♙b5 14 a3 ♙d7 15 b4 ♙e8 16 e4 h5? 17 h3 ♙g5 18 e5 ♙h7 19 ♙e2 h4

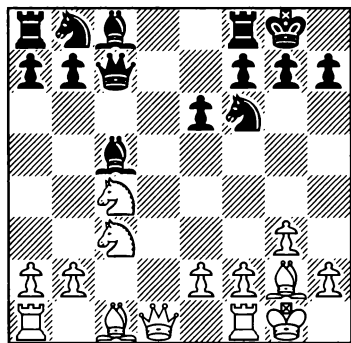
20 ♖e4 ♜h6 21 ♖c6 f5 22 ♖c5, when White's forces occupied influential posts.

9 ♖c3 ♜c7

Vaulin-Feoktistov, Moscow 1998 took a more sober course after 9...♜d4 10 ♜xd4 ♙xd4 11 ♖xc4 ♖c6 12 ♖b5 e5 13 e3 ♙c5 14 b3 ♖e8 (14...♙e6 allows White to put a knight on d6: 15 ♖bd6 ♜ab8 16 ♙b2 etc.) 15 ♙a3 ♙xa3 16 ♖bxa3 f6 17 ♙d5+ ♜h8 18 ♙xc6 bxc6 and White 'sacrificed' the Catalan bishop in order to inflict upon his opponent a weakened queenside. This provided a target in the coming ending after 19 ♖a5 ♙d7 20 ♜fd1 ♜f7 21 ♜ac1 ♜c8 22 ♜g2 etc.

9...♜e7 allows the pin on the knight with 10 ♙g5, when Ribli-Gopal, Calcutta 1992 continued 10...h6 11 ♙xf6 ♜xf6 12 ♖xc4 ♖c6 13 ♙xc6! bxc6 14 ♖e4 ♜e7? 15 ♖e5 ♜c7 16 ♖xc5 ♜xe5 17 ♜c2 ♜b8 18 b3 ♜h5 19 ♜fd1 ♜b5 20 ♜ac1 a5 21 ♜d6 and Black's weaknesses on the queenside were more important features in the position than the weakened light squares around White's king. Black can restrict his opponent to a slight edge with 14...♜f5 15 ♖xc5 ♜xc5 16 ♜a4.

10 ♖xc4



10...♙xf2+

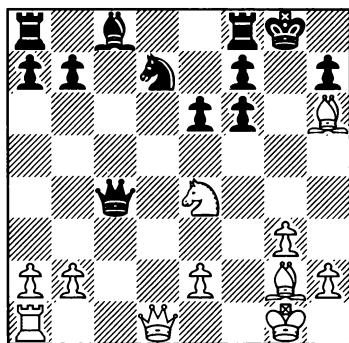
Black should avoid following 10...♜d8 11 ♙f4 with 11...e5? 12 ♙xe5! ♙xf2+ 13 ♜xf2 ♜xd1+ 14 ♜xd1 ♜e7 15 ♙xf6 gxf6 16 ♖d5 with a decisive lead for White. This leaves 11...♜e7 12 ♜c2 ♖c6 13 ♙xc6 bxc6 14 ♙g5

(we are familiar with this manoeuvre by now; White is slightly better) 14...♙d4 15 ♖e4 ♙a6 16 e3 ♙xc4 17 ♜xc4 ♙xb2 18 ♜ab1 ♜a3, which was seen in Vaulin-Stanojevic, Nis 1996. There followed 19 ♙xf6 gxf6 (19...♙xf6 20 ♖xf6+ gxf6 21 ♜g4+ ♜f8 22 ♜h5 ♜g7 23 ♜b7 ♜f8 24 ♜d1 gives White a dangerous initiative) 20 ♜xc6 f5?! (20...♜ac8 21 ♜b7 ♜b8 22 ♜c7 and White shifts the queen to the kingside) 21 ♖g5 ♙f6 (21...♜ac8 22 ♜b7 with double threats on b2 and f7) 22 ♖xe6! ♜ac8 23 ♖xd8 ♜xc6 24 ♖xc6 with a very nice ending for White, his two rooks being more than a match for the queen and Black's pawns being weak.

11 ♜xf2 ♜xc4 12 ♜xf6! gxf6 13 ♙h6 ♖d7!

The natural looking 13...♖c6? is in fact poor in view of 14 e3 ♜d8 15 ♜h5 e5 16 ♖e4 ♜e6 17 ♜h4 ♜h8 18 ♖xf6 ♖e7 (Thin-ius-Comp 'Mephisto', Berlin 1992) 19 ♙f8!, when White wins at least a piece.

14 ♖e4



Maintaining the tension poses the most problems for Black. The straightforward 14 ♙xf8 ♜xf8 15 ♜d6+ ♜e8 16 ♜d1 ♜c5+ 17 ♜xc5 ♖xc5 18 ♖b5 ♜e7 19 ♜c1 ♖d7 is unclear as White is active but Black can hold on to his pawn for a while.

14...♜b4!

14...♜d8? runs into 15 ♖xf6+ ♜h8 16 e3 and Black loses the f6-pawn for nothing: 16...e5 17 ♜h5! ♜e6 (17...♖xf6? 18 ♜g5

♗e8 19 ♖xd8 wins for White) 18 ♖xh7! ♖g6 19 ♖h4 ♗e8 20 ♖f1! ♖xh7 21 ♗e4 (Psakhis) and White has a menacing attack.

15 ♖c1 f5

Black defends well. Again 15...♗d8? is punished after 16 ♖xf6+ ♖h8 17 ♖d3! ♖b6+ 18 ♗e3 ♖xf6 19 ♖c3! ♖d6 20 ♖xf6+ ♖g8 21 ♖f1! ♗d7 22 ♖f4 ♖f8 23 ♖g4 and White wins.

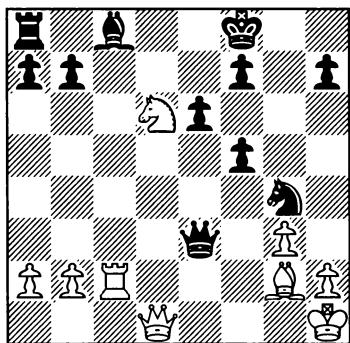
16 ♖d6

White should force matters with 16 ♗xf8!, e.g. 16...♖xf8 (16...♗xf8? 17 ♖d6+ ♖xd6 18 ♖xd6 ♖b6 19 ♖c7 ♗d7 20 ♖xb7 clearly favours White, while 16...♖xf8 17 ♖d6 ♖d8 18 e4 is also nice) 17 ♖f6+ ♖g7 (17...♖h8 18 ♖d8 is worse) 18 ♖d8 ♖b6+ 19 ♖xb6 axb6 20 ♖e8+ ♖g6 21 ♖d6 ♗d7 22 a3 and White wins back the pawn with interest in this end-game thanks to the queenside majority and active pieces.

16...♖e5! 17 ♗xf8 ♖b6+ 18 e3!?

Or 18 ♖h1 ♖g4 19 ♖xc8 ♖f2+ 20 ♖g1 ♖h3+ and Black can force the draw.

18...♖xe3+ 19 ♖h1 ♖g4 20 ♖c2 ♖xf8



Black has left the worst of his problems behind him.

21 ♖xc8 ♖f2+ 22 ♖xf2 ♖xf2 23 ♗xb7 ♖b8

White has two minor pieces for the rook but the exposed position of his king forces him to take a perpetual.

24 ♖d8+ ♖g7 25 ♖g5+ ♖h8

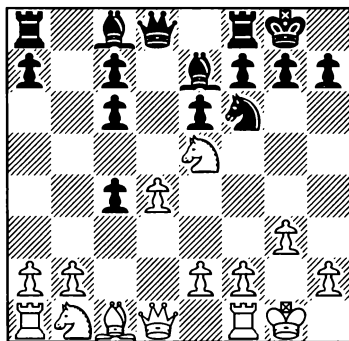
Not 25...♖f8?? 26 ♖h6+ ♖e8 27 ♗c6+

♖d8 28 ♖f8+ ♖c7 29 ♖d6+ ♖xc8 30 ♖d7 mate!

26 ♖d8+ ♖g7 27 ♖g5+ ½-½

Game 31 Gelfand-Aseev Klajpeda 1988

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♗g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♖e5 ♖c6 8 ♗xc6 bxc6



9 ♖xc6

9 ♖c3?! c5 10 dxc5 ♗xc5 11 ♖a4 ♖d5! 12 ♖e4 ♖b6 13 ♖c2 was the dubious (for White) course of Korchnoi-Petrosian, Candidates ¼-final Match (game 1), Ciocco 1977. Now 13...♖d5!? 14 ♖g5 f5 15 ♗f4 ♗d6! (Kotronias) allows Black to keep both his pawn and the light-squared bishop. His chances are better.

9...♖e8 10 ♖xe7+

10 ♖a4?! has been tried. Pigusov-Naumkin, Belgrade 1988 continued 10...♗d6 11 ♖xc4 a5 12 ♖e5 c5 13 ♖f3 ♗a6 14 ♖c2 ♖c8 and Black had the initiative: 15 ♖c3 cxd4 16 ♖xd4 ♗e5 17 ♖d1 and now 17...♖d5 (Pigusov) leaves Black on top.

10...♖xe7 11 ♖a4

Also possible is 11 b3 cxb3 12 ♗a3 b2 13 ♗xb2 ♖d8 14 ♖c2 ♖b8 with an equal position. White has the better pawn structure but Black is active.

11...c5

Black has several other options.

The queen manoeuvre 11...♖d6 12 ♖d1 ♖a6 isn't quite satisfactory in this position, either. White had the better prospects after 13 ♖xa6 ♖xa6 14 ♖c3 ♖ab8 15 e4 h6 16 f3 ♖fd8 17 ♖b1 ♖d7 18 ♖e3 ♖b6 19 ♖bc1 in Malakhov-Dervishi, Montecatini Terme 1998. Black's pawns on the c-file are weak but b2 is also an object of attack, while White enjoys more space.

Stohl-Polak, Czechoslovakia 1990 saw 11...a5 12 ♖xc4 ♖a6 13 ♖c2 ♖fd8 14 ♖d1 c5! (this freeing pawn break secures Black equal chances) 15 dxc5 ♖xd1+ 16 ♖xd1 ♖xc5 17 ♖c3 ♖g4 18 ♖f1 and now Kotronias gives 18...♖c8!? 19 ♖d2 ♖h5 20 h3 ♖e5 21 ♖g2 ♖c4 22 ♖c1 ♖f5 23 e4 ♖f6, when Black's activity fully compensates the missing pawn.

11...e5 12 dxe5 ♖xe5 is also possible, and leads to complex play. Korchnoi-Kotronias, Haifa 1989 went 13 ♖c3 ♖e4 14 ♖xc4 ♖xc3 15 ♖xc3 ♖xe2 16 ♖e1 ♖b5 17 ♖e5 ♖d7 18 ♖f4 ♖b7 19 ♖c5 ♖fd8 20 f3 ♖d3 21 ♖xc7 ♖d7 when the opposite coloured bishops offered Black adequate counterplay.

The other option is 13 ♖xc4, when 13...♖e6 leads to a further branch. Black has compensation after 14 ♖c2 ♖f5 15 ♖d2 ♖fe8 16 ♖c3 ♖e4 17 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 due (again) to the presence of opposite coloured bishops. This leaves 14 ♖d3 ♖ad8 15 ♖e3 ♖h5 16 f3, e.g. 16...♖c4! 17 ♖c3 ♖fe8 18 ♖g5 ♖h3 19 ♖f2 (19 ♖e3 ♖xe2!? 20 ♖xe2 ♖d5 21 ♖f4 ♖de5 22 ♖xa7 ♖xe2 23 ♖f2 ♖xb2 24 a4 and this pawn looks like a killer but Black generates counterplay on the opposite flank with 24...h5 – Kotronias) 19...♖xe2!? and now 20 ♖e3?! was Kachiani-Gersinska-Bojkovic, Belgrade 1990, when Black could have secured the advantage with 20...♖xf3! 21 ♖xf3 ♖g4, forcing White to part with material due to the threat against h2. However, 20 ♖f4 ♖d1!? 21 ♖e5 h6 22 ♖f4 ♖d5 23 ♖c4 is unclear. 16...♖fe8 has also been played, although the lines seem to

favour White. 17 ♖g5 is too slow but went unpunished in Gelfand-Timoscenko, Sverdlovsk 1987, when after 17...♖h3!? 18 ♖c5! ♖d5 19 e4 the only way to break the domination of the light squares was to sacrifice, but this did not prove correct after 19...♖xe4!? 20 fxe4 ♖g4 21 ♖f2 ♖xh2 22 ♖xc7 ♖c8 23 ♖xh2 ♖xc7 24 ♖xh3 ♖xc1+ 25 ♖f2 ♖xe4 26 g4, when White was winning. Black should follow the example of Pigusov-Raetsky, Voronezh 1988, 17...♖c4 18 ♖xh5 ♖xh5 19 ♖e1 ♖xe2 20 ♖xe2 ♖xe2 21 ♖f2 ♖c4 22 ♖c3 ♖f6 23 ♖e3 leading to a nice ending for White in view of the better pawn structure and the presence of knights on the board.

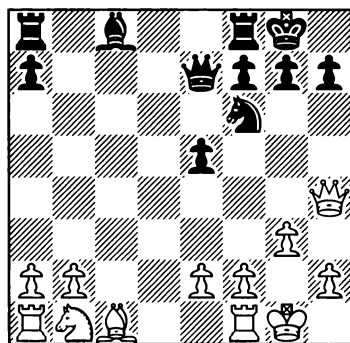
12 ♖xc4

12 ♖a3 ♖b7 13 ♖c3 ♖fc8 is equal.

12...cxd4 13 ♖xd4 e5

After 13...♖d8!? 14 ♖h4 ♖b8 15 b3 ♖a6 16 ♖c3 ♖c5 17 ♖e4 ♖xe4 18 ♖xe4 the exchange of knights should guarantee Black good counterplay due to the presence of opposite coloured bishops. The subsequent 18...♖b4 19 ♖e3 ♖c2 20 ♖a3 ♖e4 21 ♖fc1 ♖xe2 resulted in a draw in Krasenkow-Ribli, Germany 1998.

14 ♖h4



14...♖e6

Hübner-Handke, Germany 2001 continued 14...♖b8 15 b3 ♖d8 16 ♖b2 h6 17 ♖a3 ♖g4 18 ♖c4 ♖xe2 19 ♖fe1 ♖xc4 20 ♖xc4 ♖d5 21 ♖ad1 and White's forces had finally

joined the battle. After 21...♙a5 22 ♖c3 ♜c5 23 ♜d3 White's bishop and queenside majority afforded him the better prospects. White can try to repair the light squares with 15 ♖c3 ♜b4 16 e4 ♗b7 17 f3 (17 ♗g5 ♜xb2 18 ♗xf6 ♜xf6 19 ♜xf6 gxf6 20 ♙ab1 leads to an equal ending) 17...♜c5+ 18 ♗g2 ♜d8 19 ♜f2 ♜d3, when Black is active but White seems solid. Shipov gives 20 ♗g5 ♜xc3! 21 bxc3 ♖xe4!, breaking the light-squared domination and forcing White to find 22 ♗e3, when 22...♜d5 23 ♜e7 h5 24 ♜d1! ♜xd1 25 ♜xb4 ♖xf2 26 ♜xb7 ♖d3 27 ♜c8+ forces the draw.

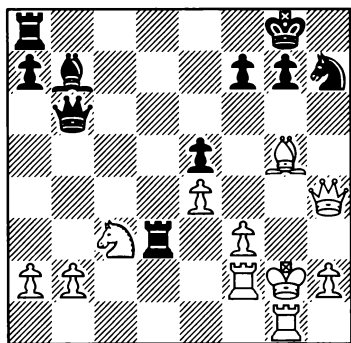
15 ♖c3 ♗b7 16 e4 ♜fc8

Worth considering is the plan to transfer the knight to d3 with 16...♖d7!? 17 g4 ♖c5 18 f3 ♖d3 (Aseev) with compensation.

17 f3 ♜b6+ 18 ♜f2

The continuation 18 ♗g2 h6 19 g4 ♗a6 20 ♜d1 ♜d8 21 ♜f2 gives White a small advantage.

18...h6 19 ♗g2 ♜d8 20 g4 ♜d3 21 g5 hxg5 22 ♗xg5 ♖h7 23 ♜g1



23...♗e8

23...♖xg5 24 ♜xg5 ♜d6 25 ♗h1 ♜g6 26 ♜d2 (Gelfand, Kapengut) is also a little better for White.

24 ♗h1 ♗e6 25 ♗c1 ♖f8 26 ♜fg2 ♜g6

Black enjoys some activity and therefore has compensation for the pawn.

27 ♜h5 ♜xg2

Less forcing is 27...♜f6 28 ♜g3 ♜xg3 29

♜xg3 ♖e6, again with compensation.

28 ♜xg2 ♖g6 29 ♜g4 ♜a6 30 ♜g3 ♗c8 31 ♜f2

31 ♗g5 allows the nice trick 31...♗h3! 32 ♜xh3 ♜xc3! etc.

31...♜d6 32 ♗g5?!

Preferable is 32 ♜f1 ♗a6.

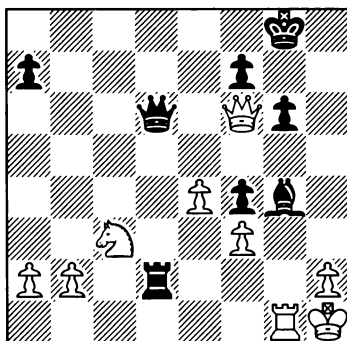
32...♖f4 33 ♗xf4 exf4 34 ♜h4 ♗e6 35 ♜f1 ♜d2! 36 ♜g1 g6?

Black misses a great opportunity in 36...♜xb2 37 ♜f6? ♗g4!! 38 ♜xd6 ♗xf3+ 39 ♜g2 ♜xg2 40 ♜d8+ ♗h7 41 ♜h4+ ♗g6 and wins.

37 ♜f6??

Necessary is 37 e5 ♜d3! 38 ♜xf4 ♜f2 39 ♖e4 ♜xf3 40 ♖f6+ ♗g7 41 ♖h5+ ♗h7 with equality.

37...♗g4! 0-1



See the lines in the note to Black's 36th move.

Game 32

Piket-Adams

Wijk aan Zee 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♗g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♖e5 ♖c6 8 ♜xc6 bxc6 9 e3

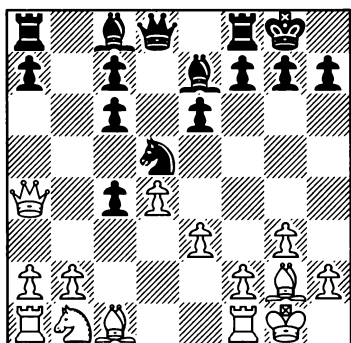
9 ♜a4 ♜xd4 10 ♖c3 ♗d7 11 ♗e3 ♜g4 12 ♗f3 ♜h3 13 ♜xc4 e5 is quite different, Khurtsidze-Moiseenko, Ukraine 1999 continuing 14 ♜fd1 ♖g4 15 ♗xg4 ♜xg4 16 ♜xg4 ♗xg4 17 f3 ♗e6 18 b3 a5, when the

bishop pair and possibilities on the queenside left Black in charge. 9 exc6 b8 10 c3 b7 11 xb7 xb7 12 b1 d7! 13 e4 fb8 is equal according to Gulko.

9... d5

9... a6 10 exc6 c3 (10... b8 11 a4 b6 12 d1 favours White) 11 xa8 cxb2 12 xb2 xf1 13 f3 and White's superior pawn structure is the main difference.

10 a4



10... b6

10... a5 11 d1 d6 12 xc4 a6 13 c2 b4 14 d2 e5 15 a3 d3 16 e4 xc1 17 xc1 exd4 18 exd4 f6 19 xc6 xd4 20 xd4 xd4 21 c3 and here a draw was agreed in Ippolito-Gormally, London 1999. The ending is equal; Black has the bishop pair while White has the better pawn structure.

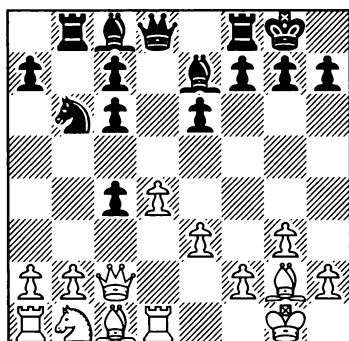
11 c2

11 xc6 b8 12 b5 b7 13 xb7 with play for both sides. Meins-Chandler, Germany 2000 saw the alternative 11 a5 d7 12 a3 d6 13 d2 e7 14 fc1 fb8 15 ab1 e5 16 xc4 exd4 17 exd4 d5! 18 e3 (18 xd5 cxd5 19 xd5 e6 20 c6 f5 21 e1 xf6 is unclear) 18... b5 19 a4 h6 20 c2! xc3 21 xe3 f5 22 xc6 ab8 23 a1 xb2 with advantage to Black. Also possible is 11... b8 12 a3 d7 13 d2 d6 14 fc1 e7 15 ab1 c5 16 dxc5 exc5 17 b4 d6 with equality in Wells-Arlandi, Escaldes 1998.

11... b8

After 11... d7 12 d2 a6 13 d1 f8 14 b3 Black should prefer the lesser evil 14... ab8 15 dxc4 dxc4 16 bxc4 c5 17 a3 cxd4 18 fxd4 e8 (Ribli) 19 xe7 xe7 20 a4 , when White has something to bite on on the queenside, to 14... cxb3 15 xc6 xc6 16 exc6 ab8 17 axb3 b7 18 xb7 xb7 19 a3 xa3 20 xa3 e5! ?, when a draw was agreed in Cs.Horvath-Yu Shaoteng, Gyula 2000, but where White could have had the slightly better prospects with 21 f3 exd4 22 fxd4 fxd4 23 dxd4 (due to the weaknesses on a7 and c7).

12 d1



12 xc6 b7 13 xb7 xb7 is equal.

12... e8

Markowski-Jaracz, Warsaw 2001 went 12... a5! 13 d2 a6 14 b3 cxb3 15 dxb3 b5 16 a4! xa4 17 xa4 dxa4 18 dxa5 b6 19 dxc6 d7 20 dxb8 xb8 21 d2 d6 22 a1 h5 23 h4 e7 24 c6 , White's bishop pair and pawn structure contributing to his lead.

13 d2 c5

Kotronias gives 13... a6 14 b3 c5 15 b2 cxd4 16 fxd4 f6! ?, planning ... e6-e5 .

14 dxc5

14 dxc4 leads only to a level game after 14... cxd4 15 exd4 (15 fxd4 f6 is also equal) 15... dxc4 16 xc4 d6 .

14... exc5 15 dxc4 dxc4 16 xc4 b5 17 xb5 xb5 18 b3 b7 19 xb7

♗xb7 20 ♖b2 ♖d6 21 ♖ac1

White has the superior pawns.

21...♗b6 22 e4 f6

22...e5 23 ♖d5 f6 24 ♖c4 slightly favours White.

23 ♖d4

23 f4!? is an interesting try.

23...♖a6 24 ♖c2 ♗b8 25 ♖f1 ♗b5 26 ♖e2 ♖f7 27 ♖d3 ♖e8 28 a4 ♗b7 29 ♖c4 ♖e7

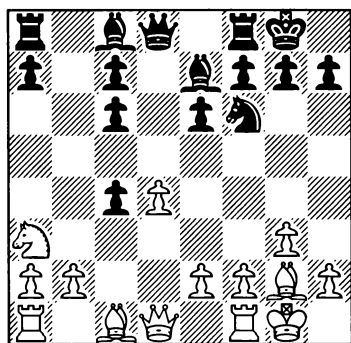
29...♖d7 30 e5 fxe5 31 ♖xe5 g6 32 ♖h4 h5 33 ♖f4 ♖e7 34 ♖f6+ ♖e8 35 ♖c4 helps White a little as it results in the further weakening of Black's pawns.

30 e5 ½-½

White is still slightly better, but the players agreed to call it a day.

Game 33 Ribli-Bönsch Thessaloniki 1988

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♖e5 ♖c6 8 ♖xc6 bxc6 9 ♖a3



9...♖xa3

After this exchange the pawn structures of both sides are totally ruined. Another move is 9...♖d5?!, when 10 ♖xc4 c5 11 dxc5 ♖xc5 12 b3 should favour White. This was borne out in Ribli-Wolf, Germany 1989 after 12...♗e7 13 ♖b2 ♖b8 14 ♗c2 ♖d8 15 ♖fd1 ♖a6 16 a3 ♖b6 17 ♖ac1 ♖xc4 18 ♗xc4

♖f6 19 e3 a5 20 ♖f3 h6 21 a4 etc.

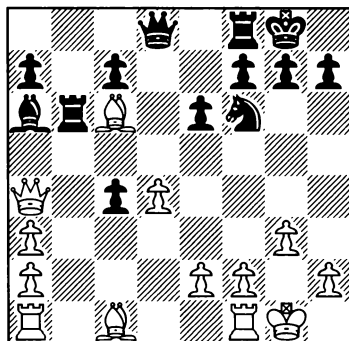
10 bxa3 ♖a6

An interesting line is 10...♗b8 11 ♗a4 ♗xd4 12 ♖e3 ♗e5 13 ♗xa7?!, e.g. 13...♗b7 (13...♖d7 14 ♖d4 ♗xe2 15 ♖ae1 ♗xa2 16 ♖xf6 gxf6 17 ♖d4 ♖c8 18 ♗xf6 ♖b5 19 ♖e4 h5 20 g4 saw White step up the pace in Istrate-Livner, Rimavska Sobota 1996) 14 ♗d4 ♗h5 15 ♖f3 e5 16 ♗xc4 ♖g4 17 ♖xg4 ♗xg4 18 ♖ac1 with chances for both sides. In Raetsky-Namyslo, Biel 1994 White ignored the a7-pawn, settling for equality after 13 ♗xc4 ♖d5 14 ♖d4 ♖a6! 15 ♖xe5 ♖xc4 16 ♖fe1 f6 17 ♖d4 ♖fd8, when White had the bishop pair but Black's forces were well placed.

11 ♖xc6

Black is better after 11 ♗a4?! ♖b5 12 ♗a5 ♗xd4! 13 ♖e3 ♗d6 14 a4 ♗a3, but a more viable, albeit rather tame option is 11 ♖g5 h6 12 ♖xf6 ♗xf6 13 ♗a4 (13 ♖xc6 ♖ab8 14 ♗a4 ♖b6 15 ♖fd1 ♖d8 16 ♖f3 c6! led to a plus for Black after the further moves 17 ♖g2 ♗e7 18 e3 ♖c8 19 h4 ♖b5 20 ♗b4 c5 in Antunes-Karpov, Tilburg 1994, Black with a passed pawn and White's doubled a-pawns of no use) 13...♖b5 14 ♗a5 c3 with equality according to Karpov.

11...♗b8 12 ♗a4 ♖b6



13 ♖g2

13 ♖f3 is a Raetsky speciality. Then 13...♖d5 14 ♗a5 brings us to a crossroads: 14...♗f6?! 15 a4 ♖b7 (15...♗xd4 16 ♖a3

♖a8 17 ♕c5 and White wins the exchange)
16 ♕a3 ♖b8 17 ♕c5 ♖b2 18 ♖ab1 c3 19
♖xb2 cxb2 20 ♖b1 ♗g5 21 ♕a3! ♕c6 22
♗c5 ♕xa4 23 e4 was excellent for White in
Raetsky-Sammalvuo, Hafnarfjörður 1998.
White has control of the centre and Black
cannot hold on to b2 forever.

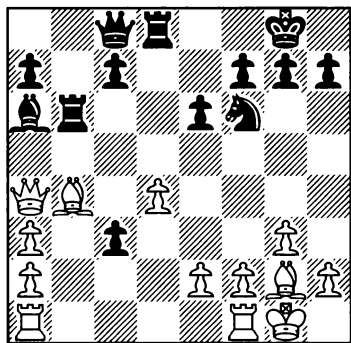
14...f5 fights for e4. Raetsky-Schoenthier,
Mannheim 1998 was unclear after 15 ♕d2
♗d7 16 ♖ab1 ♖fb8 17 ♖xb6 ♖xb6 18 a4
♗d6 19 ♖c1, when White's bishop pair and
piece play compensated for the passed pawn.

14...c3! is the best move. Black sacrifices
the pawn in order to activate his the pieces.
In Raetsky-Al.Schneider, Cappelle la Grande
1999 there followed 15 ♖e1 f5 16 ♕xd5
♗xd5 17 ♗xc3 ♖c6 18 ♗b2 ♖b6 19 ♗c3
and a draw was agreed.

13...♗c8 14 ♕d2 ♖d8 15 ♕b4

15 ♖fc1 ♖xd4 16 ♕e3 c5 17 ♕xd4 cxd4 is
given by Ribli. Black has clear compensation
for the exchange due to the strong centre
pawns.

15...c3!



16 ♖fc1 ♕xe2 17 ♕c5 ♖a6 18 ♗c2 ♕b5

The redeployment of the bishop with
18...♕c4 19 ♗xc3 ♕d5, with equality, is a
good idea.

19 ♗xc3 ♕d5 20 ♗d2

20 ♗e1!? is interesting.

20...♗d7 21 ♖ab1 c6 22 h4

White seizes space on the kingside.

22...♕b6 23 ♗e1 ♖c8 24 ♗b4 ♕a4 25

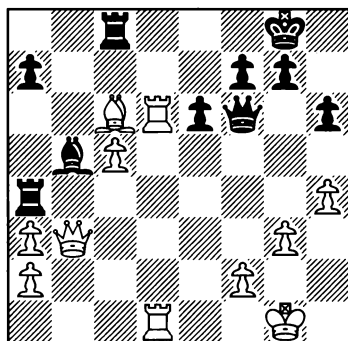
♖d1 h6 26 ♗b3 ♕xc5

Another good option is 26...♕b6.

27 dxc5 ♗e7 28 ♖d6 ♗f6

Black has to play precisely to avoid an in-
ferior position. 28...♖a4!? 29 ♖bd1 ♕c4 30
♗e3 ♗f6 looks well balanced.

29 ♖bd1 ♖a4 30 ♕xc6!?



A temporary piece sacrifice that should
lead to equality with accurate defence from
Black.

**30...♕xc6 31 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 32 ♗xa4 ♖xc5
33 ♗xa7**

White has the easier game thanks to the a-
pawn.

33...♖c2 34 a4 ♗f3

34...♖xa2?? loses to 35 ♗b8+ ♕h7 36
♗b1+.

35 ♖f1 g6 36 ♗b8+ ♕h7 37 ♗b3 ♖c3

Black manages to avoid 37...♗xb3? 38
axb3 ♖b2 39 ♖a1 ♖xb3, when 40 a5 ♖b7 41
a6 ♖a7 42 ♕f1 ♕g7 43 ♕e2 ♕f6 44 ♕d3
♕e7 45 ♕c4 ♕d6 46 ♕b5 is close to win-
ning for White.

38 ♗b2 e5

Missing the best defence in 38...♖a3 39
♖c1 ♖xa4 40 ♖c8 ♗d1+ 41 ♕h2 ♗d4 with
equality.

39 ♖e1 ♗c6?!

A clear path to equality is 39...e4 40 ♗e2
(40 ♖xe4?? ♗d1+ 41 ♕g2 ♖c1 and Black has
a decisive attack) 40...♗xe2 41 ♖xe2 ♖c4,
when the rook ending is completely drawn.

40 ♗b5! ♗c7?

After the inaccuracy on the 39th move Black could still play 40...♖c5 41 ♔g2 ♜c2 42 ♗xc5 ♗xc5 43 ♜b1 and, despite the fact that White is better here, Black has good chances of saving the game. After the text the struggle is probably over.

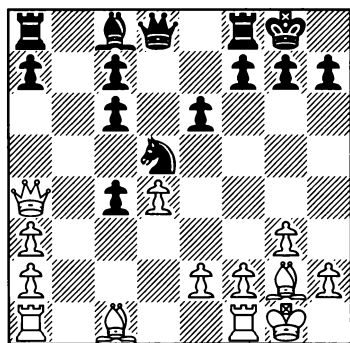
41 ♖xe5 ♜c1+ 42 ♔g2 ♜d1?

42...♜c2 43 h5 is a slight improvement for Black.

43 ♜d5 ♗e1 44 ♜d7 ♗c1 45 ♗d5 1-0

Game 34
Manor-Anand
London 1987

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♗f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♗e5 ♗c6 8 ♗xc6 bxc6 9 ♗a3 ♗xa3 10 bxa3 ♗d5 11 ♗a4



11...♗b6

Preferable to 11...♗c3?! 12 ♗c2 (12 ♗xc4? ♗xd4! and Black wins material) 12...♗b5 13 e3 ♗d6 14 a4 a5 15 ♗a3 ♗d7 16 ♗xd6 cxd6 17 ♗xc4 ♗b7 18 ♜fc1 ♜fc8 19 ♗ab1 ♗a7 20 ♗b3, when Black's extra pawn was less important than his development problems in Vera-Moran, Alcobendas 1994. In fact he was under considerable pressure after 20...c5 21 ♗b5 ♗xg2 22 ♔xg2 g6 23 dxc5 dxc5 24 ♜xc5 etc.

11...a5 12 ♗xc6 ♗a6 13 ♗c5 was played in Alburt-Browne, Philadelphia 1989. After 13...♗d6 14 ♗xa5 c3 15 ♗xd5 ♗xd5 16 ♗xc3 ♗xe2 chances were even – once again

the opposite coloured bishops ensured that Black was okay. Browne gives 12 ♗xc4 ♗a6 13 ♗c2, when White has the upper hand – he has the bishop pair and the black pawns are very weak.

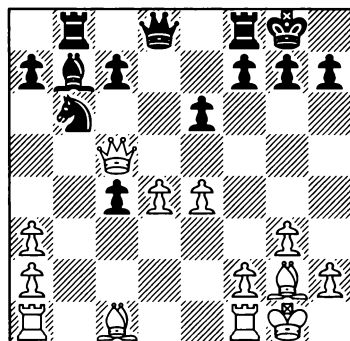
12 ♗xc6 ♗b8

12...♗a6 13 ♗c5 c6 14 ♗g5 f6 15 ♗d2 and White is better.

13 ♗c5 ♗b7

Posting the bishop more actively with 13...♗a6 seems to work out well for Black here, e.g. 14 e4! c3!? (14...♗d7?! 15 ♗f4 ♜fc8 16 ♜fd1 ♗a4 17 ♗g5 ♗b2 18 d5 h6 19 ♗g4 h5 20 ♗xh5 ♗c3 21 ♗e5 ♗xd1 22 ♗xd1 was difficult for Black in Sorg-Oettel, Schwabisch Gmuend 1996, but 17...♗b2 18 ♗d2 c3 19 ♜c2 ♗b5 20 d5!? is interesting) 15 ♗e1 ♗a4 16 ♗a5 ♗b5 17 ♗b1 c6 and Black is very solid. Also possible is 14 ♗f4 ♗d5 15 ♗xd5 ♗xd5 16 ♗xa7 ♗b6 17 ♗xc7 ♗b7 18 f3 ♗a6 (18...♗b2? 19 ♗ab1 ♗a8 20 e4 ♗b5 21 ♗b6 ♗xb6 22 ♗xb6 ♗xb1 23 ♗xb1 f5 24 ♗c5 and White had good chances thanks to his two extra pawns in Palatnik-Razuvaev, Tbilisi 1973) 19 ♗c5 ♗c8 20 ♗xd5 ♗xd5 21 ♗f4 when a draw was agreed in Ftacnik-Kurajica, Dortmund 1981. However, the following line is slightly better for White: 21...c3! 22 e4 ♗c4 23 ♜f2 ♗xa3 24 ♗d6 ♗a6 25 ♗c5 e5 26 ♜c1 exd4 27 ♗xd4 ♗xa2 etc.

14 e4



14...♗d6

Another option is 14...f5 15 f3 fxe4 16

fxe4 ♖xf1+ 17 ♜xf1 ♠a4 (17...♞f6+! 18 ♜g1 ♜f8 19 ♠f4 was seen in Raetsky-Al.Schneider, Megeve 1994, when White would have been better after 19...♞g6 20 ♜e1) 18 ♞e5 ♞d6 and White is slightly better due to the bishop pair. An improvement is 14...♞d7, an unclear situation resulting after 15 ♠f4 ♜bc8 16 ♜fd1 h6 17 ♜d2 ♜fd8 18 ♜c1 ♠a6 19 d5 exd5 20 exd5 ♠b7 in G.Agzamov-Sveshnikov, Tashkent 1980.

15 ♠f4 ♞xc5 16 dxc5 ♠a4 17 ♜fc1 ♠a6 18 ♠f1 ♠xc5 19 ♠xc4 ♠b7?

Much better is 19...♠xc4 20 ♞xc4 ♠a6 21 ♜ac1 ♜fd8 22 ♜a4 ♠b6 23 ♠xc7 ♠xc7 24 ♞xc7 a6 25 ♠b4 ♠bb8!, as in Raetsky-Ulfarsson, Reykjavik 1996. White is better here, but Black can fight for the draw.

19...♜fc8 has also been played. Raetsky-Naumkin, Budapest 1991 continued 20 ♠xa6 ♠xa6 21 ♜c6 ♠b6 22 ♜ac1 ♜f8 23 ♠e3 ♜xc6 24 ♜xc6 ♠b8 25 ♜c4. Again White's rook and bishop are stronger and more active than Black's forces. There followed 25...a6 26 ♠f4 ♜e7 27 ♞xc7+ ♞xc7 28 ♠xc7 ♠c6 29 f3 ♜d7 30 ♠b6 ♠e5 31 ♜f2 ♠c4 32 ♠c5 when the endgame with an extra a-pawn was clearly better for White, thanks in no small part to the bishop. Hjartarson-Schussler, Gausdal 1985 saw instead 26...c6! 27 ♠xb8 ♠xb8 28 ♜xc6 ♜d8! 29 ♠xa6 ♜d4 30 ♜a8+ ♜e7 31 e5 g5!, this time with an edge for White, but fighting chances for Black. Returning to 19...♜fc8, another option is 20 ♠e3 ♠xc4 21 ♜xc4 ♠d7 22 ♜ac1, e.g. 22...c5!? 23 ♠xc5 ♠xc5 24 ♜xc5 ♜xc5 25 ♜xc5 when White is in the lead but will have a hard time trying to win the race, or 22...♠b7, when 23 ♠b4! ♠xb4 24 axb4 ♠b6 25 ♜c5 ♜f8 26 ♠f4 c6 27 ♜a5 ♜a8 28 ♠a6 was very pleasant for White in Chekhov-Baikov, Moscow 1979.

20 ♠e3!

White wins the exchange.

20...♠xc4 21 ♠xc5 ♠d3 22 ♠xf8 ♜xf8 23 f3 ♜e7 24 ♜c3 ♠a6 25 ♜ac1 ♜d7 26 a4 ♠d6 1-0

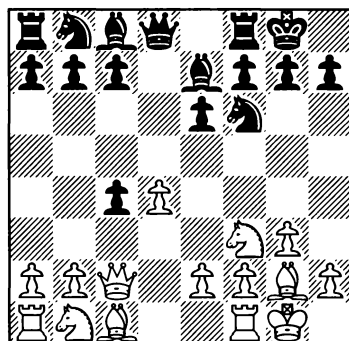
White plays 7 ♞c2 a6 8 a4

Game 35

Filippov-Sulskis

Poland 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♠f3 ♠f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♠g2 ♠e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♞c2



7...a6

Kochiev-V.Orlov, St. Petersburg 1999 went 7...b5 8 a4 ♠a6 (8...c6? 9 axb5 cxb5? 10 ♠g5 and White is winning due to the threats against a8 and h7) 9 axb5 ♠xb5 10 ♠e5 ♠d5 11 ♠a3 ♠xa3 12 bxa3 c3 13 a4 ♠a6 14 ♠a3 ♜e8 15 ♜fc1 f6 16 ♠d3 ♠c6 17 e3 with an edge for White as Black will find it difficult to hold on to the c3-pawn.

After 7...c5 8 ♞xc4 cxd4 9 ♠xd4 e5 10 ♠b3 ♠c6 11 ♠e3 ♠e6 12 ♞b5 White has some pressure on the queenside but Black is well developed. White still needs to get the rest of this forces into play. White was more successful in Kengis-Meijers, Riga 1984: 8 dxc5 ♠xc5 9 ♞xc4 ♞e7 10 ♠g5 ♠bd7 11 ♠bd2 h6 12 ♠h4! g5 13 ♠xg5 hxg5 14 ♠xg5 ♞d6 15 ♞h4! ♞d4 16 ♠f4 ♠e7 17 ♞g5+ ♜h8 18 ♜ac1! and White had created a strong attack for the sacrificed piece.

8 a4

Also possible is the complex 8 ♠g5 b5 9 ♠xf6 ♠xf6 10 ♠g5 ♠xg5 11 ♠xa8 ♞xd4 12 ♠g2 ♠d7 13 ♠c3 f5! 14 b3! cxb3 15 axb3 ♞c5 16 ♜a2 ♠e7 17 e3 ♠d6 as in Korchnoi-

Vaganian, Montpellier 1985. For the exchange Black has two pawns and decent pieces, inviting an evaluation of unclear.

Shabalov-Ivanchuk, Novosibirsk 1986 went 8 ♖bd2 b5 9 ♖g5 ♖a7 10 b3 cxb3 11 ♖xb3 ♖b7 12 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 13 e4 ♖fd7! 14 ♖f3 c5 15 dxc5 ♖xc5 16 ♖xc5, when Shabalov gives 16...♖c7 17 ♖xe6 ♖xc2 18 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 as equal.

8...c5

Quite different is 8...♖c6 9 ♖xc4 ♖d5 10 ♖bd2 (10 ♖d3 ♖d8 11 ♖c3 ♖h5 12 ♖c4 ♖d7 13 ♖f4 ♖d6 14 ♖g5! is an attractive alternative for White, who has more room for manoeuvre) 10...♖d8 11 e3, e.g. 11...♖d7 (11...♖h5 12 e4 ♖d7 13 b3 b5 14 ♖c3 ♖e8 15 axb5 axb5 16 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 17 ♖b2 ♖a2 18 ♖c1! ♖h6 19 h3 g6 20 ♖e1 ♖f8 21 ♖b1 ♖b4 22 ♖e5 ♖d7 23 ♖c3 favoured White in Kramnik-Piket, Dortmund 1995) 12 ♖e5 (12 b3 is also good) 12...♖xe5, when White should prefer 13 ♖c3 ♖f3+ 14 ♖xf3 ♖f5 15 ♖xc7, with insufficient compensation for Black, to the continuation in Lahner-Michenka, Karvina 2001, where 13 ♖xc7? ♖c6! 14 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 15 ♖xb7 ♖a5 16 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 left Black better because the rook and two pawns were no match for the bishop and knight. After 9 ♖xc4 Black has also tried 9...♖b4. For example Filippov-A.Rodriguez, Linares 1997 continued 10 ♖c3 b5 11 ♖b3 bxa4 12 ♖xa4 ♖b8 13 ♖d1 ♖b7 14 ♖c3 ♖c8 15 ♖f4 ♖d3 16 ♖xd3 ♖xf3, when Rodriguez gives 17 ♖a2!? ♖xg2 18 ♖xg2 ♖b7+ 19 ♖g1 ♖xb2 20 ♖xa6 as somewhat better for White in view of the superior structure.

9 ♖bd2

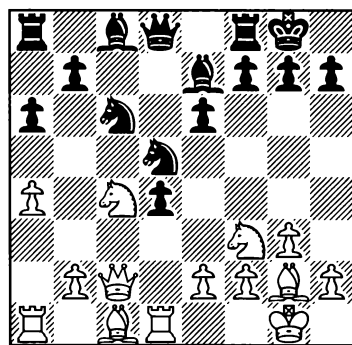
After 9 dxc5 ♖xc5 10 ♖bd2 ♖c6 11 ♖xc4 ♖e7 it seems that 12 ♖g5 is good enough only for equality, e.g. 12...h6 13 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 14 ♖fd1 e5 15 e3 ♖f5 16 ♖b3 e4 17 ♖fd2 ♖e7 18 ♖b6 ♖ad8 19 ♖d5 ♖e6 20 ♖f4 ♖xb3 21 ♖xb3 and the game is level, or 18 ♖c2?! ♖b4 19 ♖c3 ♖ac8, when Black enjoyed more space in Anastasian-Asrian,

Yerevan 2000. In fact 20 ♖e5? ♖xe5 21 ♖xe5 ♖c2 22 ♖ab1 ♖xe3! 23 fxe3 ♖xe3+ 24 ♖f1 ♖xd2 25 ♖xd2 e3 saw Black win material.

Another option is 12 b3 ♖d5 13 ♖b2 ♖d8 14 ♖ac1 ♖db4 15 ♖c3 ♖d4 16 ♖xd4 ♖xd4 17 ♖xd4!? ♖xd4 18 ♖xd4 and White had a rook and bishop for the queen in Aro-nian-Bick, Ubeda 2000. This seems okay here as Black is weak on the dark squares and lags behind on the queenside. The situation remained unclear after 18...♖c6 19 ♖e3 e5 20 ♖b6 ♖b8 21 ♖c5 ♖f6 22 ♖d5 etc.

The natural 12 ♖fe5 is White's most promising try for advantage. Gulko-Ivanchuk, Linares 1990 was a shade better for White after 12...♖xe5 13 ♖xe5 ♖d5 14 ♖d3 ♖d6 15 ♖d2 ♖f6 16 ♖ac1, while 12...♖d4 13 ♖d1 ♖d8 14 e3 ♖f5 15 ♖c2 receives a similar assessment.

9...cxd4 10 ♖xc4 ♖c6 11 ♖d1 ♖d5



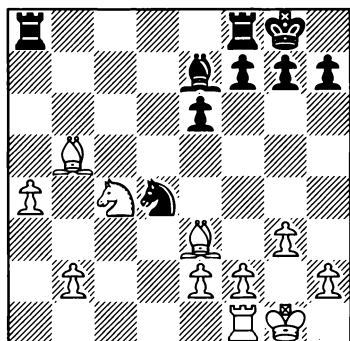
12 ♖xd4!? ♖db4 13 ♖xc6 ♖xc2 14 ♖xd8 ♖xa1 15 ♖xb7 ♖xb7

Interesting is 15...♖b3 16 ♖ba5 ♖xa5 17 ♖xa5 ♖b8 18 ♖c6 ♖b7 19 b4 and White has some compensation for the exchange. Also good enough for Black is 15...♖b8 16 ♖f4 ♖xb7 17 ♖xb8 ♖xb8 18 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 19 ♖xa1 ♖b4 20 ♖c1 ♖xa4 21 ♖b6 ♖d4 when the ending is even.

16 ♖xb7 ♖ad8 17 ♖f1

Or 17 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 18 ♖f4 with compensation. The a6-pawn is difficult to protect.

17...♖b3 18 ♙xa6 ♜a8 19 ♙b5 ♜d4 20 ♙e3



20...♜xb5

20...♜xc2+?! takes the wrong pawn. Black's majority on the kingside will not be very dangerous compared to White's a- and b-pawns. After 21 ♖g2 ♜ad8 22 ♙b6 White has the better chances.

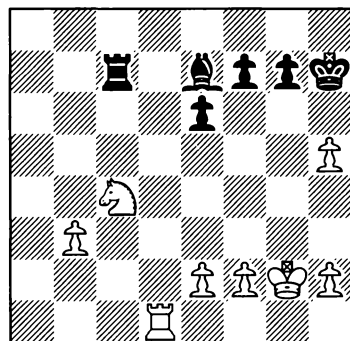
21 ♙xb5 ♜fb8 22 ♙b6 ♜b7 23 ♙b1 ♙b4 24 ♙f4 h5 25 ♙c7 h4?!

Too ambitious. After 25...g6 the situation is about equal; Black returns the exchange at the right moment.

26 ♖gxh4 ♜c8 27 ♜d1 ♖h7 28 ♖g2 ♙e7 29 h5?!

Simple and good is 29 ♜d7.

29...♙cxc7 30 ♙xc7 ♜xc7 31 b3



White is two pawns up and has genuine winning chances, although the win will not come easily.

31...♜b7 32 ♜d3 ♖h6 33 f4 f6 34 ♜e3 ♙c5 35 ♜xe6 ♜xb3 36 ♙c6 ♙b5 37 ♜c7 ♙b4 38 e4 ♜c5!

Not 38...♜xh5? 39 ♜e3 ♙f8 40 ♜f7, and White wins the g7-pawn and with it the game.

39 ♜xc5 ♙xc5 40 ♖f3 ♖xh5

White has only a modest advantage.

41 ♜e3 ♖g6 42 ♜f5 ♖f7 43 ♖g4 ♙g1 44 h3 ♙c5 45 ♜h4 ♙f2 46 ♜f3 ♙c5 47 ♜e1 ♙f2 48 ♜d3 ♙e3 49 f5

From here White tries hard to win the game but his efforts are met with some impressive defence...

49...♙b6 50 ♜f4 ♙c7 51 ♖f3 ♙d6 52 ♖e3 ♙e5 53 ♜g6 ♙c7 54 ♖d4 ♙b8 55 ♖c5 ♙g3 56 ♖d5 ♙h2 57 ♖c6 ♖e8 58 ♜h4 ♖e7 59 ♜f3 ♙f4 60 ♜d4 ♙e3 61 ♜e6 g6 62 ♜c7 ♖f7 63 ♖d7 gxf5 64 exf5 ♙d4 65 ♜b5 ♙b2 66 ♜d6+ ♖f8 67 ♖e6 ♙d4 68 ♜b5 ♙b2 69 ♜c7 ♙e5 70 ♜d5 ♖g7 71 ♜e3 ♙c3 72 ♜g4 ♙d4 73 h4 ♙c3 74 h5 ♙b2 75 ♜xf6 ♖h6 76 ♜g4+ ♖xh5 77 ♜e5 ♖h6 78 f6 ♖h7 79 f7 ♖g7 ½-½

Game 36

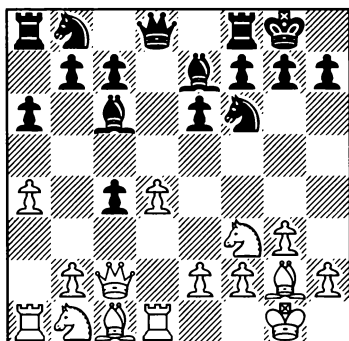
Ftacnik-Dutreeuw

Batumi 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♙e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♜c2 a6 8 a4 ♙d7 9 ♜d1

In Urban-Rozentalis, Lubniewice 1998 White unleashed the bishop with 9 ♜e5, when there followed 9...♙c6 10 ♜xc6 ♜xc6. Then 11 ♙xc6 bxc6 12 ♜d1 ♜d5 13 ♜a3 ♜h5! is nice for Black, so Urban chose 11 e3 ♜a5 12 ♜d2 c5 13 dxc5 ♜c7 14 ♜xc4 ♜xc5 15 b3 ♜ac8 16 ♜b1 ♜xc4 17 bxc4 ♜c7 18 ♙b2 ♜d7 19 a5 ♜fc8 20 ♙a3 ♜g5 21 h4 ♜f6 22 ♙b2 ♜h6 and the game was still well balanced. The b7-pawn is a bit weak, but so is c4 and, while Black's knight will find a good outpost on c5, White has the bishop pair. 13...♜c8 has also been tried here. After

14 b4 cxb3 15 ♖xb3 ♖xb3 16 ♗xb3 ♖d7
17 c6 bxc6 18 ♖d1 White emerged with
compensation in the form of the bishop pair
and activity in Anastasian-Lutz, Batumi 1999,
the subsequent 18...♗c7 19 ♖d2 ♖fd8 20 a5
♖c5 21 ♗c2 ♖b8 22 ♖c3 adding to the mix.
9...♖c6



10 ♖c3

10 ♗xc4 ♖d5 11 ♗c2 ♖c6 12 ♖bd2 ♖b4
13 ♗b1 c5 14 e4 ♖c6 15 e5 ♖d7! 16 ♖e4 h6
17 dxc5 ♖xe4 18 ♗xe4 ♖xc5 19 ♖xd8
♖xe4 20 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 is level according to
Ribli. White's Catalan bishop is good but
Black's knights are well posted and White's
queenside might prove vulnerable. However,
Black would prefer to see 17 b3?! ♖d5 18
♖c3 ♖xf3 19 ♖xf3 cxd4 20 ♖xd4 ♗c7 as in
Donguines-Villamayor, Calcutta 2001, when
the weakness on e5 tipped the scales in
Black's favour. Indeed after 21 ♖c4 ♗a5! 22
♖xb7 ♖ab8 23 ♖g2 ♖xe5 24 ♖f4 ♖xc4 25
♖xb8 ♖d2! Black collected a pawn.

10...♖bd7

10...♖xf3 is dealt with in the next main
game. Another possibility is 10...♖d5 11 e4
♖xc3 12 bxc3 b5 13 ♖e5 ♖b7 14 ♗b1 – a
typical manoeuvre for White. After 14...♖c6
15 ♖xc4 e5 16 ♖e3 exd4 17 cxd4 bxc4 18
♗xb7 ♖a5 19 ♗b2 ♖b8 20 ♗c2 ♖b3 21
♖f1 ♖b4 22 ♖ac1 ♖c3 Black does have
some compensation for his weaknesses, but
perhaps not enough.

11 e4 b5

12 d5 exd5 13 e5 ♖e4 14 ♖xd5 ♖xd5
15 ♖xd5 ♖ec5 16 axb5 ♗c8 17 ♖d1
♖d3 18 e6!

White crashes through.

18...♖b6

Dubious is 18...fxc6?! 19 ♗xc4 ♖3c5 20
bxa6 and White has a winning position.

19 exf7+ ♖xf7 20 ♖e3 axb5 21 ♖xa8
♖xa8 22 ♖d4 ♖b6 23 ♖xb5

Black's pawns are simply too weak.

23...♗d7 24 ♖c3 c5 25 b3 ♗e6 26 bxc4
♖b4 27 ♗e4! ♗xc4

The lesser evil is 27...♗xe4 28 ♖xe4 ♖xc4
29 ♖xc5, although this is anyway poor for
Black.

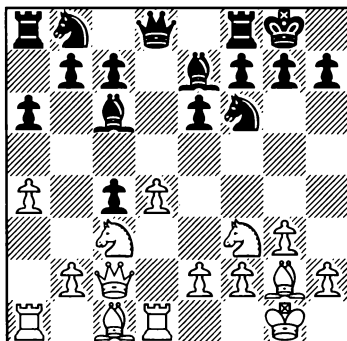
28 ♖h3! ♗xc3 29 ♖d8+!

29...♖f8 30 ♖e6 ♗a1+ 31 ♖g2 1-0

White has too many threats.

Game 37 Dizdar-Sadler Pula 1997

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5
♖g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♗c2 a6 8 a4 ♖d7
9 ♖d1 ♖c6 10 ♖c3



10...♖xf3 11 ♖xf3 ♖c6 12 ♖xc6 bxc6
13 ♖g5

13 a5 ♗b8 14 ♗a4 (14 ♖a4 ♗b3! 15
♗xb3 cxb3 16 ♖c4 c5 17 dxc5 ♖fd8 18
♖xd8+ ♖xd8 saw Black generate sufficient
activity in N.Pert-Asrian, Yerevan 1999, the
ending being equal after 19 ♖f4 ♖d5 20

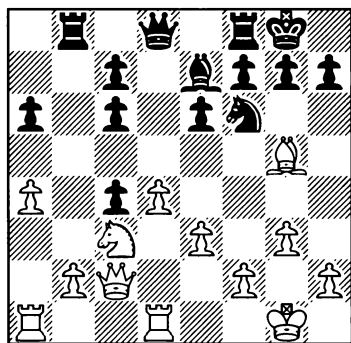
♟xd5 ♞xd5 21 ♞c3 e5 22 ♠e3 ♟f8) 14...c5 15 ♞xc4 cxd4 16 ♞xd4 c5 17 ♞d3 ♞b4 18 ♞a4 ♞b7 19 ♞a3 ♞b4 20 ♞a2 ♞ab8 was seen in Beliavsky-Stohl, Portoroz 1999, the backward b-pawn affording Black equal chances.

Black has also used the b8-square for his rook: 13...♞b8 14 ♞a4 ♞b4! (it is important to keep the c4-pawn rather than its less important partner on c6) 15 ♞xc6 ♞d6 16 ♞f3 and now Romanishin-Brunner, Altensteig 1992 went 16...♞fb8?! 17 e4 ♞c6 18 d5 with an excellent game for White, whose fortunes quickly improved after the faulty 18...exd5?, when the punishment came in the form of 19 e5 ♟e8 20 ♟xd5 ♟f8 21 ♞h5 ♞4b5 22 ♞xh7 f6 23 ♞g8! – a nice little trick that wins a piece. However, Kotronias gives 16...♞d8 17 e4 ♞c6 18 ♞e2 ♞b7 19 ♞a2 c5!? 20 d5 exd5 21 exd5 h6! with an acceptable position for Black.

13...♞b8

13...♟d5 14 ♠xe7 ♞xe7 15 ♟e4 ♞fb8 16 ♞xc4 ♞xb2 17 ♞ab1 ♞b4 18 ♞xc6 ♞xb1 19 ♞xa8+ ♞b8 20 ♞xb8+ ♞xb8 21 ♟c5 ♟c3 22 ♞d2 a5 led to a level ending in Timoshenko-Asrian, Ubeda 1998.

14 e3



Illescas-Beliavsky, Madrid 1998 continued 14 ♠xf6 ♠xf6 15 ♟e4 ♞b4 16 e3 ♞d5! and after the further 17 ♟xf6+ (17 a5 is interesting) 17...gxf6 18 e4 ♞h5! the position is unclear. Black has vulnerable pawns but

White's b-pawn can also be attacked, while Black has an extra pawn. At some point he might play ...c6-c5.

14...♟d7?!

Black had a slight edge in Ftacnik-P.Nielsen, Germany 1999 after the interesting 14...h6!? 15 ♠xf6 ♠xf6 16 ♟e4 ♞b4 17 ♟c5 ♞c8 18 ♞ac1 ♠e7 19 ♟e4 ♞b7. Here c4 is no weaker than b2, and Black has a good bishop and decent piece play.

15 ♠xe7 ♞xe7 16 ♟e4 ♞b4 17 ♟d2 c5 18 ♟xc4 ♞fb8 19 ♞ac1 h6 20 dxc5

20 d5 exd5 21 ♞xd5 is playable, when 21...♟b6 22 ♟xb6 cxb6 23 ♞cd1 ♞e4 is roughly level but 21...♞xc4? 22 ♞xc4 ♟b6 23 ♞b3! c4 24 ♞xc4 ♞a8 25 ♞c6 ♟xd5 26 ♞xd5 simply leads to the loss of a pawn.

20...♟f6

20...♟xc5? 21 ♟a5 and ♟c6 is coming.

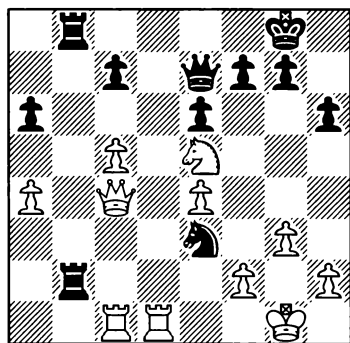
21 ♟e5 ♞xb2 22 ♞c4

22 ♟c6? runs into 22...♞e8 23 ♞xb2 ♞xb2 24 ♞d8 ♞xd8 25 ♟xd8 ♟e4 and White loses a pawn. Both players should be careful in this seemingly quiet position.

22...♟d5 23 e4?

A mistake. After 23 ♟d3!? White enjoys a small but solid edge.

23...♟e3!



Now Black is in charge!

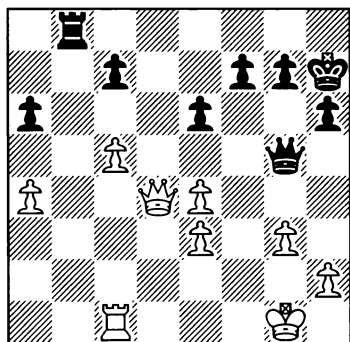
24 fxe3 ♞g5!

Not 24...♞f6? 25 ♟d3 ♞f3 26 ♟xb2 ♞xb2 27 ♞f1 ♞xe3+ 28 ♟h1 ♞xe4+ and White escapes with a draw.

25 ♖c3 ♖h5 26 ♖d8+ ♗h7 27 ♖d2
♖xd2 28 ♖xd2 ♖xe5

White's king is exposed and his centre pawns are weak. Black has a decisive advantage.

29 ♖d4 ♖g5!

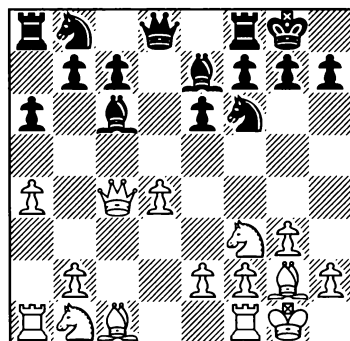


No exchange of queens!

30 ♖f1 e5 31 ♖c3 f6 32 ♗g2 ♖g4 33
♖c4 a5 34 h3 ♖d7 35 ♖c2 ♖c6 36 ♖d1
♖b4 37 ♖d8 ♖xa4 38 ♖c8 ♖b4! 0-1

Game 38
Lputian-J. Polgar
Wijk aan Zee 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5
♗g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♖c2 a6 8 a4 ♖d7
9 ♖xc4 ♗c6



10 ♗g5

In the event of 10 ♖c3?! b5! 11 ♖d3 b4

12 ♖b1 ♗e4 13 ♖d1 c5 14 ♖bd2 ♗d5 15
dxc5 ♖bd7 16 ♖b3 ♖xc5 17 ♖xc5 ♗xc5
Black had a fine position in Ara.Minasian-
Yegiazarian, Yerevan 2001. There followed
18 ♗e5 ♗xcg2 19 ♖xd8 ♖fxd8 20 ♗xcg2
♖ac8 21 ♖d3 ♗f8 22 ♗g5 ♖c2 23 ♖ac1
♖dc8 24 ♖xc2 ♖xc2 25 ♖c1 with an equal
ending, but 20...♖d5!? 21 ♖d3 ♗d6 22 ♖d1
♖d8 offers Black chances of finding more.

Also possible is 10 ♗f4 a5 11 ♖c3 ♖a6,
when Hjartarsson gives 12 ♖ae1 ♗d5 13
♖xd5 exd5 14 ♖b5 ♖c8 with a balanced
game. Delchev-Flear, Creon 2001 continued
instead 12 ♖ac1 ♖b4 13 ♖fe1 ♖fd5 14
♖xd5 ♖xd5 15 ♖xd5 (15 ♗xc7 ♖xc4 16
♖xc4 ♗xa4 17 ♖e5 f6 with approximate
equality, White's control of the centre being
weighed against Black's queenside majority)
15...♖xd5 16 ♖e5 ♖xf4 17 ♖xc6 (better
than 17 ♗xc6 ♗b4! 18 gxf4 ♗xe1 19 ♗xb7
♖a7 20 ♖xc7 ♖b8 21 ♖c8+ ♖xc8 22 ♗xc8
♖c7 with an edge for Black as White's pawns
are not quite enough for the exchange)
17...♖xe2+ (17...bxc6 18 gxf4 ♖ab8 19 ♗xc6
♖xb2 20 ♖xc7 ♗b4 looks drawn) 18 ♖xe2
bxc6 19 ♗xc6 ♖ad8 20 d5 ♗f6 21 dxe6 fxe6
22 ♗b5 and White had a minimal advantage
in the shape of Black's pawn weaknesses.

Black opted for the Catalan trade of
knight for dark-squared bishop in Hulak-
Psakhis, Zagreb 1993, emerging from
10...♖d5 11 ♖c3 ♖xf4 12 gxf4 a5!? with
control of b4. There followed 13 ♖fd1 ♗d5
14 ♖b5 ♖a6 15 e4 ♗c6 16 ♖c4 ♖b4 17
♖e5 ♗e8 with more space for White but a
solid set-up for Black, the try 18 d5 exd5 19
♖xd5 ♖xd5 20 ♖xd5 ♗d6 21 ♖f3 ♗c6 22
♖d3 ♖c8 23 e5 ♗e7 producing unclear play.
10...a5

The more modest 10...♖bd7 has also
been played, e.g. 11 ♖c3 ♖c8 12 ♖d3 ♖d5
13 ♗xe7 ♖xe7 14 e4 ♖xc3 15 bxc3 ♖fd8 16
♖fe1 ♖b6 17 ♖c2 ♗e8 18 ♖eb1 ♖b8 19 c4
e5 20 d5 ♖d7 21 ♖c3 f6 22 ♖d2 b6 23 a5
with an easier game for White (space) in
Wojtkiewicz-Watanabe, Merida 2000.

11...h6 is the other means of dealing with the bishop. In Filipppov-Kiriakov, St. Petersburg 2000 White dropped back to f4, and after 12 ♖f4 ♙d6 13 ♜fd1 a5 14 ♙e5 ♖xg2 15 ♖xg2 ♙b6 16 ♜b3 ♙fd5 17 ♙e4 ♖b4 18 ♙c5 ♙xf4+ 19 gxf4 ♜d5+ 20 ♜xd5 ♙xd5 21 ♙f3 ♖xc5 22 dxc5 ♜fd8 23 ♙d2 f5 chances remained even as both players had a knight in the centre. White can also use the tempo to turn his attentions to the queenside with 12 ♖xf6 ♙xf6 13 b4 ♙d5 14 ♙xd5 exd5 15 ♜b3 c6 16 e3 ♙e4 17 ♜fc1 ♙d6 18 ♜ab1 (Beliavsky-Karpov, Yugoslavia 1996), when Beliavsky gives the continuation 18...♖f6 19 ♙c2 ♜e6 20 b5 cxb5 21 axb5 a5 as unclear, or 13 a5 ♜d6 14 ♜fc1 ♜fd8 15 e3 ♜ac8 16 ♜b3 ♜b8 17 ♜c2 ♖xf3 18 ♖xf3 c5 19 ♙e2 cxd4 20 ♙xd4 ♙d5 21 ♜b3 ♙b4 22 ♜c4 b6 23 axb6 ♜xb6 24 ♖xb4 ♖xb4 25 ♙c6 a5 26 ♙xb8 ♜xb8, which was equal in Romanishin-Ivanovic, Belgrade 2000.

11 ♙c3 ♙a6 12 ♖xf6

Of course White is not obliged to make this capture immediately. 12 ♜ac1 ♙d5 (12...♜d6 13 ♙e5 ♖xg2 14 ♖xg2 c6 15 ♖xf6 gxf6 16 ♙f3 gave White a small edge in Kasparov-Karpov, World Championship (game 22), Moscow 1984) 13 ♜d3 ♙b4 14 ♜b1 c6 15 e4 ♖c4 16 ♜fd1 ♖b3 17 ♜e1 ♖c4!? is a line given by Chernin. Black is solid, although the position is unclear.

The alternative rook development is 12 ♜fd1. Then 12...♜d6 13 e3 h6 14 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 15 ♙d2 ♖xg2 16 ♖xg2 ♜b4 17 ♜e2 c6 18 ♙c4 is Tukmakov-Kir.Georgiev, Szirak 1995, when 18...♙d8 19 e4 ♖c7 20 d5 exd5 21 exd5 ♜fe8 22 ♜f1 ♜ad8 could have earned Black equality according to Kir.Georgiev. This leaves 12...♙d5 13 ♜b5 ♙b4 14 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 15 e4 ♖c6 16 ♜c4 g6 17 ♜ac1 ♜e8 18 d5 exd5 19 exd5 ♙d7 20 ♙d4 ♖e5 21 b3 ♜e7 22 ♜e1 ♜f6 23 ♙e4 ♜g7 24 ♙c5 with an edge for White in Ftacnik-Beliavsky, Germany 2000. White's pieces stand well but Black has his chances, too.

12...♖xf6 13 e4 ♙b4 14 ♜fd1 g6

In Delchev-Lputian, Ohrid 2001 the continuation 14...b6 15 ♙e1 ♜d7!? 16 ♙b5 ♜fc8 17 ♙c2 ♙xc2 18 ♜xc2 ♖e7 19 ♖h3 ♖xb5 20 axb5 c6 21 ♜e2 ♜f8 22 d5 cxd5 23 exd5 ♖c5 24 dxe6 ♜e8 left Black with compensation for the pawn due to the presence of opposite coloured bishops, while there is also pressure against f2.

With 15 ♜d2 ♖b7 16 ♜e2 g6 17 ♜e3 ♜e7 18 h4 White starts an attack on the kingside, but Black can defend. Romanishin-Kir.Georgiev, Ohrid 2001 went 18...♜ad8 19 ♜ad1 c5 20 e5 ♖g7 21 dxc5 ♖xf3 22 ♜xd8 ♜xd8 23 ♜xd8+ ♙xd8 24 ♖xf3 bxc5 25 ♜xc5 ♙d3 26 ♙d6 ♖f6!, the latest clever move maintaining the balance.

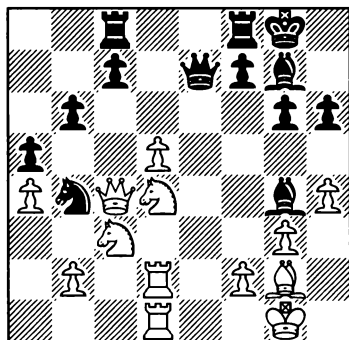
15 h4

15 ♜ac1 ♜e8 16 d5 exd5 17 exd5 ♙d7 18 ♙d4 was seen in Gelfand-Anand, Shenyang 2000, when 18...♖e5! 19 ♙cb5 ♜c8 20 ♙c6 bxc6 21 dxc6 ♖e6 22 ♜xd8 ♜cx8 23 ♜e2 ♖b3 would have given Black compensation for the material. Although there is only a rook and bishop for queen and pawn at the moment, Black's forces look menacing.

15...♜c8 16 ♜d2 ♖g7 17 ♜ad1

White is slightly better due to his presence in the centre.

17...♜e7 18 ♙g5 h6 19 ♙f3 b6 20 d5 ♙d7 21 ♙d4 exd5 22 exd5 ♖g4



23 ♙c6!

With this move White gets rid of Black's light-squared bishop and thus strengthens his

control of these squares.

23...♟xc6 24 ♜xg4 ♞e5 25 ♜e2 h5 26 ♟b5 ♜b4 27 ♞d4 ♜c5 28 ♞e4 ♞ce8 29 ♜e3 ♜xe3 30 ♞xe3 ♟c4!

Better than the passive 30...♞e7 31 ♞c1.

31 ♞xe8 ♞xe8 32 ♟xc7 ♞c8 33 d6 ♞d8

33...♟xd6 34 ♞xd6 ♞xc7 35 ♖d5 and, if anyone, White has only a minimal advantage in this endgame.

34 ♟b5 ♟xb2 35 ♞c1 ♟xa4 36 ♞c7 ♖f8 37 ♖d5 ♖xd6 38 ♞xf7 ♖h8

White is a pawn down but his initiative is strong. The knight on a4 is far from the battlefield on the kingside.

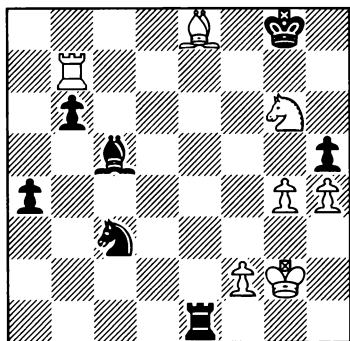
39 ♖e4 ♖e5

Another option is 39...♖c5 40 ♖xg6 ♟b2 with unclear play. Black has a dangerous a-pawn.

40 ♖xg6 ♞d5 41 ♟a7

Or 41 ♞h7+ ♖g8 42 ♖f7+ ♖xh7 43 ♖xd5 ♟c3 and the resulting opposite coloured bishop ending is drawn.

41...♞c5 42 ♞b7 ♖d4 43 ♖e8 ♞c1+ 44 ♖g2 ♟c3 45 ♟c6 ♖c5 46 ♞e5 a4 47 g4! ♞e1 48 ♟g6+ ♖g8



49 ♖f7+

49 gxf5! ♞xe8 50 h6 ♖e7 (forced) 51 ♟xe7+ ♞xe7 52 ♞xe7 a3 and Black's advanced pawns give her adequate counterplay. After 53 ♞a7 a2 54 ♖f3 b5 55 ♖f4 ♟a4 56 ♞g7+ ♖h8 57 ♞g1 b4 58 ♖g5 b3 59 ♞e1 b2 White has to force the draw: 60 ♞e8+ ♖h7 61 ♞e7+ ♖h8 etc.

49...♖g7 50 gxf5 ♟e4?

The situation is unclear after 50...♖h6.

51 ♖e8+ ♖h6

Or 51...♖f6 52 ♞f7+ ♖e6 53 ♟f4+ ♖d6 54 ♞d7+ ♖e5 55 ♟d3+ and White is winning.

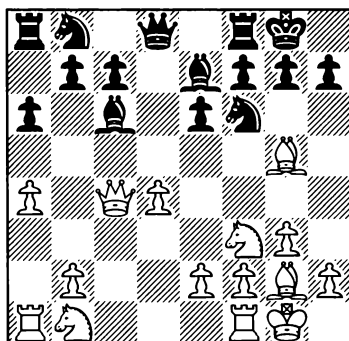
52 ♟e7 ♖h7 53 ♖g6+ ♖g7 54 ♟d5+ ♖f8 55 h6 ♟d6 56 ♞b8+ ♞e8 57 ♟f6 ♖d4 58 ♟xe8 ♖e7 59 ♟g7 ♖f6 60 h7 1-0

Game 39

Karpov-Milos

Buenos Aires 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♟f3 ♟f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♖e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♜c2 a6 8 a4 ♖d7 9 ♜xc4 ♖c6 10 ♖g5



10...♖d5 11 ♜d3 c5

11...♖e4 12 ♜e3 ♟bd7 13 ♟c3 ♖c6 14 ♜d3 ♖b4 15 ♞fe1 ♖xf3! 16 ♜xf3 c6 17 ♞ed1 ♜a5 18 h4 h6 19 ♖d2 e5 20 ♖e1 ♞fe8 21 e3 ♞ad8 was equal in Beliavsky-Z. Almasi, Ubeda 1997, Black being ultra-solid. This worked out better for Black than 14...♞b8 15 ♜c2 b5 16 axb5 axb5, which was the course of Akopian-Ghaem Maghami, Yerevan 2001. After 17 ♟e5 ♖xg2 18 ♖xg2 ♟xe5 19 dxe5 ♟d5 20 ♖xe7 ♜xe7 21 ♟e4 b4 22 ♞fc1 b3 23 ♜c5 ♜d7 24 ♜c6 ♖e7 25 h4 h6 26 ♞a7 White's activity gave him the better chances.

12 dxc5

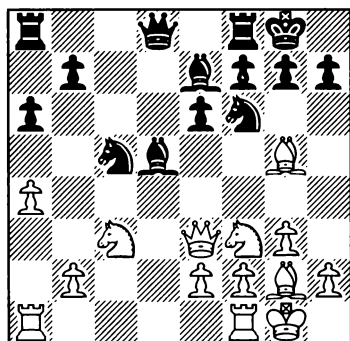
12 ♟c3 ♖c6 13 ♞fd1 cxd4 14 ♟xd4

♙xg2 15 ♖xg2 ♜a5 16 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 17 ♜e4 ♙xd4 18 ♜xd4 ♜c6 19 ♜c5 was level in Tukmakov-Beliavsky, Portoroz 1996, while Black also has the immediate 12...cxd4. Then Karpov-Beliavsky, Linares 1994 continued 13 ♜xd5 ♜xd5? 14 h4! ♜bd7?! (14...♜c6 15 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 16 ♜g5 ♜f5 17 ♙e4 ♜e5 18 ♙xc6 ♙xg5 19 ♙xb7 ♜a7 20 ♙xa6 ♙e7 21 ♜fd1 is a shade favourable for White thanks to the passed queenside pawns) 15 ♜xd4 ♜d6 16 ♜fd1 ♜c5 17 ♜c4 ♜f8 18 b4! with a clear lead for White, who won after 18...♜xa4? 19 ♜b3! ♜b6 20 e3 etc. Black is only slightly worse after the correct 13...♜xd5 14 ♙xe7 ♜xe7 15 ♜xd4, when the Catalan bishop comes into play.

12...♜bd7

12...♙xc5 13 ♜c3 ♙c6 is sensible. In Onischuk-Zvjaginzev, Poikovsky 2002 a draw was agreed after 14 ♜c4 ♜bd7 15 b4 ♙e7 16 b5 ♙xf3 17 ♙xf3 ♜e5 18 ♜f4 ♜xf3+ 19 ♜xf3 axb5 20 axb5 ♜b6 21 ♙e3 ♜c7 22 ♙f4 ♜b6 23 ♙e3. White can try 14 ♜e5 ♜xd3 15 ♜xd3 ♙d4 16 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 17 ♜e4 but 17...♙e7 is acceptable for Black, who was able to neutralise White's attempted initiative in Papaioannou-Beliavsky, Istanbul 2000 after 18 ♜fc1 ♜d7 19 ♜ec5 ♜xc5 20 ♜xc5 ♙xg2 21 ♖xg2 ♜f8 22 ♜d3 ♖f8 23 ♜c7 ♜ab8 24 ♙ac1 ♖e8 25 ♜7c4 f6 26 f4 ♜d7 27 ♜c8+ ♙xc8 28 ♜xc8+ ♜d8 29 ♜c7 ♜d7 etc.

13 ♜c3 ♜xc5 14 ♜e3



14...♙a5

Another possibility is 14...♜c8 15 ♜fd1 ♜e8 16 ♜e5 ♜b6 17 ♙h3! ♜cd8 18 a5 ♜b3 19 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 20 ♜xf7!, White's brilliant sacrifice securing an advantage in Smyslov-Nogueiras, Graz 1984 after 20...♖xf7 21 ♜xc5 ♜c8 22 ♜e3 ♙xc3 23 bxc3 ♜xc3 24 ♜f4+.

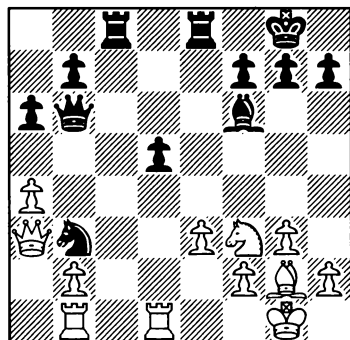
15 ♙xf6

15 ♜fd1 ♙c6 16 ♜f4 ♜b3 17 ♜ab1 h6 18 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 19 ♜e4 ♙xe4 20 ♜xe4 ♜c5 21 ♜e3 ♜b4 22 ♜e5 ♜ad8 23 ♜d3 ♜xd3 24 ♜xd3 ♜xa4 25 ♜xd8 ♜xd8 26 ♙xb7 was agreed drawn in Adianto-Short, Beijing 2000. However, an interesting suggestion is Pigu-sov's 15 ♜xd5!? ♜xd5 16 ♜a3 ♙xg5 17 ♜xg5 h6 18 ♜fc1 ♜d7 19 ♜e4 b5 20 axb5 ♜xb5 21 ♜c3 ♜xc3 22 bxc3, when the combination of the unbalanced pawn structure and bishop versus knight looks nice for White.

15...♙xf6 16 ♜xd5 exd5 17 ♜a3 ♜b6

17...♜e4!? is worth a try. 18 ♜ad1 ♜fd8 19 e3 ♜ac8 20 ♜d4 ♜c4 21 b3 ♜cc8 22 b4 ♜b6 23 a5 ♜d6 24 ♜c1 g6 25 ♜b2 ♜d7 26 b5 ♙xd4 27 ♜xd4 ♜xb5 28 ♙xe4 dxe4 and a draw was agreed in Karpov-Gelfand, Monaco (rapid) 2001. This is a bit premature as there is still a lot to play for in this position.

18 ♜ab1 ♜b3 19 ♜fd1 ♜fe8 20 e3 ♜ac8



21 ♜d2!

After the knight exchange it might seem difficult for White to generate an initiative

with opposite coloured bishops on the board, but this is not the case. 21 ♖xd5?! offers White nothing after 21...♗e7 22 a5 ♖g6 23 ♗a2 ♖c1 24 ♗a1 ♖b3 25 ♖e5 ♗c2 26 ♗a2 ♖c1.

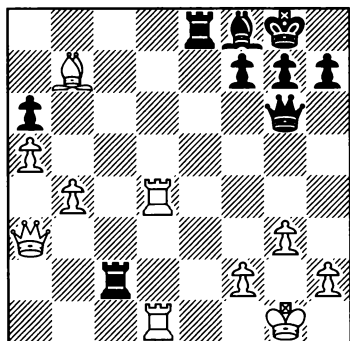
21...♖xd2 22 ♖xd2

Black's light-squared pawns are easier to attack.

22...d4 23 exd4 ♖xd4 24 a5 ♖g6 25 ♖bd1 ♖c5 26 b4 ♖f8 27 ♖xb7

White has a big advantage.

27...♖c2 28 ♖d4!



As long as White protects the c5-square f2 will be quite safe.

28...♗ce2 29 ♗f3 ♖e1+ 30 ♖g2 ♖xd1 31 ♗xd1 ♖b8 32 ♗f3 ♖e7 33 b5! axb5 34 a6 ♖c5 35 ♖d5 ♗c2

Or 35...♖a7 36 ♖d7 ♗e6 37 ♖xf7! and White is winning.

36 ♖d7 ♖h8 37 ♖e4 ♗a2 38 ♗f5 1-0

Game 40
Kramnik-Gelfand
Astana 2001

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♗c2 a6 8 a4 ♖d7 9 ♗xc4 ♖c6 10 ♖g5 ♖d5 11 ♗c2 ♖e4 12 ♗d1

The alternative is 12 ♗c1 with a wide range of possibilities.

12...♖bd7 13 ♖c3 ♖c6 14 ♗c2 ♖b4 15 ♖fe1 ♖xf3 16 ♖xf3 c6 and Black had a solid

Slav-like position in Tkachiev-Z. Almasi, Senec 1998. Indeed after 17 ♖ed1 ♗a5 18 ♖a2 ♖d6 19 ♖d2 ♗c7 20 ♖g2 a5 21 ♖ac1 ♖fd8 22 h3 ♖f8 23 e4 e5 24 ♖e3 the point was shared.

Black also had nothing to fear after 12...c5 13 dxc5 ♖bd7 14 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 15 ♖bd2 ♖d5 16 e4 ♖c6 17 ♗c2 ♗a5 18 ♖fc1 ♖ac8 19 ♖b3 ♗b4 20 ♗c4 ♗xc4 21 ♖xc4 ♖xb2 22 ♖b1 ♖a3 23 ♖a1 ♖b2 in Kir.Georgiev-Bruzon, Moscow 2001.

The proceedings during the series 12...♖c6 13 ♖bd2 ♖xd4 14 ♖xd4 ♖xg2 15 ♖xe6! fxe6 16 ♖xg2 ♗d5+ 17 ♖f3 c5 18 a5 h6 19 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 20 ♗c2 c4 21 ♖fd1 ♗b5 22 ♖d4 ♖xd4 23 ♖xd4 ♖ac8 24 ♗d2 ♖c5 25 e4 ♗c6 proved interesting but still led to equality in Kir.Georgiev-Beliavsky, Germany 2001, while 17...♖d6 18 ♗c2 ♗e4 19 ♖fc1 ♗xc2 20 ♖xc2 ♖d5 21 ♖d2 e5! left Black with an isolated pawn in the centre but compensation for this weakness in the form of active pieces in Kir.Georgiev-Brenjo, Yugoslavia 2001. After the further 22 ♖g5 ♖f6 23 ♖e6 ♖f7 24 ♖ac1 c6 25 ♖d1 ♖e7 26 ♖g5 e4 27 ♖a5 ♖d5 28 ♖c4 ♖ae8 the situation remained unclear.

Also possible is 13...♖g6 14 ♖b3 h6 15 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 16 ♖d1 ♖b4 17 ♖e1 c6 18 a5 ♖h5 19 ♗d2 ♖d5 20 ♖d3 when White had a firm grip on the dark squares in Ivanisevic-Beliavsky, Belgrade 2000.

12...h6 is sufficient for equality, e.g. 13 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 14 ♖c3 ♖xf3 15 ♖xf3 c6 with the same type of solid position for Black in Belavsky-Lutz, Leon 2001, which continued 16 e3 a5 17 ♖d1 ♖a6 18 ♗c2 ♖b4 19 ♗e4 ♗e7 20 ♖d2 ♖ad8 21 ♖ad1 ♖d7 22 ♗g4 ♖fd8 23 ♖e4 b6 24 ♖e2 g6 25 ♖c4 ♖g7 26 ♗e2 ♖d5 27 ♖c3 ♗b4 with a good game for Black. Dropping back led to equality in Khalifman-Bologan, Panormo 2001: 13 ♖f4 ♖d5 14 ♖c3 ♖xf4 15 ♗xf4 ♖xf3 16 ♖xf3 c6 17 ♖fd1 a5! 18 h4 ♖d7 19 ♗e4 etc.

12...c5

12...h6 13 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 14 ♖c3 ♖xf3 15

♟xf3 c6 16 ♖b3 ♜a7 17 a5! and White can hope for an edge. Then 17...♟xd4 18 ♜fd1 ♖f6 19 ♜a4 e5 20 ♜e4 is good for White, so Azmaiparashvili-Gelfand, Moscow 2001 went 17...♜d7 18 ♜fd1 ♖c7 19 ♜e4 ♟e7 20 ♜d2 ♜aa8 21 ♜c4 ♜ad8 22 ♜ac1 ♜f6 23 e4, although White's space advantage meant something.

13 dxc5 ♟xc5

Again Black is not without alternatives.

13...♖xd1?! is not the best option. Pigusov-Kruppa, Panormo 2001 continued 14 ♜xd1 ♟xc5 15 ♜c3 ♟c6 16 ♜e5 ♟xg2 17 ♟xg2 b6 18 ♟xf6 gxf6, and now White could have obtained the chances after 19 ♜c4 ♜a7 20 ♜e4 f5 21 ♜xc5 bxc5 22 ♜d6 with considerable play and the superior structure.

Black was okay in Kozul-Ribli, Solin/Split 2001 after 13...♜bd7 14 ♜c3 ♟c6 15 b4 a5 16 b5 ♟xf3 17 ♟xf3 ♜xc5 18 ♟e3 ♜c8 19 ♖b1 ♟d6 20 ♜e4 ♜cxe4 21 ♟xe4 ♖e7 22 ♟g2 ♟c5 23 ♟d2 b6 24 ♖b3 ♜fd8 etc.

13...h6 14 ♟e3 ♜d5 15 ♖c1 ♖a5 16 ♜bd2 ♜xe3 17 ♜b3 ♖b4 18 ♖xe3 ♜d7 sees Black develop and thus earn a level game. However, in Romanishin-Beliavsky, Belgrade 2000 White's less precise play saw Black emerge from 16 ♜a3?! ♜d7 17 ♜c4 ♖b4 18 ♜e1 ♜xe3 19 ♜xe3 ♜xc5 20 ♜1c2 ♖b6 21 a5 ♖c7 22 ♟xe4 ♜xe4 23 ♜a4 ♜d6 24 ♜a3 ♜ac8 25 ♖xc7 ♜xc7 with a slight lead, the knight rather misplaced on a3.

14 ♖xd8 ♜xd8 15 ♜bd2 ♟c6 16 ♜b3 ♜bd7

16...♟b4!? 17 ♜fc1 ♜bd7 18 ♟d2 ♟xd2 19 ♜fxd2 ♟xg2 20 ♟xg2 ♜dc8 21 ♜c4 ♜ab8 22 ♜ca5 g5 23 ♟f1 ♟f8 24 ♟e1 led to a draw in Savchenko-Pigusov, Ohrid 2001.

17 ♜fc1 ♟b6 18 ♜fd2 ♟xg2 19 ♟xg2 ♜dc8 20 ♟xf6 ♜xf6 21 ♜c4 ♟c7 22 ♜c5 ♜ab8?!

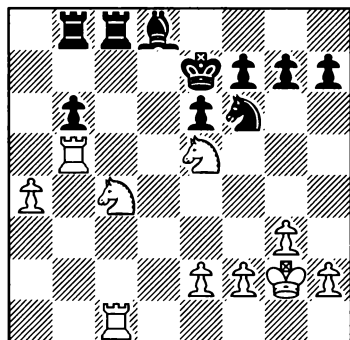
22...b6? is poor because after 23 ♜xa6! ♜xa6 24 ♜d6 ♟xd6 25 ♜xc8+ ♟f8 26 ♜d1 h5 27 ♜dd8 ♜h7 28 ♜a8 the rook and passed a-pawn are clearly superior to the two

minor pieces on the other flank. However, an improvement on the game is 22...b5! 23 ♜d2 ♟d6 24 ♜db3 ♟f8 with equality.

23 b4 ♟f8 24 ♜ab1 ♟e7

In reply to 24...b5 White sacrifices once again: 25 ♜xa6!? bxc4 26 ♜xb8 ♟xb8 27 b5 and his pawns are dangerous.

25 b5 axb5 26 ♜xb5 b6 27 ♜d3 ♟d8 28 ♜de5



28...♟f8?

28...♜e4 29 ♜d1 f6 is better, when 30 ♜d7+ ♟e8 31 ♜d4 ♜c3 32 ♜d6+ ♟e7! 33 ♜xc8+ ♜xc8 34 ♜c4 ♜xc4 35 ♜xc4 ♜xb5 36 axb5 slightly favours White as the b6-pawn needs protection. The bishop is passive and it is not easy to drive the knight away from c4. Nevertheless, Black has good chances of saving the game.

29 ♜xb6! ♜xc1

Or 29...♟xb6 30 ♜xb6 ♜xb6 31 ♜xc8+ ♟e7 32 ♜a8 when, with accurate play, White should win.

30 ♜bd7+ ♜xd7 31 ♜xd7+ ♟e8 32 ♜xb8 ♜c8 33 ♜a6 ♜c2 34 e3 ♜a2 35 ♜c5 ♟c7 36 ♜b7 ♜d8 37 ♜b4 ♟e7

37...♟d6 is another option. After 38 ♜b7+ ♟c7 39 ♜xd6 ♟xd6 40 ♜b7 ♜xa4 41 ♜xf7 ♜g4 42 f4 White has a decisive advantage.

38 ♜e4 f5 39 ♜b7 ♜c2

39...fxe4 40 ♜xc7+ ♟f6 41 ♜c4 ♟f5 42 h3 and Black's pawns are very weak.

40 ♜g5 h6 41 ♜f3 ♟f6 42 ♜d4 ♜c4 43

♖b5 ♗e5 44 f4 ♖c3 45 ♜f7+!

The minor piece ending is winning for White.

45...♙xf7 46 ♖d6+ ♗e7 47 ♖xc4 ♖d7
48 ♙f3 ♗c6 49 e4 ♗c5 50 ♖e5 fxe4+
51 ♗xe4 ♗b4 52 ♖c6+ ♗xa4 53 ♖d4
♗b4 54 ♖xe6 ♗c4 55 g4 ♖f6 56 h3
♖b2 57 h4 ♖c3 58 f5 ♖b2 59 ♖xg7
♖xg7 60 g5 1-0

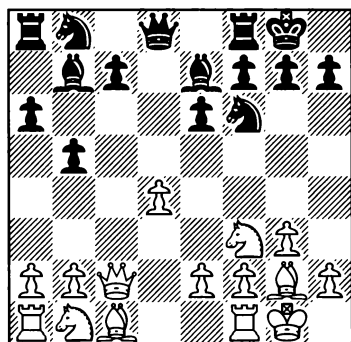
White plays 7 ♜c2 a6 8 ♜xc4

Game 41

Jo. Horvath-Wells

Odorheiu Secuiesc 1993

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5
♖g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♜c2 a6 8 ♜xc4 b5
9 ♜c2 ♖b7



10 ♖f4

10 ♖g5 ♖bd7 11 ♖bd2 ♜c8 (11...c5!? 12
♙xf6 gxf6! is interesting) and White must
address Black's desire to push the c-pawn. 12
♖b3!? ♗e4 13 ♜c1 c5 14 ♖xc5! ♖xc5 15
dxc5 ♜xc5 16 ♗e3 ♜a8 17 ♙xf6 gxf6 was
seen in Larsen-Ribli, Amsterdam 1980, when
18 ♜ad1 should secure a slight edge. White
can also throw in 12 ♙xf6 ♖xf6 in order to
reduce his opponent's influence on c5. Kas-
parov-Karpov, World Championship (game
20), Leningrad 1986 went 13 ♖b3 c5 14 dxc5
♖d5 (14...♗e4 15 ♜c3 ♖d5 16 ♜ac1 ♖xb3
17 ♜xb3 ♖xc5 18 e3 ♜b6 19 ♜c2 ♜c7 20

♖e5 ♜fc8 21 ♜d1 h6 22 ♜cd2 was drawn in
Schandorff-Nielsen, Esbjerg 2001) 15 ♜fd1
(15 ♖e1 ♖xg2! 16 ♖xg2 ♖d7 17 ♜fd1 ♜c7
18 c6 ♖b8 19 ♜ac1 ♜xc6 20 ♜xc6 ♜xc6 21
♖f4 led to a draw in Khalifman-Yusupov,
Moscow 1988) 15...♖xb3 16 ♜xb3 ♜c7 17
a4 ♜xc5 18 axb5 axb5 19 ♖d4 b4 20 e3
♜fd8 21 ♜d2 ♜b6 and the position was
symmetrical, equal and, consequently, drawn.

Also possible is 13...♗e4 14 ♜c3 (14 ♜c1
c5 15 dxc5 a5! 16 a4 ♜d5! 17 ♜e3! is un-
clear) 14...♖d5 15 ♜d2 ♖b4! 16 ♜d1 c5, the
thematic break equalising for Black in Spi-
ridonov-Kotronias, Corfu 1989 after 17 a3 c4!
18 axb4 cxb3 19 ♜xb3 ♜d6 20 ♖e5 ♖xg2
21 ♖xg2, when 21...♜xb4 is even slightly
better for Black according to Kotronias.

10...♖c6

10...♖d6 11 ♖g5 transposes to 10 ♖d2
♖d6 11 ♖g5.

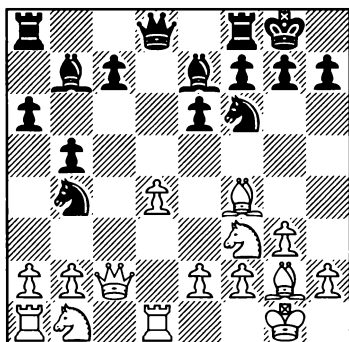
11 ♜d1

In the event of 11 ♖bd2, worth consider-
ing is 11...♖xd4 12 ♖xd4 ♖xg2 13 ♖xe6
fxe6 14 ♖xg2 c5 15 ♖f3 with unclear play.
Black's queenside majority compensates for
the slight weakness on e6. In Piket-Lautier,
Wijk aan Zee 1997 Black opted for 11...♜c8
12 ♜ad1 ♖b4 13 ♜b1 ♖bd5 14 ♖e5 ♖d7
15 ♖b3 ♜e8! 16 e4 ♖5b6 17 ♜fe1, when
17...♖c4 would have guaranteed equality
according to Lautier. Kotronias gives 12
♖b3 ♖b4 13 ♜c1 ♖d5 14 ♖fd2 ♖xg2 15
♖xg2 c5! 16 dxc5 a5! 17 a4 ♜d5+ 18 f3
♖xc5! 19 e4 ♜h5 20 g4 ♖xg4 21 fxe4
♜xg4+ 22 ♖g3 ♖b6 with an initiative for
Black thanks to White's exposed king.

Also possible is 11 ♖c3 ♖b4 (11...♖xd4
12 ♖xd4 ♖xg2 13 ♖xe6 fxe6 14 ♖xg2 c5 15
♜ad1 ♜e8 and the queen is heading for c6,
giving Black a good game) 12 ♜b1 c5 13
dxc5 ♖xc5, when the most natural course is
14 ♖g5 ♖xg2 15 ♖xg2 ♖bd5 etc. Instead
after 14 ♖e5!? ♖g4 15 ♖e4 ♖xe4! 16 ♜xe4
f5 Kirov-Vera, Timisoara 1987 went 17 ♜b1,
White being punished for his passivity after
17...♜b6 18 e3 ♖xe3! 19 fxe3 ♖xe5 20

12...c5 13 dxc5 14 e3 15 f3 16 e5 17 f4 18 c2! 19 a1 (18 a1? 19 f2 e3 and Black wins) 18...b6 and Black enjoys the initiative.

11...b4



12...c1

12...c1? 13 cxc1 14 e3 15 f3 16 e5 17 f4 18 c2! 19 a1 (18 a1? 19 f2 e3 and Black wins) 18...b6 and Black emerges the exchange up.

12...c8

Also possible is 12...c8 13 e3 14 f3 15 e5 16 f4 17 c2! 18 a1 (18 a1? 19 f2 e3 and Black wins) 18...b6 and Black emerges the exchange up.

13...c3 14...bd5 15...e5!

After 14...c3 15...bd5 16...e5 17...f3 18...e3 19...f3 20...e5 21...f4 22...c2! 23...a1 (23...a1? 24...f2 e3 and Black wins) 23...b6 and Black enjoys the initiative.

14...c5 15 dxc5 16 e3 17 f3 18 e5 19 f4 20 c2! 21 a1 (21 a1? 22 f2 e3 and Black wins) 21...b6 and Black enjoys the initiative.

White is better due to the slight weakness of Black's queenside. These pawns are more advanced and therefore more exposed.

19...f6

19...f6 20 e1 h6 21 a1 c1 22 c1 c1 23 c1 f6 24 d3 is Andersson-Kir.Georgiev, Sarajevo 1985, again with the better prospects for White.

20...d6!

20...d6 led only to equality after 20...h6 21 c5 c5 22 c1 b6 23 e5 xg2 24 xg2 in Andersson-Beliavsky, Debreceen 1992.

20...xd6 21 xd6 fc8 22 e1 xg2 23 xg2 a5 24 a6 a4 25 b3 axb3 26 axb3 g5 27 d3 c2 28 a8 xa8 29 xa8+ g7 30 f1 e4 31 b4 d2+ 32 e1 b3 33 a7 f6

If Black tries to get rid of the well placed knight on d3 with 33...c1? he is punished after 34 d1 a2 35 xa2 xa2 36 c2, when the knight is caught.

34...d7 a2?!

Dubious. 34...g4 is more appropriate, when 35 e3 d2 36 c5 xd7 37 xd7+ e7! 38 e5 f6! 39 xg4 d1 40 d2 a2 sees Black regain the pawn with immediate equality.

35 f3 h5 36 f2 g4?!

After the more stubborn 36...c2 37 f4 gxf4 38 gxf4 d1 39 e5 f5 40 f3 c3+ 41 e3 f6 42 c7! Black anyway finds his king in trouble.

37 f4 d2 38 b7 d4?

38...c2 39 e5 is also good for White, although the text loses.

39...e3 40...b3 41...e5 1-0

White wins at least one pawn.

Game 42

Kramnik-Svidler

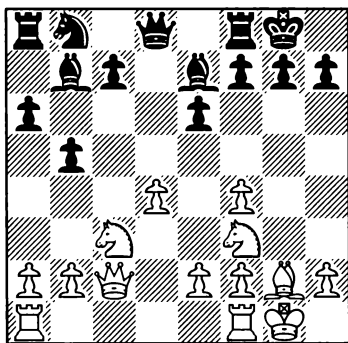
Linares 1998

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 f3 f6 4 g3 dxc4 5

♖g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♜c2 a6 8 ♜xc4 b5
9 ♜c2 ♗b7 10 ♖f4 ♖d5 11 ♖c3

Another option for White is 11 ♖bd2 ♖d7 12 ♖b3 c5 13 dxc5 ♜c8 14 ♜ad1 ♖xc5 15 e4 ♖d7 16 ♜d3 ♖5f6 (16...♖xf4 17 ♜xd7 ♖e2+ 18 ♖h1 ♖xe4 19 ♜a7 gives White too much play) 17 e5 ♖d5, when Black equalized in Beliavsky-I.Ivanov, Minsk 1976. After 18 ♜fe1 ♖xf4 19 ♜xd7 ♖xg2 20 ♜xb7 ♖xe1 21 ♜xd8 ♖xf3+ 22 ♖g2 ♜fxd8 23 ♖xf3 ♖f8 24 ♜xa6 ♜c2 White had a pawn and prospects of a passed pawn on the queenside, while Black had more active pieces.

11...♖xf4 12 gxf4



12...♖d7

Stangl-Ruf, Kecskemet 1990 went 12...♖c6 13 ♜fd1 ♖b4 14 ♜c1 ♜b8 15 a3 ♖d5 16 ♖e5 ♖xc3 17 ♜xc3 ♖xg2 18 ♖xg2 and White had a firm grip on the dark squares which soon translated to an advantage after 18...♖d6 19 ♜ac1 ♜b7+ 20 ♖c6 ♖h8 (20...♖xf4? 21 ♜f3) 21 ♜f3. The knight on c6 is very annoying for Black.

13 ♜fd1

13 ♖g5?! is best avoided, as demonstrated in Gutman-Kochiev, Ashkhabad 1978: 13...♖xg5 14 ♖xb7 ♖xf4! 15 ♖xa8 ♜h4 16 ♜fd1 ♜xa8 and Black had a pawn and an attack brewing. The further 17 ♜e4 ♜xh2+ 18 ♖f1 ♜e8 19 ♜f3 ♖d6 20 e3 f5 left both sides with something to bite on. Stangl-Blauert, Dortmund 1992 continued 13 ♖e4

♜c8 14 ♖c5?! (too ambitious – 14 ♜fd1 c5 is equal) 14...♖xc5 15 dxc5 ♖xf3 16 ♖xf3 ♜d4 17 e3 ♜xc5 18 ♜xc5 ♖xc5 19 ♜fc1 ♖d6 20 ♜c6 ♜a8 21 ♜c2 ♜ab8 22 ♜c6 and Black was slightly better due to his extra pawn, but the game was drawn.

13...♖xf3?!

13...♜c8 14 ♖e4 c5 15 dxc5 ♖xc5 16 ♖xc5 ♜xc5 17 ♜xc5 ♖xc5 18 ♜ac1 ♜fc8 19 ♖e5 ♖xg2 20 ♖xg2 f6 21 ♖f3 ♖f8 22 e3 was the course of Ribli-Karpov, Amsterdam, 1980. White has a small advantage here and he eventually won the game.

In Sosonko-Dutreeuw, Brussels 1993 White threw in 14 a4 b4 before 15 ♖e4. After the dubious 15...♖d5?! 16 ♜ac1 ♜a7 17 ♖e5 ♖xe5 18 fxe5 ♜a8 19 ♜d3! f5 20 exf6 gxf6 21 ♖f3 ♜d8 22 ♜e3 ♖h8 23 ♖h1 ♜g8 24 ♜g1 c6 25 ♖d2 Black had numerous weaknesses in this semi-closed position. Sosonko offers 15...c5 16 dxc5 ♖xc5 17 ♖d6 ♖xd6 18 ♖xd6.

14 ♖xf3 ♜b8 15 e3

15 ♖e4 ♖d6 16 e3 ♜h4 17 ♖h1 ♖f6 18 ♖xf6+ ♜xf6 19 ♜g1 ♜e7 20 ♖c6 with the better prospects for White in Smyslov-Barczay, Kapfenberg 1970. The pawn phalanx dominates the enemy bishop, while White is able to attack Black's queenside pawns.

15...♖f6

15...♜c8 leaves White in charge after 16 ♜ac1 c5 17 d5 exd5 18 ♖xd5 ♖d6 19 ♖g4 ♜d8 (19...♜c6?! 20 ♜e4 ♖h8? 21 ♖f6! and White wins a piece) 20 e4 (Sosonko). Black has problems on the d-file.

16 ♜ac1 ♜d6 17 ♖e2 ♜fc8 18 e4 ♜d7 19 d5!

White breaks through in the centre and obtains an advantage.

19...exd5

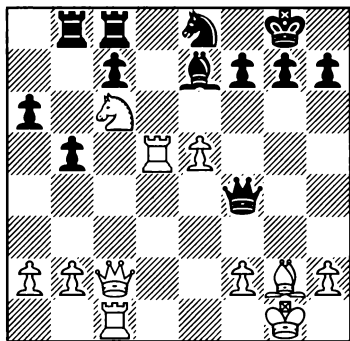
Or 19...♖f8 20 ♖d4! exd5 21 ♖c6 ♜b6 22 e5 ♖e8 23 ♖xd5 ♜h3 24 ♜e4. Notice how well White's pieces are posted compared to Black's uncoordinated forces.

20 e5 ♖e8 21 ♖xd5 ♜h3 22 ♖g2 ♜h4

23 ♖d4!

White wins material.

23... ♗xf4 24 ♖c6



24... ♗h4

After 24... ♗g5 25 ♖cd1 ♖b6 26 ♖5d4 the queen is in trouble – 26... ♖xc6 27 ♗xc6 ♗f5 28 ♖d8! and White wins (Marciano).

25 ♖cd1 ♖b6 26 ♖5d4 ♖xc6

Both 26... ♗h6 27 ♗f5 and 26... ♗g5 27 ♗e4 win for White.

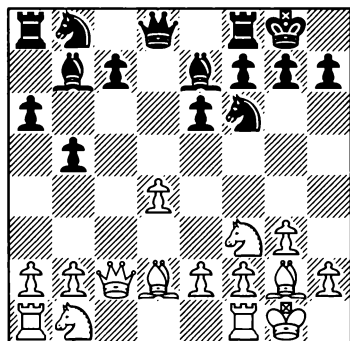
27 ♖xc6 ♗xe5 28 ♖d7 ♖d8 29 ♖xh4 1-0

Game 43

Kobalija-Kiriakov

Dubai 2002

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♖e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♗c2 a6 8 ♗xc4 b5 9 ♗c2 ♖b7 10 ♖d2



10... ♖c6

10... ♖d6 11 ♖g5 ♖bd7 is a different set-up. Ricardi-Soppe, San Fernando 1993 went 12 ♖bd2 h6 13 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 14 ♖fd1 ♖c8 15 ♖b3 ♖e4 16 ♗c3 ♗e7 17 ♖ac1 and White had a firm grip on c5, securing an advantage after 17... ♖d5 18 ♖e5 ♖xg2 19 ♖xg2 ♖xe5 20 dxe5 ♖d5 21 ♗c5 ♗g5 22 ♗d4 ♖b6 23 ♖c5. Nor did Black have any joy in Hübner-Eng, Germany 1985 after 12...c5 13 ♖xf6 ♗xf6?! 14 ♖e5! ♖xg2 15 ♖xd7 ♗d8 16 ♖xf8 ♖xf1 17 ♗xh7+ ♖xf8 18 ♖xf1 cxd4 19 ♗h8+ ♖e7 20 ♖xg7, when White won a pawn, 20... ♗h8 21 ♗g5+ ♗f6 22 ♗xf6+ ♖xf6 23 ♖c1 adding the only open file to his collection. Black has an improvement in 13...gxf6 14 ♖e4, although White is still better.

After 10... ♖bd7 White sends his bishop elsewhere – 11 ♖a5. Chetverik-Ortmann, Gyula 2000 continued 11... ♖b6 12 ♖bd2 ♖c8 13 ♖xb6 cxb6 14 ♗d3 ♗c7 15 ♖fd1 ♖fd8, White's majority in the centre counting for more than Black's on the queenside. With 16 a3 ♗c2 17 ♗xc2 ♖xc2 18 ♖e1 ♖c7 19 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 20 e3 White's chances would have been better.

11... ♖c8 12 ♖bd2 ♖b8 13 a3 ♖c6 14 ♖c3 b4?! 15 axb4 ♖xb4 16 ♗b3 ♖d5 17 ♗a4 ♖c6 18 ♗a5 ♖b8 19 ♖e5 ♖xg2 20 ♖xg2 ♖b5 21 ♗a4 c5 22 dxc5 ♖xc5 23 ♖df3 saw Black's attempt to steal the advantage leave him only with a weak a-pawn in I.Almasi-Lauber, Gyula 1997. I.Almasi gives 14... ♖d5 15 b4 ♖xc3 16 ♗xc3 ♖a8 17 ♖b3 when White is better, again due to control of c5 and the c-file.

11... ♖a7 looks artificial, e.g. 12 ♖bd2 ♗a8 13 b4 ♖b8 14 a3 ♖c6 15 ♖b3 ♖xa5 16 ♖xa5, Chetverik-B.Furman, Karvina 1998. If Black cannot move the c-pawn then the rook looks a bit silly on a7. There followed 16... ♖e4 17 ♖e1! (White goes for an advantage in the ending) 17... ♖xc2 18 ♖xa8 ♖axa8 19 ♖xc2 ♖d6 20 f4 with total control of the dark squares. After 13...e5 14 dxe5 ♖xe5 15

a3 ♖c6 16 ♗xc7 ♖d4 17 ♔d3 ♗xf3 18 ♖xf3 ♖xe2+ 19 ♔xe2 ♗xc7 20 ♖d4 Black is under pressure on the queenside.

11 e3

Preferable to 11 ♗d1?! ♖xd4 12 ♖xd4 ♗xg2 13 ♗a5 (13 ♖xe6?! ♗e4! 14 ♔xe4 ♖xe4 15 ♖xd8 ♗fxd8 and the pin on the d-file is annoying for White) 13...♗e4 14 ♔xc7 ♔xc7 15 ♗xc7 ♗ac8, when Black was happier in Plaskett-Adams, Great Britain 1997. White's queenside needs help and Black enjoys a pull.

11...♗b8

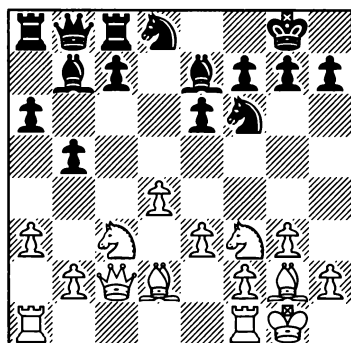
The mysterious 11...♗a7 has been played here. Salov-A.Rotstein, France 1993 continued 12 ♗c1 ♗a8 13 ♖e1 ♖b8 14 ♗xb7 ♔xb7 15 ♗a5! c5 (it is difficult to suggest an improvement for Black) 16 dxc5 ♗c8 (16...♖c6 17 ♗b6 ♗aa8 18 a4 ♖d7 19 a5?! ♗ac8 20 ♖d2 favours White) 17 ♖d3 ♖c6 18 ♗b6 ♗aa8 19 a4 bxa4 20 ♖c3 ♖d7 21 ♖xa4 and White kept the extra pawn.

Also possible is 11...♖b4 12 ♗xb4 ♗xb4 13 a3 ♗d6 14 ♖bd2, when Beliavsky-Karpov, Brussels 1988 went 14...♗c8 15 b4 a5! 16 e4 ♗e7 17 ♗ab1 axb4 18 axb4 ♗a8 19 ♗fe1 ♗a4 20 ♔c3 ♗a8 21 ♖e5 ♗d8 22 ♔xc7 ♗f8, White winning the weak c7-pawn but Black having counterplay against the pawns on b4, d4 and e4. After 23 d5 Beliavsky gives 23...exd5 24 exd5 ♗xd5 25 ♖g6+ ffxg6 26 ♔xe7+ ♗g8 as equal. Pigusov-Rozentalis, Sevastopol 1986 saw more action on the other flank: 14...♗e7 15 e4 e5 16 ♖h4! g6 17 f4 exd4 18 e5 d3 19 ♔xd3 ♗c5+ 20 ♗h1 ♗fd8 21 ♔c2 ♖d5 22 ♗ae1 and White's initiative in the centre and on the kingside looked dangerous.

12 a3 ♗c8 13 ♖c3

Timman-Hjartarson, Amsterdam 1989 went 13 ♗e1! a5 14 ♖c3 ♖d8 15 e4 b4 16 ♖a4 ♖d7 17 ♗f4 ♗d6 18 ♗e3 ♗c6 19 d5 b3 20 ♔c4 ♔b5 21 ♔xb5 ♗xb5 22 ♖c3 ♗d3 23 ♖d4 with an advantage to White thanks to his better placed pieces.

13...♖d8



14 b4

14 e4!? invites the liberating 14...c5 15 ♗f4 ♗a7 16 dxc5 ♗xc5 17 e5 ♖d7 18 ♗ad1 (Short), with only an edge for White.

14...a5 15 bxa5!?

15 ♗ab1 axb4 16 axb4 ♖c6 17 ♖a2 ♗a6 18 ♖c1 ♗a8 19 ♔d1 ♗a3 20 ♖e1 e5! saw Black free himself and equalize in Karpov-Short, Tilburg 1988, but 15 ♔b2!? axb4 16 axb4 ♖e4 17 ♖e5! is interesting. Black can then sacrifice the queen with 17...♖xd2 18 ♖d7 ♖xf1 19 ♖xb8 ♗xg2 20 ♗xg2 ♖xe3+ 21 fxe3 ♗axb8 22 ♗a6 but White emerges in front as the rook and bishop are no match for the queen in this position, where Black is quite passive. In Chetverik-M.Ponomarev, Briansk 1995 Black chose 17...♖xc3 18 ♔xc3 ♗xg2 19 ♗xg2 ♗d6 20 ♖d3 but after 20...♔b7+ 21 f3 ♗xa1 22 ♗xa1 ♗a8 23 e4 ♗xa1 24 ♗xa1 ♗c6 25 ♗f2 f5 26 ♖e3 White again stood better.

15...♗xa5

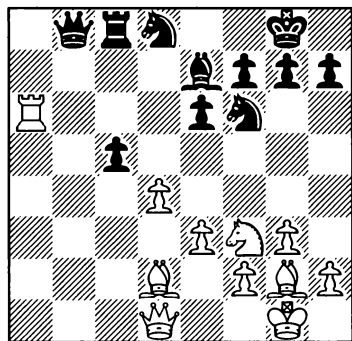
15...c5 16 dxc5 ♗xc5 17 ♔b1 favours White, Kobalija offering the subsequent 17...♗xa5? 18 ♖d5! etc.

16 ♗fb1!

16 ♖d5? runs into 16...♗xd5 17 ♗xa5 ♗a8 18 e4 ♗xe4 19 ♔c3 ♖d5 20 ♔d2 ♖c6 21 ♗b4 ♖cxb4 22 axb4 ♔b7 when White loses the b-pawn. Black has obvious compensation for the exchange and the semi-closed nature of the position is to his benefit.

16...♗a8 17 ♔d1 c6

Or 17...♙c6 18 d5! exd5 19 ♖d4 ♙xa3 20 ♙xa3 ♙xa3 21 ♖xc6 ♙xc6 22 ♖xb5 when White's activity outweighs the pawn.
 18 a4 b4 19 ♖a2 ♙xa4 20 ♖xb4 ♙xa1 21 ♙xa1 ♙b8 22 ♖a6 ♙xa6 23 ♙xa6 c5



24 ♙a1!

24 ♖e5 offers no advantage for White after 24...cxd4 25 exd4 ♙b5 26 ♙a7 ♖d6 27 ♙a1 ♖d5 and the position is equal.

24...cxd4

Better is 24...♖c6 25 dxc5 ♙xc5 26 ♙c3 ♖b4 27 ♙a4.

25 ♖xd4 ♙f8?!

A strange decision. The lesser evil is 25...♙c7 26 ♖f3 with the more pleasant position for White.

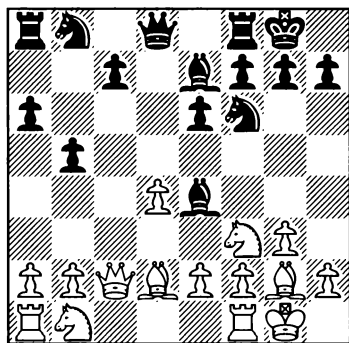
26 ♖f3

26 ♙a5! ♖d5 27 ♙xd8 ♙xd8 28 ♙xd5 exd5 29 ♖f5 secures a definite edge.

26...♙c7 27 ♙g2 ♙c5 28 ♙a5 ♙c4 29 ♙xd8! ♙xd8 30 ♙c6 ♙xc6 31 ♖xc6 ♙e8? 32 ♙a8 ♙d3 33 ♖d4 ♙c4

Or 33...♙c3 34 ♙c6+ ♙e7 35 ♙a4 ♙b6 36 ♖c6+ and White wins.

34 ♙c6+ 1-0



11 ♙c1 ♖bd7

Black has a range of options.

11...♙a7 (again!) was played in Nielsen-Krivososov, Panormo 2001. After 12 ♙e3 ♖d5 13 ♖c3 ♖xc3 14 ♙xc3 ♙b7 15 ♙fd1 c6 16 ♖e5 ♙xg2 17 ♙xg2 ♙d5+ 18 f3 b4 19 ♙b3 ♖d7 20 ♖d3 ♙b5 21 ♙ac1 Black was a little worse.

11...c6 12 ♖c3!? ♙xf3 13 ♙xf3 ♙xd4 14 ♙e3 ♙d8 15 a4 and Black had won a pawn but White had sufficient play in Nielsen-Rozentalis, Esbjerg 2001. There followed 15...b4 16 ♖e4 ♖d5 17 ♙d4 ♙c7 18 ♖c5 ♙d8 19 ♙c4 ♖d7 20 ♖xd7 ♙xd7 21 ♙c5 a5 22 ♙ac1 ♙xc5 23 ♙xc5 ♙d6 24 ♙c2 ♙ad8 25 ♙fc1 and White had compensation for the pawn.

Chetverik-Namyslo, Budapest 2002 continued 11...b4 12 ♙g5 ♖bd7 13 ♖bd2 ♙b7?! 14 ♖b3 c5? 15 ♙xf6 gxf6 16 dxc5 ♙c8 17 ♙d1 ♙c7 18 ♙h6! and the weakness of Black's kingside was cause for concern, the further 18...♖xc5 19 ♖xc5 ♙xc5? 20 ♙d4! increasing White's lead to decisive proportions: 20...♙xf3 21 ♙h4 ♙h5 22 ♙xh5 ♙c2 23 e4 etc. Black is advised to follow the example set in Sigurjonsson-Gruenfeld, Randers 1982 after 13...♙d5, although 14 ♙c2 c5 15 e4 ♙b7 16 e5 ♖d5 17 ♙xe7 ♙xe7 18 ♖e4 cxd4 19 ♙ad1 ♙fc8 20 ♙b1 proved good for White thanks to the great outpost on d6.

Finally, Black has tried 11...♖c6, e.g. 12

Game 44 Gelfand-Lutz Dortmund 2002

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♙e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♙c2 a6 8 ♙xc4 b5 9 ♙c2 ♙b7 10 ♙d2 ♙e4

♗e3 ♖b4 13 ♖bd2 ♗b7 14 ♗g5 ♜c8 15 a3 ♖bd5 16 b4!? (White clamps down on c5 and thus maintains a pull) 16...a5 17 e4 ♖b6 18 bxa5 ♖a4 and now Sosonko-Zuckerman, New York 1984 continued 19 e5 ♖d7?! 20 ♗xe7 ♜xe7 21 ♜b1 ♗a6 22 ♖e4 h6 23 ♜b4 c5 24 dxc5 ♖dxc5 25 ♜fd1 with serious problems for Black, who should have gone with 19...♖d5 20 ♖e4 (although this still favours White). After 12...♜c8 13 ♖bd2 ♗d5 Van der Wiel gives 14 ♗g5!? ♖d7?! 15 e4 ♗xg5 16 exd5 ♗xd2 17 ♜xc6, when White wins material. Mishuchkov-Raetsky, Gorki 1988 went 14 ♖b3 ♖b4 15 ♜d1 ♗e4 16 ♖e1 c6 17 ♗d2 ♗xg2 18 ♖xg2 ♜b6 19 ♗xb4 ♗xb4 20 ♖f4 ♗d6 21 ♖d3 ♖d7 22 ♜c1 ♜fd8 23 ♜c2 e5 24 dxe5 ♖xe5 25 ♖xe5 ♗xe5 26 ♖c5 with the more pleasant prospects for White.

12 ♗a5 ♜c8 13 ♖bd2

In Beliavsky-Speelman, Amsterdam 1989 13 ♖c3 ♗b7 14 a4 b4 15 ♖a2 ♜e8 16 ♗xb4 c5 17 dxc5 ♖xc5 18 ♜d1 ♜d8 19 ♜c2 ♗e4 20 ♜c4 ♗d5 21 ♜f4 ♗d6 22 ♜e3 ♖b3 gave Black compensation for the missing pawn. 16...♗xb4!? 17 ♖xb4 c5 is given by Kotrovnias.

13...♗a8 14 ♜c2

Also possible is 14 ♜e1 ♜e8 15 b4 ♖e4 16 a4 f5 17 axb5 axb5 18 e3 ♗d6 19 ♜a2 ♗d5 20 ♜c2 c6 21 ♖xe4 ♗xe4 22 ♜b2 ♜e7 with equality in Kasimdzhanov-Lutz, Essen 2002. In Chetverik-Harasta, Slovakia 1997 White emerged with advantage after 14 ♜d1 ♜e8 15 b4 ♖b8 (15...♖d5 16 a3 f5 17 ♖b3 ♜h5 18 ♖c5 is good for White) 16 ♖b3 ♖c6 17 a3 ♖xa5 18 ♖xa5 ♗d5 19 ♖e5 ♗xg2 20 ♗xg2 ♖d5 21 e4 ♖b6 22 ♜c6.

14...♜e8 15 b4 ♖d5

15...♖b8 16 a3 ♖c6 17 ♖b3 ♗d6 18 ♜ac1 e5 gave Black some freedom in Harikrishna-Beliavsky, Moscow 2001, although 19 e3 ♖xa5 20 ♖xa5 e4 21 ♖d2 ♗d5 22 ♖b1 c6 23 ♗h3 ♜c7 24 ♖c3 ♜e7 25 ♖xd5 cxd5 26 ♜a2 h5 27 ♜c2 was a shade better for White.

16 a3 f5 17 ♜ae1!

17 ♜ac1 ♜h5 18 ♜fe1 ♖5f6 19 ♖e5 ♖xe5 20 dxe5 ♖g4 21 h3 ♗xg2 22 ♜xg2 ♖xe5 23 ♜a2 ♜f7 was equal in Andersson-Lutz, Pamplona 1998. Black has chances on the kingside to make up for the weaknesses on the other flank.

17...♜g6

Another possibility is 17...♜h5 18 e4 fxe4 19 ♜xe4 ♜f5 20 ♜b3 and White is slightly better.

18 e4 fxe4 19 ♜xe4 ♜f6 20 ♜xg6 ♜xg6 21 ♖e4

This queenless middlegame favours White. Black has many weaknesses.

21...♜f8

Black can put a knight on c4 with 21...♖5b6 22 ♖c5 ♖xc5 23 dxc5 ♖c4 24 ♖e5 ♖xe5 25 ♜xe5 ♗xg2 26 ♜xg2 but this ending also favours White.

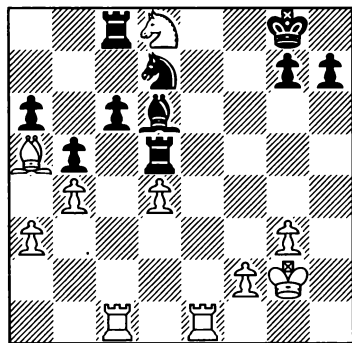
22 h4 ♗d6?!

22...♖5b6 23 ♖fd2 doesn't allow ...♖c4.

23 h5! ♜h6 24 ♖c5 ♖5b6 25 ♖g5

Now e6 is doomed.

25...♗xg2 26 ♜xg2 ♜xh5 27 ♖gxe6 ♜c8 28 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 29 ♜c1 c6 30 ♜fe1 ♜d5 31 ♖d8!



Highlighting the weakness of c6.

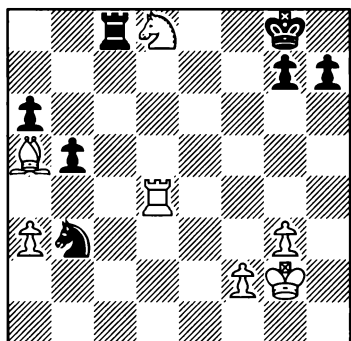
31...♗xd4?

Or 31...♖b8 32 ♜e6! ♜xd4? 33 ♜e8+ ♗f8 34 ♜xf8+ and White wins a piece.

32 ♜ed1

Black has problems on the d-file.

32...♙e5 33 ♖xd4 ♙xd4 34 ♖d1 c5 35
bxc5 ♖xc5 36 ♖xd4 ♖b3



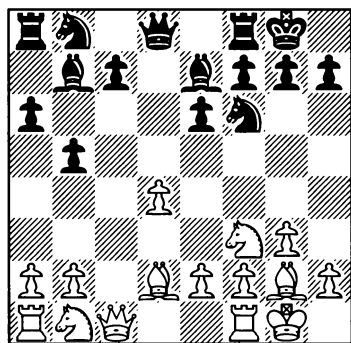
Perhaps Black relied on this fork, but...

37 ♖e4! 1-0

White keeps the extra piece due to the mate threat on e8.

Game 45
Pigusov-Aseev
Sevastopol 1986

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5
♙g2 ♙e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♖c2 a6 8 ♖xc4 b5
9 ♖c2 ♙b7 10 ♙d2 ♙e4 11 ♖c1 ♙b7



12 ♖d1

12 ♙f4 ♙d6 13 ♖bd2 ♖bd7 14 ♖b3 and
now Kasparov-Kramnik, World Champion-
ship (game 15), London 2000 went 14...♙d5
15 ♖d1 ♖e7 (15...♖b8 16 ♖e5 ♙xg2 17
♙xg2 ♙xe5 18 dxe5 ♖b7+ 19 f3 ♖d5 20 e4

favours White) 16 ♖e5 ♙xg2 17 ♙xg2 ♖d5
18 ♖c6 ♖xf4+ 19 ♖xf4 ♖e8 20 ♖f3 with a
pull for White, whose knight on c6 will prove
annoying. The later game Nielsen-Goldin,
Moscow 2001, continued instead 14...♖c8 15
♖d1 ♙d5, Black preparing to push the c-
pawn. There followed 16 ♖c5 ♖xc5 17 dxc5
♙xf4 18 ♖xf4 ♖e7 19 ♖e5! (a strong pawn
sacrifice) 19...♖xc5 20 ♖ac1 ♖e7 21 ♖c6
♙xc6 22 ♖xc6 ♖fd8 23 ♖dc1 h6 24 a3 with
an advantage to White, who should be in no
hurry to win back the pawn.

13 ♖c3 ♖bd7 14 ♖d1 ♖b8 15 ♖e5 ♙xg2
16 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 17 ♙xg2 c5 18 dxc5 ♖b7+
19 f3 ♙xc5 20 ♖e4 ♙e7 21 ♖c7 ♖xc7 22
♙xc7 ♖f6 23 ♙d6 ♙xd6 24 ♖xd6, Tukma-
kov-Lalic, Palma de Mallorca 1989 resulted in
an ending that was favourable for White.

Black has another option in 12...♖d5 13
♖c3 ♖xf4 14 ♖xf4, e.g. 14...♖d6 15 ♖fd1
♖d7 16 ♖ac1 ♖ac8 17 d5 exd5 18 ♖xd6
♙xd6 19 ♖xd5 ♙xd5 20 ♖xd5 ♖b6 21
♖dd1 b4 22 ♖c6 ♖a4 23 ♖d2 a5 24 ♖a6 ♖a8
which led to an edge for White in Fominyh-
Pihlajasalo, Elista 1998. Black's pawn struc-
ture on the queenside is a bit exposed but, on
the other hand, he has active pieces. In Piket-
Karpov, Dortmund 1995 Black took the
opportunity to push with 14...c5 15 dxc5
♙xc5 16 ♖ac1 ♖e7 17 ♖fd1 ♖a7, when
Piket proposes 18 a4! b4 19 ♖e4 ♙xe4 20
♖xe4 a5 21 ♖e5 with advantage to White.
His co-ordination is better and (again)
Black's queenside pawns are the more vul-
nerable.

12...♖c8 13 ♙a5

13 a4! is interesting. 13...c5 14 dxc5 ♙xc5
15 axb5 axb5 16 ♖xa8 ♙xa8 17 ♙e3 ♙e7 18
♖xc8 ♖xc8 19 ♖d4 ♙xg2 20 ♙xg2 b4 21
♖c1 ♖xc1 22 ♙xc1 gave White something in
Bareev-Aseev, Irkutsk 1986, an important
factor being the king's quick access to the
centre. In Pigusov-Fokin, Kemerovo 1985
Black pushed with 13...b4, but after 14 ♙g5
♖bd7 15 ♖bd2 c5 16 ♖b3 ♙d5 17 ♖xc5
♙xc5? 18 ♙xf6 gxf6 19 dxc5 ♖xc5 20 ♖h6

(Black should always be aware of this manoeuvre) White had generated a strong offensive: 20...♖b3 21 ♜xd5! exd5 22 ♗h3 ♜c2 23 ♖h4 ♖d4 24 e3 ♜d2 25 ♗f5 and White won. An improvement is 17...♖xc5 18 dxc5 ♜xc5 19 ♜xc5 ♗xc5 20 ♗xf6 gxf6 21 ♖d2!, although after the exchange of light-squared bishops Black will have some problems on this colour complex on the queen-side.

13...♗d6

13...c5 14 dxc5 ♜xc5 15 ♖bd2 ♖bd7 16 ♖b3 ♜xc1 17 ♜axc1 ♜fc8 18 ♗c7 ♖f8 was Chernin-M.Gurevich, Vilnius 1985. Black's king is approaching the centre so this end-game is equal.

14 ♖bd2 ♖c6 15 ♖b3 ♖xa5 16 ♖xa5 ♗d5 17 ♖c6 a5 18 ♗fe5 ♜a6

18...♗xg2 19 ♖xg2 ♜a6 20 ♜c2 with a slight advantage for White.

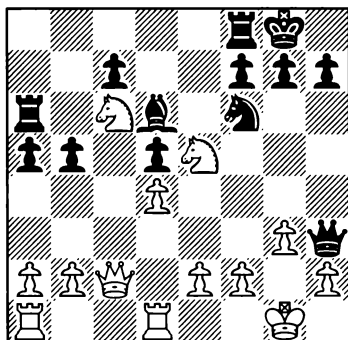
19 ♗xd5 exd5

19...♖xd5, to exchange one knight, is a dubious idea as Black loses control of e4: 20 e4 ♖b4 21 a3 ♖xc6 22 ♖xc6 ♜b7 23 d5 exd5 24 exd5 is given by Aseev. White is better.

20 ♜c2

20 ♖g2!? is worth a try – after 20...♜e8 the position is unclear.

20...♜h3



21 ♜b3

Not 21 ♜ac1? in view of 21...♜xc6! 22 ♜xc6 ♗xe5 23 dxe5? ♖g4 and Black wins. With 21 f3 White protects g4. After 21...♖h5!? 22 ♜b3?! ♗xe5 23 ♖xe5 ♖xg3 24 hxg3? ♜xg3+ 25 ♖f1 ♜h6! Black is winning, so 22 e4 is better, with an unclear situation.

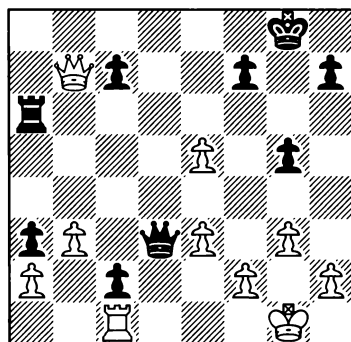
21...a4 22 ♜f3 ♖e4 23 ♜ac1 a3 24 b3 b4 25 ♖d3 ♖c3 26 ♜xc3!

White has to be careful here: 26 ♖dxb4?! ♗xb4 27 ♖xb4 ♜h6 28 ♜xc3 (28 ♜e1? ♖xe2+) 28...♜xh2+ 29 ♖f1 ♜h1+ 30 ♜xh1 ♜xh1+ 31 ♖g2 ♜xd1 when Black is the exchange up but many pawns are being exchanged, promising White hopes of a draw.

26...bxc3 27 ♜xd5 ♗e6 28 ♜f3 ♜e8 29 e3 c2 30 ♜c1 ♜g6

This is better than 30...♗xg3?! 31 ♖db4 ♜xc6 32 ♖xc6 ♗d6 33 ♖f1, which nets White the c2-pawn and with it the slightly superior ending.

31 ♖de5 ♗xe5 32 ♖xe5 ♜xe5 33 dxe5 ♜d3 34 ♜b7 g5



35 ♜xc2

White forces an equal queen ending. More ambitious is 35 ♖g2 ♜e6 36 ♜xc7 ♜d5+ 37 e4! ♜xe4+ 38 ♖g1 ♜c6 39 ♜d8+ ♖g7 40 ♜xg5+ ♖f8, although the c2-pawn remains dangerous.

35...♜xc2 36 ♜c8+! ½-½

Summary

One of the main positions in the 7 ♖a3 line arises after the natural moves 7... ♙xa3 8 bxa3 b5 9 a4 a6 10 ♙a3 ♜e8 11 ♗e5 ♗d5 12 e4. White has the very interesting sacrifice 13 ♖xf7!? after 12... ♗f6, and to us it seems that this is enough only for a draw. The jump to the other wing, 12... ♗b6 (Game 28) leads to very complex play too, and requires more practical tests. Another popular system in this line is 8... ♙d7, when after 9 ♗e5 ♙c6 10 ♗xc6 ♗xc6 11 ♙b2 White prepares e2-e4 and has genuine compensation for the pawn (Game 29).

Practice has shown that against 7 ♗e5 the best continuation is Robatsch's surgical decision 7... ♗c6!?. In the case of 8 ♙xc6 bxc6 9 ♗xc6 ♜e8 10 ♗xe7+ ♜xe7 11 ♜a4 Black can achieve a good game in more than one fashion.

For instance Black can choose to exchange queens with 11... ♜d6 12 ♜d1 ♜a6 or prepare the development of the bishop to a6 with 11... a5. Black also has good prospects if he challenges the d4-pawn with 11... c5 or 11... e5, thereby facilitating development. In the variation 11... c5 12 ♜xc4 cxd4 13 ♜xd4 Black has two reliable possibilities, 13... ♜d8 and 13... e5 14 ♜h4 ♜e6 15 ♗c3 ♙b7 (Game 31). In the complicated variation 11... e5 12 dxe5 ♜xe5 13 ♜xc4 ♙e6 14 ♜d3 ♜ad8 15 ♜e3 ♜h5 16 f3 ♙c4 (Kotronias) looks quite convincing.

After 8 ♗xc6 bxc6 9 ♗a3!? (Kuzmin) 9... ♙xa3 10 bxa3 White accepts the doubled a-pawns, the resulting situation appearing rather exotic. Then 10... ♜b8 11 ♜a4 ♜xd4 12 ♙e3 ♜e5 13 ♜xa7 deserves more practice, while in the case of 10... ♙a6!? 11 ♙xc6 ♜b8 12 ♜a4 ♜b6 there is not much difference between 13 ♙g2 and 13 ♙f3. In both cases Black tends to equalize by playing ...c4-c3 at the right moment. In order to assess the variations with 10... ♗d5 it is important to evaluate the endgame after 11 ♜a4 ♗b6 12 ♜xc6 ♜b8 13 ♜c5 ♙b7 14 e4 ♜d6 15 ♙f4 ♜xc5 16 dxc5 ♗a4 17 ♜fc1 ♙a6 18 ♙f1 ♗xc5 19 ♙xc4 (Game 34). Black must strive for a rook ending similar to Hjartarsson-Schussler. It does not seem likely that anything can be made of the extra, doubled pawn.

As Black very often reaches a good position in the 9 ♗a3 line, White has tried the solid 9 e3 during recent years (Game 32). White has a normal queenside structure but also an obvious problem with the development of the dark-squared bishop. Black has counter-chances after something like 9... ♗d5 10 ♜a4 ♗b6 11 ♜c2 ♜b8 12 ♜d1 ♜e8 followed by ...c6-c5.

In the modern line with 7 ♜c2 a6 8 a4 ♙d7 Black solves his opening problems quite successfully. After 9 ♜d1 ♙c6 10 ♗c3 ♗bd7 11 e4 b5 12 d5 exd5 13 e5 White has a dangerous initiative, although in the event of 10... ♙xf3 11 ♙xf3 ♗c6 12 ♙xc6 bxc6 the b-file means that Black's chances are not worse. After 9 ♜xc4 ♙c6 the natural 10 ♗c3 allows Black to play 10... b5 with a good game, while in reply to 10 ♙f4 Black attains equal prospects with 10... a5 11 ♗c3 ♗a6. Black should not develop in the same way against 10 ♙g5, where White can grab the centre with 11 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 12 e4. Instead of 10... a5 it is better to continue 10... ♗bd7 11 ♗c3 h6 or to follow the main line with 10... ♗d5. After 11 ♜d3 Black can continue to chase the enemy queen with 11... ♙e4 or immediately play 11... c5 with equality. The advance ...c7-c5 is also strong in the case of 11 ♜c2 ♙e4 12 ♜d1 and deserves further testing after 11 ♜c2 ♙e4 12 ♜c1. Also quite acceptable for Black here are 12... ♗bd7 and 12... h6, and a later ... ♙xf3 and ...c7-c6 with a solid set-up.

Black obtains the bishop pair and destroys White's pawn chain after 8 ♜xc4 b5 9 ♜c2 ♙b7 10 ♙f4 with 10... ♗d5 11 ♗c3 ♗xf4 12 gxf4. However, the pawn formation is quite typical for the Catalan. The pawns on d4, e3, f4 and f2 provide White with something to bite on because they offer good control over key squares in the centre.

But we believe that White does not have an advantage after 10... ♗c6 11 ♜d1 ♗b4 12

♖c1 ♖c8!? 13 ♖g5 c5!? etc. Note, however, that ...c7-c5 does not promise full equality in the case of 12...♞c8 13 ♖c3 ♖bd5 14 ♖e5. The deeper idea behind the quite passive looking 10 ♖d2 is to pin the c7-pawn with ♖d2-a5, and this comes into play after 10...♖bd7. Another central idea in this line is to address the queenside with b2-b4.

It is probably better for Black to continue 10...♖c6 11 e3 ♖b4 12 ♖xb4 ♖xb4 13 a3 ♖d6 14 ♖bd2 ♞c8 15 b4 a5! with good prospects of equality, as in the other lines White has a minimal edge, for example 10...♖e4 11 ♖c1 b4 12 ♖g5!? followed by ♖bd2. The problem with the subtle manoeuvre 10...♖e4 11 ♖c1 ♖b7 is the possibility of 12 ♖c2 with a repetition, which might occasionally be an attractive option for White. Moreover White has something after 12 ♖f4 ♖d5 13 ♖c3 ♖xf4 14 ♖xf4 or after 12 ♞d1 ♖c8 13 a4!?

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♗e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♖c2

7 ♖c3

7...♖bd7 – *Game 3* (Chapter 1); 7...♖c6 – *Game 27*

7 ♖a3 ♖xa3 8 bxa3: 8...b5 – *Game 28*; 8...♖d7 – *Game 29*

7 ♖e5

7...c5 – *Game 30*

7...♖c6

8 ♖xc6 – *Game 31*

8 ♖xc6 bxc6 (D)

9 e3 – *Game 32*

9 ♖a3 ♖xa3 10 bxa3: 10...♖a6 – *Game 33*; 10...♖d5 – *Game 34*

7...a6 8 ♖xc4

8 a4

8...c5 – *Game 35*

8...♖d7 (D)

9 ♞d1 ♖c6 10 ♖c3: 9...♖bd7 – *Game 36*; 10...♖xf3 – *Game 37*

9 ♖xc4 ♖c6 10 ♖g5

10...a5 – *Game 38*

10...♖d5: 11 ♖d3 – *Game 39*; 11 ♖c2 – *Game 40*

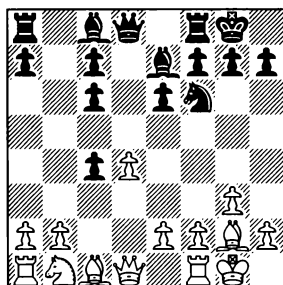
8...b5 9 ♖c2 ♖b7

10 ♖f4: 10...♖c6 – *Game 41*; 10...♖d5 – *Game 42*

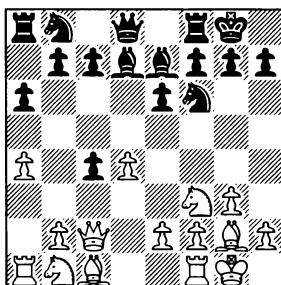
10 ♖d2 ♖e4

10...♖c6 – *Game 43*

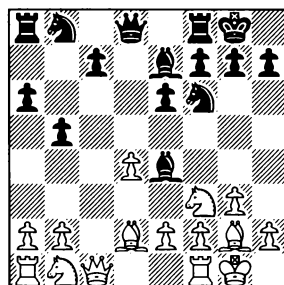
11 ♖c1 (D): 11...♖bd7 – *Game 44*; 11...♖b7 – *Game 45*



8...bxc6



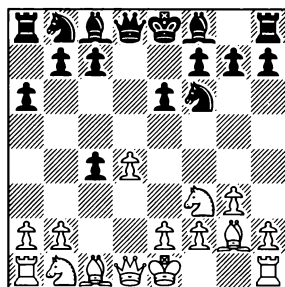
8...♖d7



11 ♖c1

CHAPTER FIVE

4...dxc4 5 ♖g2 a6



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♙f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 a6

5...a6 is one of the most popular tries to hold on to the pawn in what can rightly be called the Catalan Gambit. Black wants to defend the c4-pawn with the help of ...b7-b5, with White's compensation coming in the shape of a formidable looking centre and a lead in development. Not surprisingly the result is complex play in which tactics and aggression are major factors.

After 5...a6 there are move order issues and lines which could belong under other systems such as the Slav Defence. Fortunately this is not too confusing, and we have endeavoured to indicate the most essential transpositions. This has been done by focusing on plans rather than concrete lines, which seems to be the logical approach to positions that can arise via numerous routes.

White can choose to prevent ...b7-b5 by spending a tempo on 6 a4 (Game 46), but this cannot be recommended because after 6...♘c6 the weaknesses of both b3 and b4 will prove significant. The difference between this system and 5...c5 can be appreciated in the following variation: 6...c5 7 0-0 cxd4!? 8 ♖xd4 ♗xd4 9 ♘xd4 e5 when the inclusion of a2-a4 and ...a7-a6 benefits Black as b5 is unavailable to the knight and a4 to

the queen.

More attractive is 6 ♘e5, opening the h1-a8 diagonal and simultaneously attacking the c4-pawn. Then only vigorous measures allow Black to keep his material advantage. 6...♗b4+ (Game 47) is related to the variation beginning 5...c6 6 ♘e5 ♗b4, but there are also some differences. White does not have to enter the line with 7 ♗d2?! ♗xd4 8 ♗xb4 ♗xe5 because, compared with 5...c6, the d6-square is not weak here. But after 7 ♘c3 ♘d5 8 ♗d2 b5 White generates an enduring and satisfying initiative for the sacrificed pawn.

The logical reaction to 6 ♘e5 is 6...c5 (Games 48-50), since White has surrendered some control of d4. Defending with 7 e3 closes in the c1-bishop and, after the strongest reply, 7...♗a7! (followed by ...b7-b5), it is White who has difficult issues to address. Practical experience also offers little value to 7 ♗e3 (Game 48) as after 7...♘d5! Black will find the most appropriate moment to exchange on e3, thus damaging White's structure.

7 ♘a3 is the most promising continuation. White sacrifices the d4-pawn in return for rapid development, in the case of 7...♗xd4 responding with the strong 8 ♗a4+!? (Game 49), when Black's 'centralized' queen will not

find a safe haven. After 7...cxd4 8 ♖axc4 ♙c5 the reader should pay attention to the sacrifice of a second pawn with 9 0-0 0-0 10 b4! with a considerable lead in development, the critical position arising after 8...♞a7!? 9 ♙d2 b6 10 ♞b3 ♙b7 11 ♙xb7 ♞xb7 12 ♖a5. Black should be safe after both 12...♞a7 (quiet) and 12...♞e7!? (complex).

The most popular answer to 5...a6 is 6 0-0, White continuing development. Now Black has two different paths down which he can walk – advancing the b-pawn (...b7-b5) at once or keeping his options open with the sensible (developing) 6...♖c6.

The line 5...a6 6 0-0 ♖c6 is very similar to the system with 5...♖c6 (Chapter 6) and there are often transpositions. Little attention has been given to 7 ♖a3 ♙xa3 8 bxa3 – especially when compared to 5...♙e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♖a3 ♙xa3 8 bxa3. Black has gained a tempo with ...a7-a6, but this seems to be of little value – the notes to Gleizerov-S.Ivanov (Game 51) illustrate that it is not dangerous for Black. In that game we have also considered 7 a4, when after 7...♞b8 8 a5 it is better not to open the game with 8...b5, preference being for the completion of development with 8...♙b4.

After 5...a6 6 0-0 ♖c6 the requirements of the position are best addressed by concentrating on the centre with e2-e4. White can choose to prepare this expansion with the help of 7 e3, ♞e2 and ♞fd1 or try the quicker but riskier 7 ♖c3. After 7 e3 (Games 52-53) Black is unable to hit d4 and should turn his attention to ...b7-b5. This can be achieved with 7...♞b8, but this is probably not good enough for equality in view of the manoeuvre ♖f3-d2-c4 (rather common in the Catalan). The main continuation is 7...♙d7 8 ♞e2 b5 9 ♞d1 (Game 53).

After 7 ♖c3 ♞b8 8 e4 (Games 54-56) experience has shown that e4-e5 is not the most appropriate option. White needs to break in the centre at the best possible moment with d4-d5. Practice has given us the

following possibilities:

a) 8...♙e7 9 d5 exd5 10 exd5 ♖b4 11 ♖e5 ♙f5 12 a3 ♖d3 13 ♖xc4 ♖xc1 14 ♞xc1. This has been played often. Some commentators evaluate it as even, while others believe White's greater share of territory is enough for an edge. The latter assessment seems more accurate.

b) 8...♙e7 9 ♞e2 b5 (9...♖xd4 is not so clear and obviously need more tests) 10 ♞d1 and then d4-d5 with boundless complications (Game 54).

c) 8...b5 9 ♞e2 ♖xd4 10 ♖xd4 ♞xd4 (Game 55), which is closely related to 8...♙e7 9 ♞e2 ♖xd4.

d) 8...b5 9 d5 (Game 56).

The system with 5...a6 6 0-0 b5 (Games 57-60) resembles 5...b5, occasionally with possible transpositions between the two lines. However, 5...a6 is different in that Black has a wider variety of possibilities. In reply to 7 ♖e5 Black has to choose between 7...c6 and 7...♖d5. After 7...c6 (Game 57) play used to continue 8 ♖xc6 ♞b6 9 ♖e5 ♙b7, after which the exchange of bishops and a strong central pawn formation afforded White a modest but enduring advantage – all the way to the ending. The confidence in 7...c6 was challenged by Razuvaev, who came up with 8 b3!, the point being that after 8...cxb3 the knight receives an alternate route in ♖c6-a5-b3. Here the pawn formation in the centre clearly favours White, thus leaving 7...c6 out in the cold.

After 7 ♖e5 ♖d5 White should play 8 a4 as 8 ♖c3 (Game 58) is probably less accurate. First there is 8...c6 9 ♖xd5 exd5 10 e4 ♙e6 11 a4, which was considered dangerous for Black since the game Sosonko-Hübner. In light of 11...♞a7!? it seems that White's initiative has been overestimated. Additionally, Black also has 8...♙b7 9 ♖xd5 exd5. Here White can win the exchange with 10 e4 dxe4 11 ♞h5 g6 12 ♖xg6 fxg6 13 ♞e5 ♞e7 14 ♞xh8 but Black should receive more than sufficient counterplay.

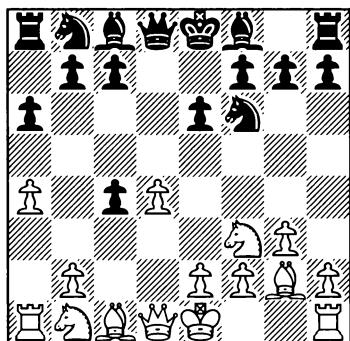
Therefore after 5...a6 6 0-0 b5 the main line is 7 ♖e5 ♘d5 8 a4 ♙b7, when White has two quite different paths. One idea is to play for positional compensation against Black's pawns and weakened squares with 9 b3 (Game 59). The second possibility is to play in the centre with 9 e4 ♘f6 10 axb5 axb5 11 ♙xa8 ♙xa8 12 ♘c3 (Game 60).

Game 46

Rashkovsky-K. Grigorian

Kishinev 1975

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 a6 6 a4



6...c5

6...♘c6 7 0-0 ♖a5 (7...♙b8 transposes to 6 0-0 ♘c6 7 a4 ♙b8) 8 ♘bd2 c5 9 dxc5 ♙xc5 10 ♖e5 c3! was Gulko-Bronstein, Vilnius 1975, Black inducing a weakness in the enemy structure and in so doing obtaining equal chances. After 11 bxc3 0-0 12 ♘ec4 ♙e7 13 ♘xa5 ♙xa5 14 ♙b3 e5 15 ♘c4 ♙c7 16 ♘b6 ♙b8 17 c4 ♙g4 Black solved his queenside problems.

7 0-0 ♘c6

7...cxd4! 8 ♙xd4 (White can try 8 ♘xd4 e5 9 ♘c2 ♙xd1 10 ♙xd1 but should expect no more than equality after 10...♘c6) 8...♙xd4 9 ♘xd4 e5 10 ♘c2 ♘c6 11 ♙xc6+ bxc6 12 ♘e3 ♙e6 13 ♘d2 and now in Rashkovsky-Sveshnikov, Moscow 1976 Black employed the same idea as in Gulko-

Bronstein, above: 13...c3! 14 bxc3 ♘d5 15 ♘e4 h6 16 ♙a3 ♙xa3 17 ♙xa3 ♘xe3 18 fxe3 ♙e7 19 ♙aa1 ♙ab8 20 ♘c5 ♙c4 21 ♙fd1 ♙hd8 with an edge. White can improve with 10 ♘f3 ♘c6 11 ♘bd2 ♙e6 12 ♘g5 ♙b4 13 ♘xe6 fxe6 14 ♙h3 when Black's pawns are weak and his extra material lacks relevance, leaving White on top.

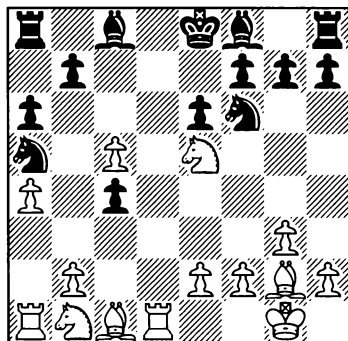
8 dxc5

8 ♘e5 ♖a5 9 dxc5 ♙xd1 10 ♙xd1 transposes to 8 dxc5 ♙xd1 9 ♙xd1 ♖a5 10 ♖e5, while 8...♙d7 9 ♖a3 cxd4 10 ♘axc4 is better for White because of the weakness on b6. This leaves 8...♘xd4 9 e3 ♘b3 10 ♙xd8+ ♙xd8 11 ♙a3! (11 ♘xf7+ ♙e8 12 ♘xh8 ♘xa1 13 ♖a3 ♙a7 14 ♘xc4 b5 15 ♖e5 ♙b7 favours Black) 11...♙e8 12 ♘xc4 ♘xc1 13 ♙xc1 ♘d7 14 ♙b3 ♙b8 15 a5, as in Gavrillov-Zhukhovitsky, Dubna 1971. Black has a pawn but problems with queenside development. The position is unclear.

8...♙xd1 9 ♙xd1 ♖a5

Karpov-Sveshnikov, Moscow 1976 continued 9...♙xc5 10 ♘bd2 ♘g4 11 e3 ♘ge5 12 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 13 ♖e4 ♙b4 14 ♙d2 ♙xd2 15 ♙xd2 ♙e7 16 ♘d6 ♙b8 17 f4 ♘g4 18 ♘xc4 ♙d7 and White won the pawn back with better prospects.

10 ♖e5



10...♘d5

Black can also play 10...♘d7 11 ♘xd7 ♙xd7 12 ♙d2 ♘b3 13 ♙xb7 ♙xc5! (13...♙d8?! 14 c6!) 14 ♙xa8 ♘xa1 15 ♘c3

♟b3 16 ♖b7 when White keeps a small edge due to the vulnerable black pawns.

10...♟b3!? 11 c6 ♟d5 12 ♖a2 bxc6 is worth a try.

11 e4

White can also try the exchange 11 ♖xd5 exd5 12 ♟c3, but 12...♖e6 13 ♟xd5 ♖c8 equalizes. Note that continuing development with 12...♖xc5 13 ♟xd5 0-0? is unsound in view of 14 ♖e3 ♖d6 (14...♖xe3? 15 ♟e7+ ♟h8 16 ♟xf7+! and Black is mated!) 15 ♟xf7! ♟xf7 16 ♟b6 etc.

11...♟b4 12 ♟d2 ♖xc5

12...♟b3 13 ♟xb3 cxb3 invites 14 ♖a3 ♖xc5 15 ♖xb3 f6 16 ♟c4 with an edge for White. Again Black is a little uncomfortable on the queenside.

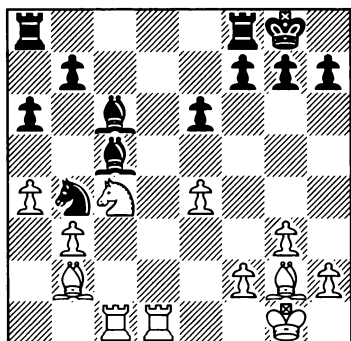
13 ♟dxc4 ♟c2?

13...♟xc4 14 ♟xc4 ♖d7 15 ♟e5 ♖c6 16 ♖f4 and White is slightly better, as is the case after 13...♟b3 14 ♖b1 0-0 15 ♖e3 ♖xe3 16 ♟xe3.

14 ♖b1 ♟xc4 15 ♟xc4 ♖d7

15...b5 is premature due to 16 e5 ♖a7 17 ♟d6+ ♖xd6 18 ♖xd6, when the bishop pair and Black's vulnerability on the dark squares combine to favour White.

16 b3 ♖c6 17 ♖b2 0-0 18 ♖bc1 ♟b4



19 ♟a5

19 ♟e5!? is an interesting option.

19...♖b6

19...♖e7 20 ♟xb7! helps White.

20 ♟xc6 ♟xc6 21 ♖d7 ♖ab8 22 e5 ♖fe8

The lesser evil is 22...♖fd8.

23 ♖e4?!

Not the best. 23 ♖xc6 bxc6 24 ♖xc6 ♖a5 25 ♖xa6 ♖xb3 26 ♖xa5 ♖xb2 27 ♖a7 gives White a winning rook endgame. He is active on the seventh rank and has a dangerous a-pawn.

23...g6 24 ♟g2 ♖ed8 25 ♖xc6 bxc6 26 ♖xd8+ ♖xd8?

Now Black loses, but 26...♖xd8 27 ♖xc6 ♖xb3 28 ♖c1 ♟g7 29 ♖xa6 is scarcely an improvement.

27 ♖xc6 ♖xf2 28 ♖a3 ♖d4 29 ♖d6! ♖xd6 30 exd6 ♖b6 31 d7 ♖d8 32 b4 f6 33 a5! ♟f7 34 b5 1-0

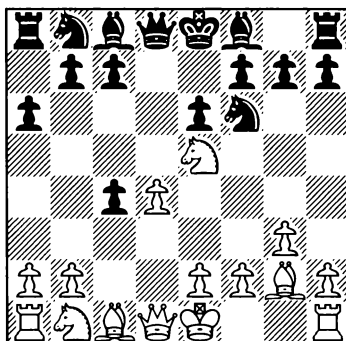
White plays 6 ♟e5

Game 47

Fominyh-Sveshnikov

Elista 1995

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♟f3 ♟f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 a6 6 ♟e5



6...♖b4+

Also possible is 6...♖a7 7 0-0 b6 (7...b5?! is dubious in view of 8 a4) 8 ♟c3 ♖b7 (Belavsky gives 8...b5 9 a4 b4 10 ♟a2 c5 11 ♟xc4 cxd4 12 a5 with compensation for the pawn) 9 ♖a4+ ♟fd7 and now Belavsky-Portish, Hungary 1999 went 10 ♖xb7?! ♖xb7 11 ♟c6 ♖c8! 12 ♟xb8 b5! with good counterplay for Black. Instead after 10 ♖d1

♙xg2 11 ♖xg2 c5 12 ♙e3 White is better, suggesting that Black's little queenside adventure is dubious.

7 ♖c3 ♖d5 8 ♙d2 b5

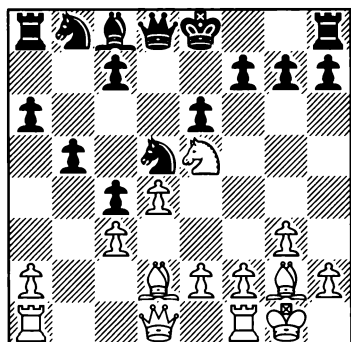
Protecting the c4-pawn with the knight has also been tried, 8... ♖b6 9 e3 ♖8d7 10 ♖xd7 ♗xd7 11 ♖e4 ♙xd2+ 12 ♖xd2 0-0 13 ♗c2 the course of Bandza-Kaidanov, Torcy 1991. After 13...e5!? 14 dxe5 ♖d8 15 0-0-0 ♖e8 16 ♖xc4 ♙f5 17 ♗xf5 ♖xc4 18 ♗c2 ♖xe5 19 ♖b1 c5 20 ♖d5 ♖xd5 21 ♙xd5 g6 22 ♗c3 the game was agreed drawn, although White stands better here, primarily because the bishop is superior to the knight.

9 0-0

White should avoid 9 a4 ♙b7 10 e4?! ♖f6 11 ♙g5 h6 12 ♙xf6 gxf6 13 ♖g4 f5 when Black has a huge advantage. Neistadt gives 10 ♖xd5 ♙xd2+ 11 ♗xd2 ♙xd5 12 e4 ♙b7 13 axb5 axb5 14 ♖xa8 ♙xa8 15 ♗a5 ♗xd4! 16 ♗xa8 0-0, Black's pawns and the activity of his queen affording him good compensation for the piece.

In the event of 9... ♙xc3 10 bxc3 f6 11 e4 ♖e7 12 ♖g4 ♙b7 13 ♗b1 c6 14 ♖e3 ♗c8 15 0-0 0-0 Black runs the risk of coming under fire on the dark squares, as was demonstrated in Tukmakov-Lputian, Rostov-on-Don 1993: 16 ♙c1 ♖e8 17 ♙a3 ♖d7 18 ♙h3 ♖f8 19 ♙c5 ♗c7 20 ♗b4 ♖ad8 21 ♖fd1 and these weak dark squares provided White with good play for the pawn.

9... ♙xc3 10 bxc3



10...f6

Black has also resisted the urge to hit the knight. 10...0-0 11 a4 c6 12 e4 ♖e7 13 ♙c1 ♖d7 14 ♖xd7 (14 f4!? is worth a try) 14... ♙xd7 15 ♙a3 ♖e8 16 ♖e1 ♖c8 17 ♗h5 ♖b6 18 a5 ♖a4 19 ♖e3 favoured White in Razuvayev-Sveshnikov, Tbilisi 1978. White's queenside pawn majority lacks mobility. White, on the other hand, has a good dark-squared bishop and possibilities of a kingside attack.

In Sulava-Sveshnikov, Pula 2000 Black chose 12... ♖b6 13 a5 ♖6d7. Then 14 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 15 e5 (with compensation) is playable, while the game continued 14 ♖g4 f5 15 ♖e5 ♖f6 16 ♙g5 h6 17 ♙xf6 ♗xf6 18 ♖e1 ♖a7 19 ♖a2 with compensation for the pawn due to the presence in the centre. However, White can win back the pawn with 16 exf5 exf5 17 ♙xc6 and emerge with an advantage.

11 e4 ♖e7

11...fxe5 12 exd5 0-0 13 dxe5 favours White. Black shouldn't open up the centre too early.

12 ♖g4 c6

Another possibility is 12...e5 13 dxe5! ♙xg4 14 ♗xg4 ♗xd2 15 exf6 gxf6 16 e5, when Black wins a piece but White's attack looks rather menacing. 12... ♙b7 13 a4 0-0 14 ♗e2 is sensible as Black's bishop is not obstructed.

13 a4 0-0

Also interesting is 13...e5!? with variations similar to those in the previous note. After 14 dxe5 ♙xg4 15 ♗xg4 ♗xd2 16 exf6 gxf6 17 axb5 ♗xc3 18 e5! there is compensation for the piece.

14 axb5 cxb5 15 e5 ♖d5 16 exf6 gxf6 17 ♖e3 ♖c6

17... ♙b7 18 ♗g4+ ♖f7 19 ♙e4 leaves White with a promising attacking stance, while 17... ♖xe3 18 ♙xe3 ♖a7 19 ♖e1 also looks dangerous.

18 ♖xd5 exd5 19 ♖e1 ♖f7

Another try is 19... ♙f5 20 ♗f3 ♙e4, but White sacrifices and gets the better chances

after 21 ♖xe4! dxe4 22 ♜xe4.

20 ♜h5 f5?

20...♟e7 doesn't save Black: 21 ♖xe7! ♜xe7 22 ♜e1 ♜d8 23 ♖xd5 ♜aa7 24 ♖h6.

21 ♖xd5! ♜xd5 22 ♜e8+ ♜f8 23 ♖h6! ♖b7 24 ♖xf8+

Or simply 24 ♜g5+ ♟f7 25 ♜ae1 and wins.

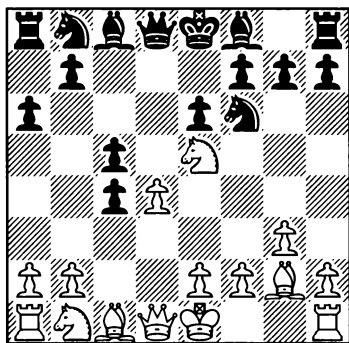
24...♖xf8 25 ♜g5+ ♟f7 26 ♜g7+ ♟e8 27 ♜e1+ ♟d8 28 ♜xb7

It is interesting to note that material is level now! Black quickly collapses.

28...♜g8 29 ♖f4! ♜d7 30 ♜b6+ ♟c8 31 d5 1-0

Game 48 Ivanchuk-Kuporosov Tallinn 1986

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♟f3 ♟f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 a6 6 ♟e5 c5



This logical central thrust addresses the slight, voluntary weakening of d4 caused by 6 ♟e5.

7 ♖e3

One of the two possible ways to guard the d-pawn, and clearly better than 7 e3, if not enough for an advantage. After 7 e3 Black can go for immediate equality with 7...cxd4 8 exd4 ♖e7 9 0-0 0-0 10 ♟xc4 ♟c6 or choose the more interesting 7...♜a7!, which had an outing in Konopka-Kucera, Decin 1995 when 8 ♟xc4 b5 9 ♟e5 ♖b7 10 ♖xb7 ♜xb7

11 dxc5 ♜xd1+ 12 ♟xd1 ♖xc5 13 ♟c3 ♟bd7 14 ♟d3 ♖d6 15 ♟e2 ♟e7 16 ♖d2 ♜c8 17 ♜hc1 ♜bc7 perhaps left Black with something. 7 ♟a3 is considered in the next two games.

7...♟d5!

This is the downside to White's previous move. After 7...cxd4! 8 ♖xd4 ♖c5 9 ♖xc5 ♜a5+ 10 ♟d2 ♜xc5 11 ♟dxc4 White had a useful lead in development in Stean-Rodriguez, Las Palmas 1978.

8 dxc5

This is the serious move here. 8 0-0 ♟d7 9 ♟xc4 b5 10 ♟cd2 ♟xe3 11 fxe3 cannot be right. In Hort-Portisch, Nice 1974, 11...♜b8 12 ♟e4 f5 13 ♟f2 ♖e7 14 e4 0-0 15 e3 ♖g5 16 ♜d3 ♟b6 favoured Black. 8 ♟c3 ♟xe3 9 fxe3 ♟d7 also looks harmless, 10 ♟xc4 ♖e7 11 0-0 0-0 12 ♟e4 ♜b8 13 a4 ♜c7 being equal in Verat-Rotstein, Cannes 1992.

8...♟d7!

Experience has shown that this is the most natural move, after which Black is genuinely threatening to take on e3. The immediate 8...♟xe3?! is very risky, e.g. 9 ♜xd8+ ♟xd8 10 fxe3 ♟e8 11 c6 bxc6 12 ♟xc4 ♜a7 13 ♟c3 ♜d7 14 0-0, Birnboim-Rapoport, Jerusalem 1996, when Black lagged behind in development and White's knights were productively posted.

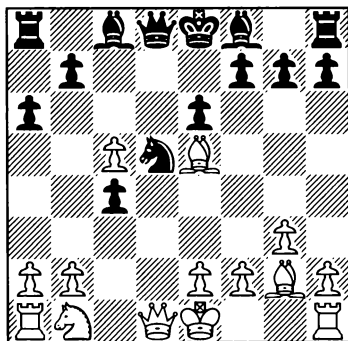
However, 8...f6 is playable. After 9 ♟xc4 ♟xe3 10 ♜xd8+ ♟xd8 11 fxe3 ♖xc5 12 ♟c3 ♜a7 Black is still playing catch-up but it looks less serious here, as was demonstrated in Beliavsky-Csom, Vilnius 1978, when 13 ♟e4 ♖b4+ 14 ♟f2 b5 15 a3 bxc4 16 axb4 ♟c6 17 b5 axb5 18 ♟d6 ♟e7 19 ♟xb5 ♜xa1 20 ♜xa1 ♟e5 21 ♜a7+ ♖d7 was even.

9 ♖d4

Practically forced. In reply to 9 ♟xd7 Black has 9...♟xe3! 10 fxe3 ♖xd7, when 11 ♖xb7 is too risky in view of 11...♖xc5 12 ♖xa8 ♜xa8 13 ♜g1 ♖xe3 14 ♜f1 ♜g2 15 ♜d6 ♜b7 and Black has a strong attack for the exchange. Dokhoian-Ftacnik, Germany 1993 continued instead 11 ♜d4 ♜a5+ 12

♖c3 ♜xc5 13 ♜xb7 (13 0-0! is a possible improvement, but Black should be fine) 13... ♜xd4 14 exd4 ♜b8 15 ♜xa6 ♜xb2 with an edge for Black.

9... ♜xe5 10 ♜xe5



10...f6

10... ♜xc5! is a sharp but apparently perfectly sound opportunity. White will get nowhere unless he accepts the challenge: 11 ♜xg7 ♜g8:

12 ♜d4?? ♖f4! 13 ♜a4+ ♜d7 14 ♜xc4 ♖xg2+ 0-1 is the miniature Verat-Antunes, Royan 1989, while 12 ♜e5 ♜g5 13 f4 ♜d8 14 ♜xd5 ♜xd5 15 ♜xd5 exd5 was also very short but agreed drawn in Tratar-A.Petrosian, Ljubljana 1995, where White could have tried 14 ♖c3!, e.g. 14... ♖e3 15 ♜xd8+ ♖xd8 16 ♜f6+ ♖e8 17 ♜e4 with a murky situation.

Salov-Portish, Brussels 1988 continued 12 ♜c3 b5 13 ♜d4 ♜b6 14 ♜xc5 ♜xc5 15 ♖c3 ♜b7 16 ♖xd5 ♜xd5 17 ♜xd5 ♜d8 18 0-0 ♜xd5 19 ♜c2 h5 with sufficient counterplay.

11 ♜d4 ♜xc5

A common trick in these positions.

12 ♜xc5 ♜a5+ 13 ♖d2

13 ♖c3 ♖xc3 14 ♜d6 ♖d5+ 15 ♖f1 ♜d8 is better according to Ruban.

13... ♜xc5 14 ♜c1 b5 15 b3 ♜b7 16 0-0 ♖e3!

An important improvement. Earlier in the same tournament Black played 16...c3! 17

♖e4 ♜c7 18 b4! in Ivanchuk-Novikov, Tallin 1986, White securing the c5-square for the knight. After 18... ♜d8 19 ♜b3 ♖f7 20 ♖c5 ♜c8 21 ♜fd1 White was doing well. An alternative is 16... ♜d8 17 bxc4 ♖e3!, when play might develop 18 cxb5! ♜b6 19 fxe3 ♜xc3+ 20 ♜f2 with a mess.

17 fxe3 ♜xc3+ 18 ♜f2 ♜xg2 19 ♖xg2 ♜d8 20 ♜c2 c3 21 ♜f3 ♜xd2 22 ♜xe3 ♜xd1 23 ♜exc3 ♖e7! 24 ♜c6 ♜d6 25 ♜c7+ ♜d7 26 ♜7c6 ♜d6

26... ♜a8 27 ♜b6 and White's activity assures him of the draw.

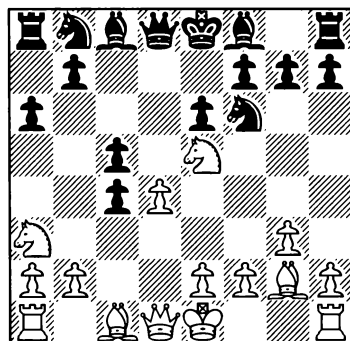
27 ♜c7+ ½-½

Game 49

Raetsky-Naiditsch

Dortmund 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♜g2 a6 6 ♖e5 c5 7 ♖a3



7... ♜xd4!

Black has problems with his queen after this capture. More natural is 7...cxd4, as in the next main game. After 7... ♜a7 8 dxc5 ♜xd1+ 9 ♜xd1 ♜xc5 10 ♖axc4 b5 11 ♖d3! White has the advantage. In Rashkovsky-Beliavsky, Baku 1977 the subsequent 11... ♜d7 12 ♖ce5 ♜d8 13 ♜d2 ♜b6 14 a4 left Black's queenside under terrible pressure. 8 ♜a4+!?

Although this check is not necessarily the strongest move, in practical terms it is the

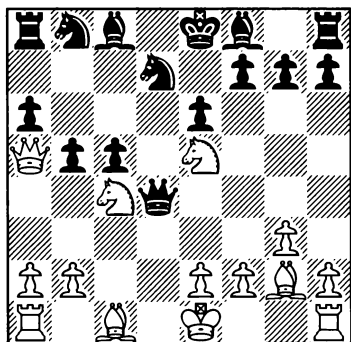
most unpleasant to face. After 8 ♖xd4 cxd4 9 ♖axc4 ♖bd7 10 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 11 0-0 ♙c5 12 e3 0-0 13 exd4 ♙xd4 14 ♙d1 e5 15 ♙e3 ♙xe3 16 fxe3 White was a little better in Agzamov-Azmaiparashvili, Yerevan 1981. There is no doubt that he will regain his pawn, and without losing his lead in development.

8...♖fd7?!

Not best. The outcome of 8...♖bd7 9 ♖axc4 b5 has also proved unsuccessful. Note that the following line is not forced: 10 ♖a5 ♖xe5 11 ♖xe5 ♖d5 12 ♖c6 ♖f6 13 a4! b4 (13...bxa4! is better, but White has the initiative) 14 e4 ♙b7? (14...♙d7! is far from ideal but not decisive) 15 exd5 exd5 16 ♙g5!! ♖xc6 (16...♖xg5? 17 ♖c7 ♙c8 18 ♖e5 ♖f6 19 ♙xd5 and White wins) 17 0-0-0 f6 18 ♙he1+ with a strong attack, e.g. 18...♙f7 19 ♙xd5+ ♖xd5 20 ♙xd5 ♙xd5 21 ♖c7+ ♙g6 22 ♖d7! ♙g2 23 ♙e3 and White has a fierce offensive against the enemy king, as well as a nice material situation. Meanwhile, there is also 10 ♖c2!? ♖xe5 11 ♖xe5 ♖d5 12 ♖c6 ♖f6 13 e4 ♖b6 14 e5 ♖g6 15 ♙e4 ♖h5 16 ♙e3 with a potent initiative.

8...♙d7 is probably safest. After 9 ♖xd7 ♖bxd7! (9...♖xd7 10 ♖xd7+ ♖bxd7 11 ♙xb7 ♙a7 12 ♙g2 is somewhat better for White) 10 ♙xb7 ♙b8 11 ♙xa6 c3 12 b3 ♖xa4 13 bxa4 ♙d6 it is not clear that White is better. Black has good development.

9 ♖axc4 b5 10 ♖a5



10...bxc4

Black has a difficult choice, one pitfall being 10...♙a7? 11 e3! and the queen is trapped. After 10...♖xe5 11 ♖xe5 ♙a7 12 ♖b6 ♖d7 13 ♖xa7 ♖xe5 14 ♙f4 ♖xb2 15 ♙d1 Black will not survive for long, but perhaps 12...♙d6!? is worth a look.

11 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 12 ♙xa8 ♖c6 13 ♖b6 ♖d4 14 ♙e3!

White exploits his lead in development. 14 0-0 ♖d6 15 ♖a5 ♖xe2+ 16 ♙h1 is only slightly favourable.

14...♖b5

Black gains little from 14...♖c2+ 15 ♙f1 ♖xe3+ 16 fxe3 ♖d6 17 ♙c6+ ♙e7 18 ♖a7+ ♙f6 19 ♙f3, when his chances for survival are slim.

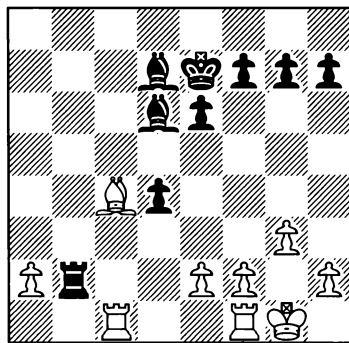
15 ♖c7 ♖d7

After 15...♙d7 White wins with 16 0-0 ♖xe2+ 17 ♙g2 ♖d4 18 a4 ♖b4 19 ♙fd1, leaving Black's kind with inadequate defence.

16 ♖xd7+ ♙xd7 17 ♙c1 ♙d6 18 ♙b7?!

18 ♙xd4 cxd4 19 ♙xc4 e5 20 ♙c6 is simpler because Black has no counterplay. White wins.

18...♙e7 19 ♙xa6 ♙b8 20 ♙xc4 ♙xb2 21 ♙xd4 cxd4 22 0-0



White is still close to winning but now there are additional technical challenges.

22...♙a4 23 ♙b1 ♙d2 24 ♙b7+ ♙f6 25 ♙a7 ♙d1 26 a4 ♙xe2 27 ♙xe2 ♙xe2 28 ♙d7 ♙c5 29 ♙c1 ♙a3

After 29...♙b6 30 ♙b1 ♙c5 31 a5 d3 32

♙xd3 ♙xf2 33 ♙f1 White is easily winning the ending.

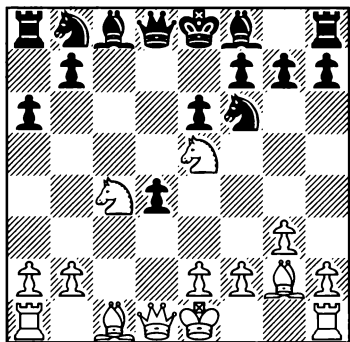
30 ♙cc7 ♙e5

30...e5 31 ♙c6+ ♙f5 32 a5 and the a-pawn is a runner!

31 a5 ♙a2 32 a6 ♙b2 33 a7 d3 34 ♙xd3 ♙d4 35 ♙xd4 ♙xd4 36 ♙xf7 g5 37 ♙xh7 e5 38 ♙d7+ ♙e4 39 ♙g2 g4 40 h3 gxh3+ 41 ♙xh3 ♙f5 42 f3 ♙a4 43 g4+ ♙g5 44 ♙g3 ♙a3 45 ♙f2 ♙f6 46 ♙e2 ♙e6 47 ♙b7 ♙f6 48 ♙d2 1-0

Game 50
Gimza-Linder
Germany 1998

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 a6 6 ♘e5 c5 7 ♘a3 cxd4 8 ♘axc4



8...♙a7

This developing move has been considered the most natural for some time, Black in danger of running into trouble if he is not sufficiently acquainted with certain factors. For example the ostensibly natural 8...♙e7 is typical of what might happen if Black believes the position is harmless. I.Almasi-Vadasz, Budapest 1997 went 9 ♙d2 a5 10 ♙b3 ♘bd7 11 ♙xb7 a4! (11...♙b8? 12 ♙xa5 ♙xb7 13 ♙xd8 ♙xh1 14 ♙b6 and Black doesn't have enough for the queen – the a-pawn is strong and f2-f3 is coming) 12 ♙f3 ♙xb7 13 ♙xb7 ♘xe5 14 ♘xe5 ♙d5 15 ♙c6+ ♙xc6 16 ♘xc6 with a more pleasant

endgame for White.

In reply to 8...♙c5 9 ♙d2 is less effective now as Black has control over the b6-square. Consequently in Albur-I.Ivanov, New York 1983 the subsequent 9...♘d5 10 ♘d3 ♙a7 11 ♙a5 ♙d7 (11...♙e7? 12 ♙xd5! exd5 13 ♙b4 and Black is in trouble) 12 ♘de5 ♙e7 13 ♙b3 ♘c6 14 0-0 0-0 15 ♙ac1 ♙b8 16 ♘xc6 bxc6 17 ♙c2 c5 18 ♙fd1 left the onus on White to demonstrate compensation. This leaves 9 0-0 0-0 10 b4! (White needs to act energetically) 10...♙xb4 11 ♙b1 ♙c5 12 ♘d3 ♙e7 13 ♘b6 ♙a7 14 ♙b3 ♘c6 15 ♙b2, Russo-Haro, Guarapuava 1992. An accurate evaluation of the position is difficult as only one game has been played, but White has compensation here. After 15...e5 he found 16 ♘xc8 ♙xc8 17 ♘xe5! ♘xe5 18 ♙xd4 ♙c5 19 ♙xe5 with the advantage of the two bishops in an open position.

9 ♙d2

9 a4 b6 10 ♙b3 ♙b7! should be okay for Black. Berezin-Novikov, Donetsk 1998 went 11 0-0 ♙xg2 12 ♙xg2 ♙d5+ 13 f3 ♙c5 14 e4 ♙b7 15 ♘d3 0-0 16 a5 with play for both sides.

9...b6 10 ♙b3 ♙b7 11 ♙xb7 ♙xb7 12 ♘a5 ♙e7!?

A provocative move, and also one that looks very strange when we consider the plight of the f8-bishop. Av.Bykhovsky-Kaidanov, Irkutsk 1983 continued 12...♙c7 13 ♙xb6 ♙c5 (13...♙c1+?? 14 ♙xc1 ♙xb6 15 ♙c8+ ♙e7 16 ♙xb8! and the threat of ♙b4+ decides the game) 14 ♙b3 0-0 15 0-0 ♙d5 16 ♙xd5 ♘xd5 17 ♙fc1 ♙fc8 18 ♘d3 ♙b6 19 ♙xc7 ♙xc7 20 ♙c1 with the standard Catalan ending advantage.

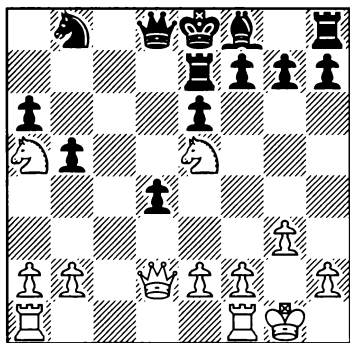
12...♙a7 13 0-0 (13 ♘ac6? ♘xc6 14 ♘xc6 ♙a8 15 ♙xb6? ♙b7 16 ♙xd4 ♙c7 cannot be recommended) 13...♘e4 14 ♙a4+ b5 15 ♙c2 ♘xd2 16 ♙xd2 ♙d5 17 ♘f3 ♙c5 18 ♘b3 0-0 19 ♘xc5 ♙xc5 20 ♙fc1 ♙d5 21 ♙xd4 ♙xd4 22 ♘xd4 ♙d7 23 ♘b3 ♙fd8 with a draw to come in Dizdar-Novikov, Lucerne 1997.

13 0-0

White achieves nothing from 13 ♖ac6. Kopylov-Yakovich, Hamburg 1999 continued 13...♗xc6 14 ♖xc6 ♖a8! 15 ♖c1 ♖c7 16 ♖xb6 ♗d5 17 ♖b8+ ♖xb8 18 ♗xb8 ♖xc1+ 19 ♖xc1 ♖d6 20 ♗c6 e5 21 ♗a5 ♖e7 and Black was better thanks to his development lead.

13...♗e4

13...bxa5? does not work in view of 14 ♖a4+ ♗bd7 15 ♖xa5 ♖b8 16 ♖ac1, when White's attack is decisive.

14 ♖a4+ b5 15 ♖c2 ♗xd2 16 ♖xd2**16...♖c7**

16...♗d5?! 17 ♖c1! exposes Black's vulnerable back rank.

17 ♖ac1 ♖c5 18 ♖f4

Perhaps White should put the brakes on here. 18 ♖xc5 leads to equality after 18...♖xc5 19 ♗b7 ♖c7 20 ♗xc5 ♖xe5 21 ♗b3 0-0 22 ♗xd4 ♖d8 23 ♖c1, when a draw is on the cards.

18...0-0

Also possible is 18...f6 19 ♗ec6 ♗xc6 20 ♖xc5 ♗e5 21 ♖xc7 ♖xc7 22 ♗b3 and Black is no worse.

19 ♖xc5 ♖xc5 20 ♗b7 ♖c7 21 ♗xc5 ♖xc5 22 ♖c1 ♗d6 23 ♖e4?!

White could also try 23 ♗c6 ♖xf4 24 ♗e7+ ♖h8 25 gxf4 g6 26 ♖g2 with play for the pawn, although Black still looks better.

23...g6 24 ♗c6

After 24 ♗f3?! ♖d8 25 ♖xd4 ♖xd4 26

♗xd4 ♖xd4 27 ♖c8+ ♖g7 28 ♖xb8 ♖d1+ 29 ♖g2 ♖d2 Black wins a pawn and maybe the game.

24...♗xc6 25 ♖xc6 ♖b4 26 ♖xa6 ♖xb2 27 ♖a7 b4 28 ♖g2

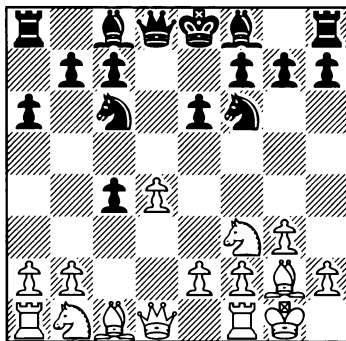
Perhaps Black is a shade better here, but White has sufficient play to hold. However, this is a road down which it might be dangerous to travel. Who knows where Black had improvements?

28...b3 ½-½

Now he settles for a draw.

Black meets 6 0-0 with 6...♗c6*Game 51***Gleizerov-S.Ivanov***Poland 1992***1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♗f3 ♗f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 a6 6 0-0**

This simple move is more dangerous for Black.

6...♗c6**7 a4**

Relatively harmless. 7 e3 and 7 ♗c3 are considered below. Also lacking punch is 7 ♗a3 ♖xa3 8 bxa3, e.g. 8...0-0 9 ♖b2 ♖b8 10 ♖c2 b5 11 ♖ad1, when Shipov-S.Ivanov, St. Petersburg 1996 went 11...♖b6!? 12 e4 ♖b7 13 ♗g5, the main idea behind this questionable knight manoeuvre perhaps being 13...a6 14 d5!?. Instead there followed 13...♗d7 14

h4 h6 15 ♖h3 ♜e8 16 ♜f4 e5! (the downside to the long knight journey) 17 dxe5 ♜cxe5 and Black was slightly better. There is some compensation for the pawn, but not really enough to recommend trying this position again. In Khalifman-Akopian, Manila 1992 the situation was a complete mess after 11...♜e7 12 e4 ♜b7 13 ♜f6! ♜g6 14 ♜c3 ♜d7 15 h4 ♜fd8 16 d5.

7...♜b8

Also interesting is 7...♜e7!? 8 ♜a3 ♜a5.

8 a5

White is trying to prevent ...b7-b5. Black also has a good game after the alternatives. 8 ♜g5 ♜e7 9 ♜c3 b5 10 axb5 axb5 11 ♜xb5!? ♜xb5 12 ♜a4 ♜b4 13 ♜xc6+ ♜d7 14 ♜a6 ♜xb2 15 ♜xc4 0-0, with chances for both sides, needs practical testing, while 8 ♜a3 ♜xa3 9 ♜xa3 b5 10 axb5 axb5 11 ♜e5 ♜xe5 12 dxe5 ♜d5 13 ♜d4 0-0 14 ♜c5 ♜e7 15 ♜e3 ♜xc5 16 ♜xc5 ♜d8 17 ♜d1 left White with good play for the exchange but hardly an advantage in Prokopchuk-Daschian, Moscow 1999. 8 ♜c3 ♜b4 9 ♜e1 ♜d5 10 ♜c2 ♜e7 11 ♜d1 0-0 12 e4 ♜cb4 13 ♜b1 ♜xc3 14 bxc3 ♜d3 15 ♜d2 ♜xc1 16 ♜xc1 e5 saw Black generate excellent counterplay in Bu Xiangzhi-Drei, Reykjavik 2000.

8...♜b4

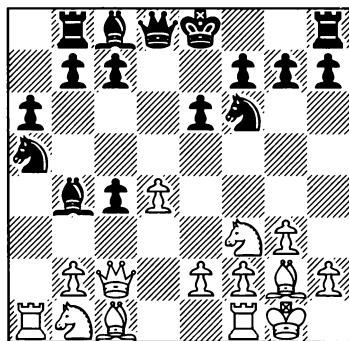
The most logical move now the a-pawn is exposed. After 8...b5 9 axb6 cxb6 White has a chance to create an initiative, e.g. 10 ♜f4 ♜d6 11 ♜e5 ♜e7 12 e4 ♜b7 13 ♜c3 0-0 14 ♜g5! b5 15 ♜xf6 gxf6 16 ♜g4 ♜g6 17 h4 with a good attack for the pawn in Petursson-Oll, Groningen 1997. 12 ♜xc4 ♜xf4 13 gxf4 0-0 was more peaceful in Timoshenko-Novikov, Nova Gorica 1997, when 14 e3 ♜fd5 15 ♜e5 ♜b7 16 ♜d2 ♜g6 17 ♜xg6 hxg6 18 ♜f3 ♜e7 19 ♜e5 ♜b4 was no worse for Black.

9 ♜c2

There is no route to an advantage here. After 9 ♜a4 0-0 10 ♜e5 ♜d7! 11 ♜xc4 ♜e7 12 ♜d1 ♜fd8 Black is fine according to S.Ivanov and Yuneev. Also harmless is 9

♜d2 ♜xd2 10 ♜xd2 0-0 11 ♜c3 b5 12 axb6 cxb6 13 ♜xc4 ♜b7 14 e3 a5 15 ♜c3 ♜b4 16 ♜ad1 ♜a6 17 ♜b3 ♜c8 with equality in Maiwald-S.Ivanov, Katowice 1993.

9...♜xa5

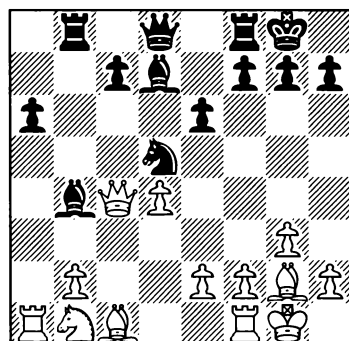


The safest option. Black can also consider taking with the bishop: 9...♜xa5!? 10 ♜e5 (it is difficult to evaluate the compensation after 10 ♜xc4 ♜b6 11 ♜d1 – enough for a pawn, but does it result in an advantage?) 10...♜xd4!? 11 ♜a4+ b5 12 ♜xa5 ♜d6! 13 ♜f3 ♜xe2+ 14 ♜h1 ♜xc1 15 ♜xc1 0-0 with an unclear game (S.Ivanov and Yuneev).

10 ♜a4+ ♜c6 11 ♜e5 ♜d5

After 11...0-0 White gets an advantage with 12 ♜xc6! bxc6 13 ♜xc6 ♜d7 14 ♜xd8 ♜xa4 15 ♜xe6 fxe6 16 ♜xa4, when his superior pawn structure will help in the ending.

12 ♜xc6 bxc6 13 ♜xc6+ ♜d7 14 ♜xc4 0-0



15 ♖d1

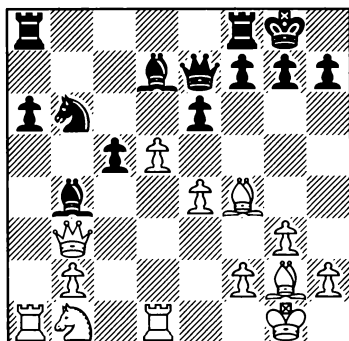
Accepting the pawn with 15 ♔xd5 exd5 16 ♖xd5 leads to equality after 16...♙b5 17 ♖xd8 ♖bxd8 18 ♖c3.

15...c5!? 16 e4

Or 16 dxc5 ♙b5 17 ♖c2 ♖e7 and Black is doing fine – Gleizerov.

16...♙b6 17 ♖b3 ♖e7

The pawn sacrifice 17...a5 18 dxc5 ♔xc5 19 ♖xa5 ♙d5! is interesting, 20 ♖a2 ♙b4 21 ♖a3 producing a messy position.

18 ♙f4 ♖a8 19 d5**19...c4?**

A horrible blunder, after which White wins by force. 19...exd5 is necessary, when 20 exd5 ♔g4 21 d6 (21 ♖c1!?) 21...♔xd1 22 ♖xd1 ♖ad8 23 ♖xa6 ♖fe8 is balanced.

20 d6!

Perhaps Black forgot about this move.

20...cxb3

20...♔xd6 21 ♔xd6 ♖xd6 22 ♖xd6 cxb3 does not work in view of 23 ♖xb6, when White emerges with an extra piece.

21 dxe7 ♖fc8

21...♔xe7 22 ♔e3.

22 ♔e3 ♔c5 23 ♔xc5 ♖xc5

White is less well developed but has the significant advantage of a pawn on the 7th rank, so now he decides the game.

24 ♖xa6! ♖xa6

24...♖b8 25 ♖xb6! is no improvement.

25 ♖xd7 ♖c1+ 26 ♔f1 ♙xd7 27 e8♖+ ♙f8 28 ♙d2

28 ♔g2? ♖xf1! 29 ♔xf1 ♖a1 30 ♔g2 ♖xb1 and Black makes a draw.

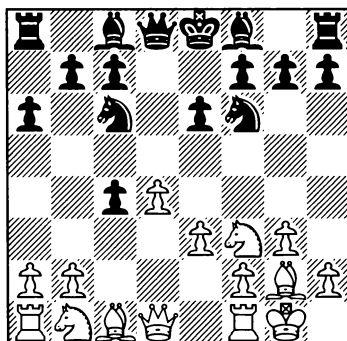
28...♖aa1 29 ♔g2 ♖d1 30 ♙xb3

White wins easily with 30 ♖d8 ♖ab1 31 ♖d4 e5 32 ♖e3 ♖xb2 33 ♙xb3 etc.

30...♖xf1 31 ♙xa1 ♖xa1 32 b4 ♖b1 33 b5 f6 34 ♖c6 ♙f7 35 ♖c7+ ♔e8 36 ♖c2! ♖a1 37 b6 ♙d7 38 b7 ♔e7 39 ♖b2 ♖d1 40 b8♖ ♙xb8 41 ♖xb8 ♖d8 42 ♖c7+ ♖d7 43 ♖c5+ ♙f7 44 ♖h5+ 1-0

Game 52
Wells-Barsov
York 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♙f3 ♙f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♔g2 a6 6 0-0 ♙c6 7 e3

**7...♔d7**

The logical, calm approach. Black has no problem parting with the exchange on a8 – as can be seen in the notes to White's 9th move in the next main game. 7...♖b8 is less accurate, White achieving a slight advantage after 8 ♙fd2!, e.g. 8...e5 9 ♔xc6+ bxc6 10 dxe5 ♙g4 11 ♙xc4 ♔e6 12 ♖c2 h5! 13 ♖d1 ♖c8 14 ♖e4! ♔d5 15 ♖xd5 cxd5 16 ♖xd5 ♔e7, Tukmakov-V.Mikhalevski, Biel 1998. Now after 17 e6! ♖xe6 18 ♖xe6 fxe6 19 h3 White is a little better according to Tukmakov. White's knights got busy in Lputian-V.Milov, Istanbul 2000: 8...♖d7 9 ♙xc4 b5 10 ♙cd2 ♔b7 11 ♙c3 ♙d8 12 ♙f3 c5 13 e4

cx d4 14 ♖xd4 ♖c6 15 ♙f4 ♙c8 16 ♖b3 ♙b4 17 e5 ♙xd1 18 ♙fxd1 ♖d7 19 ♖e4 ♖dx e5 20 ♖ec5 ♙xc5 21 ♙xe5 ♙b6 22 ♙xg7 ♙g8 23 ♙f6 and Black still had some problems to solve.

8 ♖c3

8 ♙e2 is considered in the next game.

8...♖d5

One of a number of options open to Black:

8...b5 9 ♖e5 ♖d5 10 ♖xd5 exd5 11 ♙xd5 ♖xe5 12 dx e5 c6 13 ♙e4 and White has the better prospects. 8...♙b8 looks dangerous for Black. Cs.Horvath-Marciano, Austria 1998 continued 9 ♖e5 ♖a5 10 e4 b5 11 g4! h6?! (risky) 12 f4 c5 13 d5 b4 (13...exd5 14 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 15 ♖xd5 gives White a promising initiative) 14 dx e6 ♙xe6 15 ♙a4+ ♖d7? (the decisive mistake, but after 15...♙d7 16 ♖xd7 ♙xd7 17 ♙xa5 bxc3 18 bxc3 White nevertheless has a terrifying attack) 16 f5! ♙e7 17 ♙d1! bxc3 18 fx e6 ♙xe6 19 ♖xd7 cxb2 20 ♖xf8+ ♙xf8 21 ♙xd8 bxa1 ♙ 22 ♙d7+ 1-0. Black has to play 11...b4 12 g5 bxc3 13 bxc3! ♙b5! (13...♖g8? is dangerous – after 14 ♙f3 ♙e7? 15 ♙a3 White wins) 14 gxf6 gxf6 15 ♖xd7 ♙xd7 16 ♙f3 ♙g8 17 ♙h1 when a draw was agreed in Sosonko-Piket, Rotterdam 1997. However, White would be quite justified in trying for more in this final position.

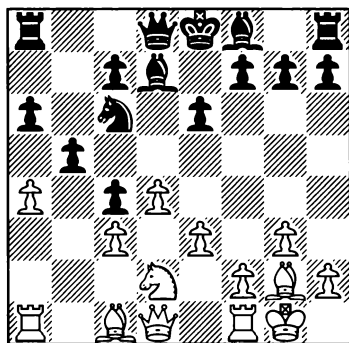
8...♙d6 is a reasonable alternative. White might need to improve on 9 ♖e5 ♙xe5 10 dx e5 ♖xe5 11 ♙xb7 ♙b8, when Black is fine. Then 12 ♙d4 ♙xb7 13 ♙xe5 0-0 14 ♙d1 ♙e7 15 e4 ♙c6 16 ♙d4 ♙b4 17 ♙e3 ♖d7! proved unreliable and left White worse in Karpov-Anand, Leon 1999. The later game Franco-Korneev, Madrid 2000 went instead 12 ♙g2 ♙e7 13 ♙d4 ♙d6 14 ♙d1 ♙xd4 15 ♙xd4 ♙b6 16 ♖e4 ♙c6 17 f4 ♙xe4 18 ♙xe4 ♖xe4 19 ♙xe4 ♖f3+ 20 ♙f2 ♖xh2 21 ♙xc4 0-0 and, this time, chances were even.

9 ♖d2

9 ♙e2 ♖xc3 10 bxc3 ♙d6 11 ♙d1 b5 12

♖e5! was the course of Khalifman-A.Petrosian, Moscow 1987. Then 12...♖xe5 13 dx e5 ♙xe5 14 ♙a3! ♙b8 15 f4 ♙d6 16 ♙xd6 cxd6 17 ♙xd6 gives White good play for the pawn, so Black chose 12...♙xe5 13 dx e5 ♖xe5, when 14 ♙h5! ♖d3 15 ♙a3 ♙b8 16 ♙e4 favoured White.

9...♖xc3 10 bxc3 b5 11 a4



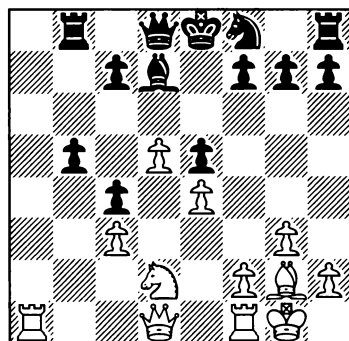
11...♙b8 12 e4

White can also try 12 ♙g4 g6 13 ax b5 ax b5 14 ♙e2 ♖e7 15 e4 ♙g7 16 e5 ♖d5 17 ♖e4 with good play for the pawn. The weakness of the dark squares in Black's camp is significant.

12...e5

The open position after 12...b4 13 ♖xc4 bxc3 14 d5 is not in Black's interest.

13 ax b5 ax b5 14 d5 ♖e7 15 ♙a3 ♖g6 16 ♙xf8 ♖xf8



17 f4

White begins his kingside attack, exploiting the development lead. Also strong is 17 ♖h5 ♕g6 18 ♖a7 0-0 19 ♖fa1 ♖c8 20 h3, when Black is under pressure.

17...♕g6 18 f5 ♕e7 19 f6 gxf6 20 ♖a6 ♕g8

This seems to be very passive, and that in itself is a risk. 20...c6!? is less clear.

21 ♖h5 ♖c8 22 ♖c6 ♖d7 23 ♕f3! ♖e7?

Black cracks under pressure, missing 23...♖xc6 24 ♕xe5! ♖xd5! 25 exd5 ♖e7 26 ♕c6 ♖e3+ 27 ♖h1 ♖b6, which is still very difficult but at least forces White to work.

24 ♖xc7 ♖d6 25 ♕g5!

White comes crashing through.

25...♕h6

25...fxg5 26 ♖xf7+ ♖d8 27 ♖xd7+ ♖xd7 28 ♖f8+ ♖c7 29 ♖c5+ ♖b7 30 ♖b1! and Black cannot defend himself.

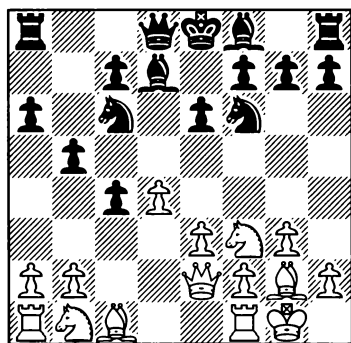
26 ♖xd7! ♖b6+

There is no defence, e.g. 26...♖xd7 27 ♖xf6 ♖a7+ 28 ♖h1 and White's attack decides.

27 ♖h1 fxg5 28 ♖fx7 ♖g6 29 ♖fe7+ ♖f8 30 ♖f3+ ♖g8 31 ♖e6 1-0

Game 53
Haba-Gorin
Pardubice 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♕f3 ♕f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 a6 6 0-0 ♕c6 7 e3 ♖d7 8 ♖e2 b5



9 ♖d1

Another natural move for White is 9 ♕c3, when 9...♖d6 invites 10 e4 e5 11 dxe5 ♕xe5 12 ♕xe5 ♖xe5 13 f4 with a fluent initiative for White, who generated an offensive in Tkachiev-Beliavsky, Enghien 1999 after the subsequent 13...♖xc3 14 bxc3 c6 15 f5! 0-0 16 ♖g5 h6 17 ♖h4 ♖b6+ 18 ♖h1 ♕h7 19 ♖ad1 ♖c7 20 e5 etc. Beliavsky-Goldin, Niksic 1997 went 9...♖e7 10 ♕e5 ♕xe5 11 dxe5 ♕d5 12 ♕xd5 exd5 13 ♖xd5 c6 14 ♖e4 0-0 15 b3 ♖e6 16 ♖c2 h6 with an unclear game.

9 ♕e5 wins the exchange but is not the strongest opportunity available. 9...♕d5 is the weak response, Tratar-A.Petrosian, Ptuj 1998 turning out advantageous for White after 10 ♕xd7 ♖xd7 11 b3 cxb3 12 axb3 ♖e7 13 ♖b2 0-0 14 ♖d1 ♕cb4 15 e4 ♕b6 16 ♕c3 ♖ad8 17 ♕a2 a5 18 ♕c3. The correct approach is 9...♕xe5! 10 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 11 dxe5 ♕e4 12 a4 (12 b3! is better) 12...♖b7 13 axb5 axb5 14 f3 ♕c5 15 e4 ♕b3 16 ♖a2 ♕xc1 17 ♖xc1 ♖c5+ 18 ♖g2 ♖d4 19 ♖d2 c5 and the two bishops and queenside majority gave Black an excellent game in Janssen-Piket, Rotterdam 1999.

9...♖e7

Also possible is 9...♖d6 10 e4 e5 11 dxe5 ♕xe5 (not 11...♕xe5? 12 ♕xe5 ♖xe5 13 f4 ♖d6 14 e5 ♖c5+ 15 ♖f1 ♕g4 16 e6 and White wins) 12 ♕c3 (12 ♕xe5 ♕xe5 13 h3 c6 14 ♖e3 is unclear) 12...0-0 13 ♖g5 ♖xc3 14 bxc3 ♖e8 15 e5 ♖g4 16 h3 ♖xf3 17 ♖xf3 ♖xe5 18 ♖xe5 ♕xe5 19 ♖xa8 ♖xa8 with enough compensation for the exchange according to Kaidanov.

10 ♕c3

An interesting line is 10 e4 0-0 11 ♕c3 ♖e8 12 ♕e5 ♖b8 13 ♖e3 h6, when White came up with the complicated 14 ♕xf7!? ♖xf7 15 e5 in Cvitan-Dautov, Dresden 1998. Then 15...♕g8 16 ♖f3+ ♖g6 17 ♖g4+ ♖f7 18 ♖xc6! ♖xc6 19 d5 gives White a winning attack, the main point being 19...♖xd5 20 ♕xd5 exd5 21 e6+ ♖f8 22 ♖g6, when mate cannot be avoided. Dautov played 15...♕b4 16 exf6 ♖xf6 17 ♕e4 ♖e7 18 ♕c5 and both

sides had decent chances. Notice that in many of these positions a pawn is only a positional factor alongside many others.

10...♖b4

A very standard manoeuvre to trade off White's bishop, but this is also rather time-consuming. Beliavsky gives 10...♖d5 11 e4 ♖xc3 12 bxc3 0-0 13 h4 with compensation for White. Who this exchange benefits is not clear.

11 e4 ♖d3 12 ♖e5 ♖xc1

12...b4 13 ♖xd7 ♗xd7 14 e5 ♖d5 15 ♖e4 0-0 16 ♗c2 seems to offer White good chances of creating an initiative. Without his bishop Black is unable to maintain sufficient influence on the light squares.

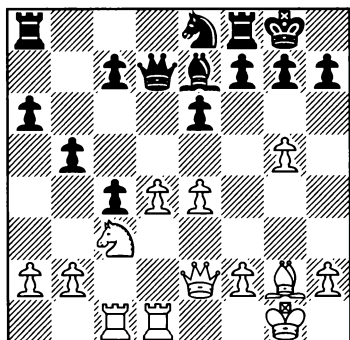
13 ♖axc1 0-0 14 g4

White has addressed development and needs to set in motion some kind of aggressive action in order to justify the pawn sacrifice.

14...♗c8

The potency of White's attack becomes evident in the following line: 14...c6 15 g5 ♖e8 16 d5! ♖d6 17 ♖xd7 ♗xd7 18 e5 cxd5! (the bishop is going, and this way is best) 19 exd6 ♖xd6 20 ♗e5 and White's prospects are slightly preferable. Note that 20...b4? 21 ♖xd5! wins for White.

15 g5 ♖e8 16 ♖xd7 ♗xd7



17 e5?

An unsound pawn sacrifice which Black should exploit. 17 h4 f6 18 e5 is complex.

17...c6?!

Black should accept the invitation and play 17...♖xg5!! 18 ♖xa8 ♖xc1 19 ♖xc1 c6!, trapping the bishop. Then 20 ♖e4 (20 ♗e4 ♗d8! and ...♗g5+) 20...♗c8 21 ♖xc6? (21 b3? and White is not so much worse) 21...♗xc6 22 b3 ♗d5! favours Black.

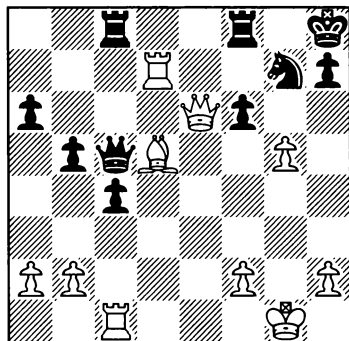
18 ♖e4 f5

18...♖c7 19 ♖f6+ ♖xf6 20 gxf6 looks very dangerous.

19 exf6 gxf6 20 ♖c5 ♖xc5 21 dxc5 ♗e7?!

The queen is in the way on this rank, and the c-pawn is hanging. After the superior 21...♗c8 22 gxf6 ♖xf6 23 ♖c3 ♖a7! the battle rolls on.

22 ♖xc6 ♖c8 23 ♖d7 ♗xc5 24 ♗xe6+ ♖h8 25 ♖d5 ♖g7



26 g6!!

A fantastic move that opens up the king-side.

26...♖fd8?!

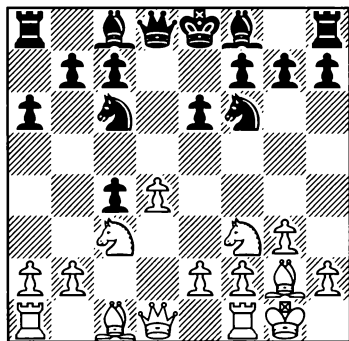
26...♖xe6 is better. After 27 ♖xh7+ ♖g8 28 ♖xe6+ ♖f7 29 ♖c3! White wins. One line goes 29...♖cc7 30 ♖xf7 ♖xf7 31 gxf7+ ♖f8 32 ♖g3 and it is all over. 26...♖c7 was the best try. Now after 27 ♗h3 h5 28 ♖xc7 ♗xc7 29 ♗e3 ♖f5 30 ♗f3 ♖g7 31 ♖e1 White has a fantastic position, probably winning, but there is still some work to do.

27 ♗h3 1-0

Black resigned because 27...h5 is met by 28 ♗xh5+ ♖xh5 29 ♖h7 mate.

Game 54
Raetsky-Ekström
Zürich 1998

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♟f6 4 g3 dxc4 5
 ♙g2 a6 6 0-0 ♟c6 7 ♟c3



7...♟b8

Experience has made this the main line. 7...♙e7 allows 8 ♖a4 0-0 9 ♖xc4 when Black has no natural plan of development. 7...♙b4 also looks too optimistic. 8 ♖c2 0-0 9 ♖d1 ♖e7 10 ♙g5 h6 11 ♙xf6 ♖xf6 12 e4 ♟b8 13 e5 ♖e7 14 d5 ♟a5 15 ♟d4 ♙d7 16 f4 ♟fd8 17 ♟h1 ♙e8 18 f5 saw White generate a promising kingside attack in Shipov-Bashkov, Cheliabinsk 1991. Note that the two bishops are of little importance here as the position is still somewhat closed. Another strong option is 8 ♙g5 0-0 9 ♟c1 ♙e7 10 e3, when Bronstein-Kholmov, Moscow 1957 continued 10...♟d5 11 ♙xe7 ♟cxe7 12 ♟e4 b5 13 b3 cxb3 14 ♖xb3 a5 15 ♟e5 b4 16 ♟c5 and White had good play on the c-file and in the centre.

8 e4 ♙e7

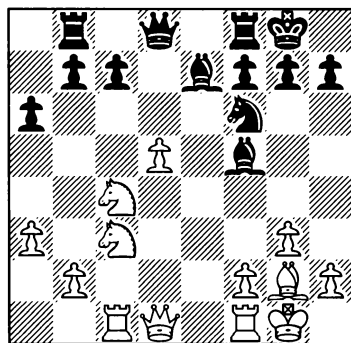
8...b5 is considered in the next game. 8...♙b4 can be met with 9 d5! ♙xc3 10 bxc3 ♟e7 (10...exd5 11 exd5 ♟xd5 12 ♟g5 ♙e6 looks risky but is not necessarily unsound) 11 ♟e1 0-0 12 ♙a3, when Petursson-Lechtynsky, Smederevska Palanka 1984 was rather unpleasant for Black after 12...exd5?

13 exd5 ♟e8 14 d6 ♟f5. Now White wins with 15 dxc7 ♖xc7 16 g4! ♟d8 17 ♖e2 ♟d6 18 ♙xd6 ♖xd6 19 ♟ad1 ♖f8 20 ♟xd8 ♖xd8 21 g5 ♟d7 22 ♖e8+ and Black loses material. An improvement is 12...♟e8 13 d6 cxd6 14 ♙xd6 ♟a8, when White has clear compensation for the pawn but Black is not necessarily so much worse.

9 ♖e2!?

White needs to develop his initiative patiently. After 9 ♙g5 0-0 10 e5 ♟d5 11 h4 ♟xc3 12 bxc3 b5 there is not enough for the pawn, 13 ♟d2 ♙b7 14 ♟e4 ♙xg5 15 hxg5 ♟e7 16 ♖h5 ♟f5 leaving Black slightly better in Franco-Korneev, San Sebastian 2000.

A famous main line is 9 d5, which steers play by force to a position where White has a little extra space and Black has the two bishops: 9...exd5 10 exd5 ♟b4 11 ♟e5 ♙f5 12 a3 ♟d3 13 ♟xc4 ♟xc1 14 ♟xc1 0-0



This position has appeared many times in practical play. Some commentators believe the situation to be equal while others prefer White. Perhaps an assessment somewhere between the two is fair, which means that Black should be able to equalise in the next ten or so moves with accurate play, but will suffer more from inaccuracies. Kaidanov-Shabalov, Seattle 2000 went 15 ♖d4 ♟e8 16 ♟e3 ♙d7 17 ♟e4 ♟d6 18 ♟c5 ♙b5 19 ♟fd1 ♙f6 20 ♖d2 b6 21 ♟b3 ♖d7 22 ♟d4 ♟be8 23 b3 a5 24 ♟xb5 and a draw was agreed. Another line goes 15 b4 ♟e8 16 ♖d4

♟d7 17 d6 cxd6 18 ♞xd6 ♠xd6 19 ♚xd6 ♞e5 with complete equality according to Haba.

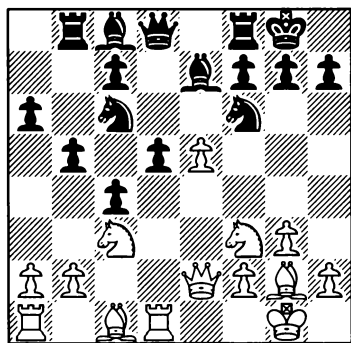
9...b5

It is dangerous to grab the pawn with 9...♞xd4 10 ♞xd4 ♚xd4, e.g. 11 ♜d1 ♚c5 12 ♠e3!? (this packs more punch than 12 e5 ♟d7 13 ♞e4 ♚xe5 14 ♠f4 ♚a5 15 ♚xc4 e5 16 ♠d2 ♚b6 17 ♠e3 c5 18 ♞c3 ♞f6 which was unclear in Klinger-Bönsch, Lugano 1989) 12...♚a5 13 ♚xc4 0-0 14 a3 and White has good compensation for the pawn as Black's queen is in need of a safe haven.

10 ♜d1 0-0

10...♞b4 11 ♞e5 ♟d7! 12 b3?! (12 ♚g4 g6 13 ♠h6 ♞xe5 14 dxe5 ♞d3 gives White a slight edge) 12...♞xe5 13 dxe5 ♞d3 14 ♠e3 0-0 15 f4 ♠b4 16 ♚c2 ♚e7 17 ♞e2 a5! 18 h4 ♠a6 and Black was clearly better in Lalic-Chandler, Hastings 1999/2000.

11 d5 exd5 12 e5!



12...d4!?

Black has to give up the knight one way or the other. 12...♟d7?! 13 e6?! ♞b6! benefits only Black, so White should play 13 ♞xd5. Then 13...♞b4 14 e6 ♞xd5 15 exd7 ♠b7 16 ♞e5 c6 17 ♞xc6?! (17 ♠f4, with a mess, is better) 17...♠xc6 18 ♠xd5 ♠xd7 19 ♠c6 ♠xc6 20 ♜xd8 ♜bxd8 gives Black all the chances, which leaves 14 ♞d4! ♞xd5 (14...♠b7?! 15 ♞xb4! ♠xg2 16 ♠xg2 ♠xb4 17 ♞c6 and White wins a piece) 15 ♞c6 ♚e8 16 ♠xd5 ♞b6 17 ♠e4! ♜a8 18 ♚h5 g6 19

♚h6 ♠g4 20 ♜e1 with a clear advantage to White according to Haba.

An interesting alternative is 12...♞b4!? 13 exf6 ♠xf6 14 ♞e5 when Black has three possibilities.

14...♜e8?! 15 ♞xd5 ♞xd5 (15...♜xe5? 16 ♞xf6+ ♚xf6 17 ♚xe5! etc.) 16 ♜xd5 ♚e7 17 f4 and White is well ahead. 14...♠b7?! 15 a3! ♜e8 16 axb4 ♜xe5 17 ♚c2 c6 18 ♞e4! was clearly better for White in Raetsky-Åström, Hafnarfjörður 1997, Black without counterplay on the dark squares. The sound option is 14...d4!, e.g. 15 a3 ♜e8 16 axb4 d3 17 ♠f4 dxe2 18 ♜xd8 ♜xd8 19 ♞xe2 with chances for both sides, although White's task is probably the easier.

13 exf6 ♠xf6 14 ♚e4

After 14 ♞e4 ♠e7 15 a4 d3 16 ♚d2 ♞b4 Black has good counterplay for the piece.

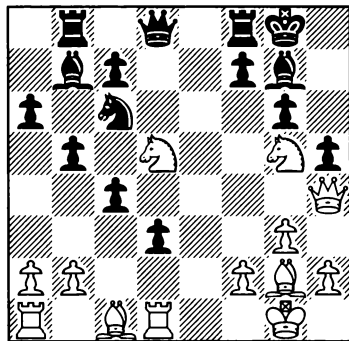
14...♠b7 15 ♞d5 d3

15...♞b4 16 ♞xf6+ ♚xf6 17 ♚f4 c5 18 ♚xf6 gxf6 19 ♠f4 and Black needs to be careful.

16 ♚f5?!

White chooses the wrong strategy in trying to deliver mate. Preferable is 16 ♞xf6+ ♚xf6 17 ♚f4! when White has some advantage in the endgame due to his control over the dark squares.

16...♠d4 17 ♞g5 g6 18 ♚h3 h5 19 ♚h4 ♠g7



20 ♞f4?!

White continues down the wrong path.

After 20 ♖f4 ♜e5 21 ♜c3 ♖xg2 22 ♜xg2 ♜e8 he is worse but can at least fight.

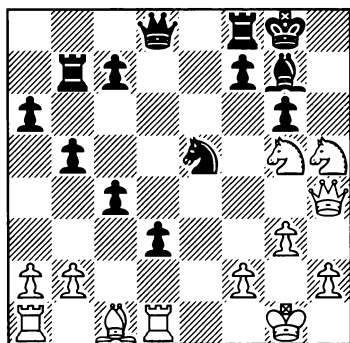
20...♜e5?

A big mistake that justifies White's approach. Much stronger is 20...♜d4! 21 ♜e4 (21 ♖xb7 ♜xb7 22 ♜xh5 f6! 23 ♜xg7 fxg5 and Black wins, as is the case after 21 ♜xh5 ♜e2+ 22 ♜h1 ♖xg2+ 23 ♜xg2 ♜d5+ 24 f3 gxh5 25 ♜xh5 ♜f5 etc.) 21...♜xh4 22 gxh4 ♜fe8 and White will not last long.

21 ♖xb7?

No doubt overlooking Black's 22nd move. 21 ♜xh5! is correct, when Black needs to play 21...f6! (21...gxh5? 22 ♖xb7 ♜xb7 23 ♜e4! and White wins) 22 ♜xg7 fxg5 23 ♖xg5 ♜d7 24 ♖f6 with a complex position. A possible continuation is 24...♖xg2 25 ♖xe5 ♖b7 26 ♜e6!! ♜xe6 27 ♜h8+ ♜f7 28 ♜h7+ ♜e8 29 ♜xc7 ♜d5 30 ♜xb8+ ♜f7 31 ♜c7+ ♜e6 32 f3 ♜xf3 33 ♜b6+ ♖c6 34 ♜d2 ♜xe5 and Black is a little better. Both sides have alternatives along the way, of course, but this variation illustrates the nature of these positions.

21...♜xb7 22 ♜xh5?



22 ♜fh3 c5 23 ♖e3 ♜c7 with a clear advantage to Black. White no longer has an attack.

22...♜xg5!!

This simplification completely destroys White's offensive.

23 ♜xg5 ♜f3+ 24 ♖g2 ♜xg5 25 ♜xg7 ♜e4 26 ♜e1 ♜f6 27 ♖h6 ♜d8 28 ♜e7

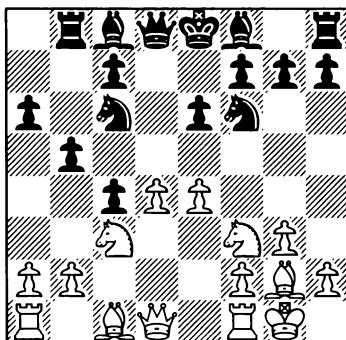
b4 29 h3 c3 30 bxc3 bxc3 31 ♜e6 fxe6 32 ♜g7+ ♜h8 33 ♜e7 ♜g8 0-1

Game 55

Khalifman-Ivanchuk

Minsk 1986

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 a6 6 0-0 ♜c6 7 ♜c3 ♜b8 8 e4 b5!?



Black wants to keep his pawn and emerge with the better chances.

9 ♜e2

9 e5?! is unnatural. After 9...♜d5 10 ♜g5 ♖e7 11 h4 h6 12 ♜h3 ♜cb4 Black is already on top.

9...♜xd4 10 ♜xd4 ♜xd4 11 ♖g5

White achieves nothing from 11 ♖e3?! ♜d3! 12 ♜e1 (12 ♜xd3 cxd3 13 e5 ♜d7 14 ♖a7 ♜b7 15 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 16 f4 c5 17 b3 g5! and White is in trouble according to Milov) 12...♜d8! 13 ♜d1 ♜d7 with a better game for Black (Khalifman). A reasonable alternative is 11 ♜d1 ♜b6 12 e5 ♜d7 13 ♜e4 ♜xe5 (13...♖b7!? 14 ♖e3 ♜a5 is unclear) 14 ♖e3 c5 15 ♖f4 ♜d3 (15...♜d7!? 16 ♖xb8 ♜xb8 – unclear – is also sound) 16 ♖xb8 ♜xb8 17 b3 ♖e7 18 bxc4 bxc4 19 ♜c2 0-0 20 ♜xc4 ♜e5 21 ♜c3 ♜c7 22 ♜ac1 and White had a pull in Miton-Jakovenko, Yerevan 2000.

11...♜b6

The messy 11...♖b7!? 12 ♜fd1 ♜e5 13 ♖e3 b4 14 f4 ♜a5 15 e5 needs investigating.

12 e5

12 ♖xf6?! gxf6 13 e5 runs into 13...f5! and White does not get to the e4-square, while 12 ♖ad1?! meets with 12...e5! 13 ♖xf6 ♜xf6 14 ♜d5 ♞d6, nullifying White's development lead.

12...♜d5

Khalifman gives the following line as winning for White: 12...♜d7!? 13 ♖ad1 ♖c5 14 ♜e4 0-0 15 ♜xd7!? ♖xd7 16 ♜f6+ gxf6 17 ♖xf6. However, Black can play 17...♜fd8 18 ♜h5 ♖f8 19 ♜xh7 ♖e8 20 ♜g8+ ♖f8 21 ♖g7 ♜c5 and we see no win – after 22 ♖f3 ♖c8 23 ♖c6+ ♖d7 24 ♖f3 a draw is all there is.

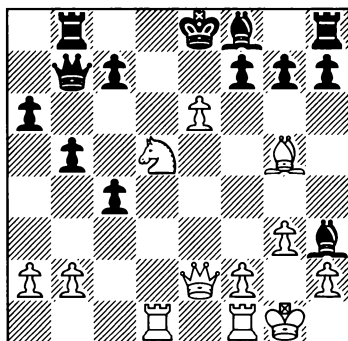
13 ♖xd5! exd5 14 ♜xd5 ♜b7

14...♜c6 15 ♖ad1 ♖e6 (15...♖b7 16 ♜f6+! gxf6 17 exf6+ ♜e6 18 ♜d2 ♖d6 19 ♜fe1 ♖e4 20 ♜d4 puts Black under pressure) 16 ♜f3! ♖xd5 17 ♜xd5 ♜e6 18 ♜fd1 ♖e7 19 ♖xe7 ♜xe7 20 ♖d7 ♜e6 21 ♜xc7 and White is better.

15 ♖ad1 ♖h3?!

Black must play 15...h6!?, when White can try 16 ♜xc7+ ♜xc7 17 ♖d8+ ♜xd8 18 ♖xd8 ♜xd8 19 ♜f3 ♖e8 and the position is rather unclear.

16 e6!



Prising open the enemy defences with decisive effect.

16...♖xe6

16...♖xf1 loses to 17 ♜e5! ♖d6 18 ♜xg7 ♜f8 19 e7! etc.

17 ♜e5! ♖d6

Forced. 17...♖c8 18 ♜xc7+! and Black is mated on d8.

18 ♜xg7 ♖d7 19 ♜f6+ ♖c6 20 ♜e4!

White has a strong attack, against which defence is very awkward.

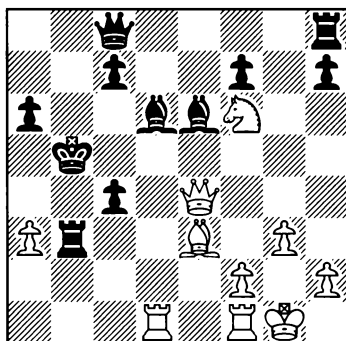
20...♜c8?!

20...♜hg8 21 ♜f6 ♜g6 22 ♜f3 is necessary, although Black's chances of survival are slim.

21 ♜d4 ♜d7 22 ♜f6! ♜c8 23 ♖e3 b4 24 a4

24 ♜e4+ ♖b5 25 ♖d5+! was simpler.

24...bxa3 25 bxa3 ♖b3 26 ♜e4+ ♖b5



27 ♖d5+! ♖xd5 28 ♜xd5+ c5 29 a4+ ♖b6 30 ♜xd6+ ♖b7 31 ♜d5+ ♜c6 32 ♜xc4 1-0

Game 56
Tukmakov-Hulak
Croatia 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 a6 6 0-0 ♜c6 7 ♜c3 ♖b8 8 e4 b5 9 d5!?

White does not waste a second, immediately pushing forward. The reasoning behind this thrust is that Black has spent time with ...b7-b5.

9...♜b4

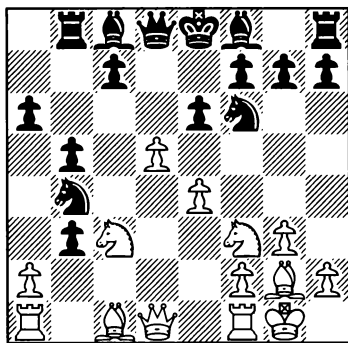
Black does not benefit from opening the centre: 9...exd5 10 exd5 ♜b4 11 b3 cxb3 (11...♜fxd5 12 ♜xd5 ♜xd5 13 ♜d4 places Black under heavy attack) 12 ♜xb3 ♜d3 13

♙g5 ♙e7 14 ♘d4 ♙d7 15 ♖ad1 ♘c5 16 ♜c2 and Black was under pressure in Gorelov-Abramov, USSR 1991.

10 b3!?

White wants to blow the position open as he has completed kingside development. There is also 10 ♘e5 ♙d6 11 f4 exd5 12 a3 ♘d3 13 ♘xd3 cxd3, when Miton-Jakovenko, Oropesa 1999 went 14 exd5?! ♙c5+ 15 ♖h1 ♙f5 16 ♜e1+ ♜e7 17 ♜e5 g6 18 h3 h5 19 ♜e1 ♙d7 20 ♜xe7+ ♙xe7 with advantage to Black. Neistadt suggests 14 ♘xd5 ♘xd5 15 exd5 0-0 16 ♜xd3 c6 with equality.

10...cxb3



11 ♜xb3

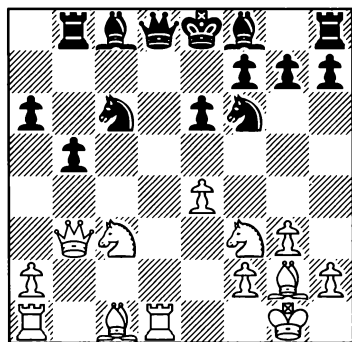
White also has a very interesting option in the sharp 11 ♘d4!?, e.g. 11...c5 (11...e5 12 ♘xb3 c5 13 a3 ♘d3 14 ♜xd3 c4 15 ♜d1 cxb3 16 ♜xb3 and White has a structural advantage) 12 dxc6 e5 13 ♘d5. In Cvitan-Luther, Germany 1998 White emerged from 13...♙d6 14 c7 ♙xc7 15 ♘xb4 ♜xd4 16 ♜xd4 exd4 17 axb3 in front. 13...♘bxd5!? is an interesting alternative, e.g. 14 exd5 exd4 15 ♜e1+ ♙e7 16 d6! (16 ♙f4? ♘xd5! 17 ♙xd5 ♜xd5 18 ♙xb8 b2 19 ♜b1 ♜xc6 and Black has healthy counterplay) 16...♜xd6 17 ♙f4 ♜b4! 18 a3 ♜a4 19 ♙xb8 ♙e6 20 ♙e5 and White stands better, albeit in a tricky position.

11...c5

Greed is dangerous – 11...exd5 12 exd5 ♘bxd5 13 ♜e1+ ♙e7 14 ♘d4 ♙b7 15 ♘f5

and White has a very dangerous attack according to S.Ivanov. Black is forced to play 15...♙f8, when White has 16 ♙g5 ♘xc3 17 ♙xb7 ♜xb7 18 ♜xc3 ♙d6 19 ♙xf6 gxf6 20 ♜f3 ♜b6 21 ♜g4 ♜g8 22 ♜h4 with a decisive attack. The problem for Black in this line is where improvements might be found.

12 dxc6 ♘xc6 13 ♜d1



13...♜b6

Black is in a difficult situation here. For example 13...♜c7 14 ♙f4 e5 15 ♘d5 ♘xd5 16 exd5 exf4 17 ♜c3! is excellent for White according to Tukmakov. However, 13...♘d7!? might be an improvement. After 14 ♙f4 ♜b7 15 ♜ac1 ♘a5 16 ♜c2 ♙a3 White went for it in Raetsky-Barsov, Abu Dhabi 2001 with 17 ♘xb5!? axb5 18 ♜xc8 ♙xc1 19 ♜xc1 0-0 20 ♙d6 ♜e8 21 e5 ♘b6 22 ♘g5 (22 ♘d4!? ♘d5 23 ♙xd5 exd5 24 ♘f5 looks very dangerous for Black) 22...♘d5 23 ♜xd5!? exd5 24 ♙xd5 h6 25 ♘e4 with compensation for the two exchanges. If Black survives he is doing well, but it is not clear that he will.

14 ♙f4 ♜b7 15 e5 ♘d7

After 15...♘g4 16 ♘e4 White has a very promising position, a sample line being 16...♘a5 17 ♜c2 ♜c7 18 ♜e2 ♘c4 (18...♙b7 19 ♘fg5! h5 20 h3 ♙xe4 21 ♘xe4 ♘h6 22 ♘d6+ and White wins) 19 h3 ♘h6 20 ♙xh6 gxh6 21 ♘f6+ ♙e7 22 ♜e4 and there is no adequate defence against 23 ♜h4.

16 ♘e4 ♘c5 17 ♜e3! ♘xe4 18 ♜xe4

♖c7

18...♙c5 19 ♖ac1! offers White good compensation.

19 ♖ac1 ♙b7?!

19...♙c5 20 ♙e3! ♙xe3 21 ♖xe3 ♖xe3 22 ♖xe3 ♙d7 (directed against ♘d4) 23 ♙d6 ♙e7 24 ♘d4 and White seems to have more than enough compensation for the missing exchange.

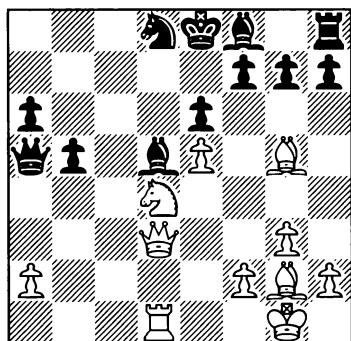
20 ♙e3 ♖a5 21 ♘d4 ♘d8

21...♙e7 walks into 22 ♖xb7!! ♖xb7 23 ♙xb7 when White is winning, e.g. 23...♖a4 24 ♙d2 ♖f6 25 ♙xe6 ♙f7 26 ♘d8+ ♙g8 27 ♙c5 and Black's king will never be safe.

22 ♖d3 ♖xc1

22...♙xg2 23 ♙b3 and Black must resign.

23 ♙xc1 ♙d5 24 ♙g5!



24...h6

In reply to 24...♙e7 White wins with 25 ♙e7 ♙xe7 26 ♙xd5 exd5 27 ♙f5+ and Black is about to be destroyed.

25 ♙xe6! ♖xe6 26 ♖g6+ ♙f7 27 ♙xd5

27 ♖xe6+! ♙xe6 28 ♙c6+ ♙d7 29 ♙xd7 mate.

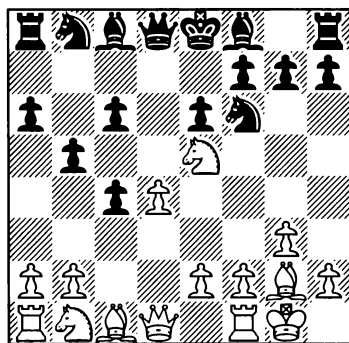
27...♙e7 28 ♙c6+ ♙f8 29 ♙xe7+ 1-0

Black meets 6 0-0 with 6...b5

Game 57
Ilincic-Djuric
Vrnjacka Banja 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♙f3 ♙f6 4 g3 dxc4 5

♙g2 a6 6 0-0 b5 7 ♙e5 c6



8 ♘xc6

Razuvaev's brilliant idea was 8 b3! cxb3 9 ♘xc6 ♖b6 10 ♙a5 ♖a7 (10...bxa2 11 ♖c2 axb1 12 ♖xc8+ ♖d8 13 ♖xd8+ ♙xd8 14 ♖xb1 ♙d5 15 ♙d2 with compensation for the pawn) 11 ♙xb3, when Razuvaev-M.Gurevich, Riga 1985 continued 11...♙e7 12 e4 0-0 13 ♙e3 ♙d7 14 ♙d1d2 ♖d8 15 a4! bxa4 16 ♖xa4 ♙b7 17 ♙a5! ♙c6 18 ♘xc6 ♘xc6 19 ♙b3 ♖b6 20 ♖a1! ♖b5 21 ♖b1 with an advantage to White thanks to the bishop pair and the centre. Another possibility is 11...♙d7 12 e4! ♙b7 13 ♖e1! ♙e7 14 e5 ♙d5 15 ♖g4 ♙f8 16 ♙g5 h5 17 ♖h4 when the plight of Black's king promises White the more pleasant prospects, although this is an improvement for Black on the dubious 15...g6?!, when Krasenkov-Kohlweyer, Ostend 1990 continued 16 ♙h6 ♙b4 17 ♙xb7 ♖xb7 18 ♖e2 ♙8c6 19 ♙c3 and, once again, Black's poor king was a significant factor.

8...♖b6 9 ♙e5

9 ♘xb8 ♖xb8 10 b3 cxb3 11 axb3 ♙b7 12 ♙xb7 ♖xb7 13 ♙f4 ♖c8 with equality.

9...♙b7 10 ♙xb7

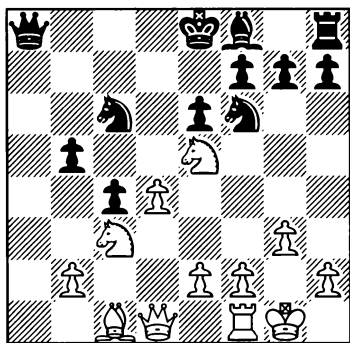
White can also try 10 e4! ♙e4 11 ♖h5 ♙d6 12 d5 g6 (the immediate capture 12...♙xd5 13 ♙xd5 exd5 14 ♙c3 ♖b7 15 ♙d1 ♙e7 16 ♙xd5 is nice for White) 13 ♖e2 ♙g7 and now 14 ♙e3! was tried in Aseev-Novikov, Lvov 1984, which went 14...♖c7

15 ♖f4 0-0 16 ♘c3 ♜e8 and Black was on top. There is no reason to lose a tempo with the bishop, which brings us to 14 dxe6 0-0! 15 ♖e3 ♜c7 16 ♖xb7 ♜xb7 17 ♖c5 ♜d5 18 ♖xd6 ♜xd6 19 ♘xf7 ♜e7, when White keeps the extra pawn but the situation remains unclear due to Black's strong bishop. Returning to 11 ♜h5, we should consider 11...g6?, when 12 ♘g6?! fxg6 13 ♜e5 ♜g8 14 ♖xe4 ♖g7 15 ♖f4 ♜f8 16 ♜g4 ♖xd4 favours Black.

10...♜xb7 11 a4 ♘c6

Also possible is 11...♘bd7 12 axb5 axb5 13 ♜xa8+ ♜xa8 14 ♘c3 b4 15 ♜a4 ♜xa4 16 ♘xa4 ♘xe5 17 dxe5 ♘d7 18 ♖f4 ♖e7 19 ♜c1, given by Cebalo. White picks up a pawn on the queenside and has excellent winning chances.

12 axb5 axb5 13 ♜xa8+ ♜xa8 14 ♘c3



14...♜b7

Another try is 14...b4 15 ♘xc6 ♜xc6 16 ♜a4 ♜xa4 17 ♘xa4 ♖d6 18 ♖e3 ♖e7 19 ♜c1 c3 20 bxc3 b3 21 ♜b1 ♜b8 22 ♖g5 h6 23 ♖xf6+ ♖xf6 24 ♖f1 and White is slightly better in the ending. His pawns are on dark squares and thus dominate the bishop, while the far advanced b3-pawn might prove vulnerable.

15 ♘xc6 ♜xc6 16 e4! b4

Or 16...♘xe4 17 ♜f3 f5 18 ♜d1! ♖e7 19 d5 exd5 20 ♘xd5 and White's activity is sufficient to keep the fire burning.

17 d5 ♜a6

Also possible is 17...♜d7 18 ♘a4 ♖e7 19 ♘b6 ♜b5 20 ♘c8 exd5 21 ♖g5 dxe4 22 ♖xf6 gxf6 23 ♘d6+ ♖xd6 24 ♜xd6 when, despite being two pawns down, White has compensation due to his opponent's poor co-ordination.

18 dxe6 fxe6

18...bxc3 gives White a strong initiative after 19 e5! c2 20 ♜d4 ♜xe6 21 exf6 etc.

19 e5! ♘d7 20 ♘e4 ♘xe5 21 ♜h5+ ♘g6?!

Correct is 21...♘f7, when after 22 ♘g5 g6 23 ♜f3 ♘xg5 24 ♖xg5 ♖e7 25 ♖xe7 ♖xe7 26 ♜e4 White still has compensation due to Black's insecure king.

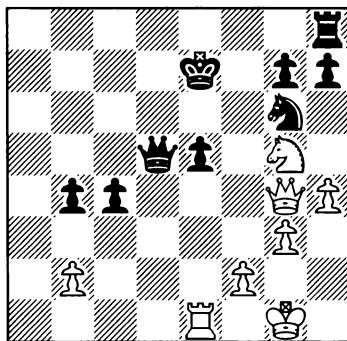
22 ♜e1 ♖e7 23 ♖g5 ♜a5

23...0-0 does not help Black in view of 24 ♖xe7 ♘xe7 25 ♘g5 h6 26 ♘xe6 ♜f7 27 ♘d8 and White wins material.

24 ♜g4 ♜d5

24...♜f5? 25 ♘d6+ 24...♜b6 25 ♖xe7 ♖xe7 26 ♘c5! wins for White.

25 ♖xe7 ♖xe7 26 ♘g5 e5 27 h4!



27...h6

No better is 27...h5 28 ♜f5 ♜h6 29 ♜a1. 28 ♘f3 ♜e6 29 ♜e4 ♜d8 30 h5 ♘f8 31 ♘xe5 ♜d5 32 ♜h4+ 1-0

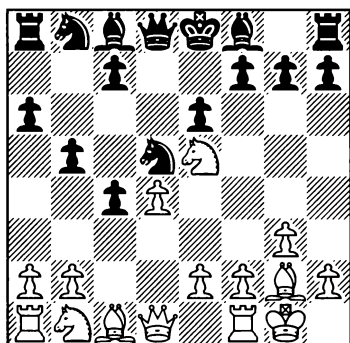
Game 58

Vajnerman-Novikov

L'vov 1984

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5

♠g2 a6 6 0-0 b5 7 ♖e5 ♘d5



8 ♘c3 ♠b7

Black can also play 8...c6 but, after 9 ♘d5 should avoid 9...cxd5 10 e4, when disaster can soon strike, e.g. 10...♠e7? 11 exd5 exd5 12 ♘xf7! ♘xf7 13 ♖h5+ g6 14 ♠xd5+ etc. Best is 9...exd5 10 e4 ♠e6 11 a4, when an interesting option is 11...♠a7!? 12 axb5 cxb5 13 exd5 ♠xd5 with unclear play. Sosonko-Hübner, Tilburg 1979 went 11...b4?! 12 exd5 ♠xd5?! 13 ♖g4! h5 (or 13...♠xg2 14 ♠e1!) 14 ♠xd5! cxd5 15 ♖f5 ♠a7 16 ♠e1 ♠e7 17 ♠g5 g6 18 ♠xe7! and White won.

9 ♘xd5

After 9 e4 ♘f6 10 d5 ♘bd7 the sacrifice 11 ♘xf7 ♘xf7 12 dxe6+ ♘xe6 13 e5 is not good enough in view of 13...♠xg2 14 exf6 ♘e5 with an advantage to Black. Speelman-Van Der Sterren, Baku 1983 continued 11 ♘c6 ♠xc6 12 dxc6 ♘e5 13 ♠f4, when Black could have secured an edge after 13...♘d3 14 e5 ♘d5 according to Speelman.

9...exd5

Not 9...♠xd5? 10 e4 ♠b7 11 ♖h5! g6 12 ♘xg6! fxg6 13 ♖e5 ♘d7 14 ♖xh8 ♖e7 15 h4! 0-0-0 16 ♠g5 ♖f7 17 d5! ♠e8 18 dxe6 ♠xe6 19 ♠ad1 ♠c6 20 ♠h6 ♘b7 21 ♠xd7 and Black resigned in Sosonko-Scheider, Buenos Aires 1978.

10 b3

10 e4 dxe4 11 ♖h5 g6 12 ♘xg6 fxg6 13 ♖e5+ ♖e7 14 ♖xh8 ♘d7 needs investigat-

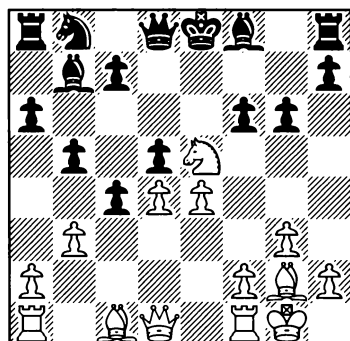
ing. Beliavsky-Sveshnikov, Frunze 1981 went 15 ♠h3 ♘f6 16 ♠g5 ♘f7 17 ♠xf6 ♖xf6 18 ♖xf6+ ♘xf6 19 a4 ♘e7 20 axb5 axb5 21 ♠xa8 ♠xa8 with compensation in the form of the active king: 22 ♠a1 ♠c6 23 ♠a6 ♘d6. Moiseev-Brilla Banfalvi, Correspondence 1984 took the following course: 15 h4 0-0-0 16 ♠g5 ♖f7 17 ♠h3 (17 ♠xd8 ♠g7 18 ♖xh7 ♘f8 19 ♖xg7 ♖xg7 20 ♠g5 ♘h7 21 ♠e3 g5 is unclear) 17...♠e8 18 ♖f6 ♘d5 19 ♠e3 ♘b8 20 ♖g5 ♘b6 and, in this semi-closed position, Black had enough for the exchange, the players agreeing a draw after 21 ♠g4 ♖g8 22 h5 ♠e7 23 ♖h6 ♠f8.

Black's approach in H.Olafsson-Van Beek, Antwerp 1998 is worth repeating: 10...♠e7!? 11 exd5 ♠xd5 12 ♘xf7 ♠xf7 13 ♠xa8 c6 14 ♠f4 ♠d5 15 ♠e1 0-0 16 ♠xb8 and White was left to contemplate the fate of his trapped bishop. Chances were even after 16...♠b4 17 ♖g4 ♠xe1 18 ♠xe1 ♠f7 19 ♠e5 ♖xb8 20 ♠xd5 ♖xa8 21 ♠e5 ♖d8.

10...c3

In the event of 10...f6 11 e4! Huzman and Schneider give 11...fxe5 12 ♖h5+ ♘d7 13 exd5 ♘c8 14 dxe5 ♘d7 15 bxc4 bxc4 16 ♠e3 ♘b6 17 ♠xb6 cxb6 18 d6 ♠xg2 19 ♘xg2 ♖d7 20 ♠fc1 b5 21 a4 with an unclear position. White has good play in return for the material deficit, and Black still needs to complete his kingside development.

Instead of the capture on e5, 11...g6 leads to the following position:



Gulko-I.Novikov, Volgodonsk 1983 continued 12 exd5!! fxe5 13 dxe5 ♠g7 14 ♠a3!, White sacrificing another pawn to keep Black's king in the centre of the board. After 14...c3 15 ♗g4 ♗c8 16 e6 c5 there followed 17 d6 0-0 18 d7 ♘xd7 19 exd7 ♗c7 20 ♠xb7 ♗xb7 21 ♗e6+ ♔f7 22 ♖ad1 ♖d8 23 ♠xc5 ♠f6 with a slight advantage to White, but even better is 17 ♗f4! ♖f8 18 ♗h4 when Black is deprived of the right to castle and White's attack continues.

11 e4 dxe4 12 ♖h5 g6 13 ♘xg6 fxg6 14 ♗e5+ ♗e7 15 ♗xh8 ♘d7 16 d5! ♗g7!

Black shouldn't give up the c3-pawn.
 16...0-0-0?! 17 ♖xc3 ♙g7 18 ♙g5! favours
 White.

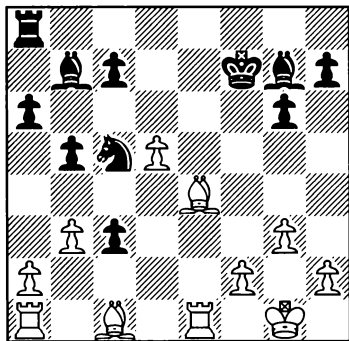
17 ♔xg7 ♖xg7 18 ♖xe4

18 ♖e1 c2 19 ♖xe4+ ♕f7 20 ♙g5 ♙xa1
21 ♖e7+ ♕g8 22 ♖xd7 ♙f6! 23 ♙d2 ♙c3
and the strong c-pawn secures Black equal
play.

18...♞c5 19 ♖e1?!

19 ♖g2 c2 20 ♖a3 ♖xa1 21 ♜xa1 ♜d3
22 ♖e4 b4 23 ♖xd3 bxa3 24 ♖xc2 0-0-0 25
♜d1 ♜xd5 26 ♜xd5 ♖xd5 results in a level
endgame, while 19 f3!? is interesting.

19...♔f7



20 g5?!

Again White has a better move at his disposal in 20 ♖a3, although 20...♟xe4 21 ♖xe4 ♟f6 still leaves Black holding his own thanks to the far advanced c-pawn.

20...h6 21 f4 xe4 22 xe4 xd5 23

♙e1 c5

Black's dangerous queenside pawns tip the scales in his favour.

24 ♖e5 ♗xe5 25 ♜xe5 ♜d8 26 f4 b4! 27 ♔f2

After 27 ♖d1 c2 28 ♜cl Black has 28... ♙xb3!! (very nice!) 29 axb3 ♜d1+ 30 ♜e1 ♜xe1+ 31 ♜xe1 c4 and wins.

27...c4 28 bxc4 ♟xc4 29 ♖b1 ♜d2+ 30 ♔e3

30 ♖e1 ♜b2 31 ♜d1 ♝b5 doesn't help
White.

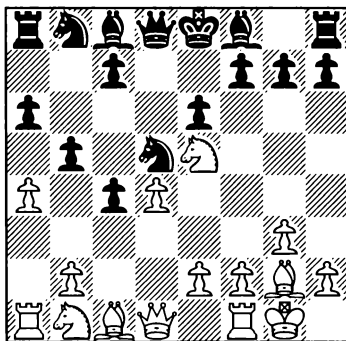
30...♖b2 31 ♖e1 ♙xa2 32 ♙d4 ♜d2+ 33 ♙c5 c2! 34 ♜e7+ ♙f6 0-1

Game 59

Rogers-Chandler

Wellington 1986

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 f3 f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 g2 a6 6 0-0 b5 7 e5 d5 8 a4



8...b7

Another form of support is offered by 8...c6. Then White can try 9 axb5 cxb5 10 ♖c3 ♗b7 (10...♖xc3? 11 bxc3 ♗a7 12 ♗c6+ and White picks up the b5-pawn with a superior position) 11 ♖xd5 exd5 12 e4, when 12...dxe4 13 ♖h5 ♖f6 14 ♗g5 ♖e6 remains complicated. Black fared worse in Heck-Zude, Hessen 1994, which continued 12...♗d6? 13 exd5 0-0 14 ♗d2 f6 15 ♖c6 ♖c7 16 ♖f3 ♖f7 17 ♗ae1. White's doubled pawns in the centre are vulnerable but this

factor is outweighed by his aggressive stance.

The immediate 9 e4 puts the question to Black's knight, e.g. 9...♖b6 10 d5!? ♖c7 11 ♗f4, when White is doing well. This brings us to 9...♗f6, with a further branch. Zaichik-A.Ivanov, Beltsy 1979 continued 10 d5!? cxd5 11 exd5 exd5 12 axb5 ♗e7 13 ♖c3 ♗b7 14 bxa6, when Black could have limited his opponent to a slight edge with 14...♗xa6 15 ♖xc4 ♖b4 16 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 17 ♗e3. White delayed d4-d5 for a move in Sosonko-Bouwmeester, Netherlands 1973, 10 ♖c3 ♗b7 11 d5!? cxd5 12 exd5 exd5 13 axb5 axb5 14 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 15 ♖xb5 ♖a5 16 ♖d4 ♗b4 17 ♗g5 seeing the active blockading strategy providing good play for the pawn.

9 b3 c3

9...cxb3 10 axb5 axb5 11 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 12 ♖xb3 c6 13 ♖c3 has also been tried. After 13...♖d7 14 ♖xd5 exd5 15 ♖e3 ♗e7 16 ♗a3 White's pressure outweighs the pawn deficit, while Romanishin-Marjanovic, Yerevan 1989 went 13...♗e7 14 ♖xd5 exd5 15 ♖a2! ♗b7 16 ♖a7 ♖c7 17 ♗f4 ♗d6 18 ♖c1 ♖e7 19 ♖a1 with a big edge for White in view of Black's problems on the queenside.

Meanwhile, White also has 10 ♖xb3, when 10...c6 transposes to 5...b5 6 a4 c6 7 0-0 ♗b7 8 ♗e5 ♖d5 9 b3 cxb3 10 ♖xb3 a6 (Game 85 in Chapter 8), and 10...♖c6 11 ♖xc6 ♗xc6 12 e4 ♖b6 13 ♖c3 ♗b7 14 axb5 axb5 15 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 16 ♗a3 provides enough for the pawn.

10 axb5

10 e4 b4!? is an interesting piece sacrifice, trapping the b1-knight. Oil-Hoelzl, Pula 1997 continued 11 exd5 ♗xd5 12 ♖h5 g6 13 ♖h3 ♗g7?! (Sosonko suggests 13...c6!?) 14 ♖xc3! bxc3 15 ♗a3 ♖a7 16 ♖fe1 ♖b7 17 ♗xd5 ♖xd5 18 ♖h4 c6 19 ♖f4 ♗xe5 20 dxe5 c2 21 ♗d6 c5 22 ♖ac1 with the better game for White due to his influence on the dark squares.

10...axb5 11 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 12 e4 b4!?

Lputian gives 12...♗f6 13 ♖xc3 b4 14 ♖b5!? c6 (not 14...♗xe4? 15 ♗xe4 ♖xe4 16

♖f3 ♗f6 17 ♖c6 with a clear advantage to White according to E.Vladimirov) 15 d5! cxb5 16 dxe6 (E. Vladimirov-Torhallsson, Gausdal 1991) 16...♖xd1 17 exf7+ ♗e7 18 ♖xd1 when White has sacrificed a piece for two pawns but the superior development and Black's poor co-ordination provide adequate compensation.

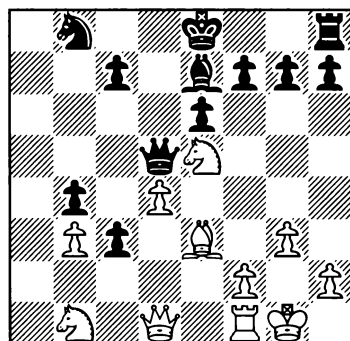
13 exd5 ♗xd5 14 ♗e3

Novikov suggests 14 ♗xd5 ♖xd5 15 ♖g4 (more active than 15 ♗e3 ♗d6 16 ♖g4 0-0 17 ♖c1 ♗xe5 18 dxe5 ♖c6!, after which Black seized the initiative in G.Kuzmin-Novikov, Kharkov 1985) 15...♖c6 16 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 as unclear. The knight is caught again and Black has strong pawns on b4 and c3, but he also has some development problems.

14...♗e7

14...♗xg2 15 ♗xg2 ♖d5+ 16 ♗g1 with play along the lines of 14 ♗xd5.

15 ♗xd5 ♖xd5



16 ♖c2

16 ♖d3 f6 17 ♖c4 0-0 favours Black. White's knight should retreat to d3.

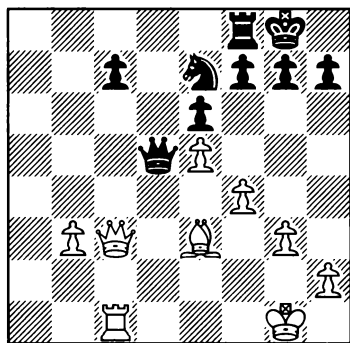
16...♗f6 17 ♖xc3

17 ♖d3 ♖c6 18 ♖f4 ♖d7! is not to be recommended for White (Rogers believes Black is clearly better). The knight is not better on f4.

17...bxc3 18 ♖xc3 ♗xe5

Or 18...c5 19 ♖c1 0-0 20 ♖xc5 ♖xb3 with equality.

19 dxe5 ♖c6 20 f4 0-0 21 ♖c1 ♗e7

**22 ♙c5**

White should be careful here. 22 ♛xc7 ♛xb3 23 ♙c5 ♘d5 24 ♛a7 and, due to his exposed king, White cannot take on f8. Black keeps his knight on the board and White's king is more insecure – Black is better.

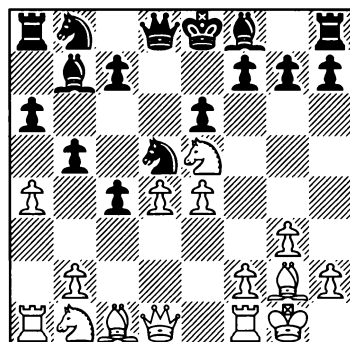
22...♙e8 23 ♙xe7 ♗xe7 24 ♛c5 ♛d8 25 ♙a1

Black gets no opportunity to exploit the enemy king position.

25...h5 26 ♙a8 ♛xa8 27 ♛xe7 ♛c6 28 ♛d8+ ♜h7 29 ♛d3+ g6 30 h4 ½-½

Game 60
Romero-Antunes
Havana 1991

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 a6 6 0-0 b5 7 ♘e5 ♘d5 8 a4 ♙b7 9 e4

**9...♘f6**

Khalifman-Ruban, USSR 1985 went 9...♘b6? 10 axb5 axb5 11 ♙xa8 ♙xa8 12 ♛h5 g6 13 ♘xg6! fxg6 14 ♛e5 with a decisive lead for White.

10 axb5 axb5 11 ♙xa8 ♙xa8 12 ♘c3 c6

White is well on top after 12...b4 13 ♛a4+ ♘bd7 14 ♘b5!, e.g. 14...♙xe4? 15 ♙xe4 ♘xe4 16 ♘c6 ♛c8 17 ♛a8! etc.

13 d5

Also possible is 13 ♙g5 ♙b7. Then a patient continuation is 14 d5 ♙e7 15 dxe6 fxe6 16 ♛e2 0-0 17 h4 ♛e8 18 h5 ♘bd7 19 ♘xd7 ♘xd7 20 ♙xe7 ♛xe7 21 e5 ♘c5 as in Smejkal-Chandler, Germany 1985, when 22 f4 would have provided compensation for the pawn. More adventurous is 14 ♘xf7? ♜xf7 15 e5 h6, with a choice for the bishop. The faulty 16 ♙h4?! was seen in Khalifman-Novikov, Lvov 1985, when Black should have continued 16...g5! 17 exf6 ♛xf6 18 ♘e4 ♛g6 19 ♛a1 ♘a6. Later, in Nesis-Block, Correspondence 1987, White sacrificed a piece for an initiative after 16 ♙xf6 gxf6 17 ♛h5+ ♜g7 18 ♙a1, the subsequent 18...f5! 19 ♘e2 ♙g8 20 ♘f4 ♛d7 21 ♙a7 ♜h8 22 ♘xe6 ♛xe6 23 ♙xb7 maintaining the dynamic balance.

Black can play the immediate 13...♙e7, when after 14 ♛a1 ♙b7 15 ♛a7 ♛c8 Flear gives 16 ♘f3 h6 17 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 18 e5 ♙e7 19 ♘d2 0-0 20 ♘xb5 cxb5 21 ♛xb7 ♙b4! as equal. Stajic-Hoelzl, Austria 1997 went 16 d5 0-0 17 dxe6 fxe6 18 ♙h3 ♘a6 19 ♙e3 ♙d6 20 ♘f3 ♙e8 21 e5 ♙b8 22 ♛d4 ♘d7 23 ♙d1 ♘f8 with chances for both sides – Black has a pawn, but White is active.

13...♙d6

Another option is 13...cxd5 14 exd5 ♙xd5 15 ♘xd5 exd5 16 ♘g4 ♙e7 17 ♘xf6+ ♙xf6 18 ♙e1+ ♜f8 19 ♙xd5 h5 20 ♛f3 g6 21 b3 ♜g7 22 bxc4 bxc4 23 ♙xc4 ♛c7 24 ♙d5 with the more harmonious force for White in Cvitan-Ekstroem, Dresden 1998. 13...♙e7 14 dxe6 fxe6 15 ♛e2 0-0 16 ♙h3 ♛c8 17 ♘f3 ♘a6 18 ♘g5 ♘c7 19 ♙f4 was the course of

Zilberstein-Novikov, Blagoveschensk 1988, 19...h6 20 ♖xc7 hxg5 21 ♙e5 offering White sufficient play, with Black's damaged pawn structure to aim at.

14 ♖g4!?

14 ♖f4 ♛c7! 15 ♛a1 is unclear, rather than 14...exd5? 15 exd5 cxd5 16 ♛a1! ♙xe5 17 ♙xe5 ♖c6 18 ♙c7! ♛xc7 19 ♛xa8+ with a big advantage to White in Ulibin-Antunes, Bayamo 1991.

14...b4

Black can avoid spoiling the queenside pawns and instead play 14...♘g4 15 ♛xg4 ♛f6 16 dxe6 fxe6 17 ♚d1 (17 ♙h3!? is an interesting option) 17...0-0 18 ♙e3 with an unclear position. White has the usual compensation in his more threatening forces.

15 ♖xf6+ gxf6

15...♛xf6 16 dxc6 ♙c7 17 ♖b5 favours White.

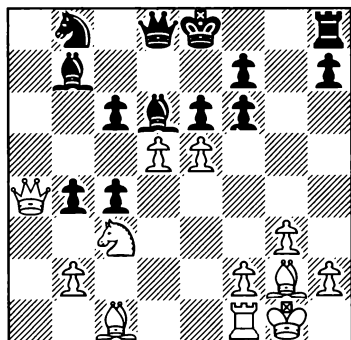
16 ♛a4

16 ♖b1 cxd5 17 exd5 ♙e7 18 dxe6 ♙xg2 19 ♙xg2 fxe6 20 ♛g4 sees White both win back the pawn and maintain the initiative.

16...♙b7?!

Preferable is 16...bxc3 17 ♛xa8 cxb2 18 ♙xb2 cxd5 19 exd5 when White can claim compensation for the pawn. In the game he is just better.

17 e5!



17...bxc3

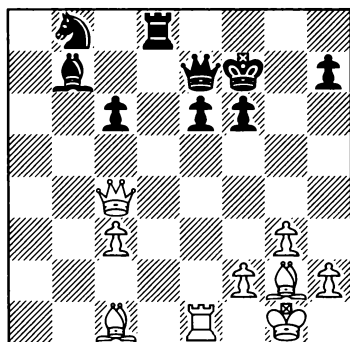
Or 17...♙xe5 18 dxc6 0-0 19 cxb7 bxc3 20 ♙h6 and the bishop pair and passed pawn

on b7 give White a clear advantage.

18 exd6

18 dxc6!? looks promising. After 18...♙xe5 19 c7+! ♛d7 20 cxb8 ♛+ ♙xb8 21 ♛xd7+ ♙xd7 22 ♙xb7 cxb2 23 ♙xb2 ♙e5 24 ♙xe5 fxe5 25 ♙a6 White is close to winning the ending.

18...♛xd6 19 dxe6 fxe6 20 bxc3 ♙f7 21 ♚d1 ♛e7 22 ♛xc4 ♚d8 23 ♙e1!

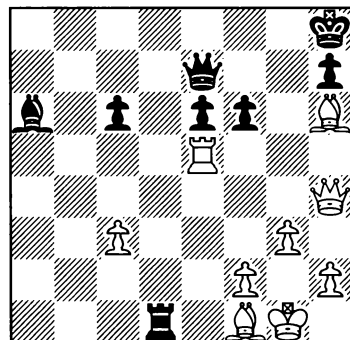


No exchange of rooks! Black's king is exposed so White makes sure to keep as many pieces as possible on the board.

23...♖d7 24 ♙e3 ♖e5?

The lesser evil here is 24...♙g7 25 ♛b4 ♛xb4 26 cxb4 with a problematic ending for Black.

25 ♛h4 ♙g7 26 ♙h6+ ♙h8 27 ♚xe5 ♚d1+ 28 ♙f1 ♙a6



29 ♚a5 ♙xf1 30 ♚a8+ ♚d8 31 ♛b4 ♛d7 32 ♛f8+! 1-0

Summary

Let us compare the two 5...a6 main lines after 6 ♘e5 and 6 0-0.

If 6 ♘e5 practice has demonstrated that after 6...c5 7 ♘a3 cxd4 8 ♘axc4 ♙a7 White has difficulties achieving an advantage.

The variation with 6 0-0 features more variations and promises much more interesting play. After 6...♘c6 White can choose between 7 e3 and 7 ♘c3 and, in the case of the former, with 7 e3 ♖d7 8 ♙e2 b5 9 ♙d1, there is no reason to write off the older continuation 9...♖d6. Certainly after 10 e4 the departure 10...♖e7?! is simply a loss of time, but the break in the centre with 10...e5 seems to be reasonable. Meanwhile, after 9...♖e7 10 ♘c3 a useful manoeuvre was seen in the game Haba-Gorin, where Black found ...♘b4-d3, exploiting the weakness of d3.

The position arising after 7 ♘c3 ♙b8 8 e4 ♖e7 9 ♙e2 b5 10 ♙d1 is critical. The impression today is that after 10...0-0 11 d5 exd5 12 e5 a sharp, open struggle occurs where White's chances are preferable. As for Black, he should be looking out for the aforementioned manoeuvre ...♘b4-d3. After 8...b5 9 ♙e2 ♘xd4 White's initiative and Black's material superiority more or less cancel each other out, while 8...b5 9 d5 ♘b4 10 b3!? seems to give White the better chances. Black should be cautious, perhaps avoiding this line altogether.

After 5...a6 6 0-0 b5 7 ♘e5 ♘d5 8 a4 ♖b7 the challenge with 9 b3 allows Black to try a very interesting piece sacrifice in 9...c3!? 10 e4 b4 or 10 axb5 axb5 11 ♙xa8 ♖xa8 12 e4 b4!?, forever leaving the knight entombed on b1. Of course White can always return the piece with ♘xc3, but it seems that he can expect little in terms of an advantage.

A kind of tabia occurs after 9 e4 ♘f6 10 axb5 axb5 11 ♙xa8 ♖xa8 12 ♘c3 c6. Previously 13 ♖g5 was often played here, but it is not clear whether the bishop belongs here. Perhaps this decision should be delayed. After 13 d5 ♖d6 14 ♘g4!? White has a strong initiative, and although this is not cut and dried, Black should probably resort to 13...♖e7, after which a degree of accuracy is required to hold the balance.

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 a6 6 0-0

6 a4: 6...c5 – *Game 46*; 6...♘c6 7 0-0 ♙b8 – 6 0-0

6 ♘e5

6...♖b4+ – *Game 47*

6...c5 (D)

7 ♖e3 – *Game 48*

7 ♘a3: 7...♙xd4 – *Game 49*; 7...cxd4 – *Game 50*

6...♘c6

6...b5 7 ♘e5

7...c6 – *Game 57*

7...♘d5

8 ♘c3 – *Game 58*

8 a4 ♖b7 (D)

9 e4 – *Game 60*

9 b3: 9...c3 – *Game 59*; 9...cxb3 10 ♙xb3 c6 – *Game 85* (Chapter 8)

7 ♘c3

7 a4 – *Game 51*

7 e3 ♖d7: 8 ♘c3 – *Game 52*; 8 ♙c2 – *Game 53*

7...♙b8 8 e4

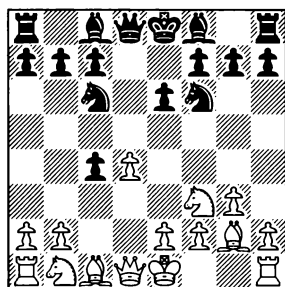
8...♖e7 – *Game 54*

8...b5 (D)

9 ♙e2 – *Game 55*; 9 d5 – *Game 56*

CHAPTER SIX

4...dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♘c6



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♘c6

5...♘c6 is a modern treatment of the Catalan Opening, becoming popular in the 1980s. There is considerable reasoning behind this development. The Catalan arises mainly from the Orthodox Defence of the Queen's Gambit Declined and from the neo-classical Nimzo Indian Defence. In the Queen's Gambit the move ...♘c6 occurs very rarely at higher levels as it obstructs the c-pawn and therefore hinders the freeing advance ...c7-c5 as well as the often helpful support of d5 offered by ...c7-c6. (Only in the 1990s did the Chigorin Defence establish itself as a serious defence for Black, due to the creative input from Grandmaster Alexander Morozevich).

However, in the Catalan ...♘c6 supports the thrust ...e6-e5, an alternative to ...c7-c5 in the fight for space in the centre. Additionally the knight attacks the d4-pawn, for which the natural defence is e2-e3, which causes a slight weakening of White's light squares. Finally, the knight is prepared to go to a5 and defend the c4-pawn and, if the occasion presents itself, begin an offensive with ...♘b4.

In reply to 5...♘c6 White usually plays either 6 0-0 or 6 ♖a4. After 6 0-0 ♖b8 with the follow-up ...b7-b5 the lines are very similar to those of Chapter 8. Moreover, ...a7-a6

often transposes to the line 5...a6 6 0-0 ♘c6 (Chapter 5) and these two chapters are suitable for a parallel study in connection with this set-up. Here we shall treat only those cases where Black manages without an early ...a7-a6.

White has several continuations at his disposal after 6 0-0 ♖b8, although these options are not of equal value. The aggressive 7 ♘e5 is not dangerous here, for after 7...♘xe5 8 dxe5 ♖xd1 9 ♖xd1 ♘d5! the game is simplified at White's cost. 7 ♖g5 enjoys little popularity as White can wait for this posting. Much more popular is 7 e3 (Game 61). White defends the d4-pawn with the intention of following up with ♘d2xc4, but with the knight going to d2 his control over the centre is reduced and Black will find it easier to execute ...e6-e5, often with the assistance of 7...♗d6. But here it is perhaps even better to simply protect the c4-pawn with 7...b5, which offers sufficient counter-chances.

7 a4 (Game 62), the most natural way to prevent ...b7-b5, weakens both b3 and b4. Then 7...a6 is considered in Game 51 in Chapter 5 (after the move order 5...a6 6 0-0 ♘c6 7 a4 ♖b8), and 7...♗b4 and 7...♘a5 are quite reasonable, but perhaps the most exact is the simple 7...b6, when Black appears to have an edge.

White's most popular selection is 7 ♜c3. If Black prefers not to transpose to 5...a6 with 7...a6 he can choose between 7...♗b4 (Games 63 & 64) and 7...b5 (Games 65 & 66). 7...♗b4 prevents White's planned expansion with e2-e4 and simultaneously prepares kingside castling. Here (unexpectedly) a transposition to the Nimzo-Indian Defence is possible, e.g. 1 d4 ♟f6 2 c4 e6 3 ♜c3 ♗b4 4 g3 d5 5 ♖g2 0-0 6 ♟f3 dc4 7 0-0 ♜c6 8 e3 ♝b8.

All things considered, the logical follow-up to playing 6...♝b8 must be the consistent 7...b5. Subsequently, in the case of the natural 8 e4 Black has won a tempo compared to the lines with 5...a6, and as a bonus the a6-square remains vacant for the bishop. Not surprisingly the battlefield of the variation starting with 5...♜c6 6 0-0 has not been after 8 e4 (which still earned a place in Game 65) in recent years, but rather the more ambitious 8 ♜e5!? (Game 66).

With 6 ♖a4 White attacks the c4-pawn at once and generates pressure on the a4-e8 diagonal, but Black will also be able to use the early development of the queen to create counterplay. Black has tried many moves in practice – 6...♗d7 (Game 67), 6...♜d7 (Games 68 & 69) and 6...♗d6 (Game 70) – but 6...♗b4+ (Games 71-75) is seen most often.

The position after 6...♗d7 7 ♖xc4 can also arise after 5 ♖a4+ ♗d7 6 ♖xc4 ♜c6 7 ♟f3. Black concentrates mainly on queenside development, so 7...♗d6?! (aimed at ...e6-e5) is insufficient and does not promise equality. More common is 7...♜a5, which at once attacks the queen and prepares the advance of the c-pawn. Now 8 ♖c2 is not the strongest because after 8...♝c8 and ...c7-c5 the queen feels the pressure down the c-file. The main line is 6...♗d7 7 ♖xc4 ♜a5 8 ♖d3 c5. The eccentric manoeuvre ...♜d7-b6 (as seen in Games 68 & 69) does not impress, the knight being no better on b6 than it was on f6. Nevertheless, 6...♜d7 7 ♖xc4 ♜b6 has

become popular in Grandmaster practice. Black gets rid of the irritating pin and frees his position with the help of ...e6-e5. Let us consider the situation after 8 ♖d3 e5 (8...♜b4, with further selection between ...e6-e5 and ...c7-c5, is seen less often). The continuations 9 dxe5 and 9 0-0 are both harmless, but Alexander Raetsky's 9 ♗e3, consolidating the d4-pawn, introduces interesting challenges. Notice that it is not clear whether White profits from the inclusion of 9 ♗g5 f6 and then 10 ♗e3. Furthermore, it is reasonable for Black to play 9...♗e7. Nevertheless the continuation we see most often is 9 ♜xe5 ♜b4, when White has tried 10 ♖d1, 10 ♖b3 (so that after 10...♗e6 11 ♖d1 the b7-pawn has been weakened – an idea meant to discourage 11...♖xd4) and 10 ♖c3, which often leads to the exchange of queens after 10...♖xd4 11 0-0 ♖xc3 12 ♜xc3.

The main reply to 6 ♖a4 is 6...♗b4+. Black prevents ♖xc4 and after 7 ♗d2 ♜d5 (7...♗xd2?! 8 ♜bxd2 gives White a stable Catalan advantage after winning back the c4-pawn) takes the game into wild complications. Since 1998 7...♗d6 has been seen in tournament play (including super-GM events). Black switches strategies and plays for the realisation of ...e6-e5, providing the Catalan prisoner on c8 with some air. This variation should, of course, be compared to the line with an immediate ...♗d6. 6...♗d6 (Game 64) is seen much less frequently. Here White has the manoeuvre ♜b1-d2xc4, and after 7 0-0 0-0 there is 8 ♝d1, which can hinder ...e6-e5.

After 6...♗b4+ 7 ♗d2 ♗d6 White has several possible continuations, the main feature being whether or not to allow ...e6-e5. If he wishes to take the prophylactic approach, then after 8 ♗c3 and 8 ♜e5 tactics will dominate. But after 8 ♖xc4 e5 and 8 0-0 0-0 9 ♖xc4 e5 the game goes down a strategic path, and one that has clear reference points.

Although subtle, the bishop manoeuvre has not been able to take its place as the main

continuation, which is still 6 ♖a4 ♙b4+ 7 ♙d2 ♘d5. Here, apart from 8 ♙xb4, White occasionally essays a strange queen manoeuvre with 8 ♖b5 in order to collect the c4-pawn. Black can keep the extra pawn by an almost forced sequence: 8...♙xd2 9 ♘bxd2 c3 10 bxc3 ♘xc3 11 ♖d3 ♙d5 12 0-0 0-0 when, after having lost a pawn, White relies on his completed development with e2-e4, establishing a strong pawn centre, when Black should try to avoid weaknesses and, with accurate manoeuvring, endeavour to hang on to the pawn by sitting out White's initiative. To play such a position as Black can be rather unpleasant, especially for those players whose style is on the aggressive side. Instead of 8...♙xd2 9 ♘bxd2 c3 Black often prefers 8...♙e7 or 8...0-0 (Game 72).

The main position of the 6 ♖a4 complex arises after 6...♙b4 7 ♙d2 ♘d5 8 ♙xb4 ♘xb4. The fascinating complications that develop here have been tested for more than half a century (since Aisenstadt-Taimanov, Leningrad 1949, in fact). 9 a3 (Game 73) leads to fireworks after 9...b5 10 ♖xb5 ♘c2, when Black picks up the rook but loses the c6-knight and, subsequently, the cornered knight. However, the conventional 'advantage' of having two knights against a rook is nullified by the unhappy lot of White's king, which is stripped of the right to castle. The practical results at the end of the last century were so poor for White that the authors of this book produced an article in *Chess in Russia* in 1997 that was dedicated exclusively to 9 a3 and went under the title 'The Dying Continuation'. Then in 2001 in Wijk aan Zee Kasparov himself played it! The truth was that he was content with a draw in that game, but of course 9 a3 took a step forward in its development.

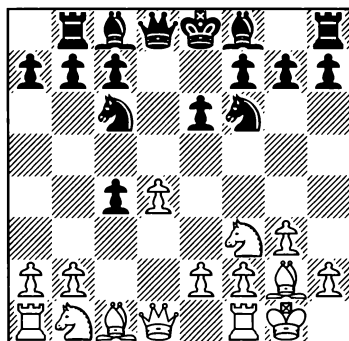
9 ♘e5 (Game 74), which immediately exploits the pin on the a4-e8 diagonal, has not received widespread attention. The reason is obvious – Black does not have any problems here. However, simple development of the

kingside with 9 0-0 (Game 75) does pose problems for Black. The games played from this position have often continued 9...♖b8 10 ♘c3 a6 11 ♘e5 0-0 12 ♙xc6 ♘xc6 13 ♘xc6 ♙xc6 14 ♖xc4 ♖xb2 15 ♖ab1 ♖b6 16 ♖c5, which is an important tabia for the evaluation of the whole variation. For Black, despite the extra pawn, it is necessary to fight for equality. White has more space and the knight is obviously stronger than the bishop on c8. Black is in the unenviable situation of having to defend with some precision, and it is no wonder that in recent practice Black has avoided this critical position.

White plays 6 0-0

Game 61 Rustemov-Sax Germany 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♘c6 6 0-0 ♖b8



7 e3

A major alternative is 7 ♙g5 ♙e7 8 e3 0-0 9 ♘fd2 (9 ♘bd2 b5 and Black holds on to the pawn) 9...e5! 10 ♙xf6 (10 ♙xc6 bxc6 11 dxe5 ♘g4 12 ♙xe7 ♖xe7 13 ♘xc4 ♘xe5 and White's weak squares leave him worse) 10...♙xf6 11 d5 e4!, which was the course of D.Gurevich-Adams, Biel 1993. There followed 12 ♘xc4 b5 13 ♘c3 bxc4 14 dxc6 ♖xb2 15 ♖c1 ♖b8, when Black had the

bishop pair and White's pieces lacked co-ordination. Adams offers 12 ♖c1 ♜xd5 13 ♜xe4 ♖e5, when White regains the pawn and mass exchanges will follow, leading to a level middlegame.

7...b5

7...♙d6 8 ♜fd2 e5!? is interesting. Then after 9 ♙xc6+ bxc6 10 dxe5 ♙xe5 11 ♜xc4 ♙d6 12 ♖c2 the vital light-squared bishop leaves the arena but White has play against Black's damaged queenside. Kozul-Plachetka, Charleville 2000 took a much different course – after 9 d5 ♜e7 10 ♜xc4 0-0 11 e4 ♙d7 12 a4 ♜g6 13 ♜xd6 cxd6 14 ♜a3 ♜e8 15 ♙e3 b6 16 ♖b3 White stood better in this King's Indian structure, with the bishop pair and easy play on the queenside. Note that Black's counterplay on the kingside seems rather slow.

8 b3

8 a4 a6 9 axb5 axb5 10 b3 cxb3 11 ♜bd2 ♙e7 12 ♜xb3 0-0 13 ♙a3 ♙xa3 14 ♜xa3 ♖d6 15 ♖a1! b4 16 ♜a2 ♜e4! 17 ♜fd2 ♜xd2 18 ♜xd2 ♜e7 was instructive in Steckner-Ionov, Dortmund 1991. Again White is happy to play a pawn down, with pressure on the c-file and control of the key c5-square. Black, typically, is not without chances of his own.

8 ♖e2 ♙e7 9 ♜d1 0-0 10 e4 ♙b7 11 ♜c3 b4 12 d5 exd5 13 ♜xd5 ♜xd5 14 ♜xd5!? ♙d6 15 ♖xc4 is interesting, while Kachiani Gersinska-Rabiega, Germany 1995 continued 14 exd5 ♜a5 15 ♙e3 ♙f6 16 ♙xa7 ♜e8 17 ♖c2 ♜a8 18 ♙d4 ♙xd4 19 ♜xd4 ♖f6 20 ♜c6 ♜xc6 21 dxc6 ♙a6, Black's pieces taking up influential posts.

8...cxb3 9 axb3 a6 10 ♖e2 ♙e7 11 ♜d1 0-0 12 ♙b2 ♜b4 13 ♜bd2

White played the immediate 13 e4 in Tratar-Tukmakov, Bled 1996, which continued 13...♙b7 14 ♜c3 ♖e8 15 ♜ac1 ♜d8 16 ♖e3 (16 e5 ♜fd5 17 ♜e4 and White controls the c5-square and therefore has full compensation for the pawn) 16...h6 17 h4 ♜g4 18 ♖f4 f5 19 exf5 exf5 (19...♙xf5!?

leads to exchanges and a level endgame after 20 ♖xg4 h5 21 ♖h3 ♙xf3 22 ♙xf3 ♜xf3 23 ♖xe6+ ♖f7) 20 ♖xc7 ♜d7 21 ♖b6 ♙f6 22 ♖a5 ♖a8 with a complex struggle ahead.

13...♙b7 14 e4 c5 15 e5 ♜fd5

Another option is to protect c5 and instead put the bishop on d5, 15...♜d7!? 16 ♜e4 ♙d5 giving chances for both sides.

16 dxc5 ♙xc5 17 ♜e4 ♙e7

More straightforward is 17...♜c8 18 ♜xc5 ♜xc5 19 ♜ac1 ♜xc1 20 ♜xc1 with compensation, although it makes a lot of sense to keep the dark-squared bishop.

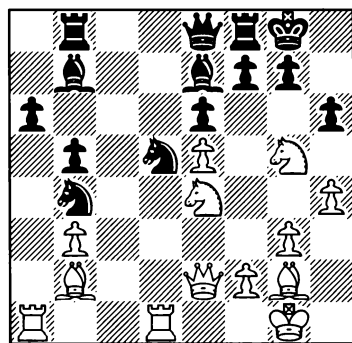
18 h4!? ♖e8?

Better and more natural is 18...♜c8 19 ♜e1 ♖b6 20 ♖g4 ♜fd8 21 ♜d2 with compensation.

19 ♜fg5

19 ♜d6 ♙xd6 20 exd6 ♖d7 21 ♜g5 is another means of attack.

19...h6



20 ♖g4!! f5

20...hxg5 21 hxg5 ♖c6 (21...g6 22 ♜f6+ ♙xf6 23 gxf6 ♜c2 24 ♖h4 and Black is about to be mated) 22 ♜ac1 (22 ♜f6+? ♜xf6 leaves Black a piece up) 22...♖b6 23 ♜f6+ ♙xf6 24 gxf6 g6 25 ♖g5 and (again) the weak dark squares around Black's king will prove decisive. Nor does 20...♖c6 21 ♜ac1 ♖b6 22 ♜f6+ ♙xf6 23 exf6 g6 24 ♙d4 help Black – a knight sacrifice on e6 is coming next.

21 exf6 ♜xf6 22 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 23 ♜xf6+

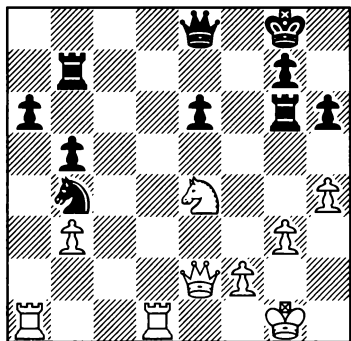
xf6 24 xxb7 xxb7

24...hgx5 25 hgx5 f8 26 g6 wins for White.

25 e4

Or 25 e4 hgx5 26 xxb7 gxh4 27 e4 with a huge advantage.

25...g6 26 e2



The party is almost over for Black.

26...c7 27 h5 c2 28 f3 1-0

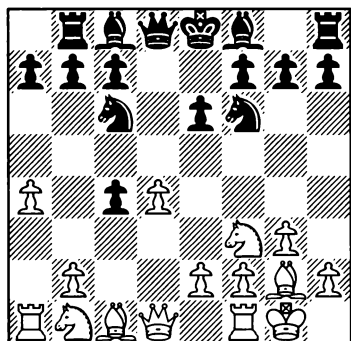
The rook is trapped.

Game 62

Sandner-Luther

Bad Zwesten 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 f3 f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 e2 c6 6 0-0 b8 7 a4



7...b6

7...a6 transposes to 5...a6 6 0-0 c6 7 a4 b8 (Game 51 in Chapter 5). After 7...b4

the modest 8 e3 is too slow: 8...a5 9 d2 e7 10 a3 e4 11 xxb4 xb4 12 e1 xe1 13 fxe1 d6 and Black holds on to the pawn. Maslov-S.Ivanov, St. Petersburg 1992 saw the more fluid 8 c2 xd4 9 xd4 xd4 10 e3 d6 11 xc4 0-0 12 c3 e7 13 xa7 a8 14 d4 a5, and now 15 xf6 gxf6 16 fdl secures White an edge in view of his superior pawns and development.

7...a5 looks promising. Then 8 b2 c5 9 dxc5 xc5 10 c2 c7 11 e4 e5 12 xe5? soon led to disaster for White in Gorodilov-Raetsky, Vladimir 1987 (although Black was already slightly better) after 12...xe5 13 xc4 xc4 14 f4 h5 15 xb8 g4 16 h3 ge3! etc. Instead the continuation 10 e5 c3 11 bxc3 0-0 12 c2 b6 steers the game to equality after 13 b3 xb3 14 xb3 b7 15 c6 xc6 16 xc6 c7, when White has the bishop pair but weak pawns on the queenside. Black also has 12...c7 here, Chashev-Raetsky, Makhachkala 1987 producing another equal position after the subsequent 13 d3 d6 14 c4 e5 15 c5 b6 16 a3 bxc5 17 xc5 b7 18 fc1 xg2 19 xg2 fc8. The possession of the c5-square is not so relevant here.

8 a3

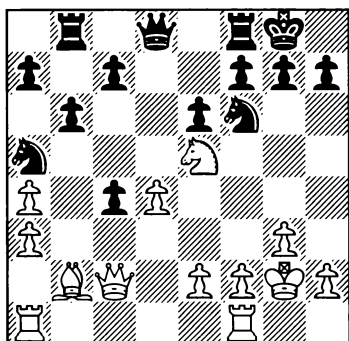
Again White can try 8 e3, and again it seems a bit slow. Alburtt-I.Ivanov, Long Beach 1989 is a good example: 8...b7 9 b2 a5 10 c2 d5!? 11 e5 (11 xc4? b4 12 c3 xc4 13 xc4 a6 and Black is winning) 11...b4 12 d1? (White has to be satisfied with a repetition with 12 c3 d5) 12...xg2 13 xg2 d5+ 14 f3 f5! (closely monitoring e4) 15 e4? xd4 16 h5+ g6 17 xg6 hgx6 18 xg6+ d7 19 f3 xc4 20 e1 d5 21 f7+ e7 22 g5 be8 23 e5 c6 24 ae1 hf8 25 h7 d3 and Black won. White's attack was simply too optimistic.

8...xa3 9 bxa3

Preferable to 9 xa3 b7 10 e1?! (10 c2 xd4 11 xc4 offers White some

compensation for the pawn) 10...♗e4 11 ♖e3 f5 12 b3 cxb3 13 ♖xb3 0-0 14 ♗d3 ♖f7 15 ♖b1 ♗d7, when Black was in control of the light squares in the centre in Chetverik-Siklosi, Kecskemet 1995.

9...♖b7 10 ♖b2 0-0 11 ♖c2 ♖a5 12 ♖e5 ♖xg2 13 ♖xg2



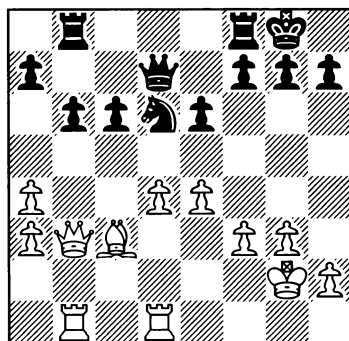
13...♖e8

The direct approach 13...c5!? 14 dxc5 ♗d5+ 15 ♖g1 ♗xc5 gives Black more breathing space and better chances due to the extra pawn.

14 e4 ♖d6 15 ♖c3 ♖b3

Also possible is the more forcing 15...f6 16 ♖xa5 fxe5 17 dxe5 bxa5 18 exd6 cxd6 19 ♗xc4 with chances for both sides.

16 ♖ab1 ♗e8 17 ♖xc4 ♖xc4 18 ♗xb3 ♖d6 19 f3 ♗d7 20 ♖fd1 c6



White has the superior minor piece and more space, but Black is solid.

21 ♖bc1 ♖fd8 22 ♖b4 ♖e8 23 ♖d2 ♖bc8 24 a5 b5 25 ♖g5 f6 26 ♖e3 ♖d6 27 a6 ♖c4 28 a4 f5 29 axb5 cxb5 30 exf5 exf5 31 ♖f4

Black has secured himself an outpost on c4, while White has a passed pawn in the centre.

31...♗d5 32 ♖b1 ♖e8 33 ♖e1 ♖xe1 34 ♖xe1 h6?!

34...♖b6 35 ♖b1 b4 36 ♖d6 ♗xb3 37 ♖xb3 ♖d5 is equal.

35 ♖e5

35 ♖e7!? is interesting.

35...♗xd4 36 ♖xb5 ♖h7 37 ♗b1 ♖c5 38 ♖xc5 ♗xc5 39 g4 ♖g6 40 ♗xf5+ ♗xf5 41 gxf5+ ♖xf5 42 ♖g3

42 ♖b8 ♖e3+ 43 ♖g3 ♖d5 44 ♖xa7 ♖c7 45 ♖d4 ♖xa6 46 ♖xg7 ♖g6 presents White with more chances to play for a win, although a draw is the most likely result.

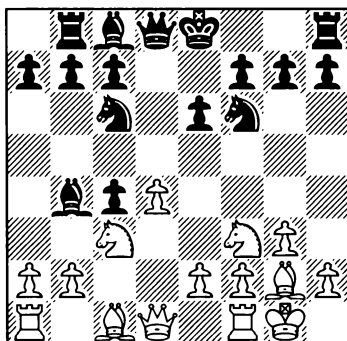
42...♖e5 43 ♖e3 ½-½

Game 63

Ricardi-Smyslov

Buenos Aires 1990

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♖c6 6 0-0 ♖b8 7 ♖c3 ♖b4



8 e3

Three other important continuations have been tried here. 8 ♖e5 simplifies too much: 8...♖xe5 9 dxe5 ♗xd1 10 ♖xd1 ♖xc3 11 bxc3 ♖d5 with equal chances. 8 ♖e1 ♖d5 9

♖c2 ♕e7 10 a3 ♜a5 11 ♚b1 0-0 12 e4 is a bit more ambitious, White turning his attention to the centre after some preparatory work. However, Black is ready to meet this expansion, e.g. 12...♜xc3 13 ♖xc3 b6 14 ♕f4 ♕d6 15 ♕g5, Poluljahov-Raetsky, Simferopol 1989 with equality after 15...♕e7. If Black is not satisfied with a draw, then 14...♕b7!? is an interesting alternative here.

Moiseenko-C.Horvath, Pula 1999 continued 8 ♕g5 0-0 9 ♚c1 h6 10 ♕xf6 ♖xf6 11 ♜e4 ♖f5 12 ♜ed2 ♖a5 13 a3 ♕xd2 14 ♜xd2 ♖b6 15 ♕xc6 ♖xc6 16 ♚xc4 ♖d6 17 ♖c2 b6 18 ♚xc7 ♕b7 19 ♜f3 ♕xf3 20 exf3 ♖xd4 21 ♚d1 ♖f6 22 ♕g2, when White's activity (rook on the seventh rank) is enough for the better game. Black has a possible improvement in 17...♕d7!?, which has the advantage of not committing the queenside structure.

8...0-0 ♖e2

9 ♖c2 is another reasonable move, when 9...b5 10 ♜d1 ♖e8 11 e4 e5 12 dxe5 ♜xe5 13 ♜xe5 ♖xe5 was the course of Bezold-Romanishin, Balatonbereny 1995. After 14 ♕f4 ♖e7 15 e5 ♕xc3 16 ♖xc3 the bishop pair and activity provide compensation.

9...b5 10 a4 a6 11 axb5 axb5 12 ♚d1

White controls the a-file.

12...♜a5

As in other lines after a2-a4, the b3-square has become a target.

13 ♜e5 ♕b7 14 ♕xb7 ♚xb7 15 e4

15 ♖f3 ♜d5 16 ♕d2 ♕xc3 17 ♕xc3 ♜xc3 18 ♚xa5 leads to complicated play where White shouldn't be worse.

15...♖e8 16 ♕g5 ♜d7 17 ♖g4 ♕h8

17...f5!? deserves attention.

18 ♜xd7 ♖xd7 19 ♕f6!?

Tough play! 19 d5 ♜b3 20 ♚a6 ♖c8 21 dxe6 c6 is complex, although Black still has an extra pawn.

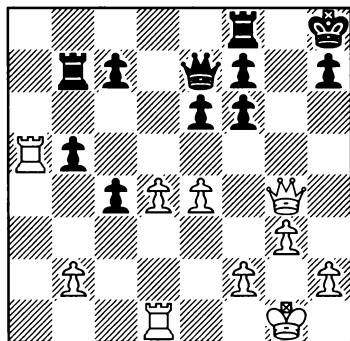
19...gxf6 20 ♜d5 ♕e7

20...♜b3? loses after 21 ♜xf6 ♖d8 22 ♖h4 ♕g7 23 ♖g5+ ♕h8 24 ♖h6 etc.

21 ♜xe7 ♖xe7

21...♜b3!? should be considered, e.g. 22 ♜d5! f5 (22...♖d8 sees a forced draw after 23 ♖h4! exd5 24 ♚a8! ♖d6 25 ♚xf8+ ♖xf8 26 ♖xf6+ 23 ♖h4 (23 ♜f6?! fxg4 24 ♜xd7 ♜xa1 25 ♜xf8 ♜c2 and the extra pawn begins to tell) 23...f6 24 ♜f4 with a struggle ahead in view of Black's exposed king.

22 ♚xa5

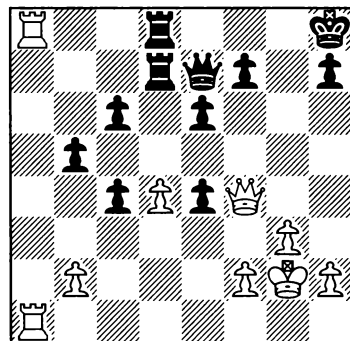


In this major piece ending White has compensation for the pawn in his active forces and the a-file, while Black also has vulnerable pawns.

22...♚d8 23 ♖h5 c6 24 ♚a6 ♚c7 25 ♕g2 ♚cc8 26 ♖h4 ♚d7 27 ♚da1 f5 28 ♖f4 fxe4

28...♖f6 29 ♚a8 ♚cd8 30 e5 ♖e7 31 ♖h6 demonstrates White's potential.

29 ♚a8 ♚cd8



30 ♖xe4?

White can force a draw with 30 ♚a1!

♙xa7 31 ♙xa7 ♜xa7 32 ♜f6+.

30...♜d6

Bringing the queen into play with advantage.

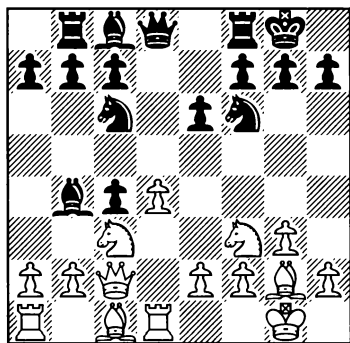
31 ♜f3 ♜d5! 32 ♙xd8+ ♙xd8 33 ♙a7 ♜g8! 34 ♙xf7 ♜xf3+ 35 ♙xf3 ♙xd4

Converting this rook endgame should be fairly automatic for a virtuoso such as Smyslov.

36 ♙f6 ♙e4 37 ♜f1 ♜g7 38 ♙f3 b4 0-1

Game 64
Gleizerov-Raetsky
Riazan 1991

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♜c6 6 0-0 ♙b8 7 ♜c3 ♙b4 8 ♜c2 0-0 9 ♙d1



9...♜e7

In the event of 9...♖e7 10 e4 b5 11 ♜e2 ♙e8 12 ♖e3 ♖d7 the course of Summermatter-Sosonko, San Bernardino 1991 is not to be recommended for White because after 13 ♜g5?! e5 14 dxe5 ♜xe5 15 ♖xa7 ♙a8 16 ♙d4 ♜d3 White had won back the pawn but the outpost on d3 gave Black the advantage. After 13 ♜e5!? b4 14 ♜a4 ♜a5 15 ♜c5, on the other hand, White is very active.

Also possible is 9...b5 10 d5!? exd5 11 ♜xd5 h6 as in Sorokin-Kacheishvili, New York 1999, when 12 ♜e5!? ♜xe5 13 ♜xb4 ♜e7 14 ♖f4 would leave White well developed and ready for action, although Black is

not without chances.

10 e4

Another option is 10 ♖g5 h6 11 ♖xf6 ♜xf6 12 ♜e4 ♜f5 13 ♜h4 ♜b5 14 ♙ac1 with fluid development for White.

10...♖xc3

Black might consider 10...e5!? 11 dxe5 ♜xe5 12 ♜xe5 ♜xe5 13 ♖f4 ♜e7 14 ♜b5 ♖g4 with unclear play.

11 bxc3 e5

11...b5 12 e5 ♜d5 13 ♜g5 f5 14 exf6 gxf6 15 ♜e4 is quite typical, Black's weakened pawns and the inviting c5-square affording White compensation.

12 d5!

White wins the exchange.

12...♜a5 13 ♜a4

Yusupov gives 13 ♜xe5!? ♜xe5 14 ♖f4 ♜e7 15 d6 ♜e6 16 dxc7 ♙a8 17 ♖d6 ♙e8 18 e5 ♜g4 with an assessment of unclear – White has only one pawn for the piece but Black lacks co-ordination and is behind in development.

13...b6 14 ♖a3 ♜e8 15 ♜c2 ♖g4

15...♖d7 16 ♙e1 c5 17 dxc6 ♖xc6 18 ♖xf8 ♜xf8 favours White, for whom the d-file will be a more significant factor than Black's extra pawn on the queenside (as compensation for the exchange).

15...♜b7 16 ♖xf8 ♜xf8 17 ♜d2 ♜d6 18 ♙ab1 and now Yusupov-Agdestein, Belgrade 1989 saw 18...♖d7?! 19 ♙e1 ♖a4 20 ♜c1 ♜g8 21 ♖f1, when White won the pawn back with interest. The bishop is needed on a6. An improvement is 18...♜d7!?, e.g. 19 ♖f1 ♖a6 20 ♙b4 ♜c5 and White collects the pawn but the closed flavour of the position leaves the situation unclear, or 19 ♙a4 ♜c5 20 ♜xa7 ♖b7 21 ♙a3 ♙a8 22 ♙b2 ♙a4, again returning the pawn but at the cost of sufficient time to permit Black activity (the closed structure and Black's pressure on the a-file offer adequate compensation for the exchange).

16 ♖xf8 ♜xf8

16...♜xf8 17 ♜xe5 ♖xd1 18 ♙xd1 (White

invests his exchange to achieve a superior position – the centre, dominating bishop and superior piece placement) 16...♙xf3! 17 ♙xf3 ♖xf8 18 ♙e2 is given by Gleizerov. Black transfers his f6-knight to d6 but, despite the closed position, White's prospects are slightly preferable.

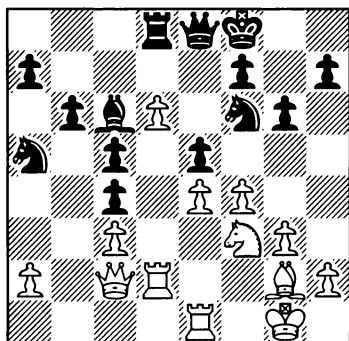
17 d6 c5?!

More promising is 17...cxd6 18 ♖xd6 ♖b7 19 ♖d2 ♙xf3 (19...♙c5 20 ♖e1 ♙d7 21 f3 is an edge for White) 20 ♙xf3 ♖c5. Again the d-file is open, but this time Black is quite active. The subsequent 21 ♙g2 ♖d3 22 ♙f1 ♖xe4 23 ♙xd3 ♖xd2 24 ♙e2 ♖d8 25 ♖d1 ♖d7 26 ♖xh7 f6 leads to complex play.

18 ♖d2 ♖d8 19 ♖h4 g6 20 f4! ♙d7 21 ♙e1 ♙c6

21...exf4 22 gx4 ♖h5 23 ♖f2 ♖e6 24 f5 ♖xd6 25 fxg6 hxg6 26 e5 and White has succeeded in opening up the position with a dangerous initiative.

22 ♖f3



22...♖d7

22...exf4 23 e5 ♖d5 24 ♖c1 puts h6 in White's sights and is awkward for Black.

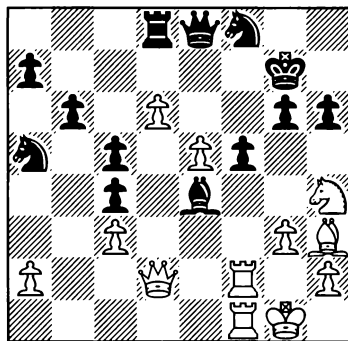
23 ♙h3 f6 24 ♖f2 ♙g7 25 ♖d2 h6

Black has no time to return the knight to the fold: 25...♖b7 26 ♙xd7 ♖xd7 27 fxe5 fxe5 28 ♖g5 with a superior position for White.

26 ♖h4 ♖f8 27 ♖ef1!

White is now ready to change gear... the knight is still on a5!

27...♙xe4 28 fxe5 f5



29 ♙xf5!

White crashes through!

29...gxf5 30 ♖xf5+ ♙xf5 31 ♖xf5 ♖c6

No better is 31...♖e6 32 ♖f7! ♖xf7 33 ♖xf7+ ♖xf7 34 ♖xh6 and White is winning.

32 ♖xf8 1-0

Game 65

Yevseev-Goldin

St. Petersburg 1998

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♖c6 6 0-0 ♖b8 7 ♖c3 b5 8 e4

8 ♖g5 ♖b4 (8...♙d7 9 d5! exd5 10 ♙xd5 ♖e5 11 ♙f4 is dangerous for Black) 9 a4 a6 10 axb5 axb5 11 e4 h6 12 e5 ♖f5 13 ♖ge4 ♙e7 14 ♖g4 g6 was seen in Ulibin-Krasenkow, Las Palmas 1993. White's compensation consists of control of key dark squares – such as c5 – and better development.

8...b4

The quiet 8...♙e7 has proved a good alternative. Then 9 d5 seemed too early in Yevseev-Brodsky, Nizhniy Novgorod 1998, which continued 9...exd5 10 exd5 ♖b4 11 ♖d4 ♙g4 12 ♖d2 ♙d7 13 b3 0-0 14 a4 a6 15 axb5 axb5 16 bxc4 bxc4, when Black had doubled c-pawns but a useful outpost on d3. Nor was White in a healthy state in Ulibin-Kogan, Cappelle la Grande 1995: 9 ♖e2 b4 ♖...♖xd4 10 ♖xd4 ♖xd4 11 ♙e3 ♖d3 12

♙xd3 cxd3 13 e5 ♘d5 14 ♘d5 exd5 15 ♙xd5 and both a7 and d3 are easy to attack) 10 ♘a4 ♙a6 11 e5 ♘d5 12 ♙e4 c3 and Black seized the initiative.

9 ♘e2 ♙b6

9...♘xe4?! runs into 10 ♘d2 f5 11 ♘xe4 fxe4 12 ♙xe4 ♙b7, when Black has many weaknesses and White steers the game to his advantage after 13 ♙e3 ♙d6 14 ♙c2.

10 d5!?

The alternative is 10 e5 ♘d5 11 ♙g5 ♙e7 12 ♙xe7 ♙xe7 13 ♘d2 ♙a6. Before White gets his knight to the desired e4-square Black completes development with this active bishop move, threatening a timely ...c4-c3. Black is slightly better.

10...exd5 11 exd5 ♙xd5

The recapture with the knight is risky: 11...♘d5 12 ♘f4 (12 ♙e1!) 12...♘xf4 13 ♙xf4 ♙d6 14 ♙e1+ ♙e6 15 ♙e3 and the initiative is in White's hands.

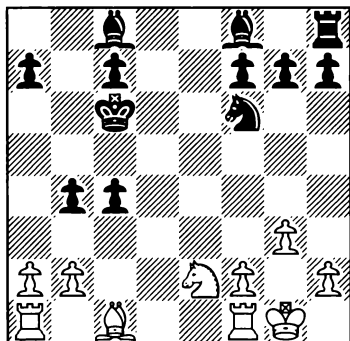
12 ♘fd4 ♙d7 13 ♘xc6 ♙xc6 14 ♙xd7+

The alternative is to keep the queens on the board, 14 ♙xc6! ♙xc6 15 ♘d4 offering White a pull.

14...♙xd7

The king is well placed on c6, making the text preferable to 14...♙xd7 15 ♙xc6 ♙xc6 16 ♙f4 ♙c5 17 ♙ac1 ♙b5 18 ♙e5, which is difficult for Black.

15 ♙xc6+ ♙xc6



Black has clear compensation in the form of his active king, the bishop pair and two

pawns for the exchange. Nevertheless a degree of caution is called for here as White enjoys better development.

16 ♙e3 ♙c5 17 b3

The less radical 17 ♙ac1 ♙xe3 18 fxe3 ♙a6 19 ♘d4+ ♙b6 is probably better, although Black should be okay.

17...♘d5

17...♙h3!? 18 ♙fc1 ♙xe3 19 fxe3 c3 20 a3 a5 21 axb4 axb4 seems like a good line for Black.

18 ♙xc5 ♙xc5 19 bxc4 ♘c3 20 ♘xc3 bxc3 21 ♙ac1 ♙xc4 22 ♙fe1 ♙d8 23 ♙e7 ♙d7

The more ambitious 23...c5!? 24 ♙xf7 g5 25 ♙xa7 ♙f5 is worth a try.

24 ♙e8 ♙b7 25 ♙e3 ♙d3 26 ♙e7

White has infiltrated on the seventh rank but the c3-pawn is very dangerous.

26...♙d5 27 ♙xc7+ ♙d4 28 a4

28 ♙xa7? c2! and White can do nothing about ...♙d1.

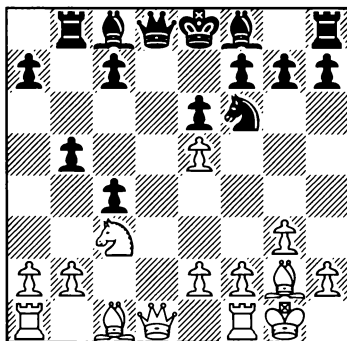
28...a5 29 ♙f1 ♙b3 30 ♙d7+ ♙c4 31 ♙c7+ ♙d4 32 ♙d7+ ♙c4 33 ♙c7+ ½-½

Game 66

Raetsky-Kelecevic

Silvaplana 1997

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♖c6 6 0-0 ♙b8 7 ♘c3 b5 8 ♘e5 ♘xe5 9 dxe5



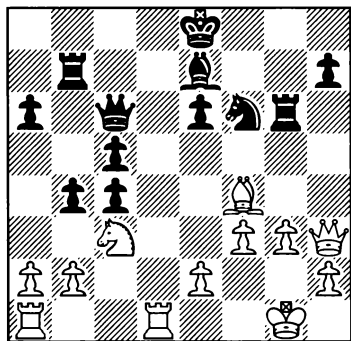
9...♘d7

9...♖xd1? 10 ♜xd1 ♜d5 11 a4! sees White open the queenside and in doing so seize the initiative, while after 9...♜d5 10 ♜xd5 exd5 11 ♙xd5 ♙e6 12 ♙c6+ ♙d7 13 ♜d5 White stands better. Delchev-Genov, Pazardzik 1991 continued 13...♙xc6 14 ♜xc6+ ♜d7 15 ♜e4 ♙c5 16 ♙g5 0-0 17 ♜ad1 ♜e6 18 ♜d5 ♙e7 19 ♙xe7 ♜xe7 20 f4 ♙fd8 21 ♙fd1 and White was still in the driving seat.

10 ♜d4!?

10 ♙c6 has also been played. Kaidanov-Serper, Gausdal 1991 went 10...a6 11 ♜d4 ♜b6?! 12 ♜e4 ♙c5 13 ♙xd7+! ♙xd7 14 ♜g4. This is the usual stuff, Black winning a pawn but White generating sufficient play. Black has problems with g7. Play continued 14...♙f8 15 ♜d1 h5 16 ♜f4 h4 17 ♜e4 ♙e7 18 ♙e3 hxc3 19 fxc3! (the f-file opens and White goes on the offensive) 19...♙c6 20 ♜f1 ♙e8 21 ♜ad1 ♜c8 22 ♜f3! ♙g8? 23 ♙g5 ♙f8 24 ♙xe7+ and White won.

Black should instead look to the following: 11...♙b7 12 ♙xb7 ♜xb7 13 ♜d1 c5 14 ♜g4 ♜c7 15 ♙f4 ♜c6 16 f3 f5 (Black has to free himself somehow, and this is a creative solution) 17 exf6 ♜xf6 18 ♜g5 ♙e7 19 ♜xg7 ♜g8 20 ♜h6 ♙g6 21 ♜h3 b4!



We are following Gleizerov-Werle, Hoo-geveen 2000, which witnessed the rather passive 22 ♜b1?, to which Black responded 22...♜d7! 23 ♜d2 c3 24 ♜c4 cxb2 25 ♜xb2 ♜xd1+ 26 ♜xd1 c4 with advantage thanks to

the dangerous queenside pawns. S.Ivanov & Yuneev offer the following: 22 ♜e4 ♜xe4 23 ♜xh7 e5! 24 ♙xe5 ♜g5 25 ♜h8+ ♙f7 26 ♜h5 and the attack on Black's troubled king compensates for the sacrificed piece, or 25...♙f8 26 ♜d8+ ♙xd8 27 ♜xf8+ ♜e8 28 ♙f6+, again with pressure against the black king.

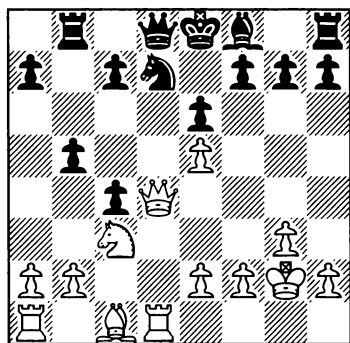
10...♙b7

Also possible is 10...c5 11 ♜f4 ♜c7 12 ♜d1 ♜b6 13 a4 b4 14 ♜b5 ♜d8 15 ♜d6+ ♙xd6 16 exd6 0-0 17 a5 when White was in charge in Prakken-Ippolito, Ubeda 2000. Even worse is 12...♜xe5? 13 ♜xd7!, while 12...♜xe5 13 a4 a6 14 axb5 axb5 15 ♙c6+! ♜xc6 16 ♜xe5 is very pleasant for White.

11 ♜d1

The greedy 11 ♜xa7?! is less convincing as 11...♙c5 12 ♜a5 ♙xg2 13 ♙xg2 ♜c8 14 f3 ♜b7 looks good for Black. White's e5-pawn is weak and Black's queenside majority seems the more useful.

11...♙xg2 12 ♙xg2



12...♜c8

12...c5 is also possible but it is logical to keep this square free for a piece. After the further 13 ♜e4 ♜c7 14 a4! the opening of the a-file helps only White.

13 a4 a6 14 axb5 axb5 15 f3 ♙e7

15...♙c5 16 ♜g4 g6 17 ♙h6 ♜xe5 18 ♜e4 ♜d7 19 ♜c6 and Black is struggling against the tide.

16 ♙a5 b4

Black seeks counterplay. After 16...c6 17 ♜e4 h6 18 ♜d6+ ♙xd6 19 ♜xd6 ♜b7 20 ♙e3 his dark squares are too weak.

17 ♜b5 ♜b6 18 ♜g4 ♙f8

Something has gone wrong for Black.

19 ♜a7 ♜b7 20 ♜e4 ♜xa7 21 ♜xa7 ♜a6 22 ♜c6 ♜a4

22...♜d5 23 ♜xe7 ♙xe7 24 ♙g5+ f6 25 exf6+ ♜xf6 26 ♙xf6+ gxf6 27 ♜g4 leaves Black's king walking on thin ice.

23 ♜d4 ♜a8 24 ♙e3 f5?

The final mistake, although the correct 24...h6 25 ♜d1 ♜a4 26 ♜c1 is still good for White.

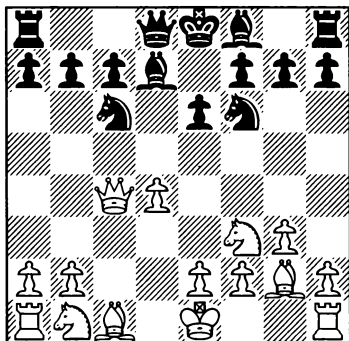
25 exf6 ♙xf6 26 ♜xe6 ♜e8 27 ♜d8! 1-0

Coming next is ♙c5.

White plays 6 ♜a4

Game 67
Tkachiev-Solozhenkin
France 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♜c6 6 ♜a4 ♙d7 7 ♜xc4



7...♜a5

7...♙d6 8 ♜c3 0-0 9 0-0 h6 10 ♙f4 ♙xf4 11 gxf4 gives rise to White's typical grip on the dark squares in the centre. Consequently Black tried 10...♜b8?! in Tukmakov-Barle, Bled 1996, but 11 ♜e5! b5 12 ♜d3 ♜b4 13 ♜d2 ♜bd5 14 ♜a1 ♜xf4 15 ♜xf4 ♜b6 16 ♜e4 ♜xe4 17 ♜xe4 ♜a6 18 a3 ♜a4 19 e3

♙e8 20 ♜b7 then left White with the superior pawn structure, while control of the c-file and the c5-square also remained intact.

8 ♜d3

The queen is worse on c2 than d3 because of the semi-open c-file, e.g. 8...♜c8 9 ♜e5 c5 10 ♜xd7 ♜xd7 11 dxc5 ♙xc5 12 ♜c3 ♜d5! 13 ♙xd5 exd5 14 0-0 0-0 15 ♜d3 d4 16 ♜e4 ♙e7 17 ♙f4 ♜d5 when Black had sufficient play to compensate the isolated d-pawn in Vaganian-Taimanov, USSR 1974. Tratar-Plachetka, Charleville 2000 continued 9 0-0 c5 10 ♜c3 cxd4 11 ♜xd4 ♙c5 12 ♜d1 ♜b6 13 e3 0-0 14 ♜b3 ♜xb3 15 ♜xb3 ♜xb3 16 axb3 ♙c6 17 ♙d2 ♙xg2 18 ♙xg2 ♜fd8 with no problems for Black throughout.

8...c5 9 0-0

The more aggressive 9 ♜e5 was tried in Shipov-Kacheishvili, Berlin 1995: 9...♜c6 10 0-0 cxd4 11 ♙f4 ♙c5 12 ♜d2 0-0 13 ♜a1 ♙b6 14 ♜dc4 (14 ♜xc6 ♙xc6 15 ♙xc6 bxc6 16 ♜xc6 ♜d5 is only equal) 14...♜d5 15 ♜fd1 ♜xf4 16 gxf4 ♜xe5 17 ♜xe5 ♜b8 is instructive, White exerting some pressure on the queenside, with Black generating sufficient play to maintain the balance.

9...♙c6 10 ♜c3

Another option is 10 ♜d1 c4 11 ♜c2 ♙e4 (note that this move is made possible by the omission of ♜c3) 12 ♜d2 h6! 13 ♜e1 ♜c6 14 ♜f1 ♙d5 15 ♜c3 ♙b4 as in Lautier-Karpov, Ubeda 1994, when Black could successfully fight for e4 thanks to 16 ♜xd5 exd5 17 ♜e5 0-0!, with equal chances.

10...cxd4

10...♜c8 11 ♜d1 c4 merely gives White a free hand to get busy in the centre, e.g. 12 ♜c2 ♙b4 13 d5!? 13...exd5 14 e4 ♙xc3 15 exd5 ♜xd5 16 bxc3 0-0 17 ♜g5 g6 18 ♜e4 and (again) the weakness of the dark squares proved a good investment in Ftacnik-Lechtynsky, Czechoslovakia 1979. Then 18...f5!? is interesting, while 18...♜e7 19 ♙g5 f6 20 ♜xd5! was a little combination that returned the pawn, 20...♙xd5 21 ♜xf6+ ♙xf6 22 ♙xd5+ ♙g7 23 ♙xf6+ ♙xf6 24

♖d2 spelling trouble for Black.

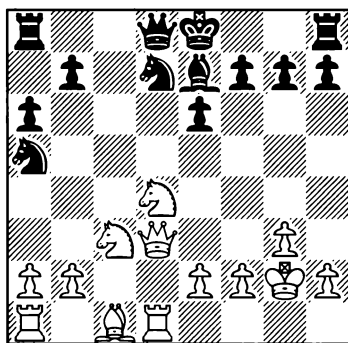
11 ♖xd4 ♙c5

11...♙xg2 12 ♙xg2 ♖d7 13 ♖d1 ♙c5 14 ♙g5 favours White.

12 ♖d1 ♙xg2 13 ♖b5+!? ♖d7 14 ♙xg2 a6

14...0-0?? 15 ♖f3 loses the knight.

15 ♖d3 ♙e7



16 ♙f4! ♖c8

The tempting 16...e5? loses material due to 17 ♖f5 exf4 18 ♖xg7+ ♙f8 19 ♖xd7.

17 ♖f3 ♖c4 18 ♖a4 b5 19 b3! ♖cb6 20 ♖xb6 ♖xb6 21 ♖xd8+ ♙xd8?!

21...♖xd8 22 ♖xd8+ ♙xd8 23 ♖c1 is the lesser evil.

22 e4

The b6-knight is deprived of the last good square. White has a clear advantage.

22...f6

22...♖d7 23 ♖ac1 ♖xc1 24 ♖xc1 ♖f6 25 e5 ♖d5 26 ♖c8 and Black is trailing. After the text the queenside pawns come under attack.

23 ♖d6 ♙e7 24 ♖d4 e5 25 ♖f5+ ♙f7 26 ♙e3 g6 27 ♖h6+ ♙g7 28 ♖ad1

Suddenly White is very active.

28...♖b8 29 ♖d7+!

A nice exchange sacrifice.

29...♖xd7 30 ♖xd7+ ♙f8 31 ♖f7 ♖g8 32 ♖d6!

Mate cannot be avoided without heavy loss of material.

32...g5 33 ♖f7 mate!

Game 68

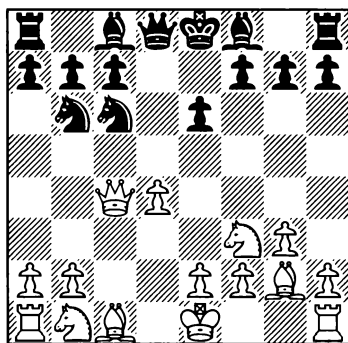
Raetsky-S.Ivanov

Simferopol 1989

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♖c6 6 ♖a4 ♖d7

6...♖d5 7 ♖xc4 ♖b6 transposes to 6...♖d7 7 ♖c4 ♖b6.

7 ♖xc4 ♖b6



8 ♖d3 e5

Another idea is 8...♖b4, e.g. 9 ♖b3 e5 10 ♖g5 ♖e7 11 a3 ♖c6 12 ♙xc6+ bxc6 13 dxe5 h6 14 ♖f3 ♙h3 with unclear play according to Shipov, or 9 ♖c3 e5 10 dxe5 ♙f5 11 0-0 ♙xb1 12 ♖xb1 ♖xa2 13 ♖b3 ♖xc1 14 ♖bxc1, Shipov-Gofstein, Paris 1995, when White had a lead in development.

9 ♙e3!?

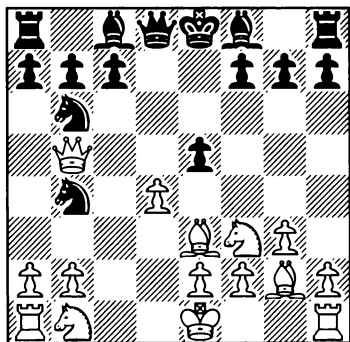
A home-made idea from one of your authors! In Gasimov-Zvjagintsev, Yurmala 1992 a draw was agreed in the equal position that resulted from 9 dxe5 ♖xd3 10 exd3 ♖b4 11 ♖d2 ♙f5 12 a3 ♖xd3 13 ♖h4 ♖xc1 14 ♙xc1 ♙xb1 15 ♖xb1. Meanwhile, in Poluljakhov-Brodsky, Krasnodar 1999 the continuation 9 ♙g5 ♙e7 10 ♙xe7 ♖xe7 11 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 12 dxe5 ♖xe5 13 ♖c3 0-0 14 0-0 c6 15 ♖fd1 ♙e6 16 ♖d4 ♖c7 saw Black entering the middlegame phase with no problems.

9...♖b4

9...exd4 10 ♖xd4 ♖b4?! 11 ♖e4+ ♙e7 12

♖c3 ♖c4 13 ♖d1!? ♖d6 (13...♖xb2 14 ♖c6 ♖xd1 15 ♖xd8 ♖xc3 16 ♖e5 clearly favours White) 14 ♖b1 0-0 15 0-0 ♖e8 16 ♖f4 ♖d7 17 a3 ♖c6 18 ♖db5 and, after some weird manoeuvring, Black was drifting into trouble in Filippov-Short, Batumi 1999. In fact after 18...♖c8 19 ♖xc7! ♖xc7 20 ♖d5 ♖f5? 21 ♖xc7 White won. A lesser evil is 10...♖xd4 11 ♖xd4 ♖b4+ 12 ♖c3 0-0 13 a3 ♖e7 14 ♖d1 c6 15 ♖e4!, although Black has problems with the co-ordination of his pieces.

10 ♖b5+



10...♖d7

10...♖d7!? is a clever move with which Black sacrifices a pawn in order to seek to exploit the insecure position of White's queen. In J.Horvath-Rabiega, Austria 1996 this did not work out for Black after 11 ♖xe5+ ♖e7 12 ♖a3 0-0 13 0-0 ♖d5 14 ♖d2 ♖e8 15 ♖xb4 ♖xb4 16 ♖f4 ♖e6 17 ♖b5! ♖d5 18 ♖d2 ♖b4 19 ♖c2 c6 20 ♖c3. However, there is an improvement in 14...♖f6 15 ♖h5 g6 16 ♖h6 ♖g7 17 ♖h4 ♖xh4 18 gxh4 ♖fe8, when White's kingside structure is compromised and Black has some compensation for the pawn deficit.

11 ♖a4 exd4

11...b5!? 12 ♖b3 ♖b7 13 ♖xe5! is bad for Black, and after 11...e4 12 ♖g5 ♖d5 13 ♖b3 White has numerous threats (e4 is weak and Black is behind in development).

12 ♖xd4 c6 13 ♖c3 ♖b6 14 ♖b3 c5

Perhaps this is too ambitious as it helps

White's Catalan bishop. Also possible is 14...♖d4 15 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 16 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 17 ♖xd5 cxd5 18 ♖b5 with an endgame that is generally slightly better for White and here also features a lead in development.

15 ♖db5 ♖e6

15...♖f5 16 ♖d1 ♖c2+ 17 ♖f1 ♖xe3+ 18 fxe3 ♖c8 19 ♖d5 and in return for his damaged pawns White has a strong attack.

16 ♖d1 ♖f5?!

A waste of time, but the alternative 16...♖xd1+ 17 ♖xd1 ♖c2+ 18 ♖f1 ♖xe3+ 19 fxe3 is also good for White. Again the doubled e-pawns are balanced by White's more rapid deployment.

17 0-0

White is better, with pressure against Black's queenside.

17...a6 18 ♖xd8+ ♖xd8 19 ♖c7+ ♖d7 20 ♖7d5 ♖4xd5 21 ♖xd5 ♖c4 22 ♖fd1 ♖xb2?

Losing immediately. After 22...♖d6 23 b3 ♖xe3 24 ♖xe3 Black loses at least a pawn as b7 is hanging.

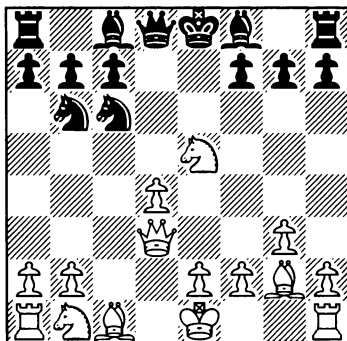
23 ♖d2 ♖c4 24 ♖b6+ 1-0

Game 69

Polovodin-Zviagintsev

St. Petersburg 1994

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♖c6 6 ♖a4 ♖d7 7 ♖xc4 ♖b6 8 ♖d3 e5 9 ♖xe5



9...♖b4

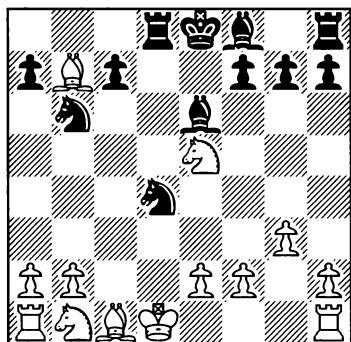
After 9...♖xd4 10 e3 ♖e6 11 ♗xd8+ ♖xd8 the game is equal, while 10 ♙e3 ♙c5 11 ♖c3 ♙f5 12 ♙e4 ♙xe4 13 ♗xe4 f5 14 ♗d3 ♗d6 is unclear. White's best is 10 0-0 f6 11 ♖f3 ♖xf3+ 12 ♖xf3 ♙d6 13 ♖c3 with a slight edge.

10 ♗b3

In the event of 10 ♗d1 ♗xd4 11 ♗xd4 ♖c2+ 12 ♖d1 ♖xd4 13 e3 ♖e6 Black shouldn't experience any problems. Gelfand-Ivanchuk, Sochi 1986 continued 14 ♖c3 f6 15 ♖d3 ♖c5 16 ♖xc5 ♙xc5 17 ♖c2 ♙f5+ 18 e4 ♙e6 19 f4 0-0-0 20 b3 h5 with equal chances.

10 ♗c3 ♗xd4 needs investigating. After 11 ♗xc7!? ♙e7 12 ♖f3 ♗c4 13 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 14 ♖d4 ♙f6 15 a3 ♙xd4!? 16 axb4 ♖xb2 17 ♙a2 Black wins the pawn back but White keeps an edge, while Haba-Klovans, Leinfelden 2001 saw instead 15...♖xa3 16 ♖xa3 ♙xd4 17 0-0 0-0 18 ♙d1 ♙f6 19 ♖b5. Again Black managed to collect the invested pawn, but White's pressure on the queenside secured an advantage. The earlier encounter Beliavsky-Adams, Madrid 1998 went 11 0-0 ♗xc3 12 ♖xc3 ♙d6 13 ♖f3 c6 14 ♙d1 ♙e7 15 ♖d4 0-0 16 a3 ♖d4d5 17 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 with a level game, but 15 e4!? is interesting and seems to give White some advantage after 15...0-0 16 a3 ♖a6 17 ♙f4.

10...♙e6 11 ♗d1 ♗xd4 12 ♗xd4 ♖c2+ 13 ♖d1 ♖xd4 14 ♙xb7 ♙d8



15 ♙d2

In Kaidanov-Shariyazdanov, Elista 1998 White preferred 15 ♖d2, and after the further 15...f6 16 ♖c6 ♖xc6 17 ♙xc6+ ♖f7 18 ♖c2 ♙c5 19 ♖b3 ♙xf2 20 ♙f1 ♙d4 21 ♙f4 Black returned the material with equality after 21...♙xb3+ 22 ♖xb3 ♖d5.

15...f6 16 ♖c6 ♖xc6 17 ♙xc6+ ♖f7 18 ♖c2 ♙c5

Black's activity compensates for the pawn deficit.

19 f3 ♖c4 20 ♙e4 ♙d6 21 ♙d3 ♙b8

Now all of Black's pieces are in play.

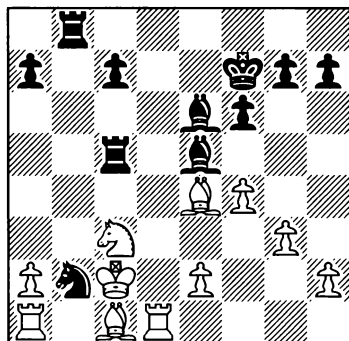
22 ♙c1

22 b3 ♖e5 23 ♙e4 f5 24 ♙c3 fxe4 25 ♙xe5 ♙d5 26 f4 e3 is to Black's benefit. White has problems mobilising his forces and his light-squared bishop has a bright future.

22...♙d4 23 ♖c3 ♙c6 24 ♙e4 ♙c5 25 ♙d1

Another move is 25 e3 but Black has a strong reply – 25...♖a3+! 26 ♖d2 ♙xc3+ 27 bxc3 ♙d8+ 28 ♖e2 ♖b5 and Black both regains the pawn and maintains the offensive.

25...♙e5 26 f4 ♖xb2!



A nice little combination that wins back the pawn.

27 ♙xb2 ♙xb2+ 28 ♖xb2 ♙xc3+ 29 ♖b1 ♙c4

Of course Black has no intention of restoring the material balance immediately as

his bishop is far better than the rook.

30 a4 f5 31 ♖c1?

After the more circumspect 31 ♖f3 ♖xa1 32 ♖xa1 ♖b3 Black wins a pawn but White's forces then enjoy sufficient freedom with which to secure equal chances.

31...♖xa1 32 ♖xc4 ♖xc4 33 ♖d5+ ♖f6 34 ♖xc4 ♖d4

This opposite coloured bishop ending is far from a draw. Had White's king been on the kingside the draw would have been obvious. Now these pawns make easy targets for the enemy bishop.

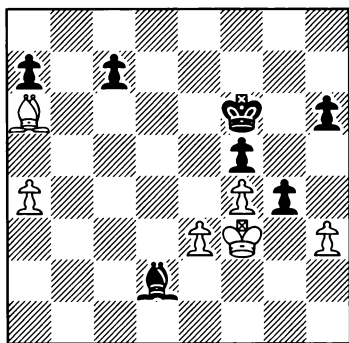
35 ♖c2 ♖g1 36 h3 ♖h2 37 ♖d3 ♖xg3 38 e3 h6 39 ♖e2 g5 40 ♖f3 ♖e1 41 ♖e2 ♖b4

Black already has one passed pawn but to win the game he has to create a second.

42 ♖f3 ♖d2 43 ♖a6?!

Better is 43 fxg5+ hxg5 when Black has to work to make progress on the kingside.

43...g4+!



Forcing an exchange that results in a second, decisive passed pawn.

44 hxg4 fxg4+ 45 ♖xg4 ♖xe3 46 ♖f3 ♖c1 47 ♖e4 ♖e6 48 ♖e2 a5 49 ♖h5 ♖d6 50 ♖d1 ♖c5 51 ♖e5 ♖b4 52 f5

White also has a passed pawn that needs attention, but the win is uncomplicated. If necessary Black will sacrifice his bishop for the f-pawn so that his two runners cannot be held at bay by White's lone bishop.

52...c5 53 f6 ♖b2+ 54 ♖f5 c4 55 f7

55 ♖g6 ♖xf6 56 ♖xf6 ♖c3 57 ♖e2 ♖d4 doesn't help White.

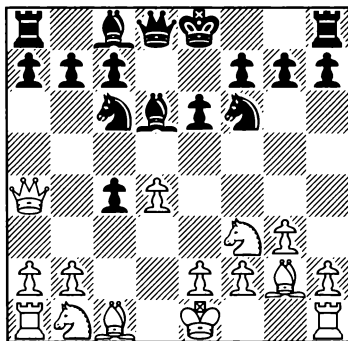
55...♖g7 56 ♖e4 ♖c3 57 ♖g4 ♖d2 0-1

Game 70

Zsu.Polgar-Benjamin

Dortmund 1985

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♖c6 6 ♖a4 ♖d6



7 0-0

In the event of 7 ♖bd2 (note that with the moves ...♖b4+ and ♖d2 inserted this is not possible) 7...0-0 8 ♖xc4 Black must not allow the exchange of his potentially useful dark-squared bishop for White's knight. Therefore in this position practice has seen the forcing 8...b5!? 9 ♖xb5 ♖b8 10 ♖xc6 ♖d7 11 ♖a6 ♖b5 12 ♖a5 ♖xc4 13 a3. Then 13...♖e4!? is worth a try, with compensation after 14 ♖e5 ♖d5 15 0-0 c5. Instead Jo.Horvath-Van Der Werf, Haarlem 1995 continued 13...c5 14 ♖xd8 ♖fxd8 15 dxc5 ♖xc5 16 b4 ♖b6 17 ♖b2, when 17...♖e4 18 e3 ♖c5! 19 ♖e5 ♖d3+ 20 ♖xd3 ♖xd3 21 ♖c1 a5 gives Black slightly less than a pawn's worth of compensation.

7...0-0 8 ♖d1

If White is not prepared to forget about the c4-pawn he should play 8 ♖xc4 e5 9 ♖c3 exd4 10 ♖xd4 ♖e5 11 ♖a4 ♖d7 (11...c6!? is interesting) 12 ♖b3 c5 13 ♖db5 c4 14 ♖c2 ♖c5 15 ♖f4 ♖e7 16 ♖ad1, when

White had an edge in Gleizerov-Dzhakaev, Hoogeveen 2000. The ambitious thrust of the c-pawn seemed to have helped White more than Black.

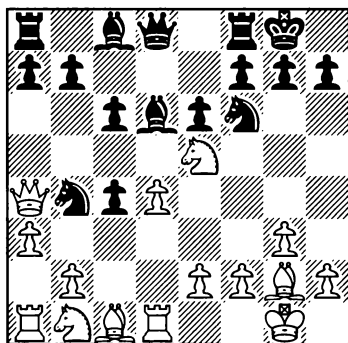
8...♟b4

An interesting approach to the position is 8...♟e8!? 9 ♟xc4 e5 10 d5 ♟b4, when the queen monitors both the e-file and the a4-e8 diagonal. Filippov-Loeffler, Ubeda 1998 continued 11 ♟c3 ♟c2 12 ♟b1 e4 13 ♟d4 ♟xd4 14 ♟xd4 ♟f5 15 ♟xe4 b5 16 ♟d3 ♟xe4 17 ♟xe4 ♟c5 18 ♟f3 ♟xd4 19 ♟xd4 and White enjoyed a greater share of territory and decent attacking chances in return for the exchange.

9 ♟e5 c6

Another option is 9...♟fd5!? 10 a3 ♟b6 11 ♟a5 ♟c2 12 ♟a2 f6 and the position remains unclear.

10 a3



10...♟a6

Black can also head directly for the end-game with 10...b5!? 11 ♟xc6 bxa4 12 ♟xd8 ♟c2 13 ♟a2 ♟d5 14 ♟c6. White's rook looks a bit silly at the moment but he has made progress in the centre and Black's queenside has seen better days. Not surprisingly this is a difficult position to assess. We should not forget that Black has two other possibilities after 11 ♟xc6, the most obvious being 11...♟xc6 12 ♟xb5 ♟d7 13 ♟xc6 ♟b8 14 ♟a4 ♟c7 15 ♟xd7 ♟xd7 with a lead in development and pressure on the b-file pro-

viding compensation for the missing pawn. Finally, after 11...♟b6 12 ♟a5 ♟c2 13 ♟a2 ♟d5 14 ♟xb6 axb6, we have another complex battle to look forward to.

11 ♟c3 ♟c7

Black can try 11...♟d5 12 ♟e4 b5 13 ♟c2 but the resulting dark square weaknesses give White something to aim at. You might have noticed that after 12 ♟xc4?? ♟xc3 13 bxc3 ♟xe5 Black is winning.

12 ♟xc4 ♟xe5 13 dxe5 ♟xe5 14 ♟f4 ♟h5 15 ♟d6

The dark squares again give White enough play.

15...♟e8 16 ♟f3 ♟f5 17 ♟xc6?!

A more quiet approach with 17 b4!? should be preferred.

17...bxc6 18 ♟xc6 ♟b8

18...♟d7 19 ♟xa6 ♟e4 20 ♟xe4 ♟xe4 21 ♟d3 slightly favours White.

19 ♟xb8 ♟xb8 20 ♟b5 ♟h3

After 20...♟xb5 21 ♟xb5 a6 22 ♟d6 ♟f8 the exchange of queens helps White's cause, whereas the text at least draws attention to White's king.

21 ♟e4

21 ♟xb8?? ♟g4 and mate is on the menu.

21...♟bd7 22 ♟xf6+ ♟xf6 23 f3 e5 24 e4 ♟e6

24...h5 25 ♟d6 h4 26 ♟f1 sees White exchange queens to leave Black with only a small edge.

25 ♟ac1 ♟d7 26 ♟b4 ♟a6 27 ♟f2 ♟e6 ½-½

Game 71 Bauer-Ippolito New York 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♟f3 ♟f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♟g2 ♟c6 6 ♟a4 ♟b4+ 7 ♟d2 ♟d6 8 ♟e5

White has a range of possibilities here. In the case of 8 ♟a3 the most direct response is 8...♟xa3, when after 9 ♟xa3 ♟xd4 10 ♟xd4 ♟xd4 11 ♟d1 White has sacrificed two

pawns but the lead in development and pressure against Black's queenside make life rather awkward for the defender. An unclear position arises after 8...a6 9 ♜xc4 b5 10 ♜xd6+ cxd6 11 ♖a3 ♙b7, which leaves 8...♙e4 9 ♜xc4 ♜xd2, Black making use of the 'extra' ♙d2 to remove a potentially influential bishop. After 10 ♜fxd2 ♙d7 Beliavsky gives 11 e3! 0-0 12 ♖b3 as an interesting choice, while in Beliavsky-Anand, Dortmund 1998 the continuation 11 ♜xd6+ cxd6 12 ♙e4 0-0 saw Black sacrifice a pawn for a more fluid deployment of his forces: 13 ♜xd6 ♖c7 14 ♙e4 ♜fd8 15 ♖c4 ♖b6! 16 e3 ♜ac8 17 ♖b3 ♖a5+ 18 ♜c3 e5! 19 d5 ♜d4! 20 exd4 exd4 21 0-0 dxc3 22 bxc3 ♜xc3 23 ♖xb7 ♖c5! with a balanced game.

Another option is 8 ♙c3 0-0 9 ♖xc4 with a space advantage for White. This was translated to a general lead in Wojtkiewicz-Goldin, Oak Bridge 2000, which went 9...♖e7 10 ♙e5 ♙xe5 11 dxe5 ♜d5 12 0-0 ♜d8 13 ♜d1 ♙d7 14 ♜d2 ♜xc3 15 ♖xc3 ♙e8 16 ♜b3 ♖xd1+ 17 ♜xd1 ♜d8 18 ♜c1.

Of course White can capture on c4 immediately. For example D.Gurevich-Beliavsky, Las Vegas 1999 went 8 ♖xc4 e5 9 dxe5 (9 d5! is interesting) 9...♙xe5 10 ♜xe5 ♙xe5 11 ♖b5+ (the point of the exchange on e5, but Black is still okay) 11...♜d7 12 ♙c3 0-0! (a temporary piece sacrifice) 13 0-0 (13 ♙xe5 c6!) 13...c6 14 ♖c4 ♜e8 15 a4 ♜b6 16 ♖c5 ♙g4! and Black was doing fine.

Finally there is 8 0-0 0-0 9 ♖xc4, when 9...e5 presents White with a decision regarding the d-pawn. 10 dxe5 ♜xe5 11 ♜xe5 ♙c3 doesn't seem to pose Black any problems, e.g. 12...♖e7 13 ♙xe5 ♖xe5 14 ♜c3 c6 15 ♜fd1 ♙e6 16 ♖b4 ♜ab8 17 ♜d2 a5 18 ♖b6 ♜d7 19 ♖d4 ♖xd4 20 ♜xd4 ♜fd8 21 ♜ad1 ♙f8 with a draw in Karpov-Kramnik, Wijk aan Zee 1998. Instead in Raetsky-Shariyazdanov, Biel 1999 White pushed with 10 d5, which earns a territorial advantage after 10...♙e7 11 ♜c3 a6 12 ♙g5 ♜e8 13 e4.

8...♙xe5 9 ♙xc6+

9 dxe5 ♜d5 10 f4 ♜b6 11 ♙xc6+ bxc6 12 ♖xc6+ ♖d7 is unclear because, while Black's pawns look fragile they are not easy to attack and, in the meantime, he has the b-file.

9...bxc6 10 dxe5 ♖d5

Also possible is 10...♜d7 11 ♙c3 ♜b6 12 ♖xc6+ ♖d7 13 ♖xd7+ ♙xd7 14 ♙a3 ♙a6 15 0-0-0+ ♙c6 16 ♜d4 (Ilincic). Compared with the previous note featuring 9 dxe5, White has clearly improved and his forces are much better placed.

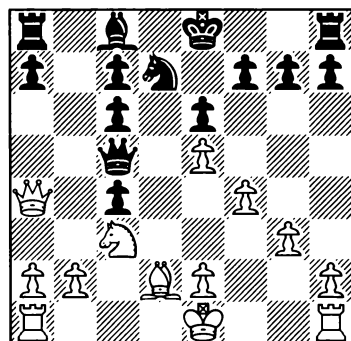
11 f3 ♜d7

11...♖xe5? 12 ♖xc6+ ♙d8 13 ♖xa8 ♖xb2 14 0-0 ♖xa1 15 ♖xa7 nets a pawn for Black but he will soon feel the power of his opponent's pieces.

12 ♜c3 ♖c5

12...♖xe5 13 ♖xc6 ♜b8 14 ♙f4 ♖d4 was tested in Ilincic-Marjanovic, Yugoslavia 1998. After 15 ♖xc7 0-0 16 ♜d1 ♖b6 17 ♖xb6 ♜xb6 18 ♙d6! ♜e8 19 ♙a3 f5 20 ♜d2 ♜f6 21 ♙f2 e5 22 ♜hd1 White's control of the d-file and more sound structure secured the better prospects. Perhaps Black should look to 14...♖f5! 15 ♙xc7 ♖xb2 16 ♙d6 ♙b7 17 ♖xc4 ♖a5! with good counterplay. In return for leaving his king in the centre Black can generate pressure of his own.

13 f4



13...0-0

The situation after 13...♜b6! 14 ♖c2 ♙b7 15 0-0-0 0-0-0 16 ♙e4 ♖e7 17 ♙e3

♖d5 is given as unclear by Bauer.

14 0-0-0 ♖b8 15 ♜e4 ♜b5 16 ♜c2 c3?!

After 16...♜b7 17 ♜g5 g6 18 ♜c3 Black keeps the c4-pawn but the question is how much is it worth, as without the pawn Black has more room for manoeuvre – hence the text.

17 ♜xc3 ♜b6 18 ♜g5 g6 19 h4 ♜d5 20 h5!!

The direct approach. Time is more important than material.

20...♜e3 21 ♜e4 ♜xd1 22 ♜xd1 ♜g7

Other moves are clearly worse, e.g. 22...h6 23 hxg6! hxg5 24 ♜h1! with the cruel threat of ♜h8+!, or 22...c5 23 ♜h1!, heading for h7.

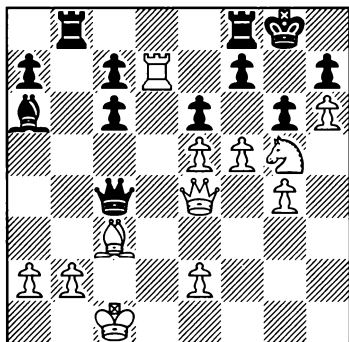
23 g4

Here White misses a great opportunity to continue in gambit style with 23 f5!! gxf5 (23...exf5 24 e6+ f6 25 ♜h4 wins – h7 is the problem) 24 h6+ ♜g8 25 ♜h4 and White is winning (it is safe to say that Black is weak on the dark squares!).

23...♜a6

23...h6 24 ♜xf7! ♜xf7 25 ♜xg6+ ♜e7 26 ♜xh6 and White's attack looks dangerous.

24 ♜d7 ♜c4 25 h6+ ♜g8 26 f5!



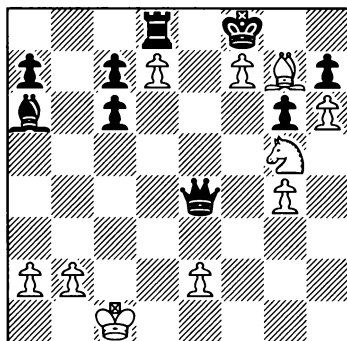
26...♜bd8

Even the exchange of queens doesn't help Black: 26...♜xe4 27 ♜xe4 gxf5 28 gxf5 ♜c8 29 ♜xc7 ♜b7 30 ♜xc6 with a huge advantage to White.

27 fxe6 ♜xd7

White's win is practically forced.

28 exd7 ♜d8 29 e6! ♜xe4 30 exf7+ ♜f8 31 ♜g7+



31...♜e7 32 f8♜+ ♜xf8 33 ♜xf8+ ♜xf8 34 d8♜+ 1-0

Mate is unavoidable.

Game 72

Grabliauskas-Benjamin

New York 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♜f3 ♜f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♜g2 ♜c6 6 ♜a4 ♜b4+ 7 ♜d2 ♜d5 8 ♜b5 0-0

8...♜xd2+ 9 ♜bxd2 c3 10 bxc3 ♜xc3 11 ♜d3 ♜d5 nets Black a pawn but White has compensation, e.g. 12 0-0 0-0 13 e4 ♜f6!? 14 ♜fd1 ♜e7 15 ♜ac1 ♜d8 16 ♜f1 ♜d7 17 ♜e3 ♜e8 18 a3 h6 19 d5 ♜ac8 20 ♜b1 ♜a5 21 ♜c3 Iljushin-Aleksandrov, Smolensk, 2000. In Van Heste-Barsov, Netherlands 1998 Black tried 13...♜b6 with some patient manoeuvring after 14 ♜b3 ♜e7 15 ♜ac1 ♜d7 16 ♜c5 ♜d8 17 ♜fe1 ♜e8 18 h4 h6 19 ♜b3 ♜c8 20 ♜e5 c6 21 ♜c4 b6 22 ♜d3 ♜b7 23 e5, although White emerged with a pull.

Well worth considering is the retention of dark-squared bishops with 8...♜e7!?, when Paunovic-Zvjagintsev, Yugoslavia 1995 went 9 ♜xc4 ♜b6 10 ♜d3 0-0 11 0-0 e5 12 ♜c3 exd4 13 ♜xd4 ♜xd4 14 ♜xd4 ♜f5 15 ♜xf5 ♜xd4 16 ♜c3 c6, Black succeeding in neutralising White's aggression. Instead of 12

♙c3 White can try 12 ♜xe5, e.g. 12...♜xe5 (12...♜xd4 13 ♙c3 is an edge thanks to White's modest development lead) 13 dxe5 ♜xd3 14 exd3 ♜d8, when the attack down the d-file provides Black with compensation.

9 ♜xc4

Also possible is 9 ♙c3, when the forcing 9...♙xc3+!? 10 ♜xc3 ♜xc3 11 bxc3 ♜d5 is okay for Black. An alternative to the bishop trade is 9...e5!?, e.g. 10 dxe5 ♙e6 11 0-0 a6 12 ♜a4 ♙f5 13 ♜h4 ♙xb1 (13...b5!? might be better, when 14 ♜d1 ♙e6 15 a4 ♜b8 is unclear) 14 ♜axb1 ♙xc3 15 ♜xc4 ♙xe5 16 ♙xd5 with the easier game for White in Romanishin-Brodsky, Nikolaev 1995. Note that 10 0-0?! is not in White's interest in view of 10...a6 11 ♜xc4 e4 12 ♙xb4 (directed against ...♜a5) 12...exf3 13 ♙xf8 fxe2 14 ♙xg2 ♙e6! and the resulting rook versus two minor pieces middlegame clearly favours Black.

9...♜b6 10 ♜d3 e5

10...♙xd2+ 11 ♜bx2 e5 12 ♜xe5 ♜b4 13 ♜b1 ♜xd4 14 ♜df3 ♜d8 15 a3 ♜d5 16 0-0 ♙e7 17 ♜c2 a5 was fine for Black in De Boer-S.Polgar, Netherlands 1996.

11 ♙xb4

11 ♜xe5 ♙xd2+ 12 ♜xd2 ♜b4 13 ♜c3 ♜xd4 14 0-0 ♜xc3 15 bxc3 ♜d5 is pleasant for Black.

11...♜xb4 12 ♜d2 a5 13 a3 e4!?

13...♜c6 14 dxe5 ♙e7 15 ♜f4 a4 16 0-0 ♜a5 17 ♜c3 ♜xe5 with a draw in Konopka-Grabliauskas, Litomysl 1996. The text is more ambitious.

14 axb4 ♜c4!

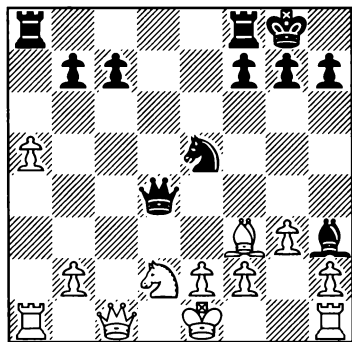
14...exf3? 15 ♙xf3 ♜c4 16 ♜d3 ♜xb2 17 ♜c3 and the knight is lost.

15 ♜c1!?

15 ♜f4 has more bite. Benjamin gives 15...exf3 16 ♙xf3 ♙e7 17 ♜c3 (17 bxa5 ♜b4+ 18 ♜c3 ♜xb2 19 ♜c1 ♜xc1+ 20 ♜xc1 c6 leads to equality) 17...♜xb4 18 0-0 ♜xb2 19 ♜d5 ♜d2 20 ♜fd1 ♜xf3+ 21 ♜xf3 c6 22 ♜e7+ ♙h8 23 ♜ab1 ♜c2 24 e3. White wins back the b7-pawn with an equal game.

15...exf3 16 ♙xf3 ♜xd4 17 ♜d2 ♙e5

18 bxa5 ♙h3!



Black's is a sensible pawn sacrifice. White's king is kept in the centre for the time being.

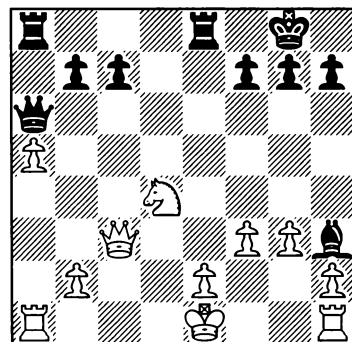
19 ♜c3

In the event of the greedy 19 ♙xb7 Black generates a formidable attack after 19...♜ae8 20 ♙e4 ♜g4.

19...♜xf3+ 20 ♜xf3 ♙e4 21 ♜d4 ♜c6 22 ♜c3 ♙a6

No exchange of queens. By now White really misses his Catalan bishop!

23 ♜d4 ♜fe8 24 f3?



White tries to repair the light squares, but he cannot afford the time. 24 b4 ♜ad8 25 e3 ♜f6 is necessary.

24...c5! 25 ♜xc5 ♙g2 26 ♙f2

The point behind Black's play is seen in the line 26 ♜g1 ♙xf3 27 ♙f2 ♙xe2+ 28 ♙xf3 ♜d3+ 29 ♙g4 ♜xh2, when White's

king is in dire straits.

26...♙xh1 27 ♖xh1 ♖ec8 28 ♜g5 h6 29 ♜g4 ♜xa5

The knight and pawn are no match for the rook in this wide open position.

30 ♖f5 ♜b6+ 31 ♔g2 ♜f6 32 ♙h3?

32 ♖d4!? puts up more resistance.

32...♙c2 33 ♖d1 ♖xe2 34 ♖d6 ♖e6 35 ♖d7 b5?!

A quicker win results from 35...h5 36 ♜xh5 g6 37 ♖h6+ ♔g7.

36 f4 b4 37 ♜b7 ♜xb2 38 ♖xb4 ♜f6

With or without rooks and queens Black will win the game.

39 ♜b7 ♖d8 40 ♜b5 ♖d2 41 ♜b8+ ♔h7

42 ♖h4 ♖ee2 43 ♖f3 ♜b2 44 ♖f8 ♖f2

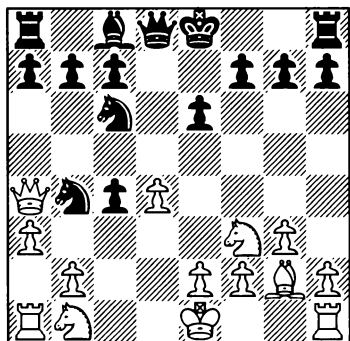
45 f5 ♜e7 46 ♖a8 ♜e2 0-1

Game 73

Ivanchuk-Korchnoi

Tilburg 1989

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♔g2 ♖c6 6 ♜a4 ♙b4+ 7 ♖d2 ♖d5 8 ♙xb4 ♖xb4 9 a3



9...b5!

Simagin.

10 ♜xb5 ♖c2+ 11 ♖d2

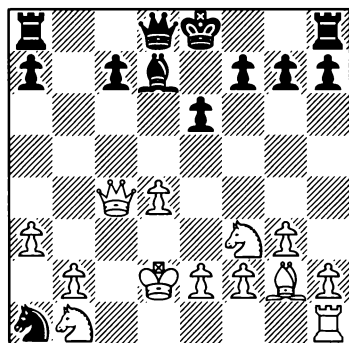
This is better than 11 ♔f1 ♖d7 12 ♖a2 ♖2xd4 13 ♖xd4 ♖xd4 14 ♜c5 ♖b3 15 ♜xc4 ♖b8 16 ♖f3 0-0 17 ♔g2 e5 18 ♖c3 c6 19 ♖d1 ♜e7 20 ♖g4 ♖xg4 21 ♜xg4 ♖fd8 with an advantage to Black in Bogdanovsky-

Dorfman, Cannes 1990. The rook looks rather silly on a2.

11...♖xa1

An interesting line is 11...♖d7!? 12 ♜xc2 ♖xd4+ 13 ♖xd4 ♙xb5 14 ♖xb5 ♖b8, e.g. 15 ♖c6+ (15 ♖1c3 0-0 16 ♖ad1 ♜e7!? 17 ♖xa7 ♜c5 18 ♖c6 ♖b6 19 ♖a4 ♜f5+ 20 e4 ♖b5 with a highly complex struggle ahead) 15...♔f8 16 ♖1c3 ♜e7 17 ♖hd1 ♜c5 (Chetverik-Grabliauskas, Martin 1996) 18 ♖f3 ♖xb5 (the less forcing 18...a6 19 ♖d4 ♖b6 20 b4 cxb3+ 21 ♔b2 also merits attention) 19 ♖d8+ ♔e7 20 ♖xh8 ♖b3. If judged only in material terms, then White has more than enough for the queen. But Black has an active position and White's king could be more secure.

12 ♜xc6+ ♖d7 13 ♜xc4



13...c5!?

The main alternative is 13...♖b8, e.g. 14 b4 c5! 15 ♖c3?! cxd4 16 ♖e4 ♙b5 17 ♜a2 d3 with considerable counterplay for Black in Zilberstein-Raetsky, Voronezh 1988. After 18 ♖xa1 ♖c8! 19 ♖c5 ♖xc5! 20 bxc5 ♜a5+ 21 ♔e3 ♜c3 22 exd3 ♜xd3+ 23 ♔f4 g5+ 24 ♖xg5 ♜f5+ Black's attack is indeed very dangerous.

White should go for the knight immediately, Kozlov-Chernikov, Vladivostok 1978 being a good example of model play after 15 ♜c3! cxb4 16 axb4 a5 17 ♜xa1 axb4 18 ♖e5 0-0 19 ♖d1! b3 20 ♔e1 b2 21 ♜a7 ♙b5 22 ♖c3 ♜d6 23 ♜a5 ♖fd8 24 ♖e4 (24 ♖xb5?

♙xe5! is a nice little trick that illustrates the power of the b2-pawn) 24...♙e8. White has two minor pieces for the rook, a fine centre and his king is about to feel safer on the kingside, but the b2-pawn is dangerous.

14 ♖a2 ♖a5+! 15 b4

15 ♖c3 is also interesting and has been tried at the highest level recently: 15...cxd4 16 ♖xd4 ♖d8 17 ♖xa1 e5 (17...♙b6!? 18 e3 e5 19 ♖d5 ♙h6! offers Black counterplay, or 19 ♖de2 ♙e6+ 20 ♙d5 ♙c5 and White cannot hold on to f2) 18 b4 ♙b6 19 ♖c2 ♙e6+ (19...♙xf2 20 ♙d5 0-0 21 ♙c4 ♙e6 22 ♖e3 ♙xh2 23 ♙h4 ♙xh4 24 gxh4 f5 25 ♖c2 ♖f7 26 ♖d1 f4 27 ♖c4 gave White the smallest of edges in Kasparov-Adams, Wijk aan Zee 2001, the game eventually ending in a draw) 20 ♙d5 ♙xf2 21 ♖d1! (White wants to transfer the king to the queenside) and now in Kir.Georgiev-Timoschenko, Panormo 2001 there followed 21...0-0?! 22 ♖c1 ♙xd5 23 ♖xd5 ♖h8 24 ♙c4 ♙xh2 25 g4 ♙g2 26 ♖de3, when White was well co-ordinated and had the better prospects. Timoschenko proposes 21...♙xh2! 22 ♖c1 ♙xd5 23 ♖xd5 ♖c8 24 ♙b3 ♙xe2 25 ♙a4+ ♖f8 26 ♖c7 g6 27 ♙d7 ♖g7 as an improvement (with two pawns and an insecure king to aim at, Black should be satisfied with his lot).

15...cxb4 16 ♙xa1 ♖c8 17 ♖e5

Not to be recommended is 17 e4 0-0 18 ♖e3 bxa3, when the a-pawn looks menacing and White's king might prove awkwardly placed.

17...♙b5 18 ♖e3?

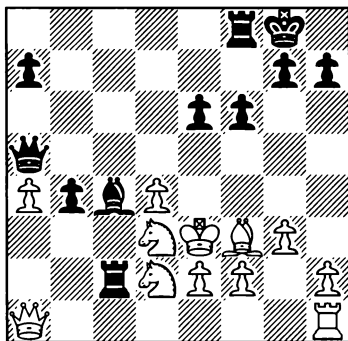
White should address the threatened infiltration. 18 ♙e4?! 0-0 19 ♖e3 f6 20 ♖d3 f5 21 ♙f3 ♙xd3 22 ♖xd3 ♙a4 saw White experience problems in Raetsky-Pushkov, Podolsk 1992, when 23 ♙b2 bxa3 24 ♙xa3 ♙c4+ 25 ♖e3 e5! 26 ♙d6 ♙b3+ led to a win for Black. The best course is 18 a4! 0-0 19 ♙e4 f6 20 ♖f3! (Byrne & Mednis) and the struggle continues.

18...♖c2 19 ♙f3 0-0 20 a4 f6 21 ♖d3

21 ♖d2 fxe5 22 axb5 ♖c3+ 23 ♖e4 ♙xb5

and with this king position White can't expect to survive much longer.

21...♙c4 22 ♖d2



22...♙g5+

22...♙xd3! 23 exd3 ♙g5+ wins on the spot.

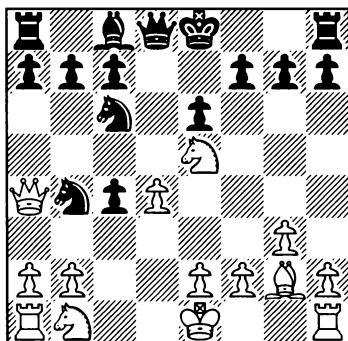
23 ♖f4 e5 24 ♖xc4 exf4+ 25 gxf4 ♙f5 26 ♖d6

26 ♙e4 ♖c3+ 27 ♙d3 (27 ♙xc3 ♙h3+) 27...♖e8+ 28 ♖d2 ♙xf4+ 29 ♖d1 ♙xd4 and Black has a decisive advantage.

26...♙e6+ 0-1

Game 74
Vakhidov-Ziatdinov
Tashkent 1987

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♖c6 6 ♙a4 ♙b4+ 7 ♙d2 ♖d5 8 ♙xb4 ♖xb4 9 ♖e5



9...♙d7

9...0-0 invites White to contemplate the captures on c6. White can cause considerable structural damage with 10 ♙xc6?! ♜xc6 11 ♜xc6 bxc6 12 ♞xc4 but this leaves him open to trouble on the b-file, e.g. 12...♞b8 13 0-0 (13 b3 ♙a6!) 13...♞xb2 14 ♜c3 ♞d6 15 ♞ab1 ♞b6 16 ♞fc1 ♞d8 17 e3 e5 18 dxe5 ♞xe5 and the light-squared bishop gave Black a plus in Stajcic-Luther, Kecskemet 1993. Note that 10 ♜xc6 ♜xc6 11 ♙xc6 is quite different in that it allows the interesting 11...♞xd4!?, which leaves 11 e3, when Mochalov-Korneev, Minsk 1995 went 11...e5 12 d5 ♜e7 13 ♞xc4 ♜f5 14 0-0 ♜d6 15 ♞c3 ♞e8 16 ♜d2 ♙f5 17 ♞ac1 ♞c8 18 ♞fd1 ♞d7 with a very solid set-up for Black.

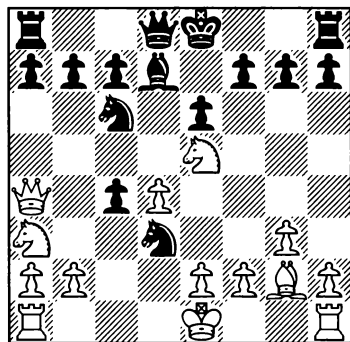
10 ♙a3?!

Not the most accurate of the available options. 10 ♜xd7 ♞xd7 11 a3?! b5 12 ♞xb5 ♜c2+ 13 ♜f1 ♜6xd4 14 ♞xc4 ♞d8! 15 ♞a2 0-0 16 ♙e4 (16 b4 ♜f5 and mate on d1 is threatened) 16...f5 17 ♙d3 f4! leaves Black with the initiative. Instead Gulko assesses 11 ♜c3 ♞xd4 12 a3 ♜d5 13 ♞d1 ♞e5 as unclear.

10 0-0 appears best, when the following line is given as slightly better for White by V.Mikhalevsky: 10...♜d5 11 ♞xc4 ♜xe5 12 dxe5 ♙c6 13 ♜c3 0-0 14 ♞fd1 ♜b6 15 ♞c5 ♜d7 16 ♞d4 ♙xg2 17 ♜xg2 ♜b6 18 ♞e4 – again White enjoys a space advantage. 10...a5 11 ♜xd7 ♞xd7 12 ♜c3 ♞d8 13 ♞fd1 0-0 14 a3 was the course of V.Mikhalevsky-Beshukov, Saint Vincent 2000, 14...♜d5 15 ♞xc4 ♜b6 16 ♞c5 ♜xd4 17 ♞ab1 providing White with compensation thanks to Black's loose pawns. Kobylkin-Nadyrhanov, Krasnodar 2002 continued 10...0-0 11 ♜xc6 ♜xc6 12 ♞xc4 e5 13 dxe5 ♜xe5 14 ♞d5 (more promising than 14 ♞f4 ♞e7 15 ♜c3 c6 16 ♞fd1 f6 17 ♞d4 ♞fd8 18 ♞ad1 ♙e6 with equal chances in O'Connide-Adams, Kilkenny 1999) 14...♞f6 15 ♞xb7 ♙c6 16 ♙xc6 ♜xc6 17 ♜c3 ♞ab8 18 ♞xc7 ♞fc8 19 ♞d7 ♞d8 20 ♞g4 ♞b4 21 ♞h5 ♞xb2 and

Black achieved some chances but was still a pawn down, Nadyrhanov evaluating the position after 22 ♞fc1 ♜d4 23 ♞ab1 ♞d2 24 ♞b7 g6 25 ♞g4 as slightly favourable for White.

10...♜d3+!



11 ♜xd3 cxd3 12 e3 d2+ 13 ♙xd2 e5 14 d5

With the king on d2 White has to keep the position closed.

14...♜e7 15 ♞e4 0-0

Black can opt for an equal endgame with 15...♙c6 16 ♞xe5 ♙xd5 17 ♙xd5 ♞xd5+ 18 ♞xd5 ♜xd5.

16 ♙e2

16 ♞xe5 runs into 16...♜xd5!, e.g. 17 ♙xd5 (17 ♞xd5 ♙c6 gives Black a superior ending in view of his stronger minor piece) 17...♙e6 18 e4 c6 and Black opens the centre and begins an attack against the troubled king.

16...c6 17 ♞xe5

17 d6 ♜f5 18 ♞hd1 ♞f6 and Black has the initiative. The d6-pawn is a bit loose.

17...♜xd5 18 ♙xd5 cxd5 19 ♞hd1 ♙c6 20 ♜d4?!

20 ♜c2 ♞e8 21 ♞f5 ♞b6 and White has no time to consolidate with ♜d4. Black's initiative is too strong.

20...♞e8 21 ♞f5?

A lesser evil is 21 ♞f4 ♞b6 22 ♞b4 ♞a6+, although Black retains the upper hand.

21...♞b6 22 ♜c2

22 ♖d2 d4! blows away the defences.

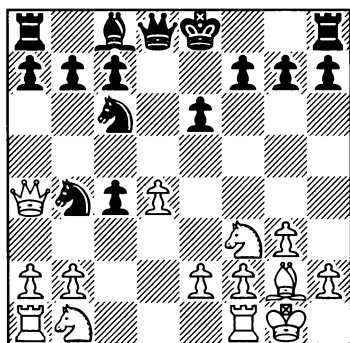
22...g6 23 ♖g5 ♖xb2

Black is winning.

24 ♖d2 ♖e4 25 ♖c1 ♖c8 26 ♖xe4 dxe4
27 ♖a5 ♖b5 0-1

Game 75
Filipov-Rausis
Dubai 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5
♖g2 ♖c6 6 ♖a4 ♖b4+ 7 ♖d2 ♖d5 8
♖xb4 ♖xb4 9 0-0



9...♖b8 10 ♖c3

10 ♖e5?! is a dubious idea, for after 10...♖xd4 11 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 12 ♖xc6+ bxc6 13 ♖xc6+ ♖d7 14 ♖xc7 0-0 – as in the previous game – the light-squared bishop gives Black the better chances.

After 10 ♖a3 ♖d7 11 ♖b5 White collects the pawn with the usual Catalan space advantage, while Wojtkiewicz-Krasenkow, Manila 1998 went 11 ♖e5 0-0 12 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 13 ♖xc4!, the subsequent 13...♖xd4 14 ♖xc6 ♖xc4 15 ♖xc4 bxc6 16 b3 ♖d8 17 ♖fd1 ♖d7 18 ♖d2 leading to a pleasant ending for White in view of Black's poor pawns. However, in Wojtkiewicz-Yuneev, Yerevan 1996 Black fared better, the simple and sensible 10...0-0 11 ♖b5 b6, with the idea of ...♖a6, being a common theme in the Catalan. There followed 12 ♖xc4 ♖a6 13 ♖b5 ♖d5 14 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 15 a4 ♖a5 16 ♖e5 ♖bd8 17

♖ac1 ♖b3 18 ♖cd1 ♖b4 19 e3 c5 with equal chances.

10...a6

10...0-0 11 a3 ♖d5 12 ♖xc4 ♖a5 13 ♖d3 favours White, but 10...♖d7 leads to complicated play, e.g. 11 a3 b5 12 ♖xb5 ♖d5 (12...a6 13 ♖c3 ♖xd4 14 ♖a5! ♖b3 15 ♖e5 f6 16 ♖e4 ♖xa1 17 axb4 ♖b3 18 ♖xc4 ♖e7 19 ♖xb3 and the knights are stronger than the rook) 13 ♖c3 (13 e4 ♖ce7 14 exd5 ♖xb5 15 ♖xa7 c3 and Black has good counterplay) 13...♖xb2 14 ♖xc4 ♖a5 15 ♖d3 ♖b3 16 ♖fc1 c5 17 ♖d2! c4 18 ♖e5 ♖xc3 19 ♖xc3 and White's centre was the difference in Romanishin-Aleksandrov, Pula 1990.

11 ♖e5

11 a3 b5 12 ♖d1 ♖d5 is nice for Black. 11 ♖fc1, on the other hand, is more to the point: 11...0-0 12 ♖d1 b5 13 b3 ♖a5 14 ♖e4 ♖d5 15 ♖c5 ♖b6 16 ♖e5 f6 17 b4 fxe5 18 bxa5 exd4 19 axb6 (Nedobora-Sjödahl, La Coruna 1993) 19...cxb6!? with an unclear position.

11...0-0

11...♖xd4 is thematic, e.g. 12 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 13 ♖xc6+ bxc6 14 ♖xc6+ ♖d7 15 ♖xc4 0-0 16 b3 ♖e7 17 ♖a4, Lavrov-Raetsky, Lipetsk 1993. In this knight versus bishop middle-game Black's weaknesses on the queenside are more important than the compromised light squares around the white king. Nevertheless, White's advantage is only small.

12 ♖xc6

12 ♖xc6 bxc6 13 a3 ♖d5 14 ♖xc4 ♖xb2 15 e3 is also possible. White has a good pawn structure and compensation for the pawn.

12...♖xc6 13 ♖xc6 bxc6 14 ♖xc4

14 ♖xc6 ♖xd4 15 ♖fd1 ♖e5 16 ♖d2 ♖b4 17 ♖ad1 ♖b7 18 ♖d7 ♖c5 was balanced in Rashkovsky-S.Ivanov, Elista 1995.

14...♖d6!?

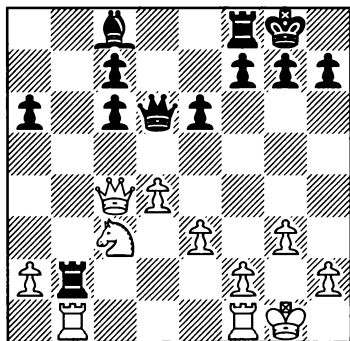
The immediate capture on b2 needs investigating: 14...♖xb2 15 ♖ab1 ♖b6 (15...♖d2!? 16 e3 e5 17 dxe5 ♖f5 is interesting) 16 ♖c5 h6 17 ♖fd1 ♖xb1 (17...♖d7 18 a4 ♖b8 19 a5 ♖b2 20 ♖a3 ♖xb1 21 ♖xb1 ♖a7 22 ♖c5

♖xc5 23 dxc5 ♙c8 favoured White in Cs.Horvath-Luther, Budapest 1991) 18 ♜xb1 ♜d6 19 ♘e4 ♜d5 20 ♜xd5 cxd5 21 ♘c5 ♜e8 22 ♜b8 was seen in Khalifman-S.Ivanov, St. Petersburg 1996. Despite the pawn deficit White's chances are preferable because Black's bishop is quite poor at the moment and White has a firm grip on the dark squares.

15 e3

White can't protect both b2 and d4, so he has to choose. 15 b3 ♜b4 16 ♘e4 ♜xc4 17 ♘xd6 ♜xd4 18 ♘xc8 ♜xc8 19 ♜fc1 a5 20 ♜xc6 a4 21 ♜ac1 g6 was agreed drawn in Mittelman-Zifroni, Tel Aviv 2001, but 15 ♘e4!? is interesting, e.g. 15...♜d5 16 ♜c2 ♜xd4 17 b3 ♜b5 18 ♜fd1 ♜e5 19 ♘c3 ♜c5 20 ♜d3 with an edge for White in Kamenets-Mohrlock, Correspondence 2001.

15...♜xb2 16 ♜ab1



16...♜b6

Also possible is 16...♜xb1 17 ♜xb1 e5 18 dxe5 ♜xe5 19 ♜xc6 ♙h3 20 ♘e2 g5 21 ♜h6 ♜e4 22 ♜xg5+ with a draw in Rausis-Nisipeanu, Cappelle la Grande 2002. Here White can be more ambitious with 20 ♘d5 ♜d8 21 ♘f4 ♙f5 22 ♜c1, but Black gets excellent counterplay due to the weakness of the light squares – 22...♙e4 23 ♜xa6 g5 (Nisipeanu & Stoica).

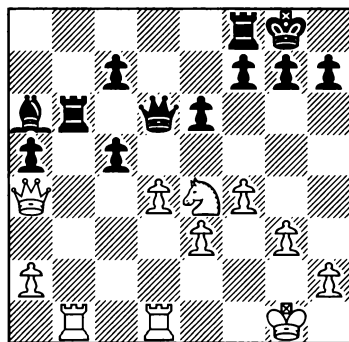
17 f4

White prevents the thematic ...e6-e5 break. 17 ♘a4 ♜b5 doesn't force Black to surrender the b-file, while after 17 ♜fc1 e5 18 dxe5 ♜xe5 19 ♜xb6 cxb6 20 ♜xc6 ♜a5 Black has a good position.

17...a5 18 ♜a4 ♙a6 19 ♜fd1 c5!?

19...♜fb8 20 ♜xa5 ♙c4 can also be considered. The position remains unclear.

20 ♘e4



20...♜d5 21 ♜xb6 ♜xe4 22 ♜xa6 ½-½

Black forces a draw by repetition.

Summary

After 6 0-0 ♜b8 White's strongest seems to be 7 ♜c3. Then after 7...♙b4 White can claim a slight advantage after both 8 ♙g5 and 8 ♜c2. In reply to 7...b5, reacting with 8 e4 is not in White's interest, but Black should probably avoid the unclear 8...b4 and develop naturally with 8...♙e7. It is interesting that the game can transpose to the 'normal' variation 5...♙e7 6 0-0 0-0 7 ♜c3 ♜c6 8 e4 ♜b8 followed by 9...b5, as seen in the notes to Game 27 in Chapter 4. Instead the best way to meet the early push of the b-pawn is undoubtedly 8 ♙e5. Sufficient research has been carried out on the line 8...♙xe5 9 dxe5 ♜d7 10 ♙xc6 a6 11 ♜xd4 ♙b7 12 ♙xb7 ♜xb7 13 ♜d1. Here it is not so easy for White to demonstrate compensation for the pawn, so it is necessary to pay attention to 10 ♜d4! (Game 66).

Now we turn to 6 ♜a4. The strategy beginning with 6...♙d7 appears not to offer Black equality. In the main variation 7 ♜xc4 ♙a5 8 ♜d3 c5 9 0-0 ♙c6 10 ♜c3 Black can choose between the plan with ...c5-c4 (immediately or – as is seen more often – after 10...♜c8 11 ♜d1) or the less ambitious exchange on d4. In the former case White is given the pawn majority in the centre and often develops an initiative through the positional breakthrough d4-d5 (see, for example, Ftacnik-Lechtinsky in Game 67, note to Black's 10th move). After 10...cxd4 the game tends to be simplified and it is not so easy for Black to neutralise the slight but often enduring superiority enjoyed by White.

After 6...♙d7 7 ♜xc4 ♙b6 8 ♜d3 e5 9 ♙e3 White cannot realistically claim a genuine advantage, but Black must be careful to avoid quickly running into trouble (see Raetsky-S.Ivanov, Game 68 – including Filippov-Short). In the case of 9 ♙xe5 ♙b4 the queen moves to d1 and b3 fail to furnish White with anything positive, and nor does 10 ♜c3 if Black plays 10...♜xd4 11 0-0 ♜xc3 12 ♜xc3.

As a whole the variation starting with 6...♙d7 contains numerous areas for new discoveries. For example 9...♙d4 has never been tested despite the fact that we do not see how White should achieve any appreciable advantage.

Another deviation from the main line (which, of course, is 6...♙b4+), namely 6...♙d6, is quite playable. After 7 0-0 0-0 8 ♜d1 Black can exploit the absence of White's bishop from d2 (as opposed to the modern line 6...♙b4+ 7 ♙d2 ♙d6 8 0-0 0-0) by playing 8...♙b4, illustrating the downside to the posting of White's queen on a4 (Polgar-Benjamin, Game 70). If White is not suited to these complex positions it is better to allow ...e6-e5 with 8 ♜xc4, or to play another line starting with 7 ♙bd2.

The theory of the line with 6...♙b4+ 7 ♙d2 ♙d6 has only just begun to develop. It is particularly difficult to evaluate how the chances are divided after 8 ♙e5. After 8 ♜xc4 0-0 9 0-0 e5 10 dxe5 almost all games have ended in a draw, and White, if he is looking to achieve something in the opening, should go for 10 d5 ♙e7 11 ♜c3.

After 6 ♜a4 ♙b4+ 7 ♙d2 ♙d5 the manoeuvre 8 ♜b5 loses time and is not dangerous for Black, who should simply continue with 8...0-0. For example in Grabliauskas-Benjamin (Game 72) an important feature is the potentially precarious situation of White's king, which is stuck in the centre.

In the very sharp line 8 ♙xb4 ♙xb4 9 a3 b5 10 ♜xb5 ♜c2 11 ♙d2 several recommendations can be made for Black. First there is 11...♙d7! 12 ♙xc2 ♙xd4+ 13 ♙xd4 ♙xb5 14 ♙xb5 ♜b8 (Chetverik-Grabliauskas in Game 73, note to Black's 11th move), which is not often quoted, although Black's queen does not seem to be inferior to White's three pieces. Secondly, Black no longer plays 11...♙xa1 12 ♜xc6+ ♙d7 13 ♜xc4 ♜b8 14 b4 c5!, but all the possibilities have not been refuted here. Finally, the modern line 13...c5 14 ♜a2 ♜a5 15 ♜c3

cx d4 16 ♖xd4 ♙d8 also gives Black sufficient counterplay (according to analysis by Timoschenko) due to White's vulnerable king.

In the solid variation with 9 0-0 we have seen considerable changes in recent fashion. The position after 9...♙b8 10 ♖c3 a6 11 ♖e5 0-0 12 ♙xc6 ♖xc6 13 ♖xc6 ♙xc6 14. ♗xc4 ♗d6!? has become critical:

Black prevents the enemy queen from taking up a dominating position on c5. If White does give up the b2-pawn Black's rook will have other qualities than those of a savage killer on the b-file (15 b3 ♙b4 and 15 ♖e4 ♗d5 16 ♗c2 ♗xd4 17 b3 ♙b5 should be noted). We do not see anything special for White here. More attention might be given to Wojtkiewicz' 10 ♖a3, which sees the knight monitor both c4 and b5. If Black doesn't play 10...a6 White regains his pawn with the familiar manoeuvre ♗b5-c4.

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♖c6 6 ♗a4

6 0-0 ♙b8 (D)

7 e3 – Game 61

7 a4

7...a6 – Game 51 (Chapter 5); 7...b6 – Game 62

7 ♖c3

7...♙b4

8 e3 – Game 63; 8 ♗c2 – Game 64

7...b5

8 e4 – Game 65; 8 ♖e5 – Game 66

6...♙b4+

6...♙d7 – Game 67

6...♙d6 – Game 70

6...♖d7 7 ♗xc4 ♖b6 8 ♗d3 e5 (D)

9 ♙e3 – Game 68; 9 ♖xe5 – Game 69

7 ♙d2 ♖d5

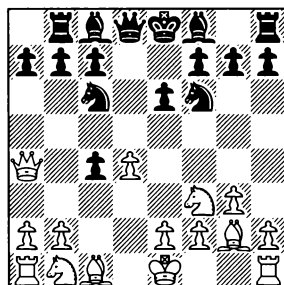
7...♙d6 – Game 71

8 ♙xb4

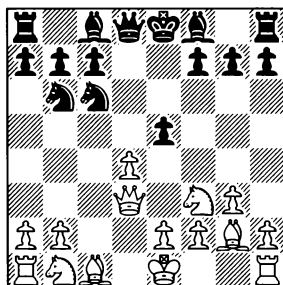
8 ♗b5 – Game 72

8...♖dxb4 (D)

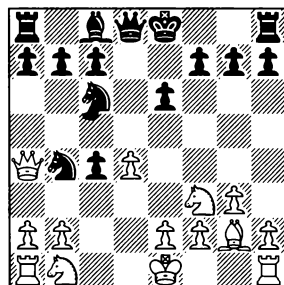
9 a3 – Game 73; 9 ♖e5 – Game 74; 9 0-0 – Game 75



6...♙b8



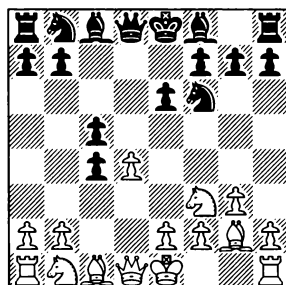
8...e5



8...♖dxb4

CHAPTER SEVEN

4...dxc4 5 ♖g2 c5



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♙f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 c5

This is a rather logical continuation. 4...dxc4 has already given Black sight of the d4-pawn and what would be more natural than for Black to immediately contest the centre in this manner? Consequently it is not surprising that the 5...c5 system has maintained its popularity since its use during the early days of the Catalan.

In reply to 5...c5 White occasionally continues 6 ♖a4+ (Game 76), and of course this can transpose to 5 ♖a4+. The variation with 6 ♖a4+ ♗d7 7 ♖xc4 ♗c6 was tested twice in the Kasparov-Korchnoi encounters in London in 1983. Black solved the problems with his queen's bishop and managed to equalise with accurate play. Therefore 6 ♖a4+ has lost ground to the modern 6 0-0. Here Black is not obliged to resolve matters in centre at once with 6...cxd4 (Game 77), when White gets an enduring, albeit tiny advantage after both 7 ♖xd4 and 7 ♘xd4. With this in mind Black almost always prefers 6...♗c6, increasing the pressure on the d4-pawn. White must act quickly if he is to achieve anything positive. The exchange in the centre with 7 dxc5 is harmless for Black as he has good development, but the direct 7 ♗e5 presents Black with serious problems to

address. After 7...♗xe5 8 dxe5 ♖xd1 9 ♖xd1 ♗d5 (or 9...♗d7) the manoeuvre ♗a3xc4 regains the pawn and secures a small but steady advantage, while even 8...♗d5 (Game 78) favours White.

The main answer to 7 ♗e5 is 7...♗d7. Now White must choose between 8 ♗c6, 8 ♗c4 and the main move 8 ♗a3 (Games 79 & 80).

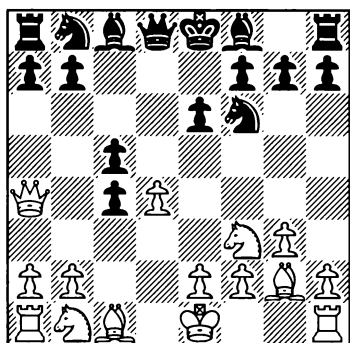
Another common continuation in the diagram position above is the standard attack with the queen – 7 ♖a4. Then we have a branch with 7...cxd4 (Game 81) and 7...♗d7 (Games 82 & 83). After 7...cxd4 8 ♗xd4 ♖xd4 9 ♗xc6+ ♗d7 10 ♖d1 the ending that results from 10...♗c6 11 ♖xc6 bxc6 12 ♖d4 tends to be inferior for Black, which explains why there is a preference for sacrificing the queen for rook, bishop and pawn with 10...♖xd1 11 ♖xd1 ♗xc6.

In the case of 7 ♖a4 the reply 7...♗d7 has become increasingly popular. It has been established that 8 dxc5 does not confer an advantage due to 8...♗a5 9 ♖c2 ♗xc5, which brings us to the main continuation, 8 ♖c4, when Black has two possibilities – 8...cxd4 (Game 82) and 8...b5 (Game 83). Portisch-Radulov and Ribli-Ljubojevic received much attention and must have helped in promoting the popularity of 7 ♖a4.

White plays 6 ♖a4+

Game 76
Inkiöv-Pinter
Zagreb 1987

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5
♙g2 c5 6 ♖a4+



6...♙d7

Of independent relevance is 6...♙c6. Then 7 0-0 ♙d7 transposes to 6 0-0 ♙c6 7 ♖a4 ♙d7 below (Game 82). 7 dxc5 ♙xc5 8 0-0 9 ♖xc4 ♖d5 10 ♖fd2 ♖xc4 11 ♙xc4 ♖d4 12 ♖c3 ♙b4 13 e3 ♙xc3 14 bxc3 ♖e2+ 15 ♖h1 ♖xc1 16 ♖fxc1 ♖b8 17 e4 ♖d7 18 f4 b6 19 ♖d6 ♙b7 20 ♖d1 ♖c5 achieved nothing for White in Balashov-Beliavsky, Vilnius 1980.

This leaves 7 ♖e5 ♖d5 (7...♙d7 8 ♖xc6 ♙xc6 9 ♙xc6+ bxc6 10 0-0 transposes to 6 0-0 ♖c6 7 ♖e5 ♙d7 8 ♖xc6 ♙xc6 9 ♙xc6+ bxc6 10 ♖a4, dealt with in Game 79) 8 ♖xc6 bxc6 (8...♙d7 9 ♖xc4 ♖xc6 10 ♖c3 cxd4 11 ♖xd4 ♖b6 12 ♖xb6 ♖xb6 13 0-0 favours White because Black is behind in development and is under pressure on the long diagonal) 9 dxc5 ♙b7 10 ♖xc4 ♖a5+ 11 ♙d2 ♖xc5 12 ♖xc5 ♙xc5 13 ♖c3 and White has a slight but enduring edge.

7 ♖xc4 ♙c6 8 0-0

Another possibility is 8 dxc5, when 8...♖d5 9 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 10 ♖e5 should favour White. Indeed 10...♖b4 11 ♖xc6

♖8xc6 12 ♖a3 ♙xc5 13 ♙d2 0-0 14 0-0 ♙d4 15 ♖c4 ♖ab8 16 a3 ♖d5 17 ♖ac1 ♙f6 18 e3 was rather pleasant in Keres-Klovan, Parnu 1960. Black needs to be active, and a good try is 8...♖bd7 9 ♙e3 ♙d5 10 ♖b4 a5, which was the subject of Sosonko-Farago, Wijk aan Zee 1988. The game continued 11 ♖h4 ♙xc5 12 ♙xc5 ♖xc5 13 ♖c3 ♙xf3 14 ♙xf3 0-0 15 0-0 ♖b6 16 ♖a4 ♖xa4 17 ♖xa4 ♖ad8 18 ♖ad1 ♖xb2 19 ♖xa5 ♖a8 20 ♖d2 ♖xa5 21 ♖xb2 ♖d5 and the simplifications and the pressure against a2 left Black with no problems and should have resulted in a draw. This is certainly an improvement for Black on 10...♖c8 11 ♖c3 ♙xc5 12 ♙xc5 ♖xc5 13 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 14 ♖d2 ♖c8 15 0-0 0-0 16 ♖ac1 ♖b6 17 ♖d4 ♖fd8 18 ♖fd1 ♖xd4 19 ♖xd4, which led to White's standard Catalan advantage of bishop versus knight in Korchnoi-Kasparov, World Championship Candidates Match (game 8), London 1983.

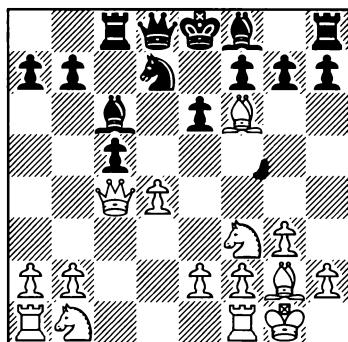
8...♖bd7 9 ♙g5

9 ♖c3 is rendered harmless by 9...b5!, the point being that 10 ♖xb5?? ♖b6 11 ♖b3 c4 sees White lose the knight. After 10 ♖d3 c4 11 ♖c2 b4 12 ♖d1 ♖b6 13 ♙g5 ♙e7 14 ♖e3 ♖c8 only Black can claim to be better.

9...♖c8

Black can also equalise with 9...♖b6 10 ♖d3 cxd4 11 ♖bd2 ♙e7 12 ♖xd4 ♙xg2 13 ♖xg2 0-0 etc.

10 ♙xf6



10...gxf6!

Perhaps too inventive for some, but Black does not want to recapture with a piece. In fact after 10...♟xf6 White is guaranteed a slight edge with 11 dxc5 ♟xf3 12 ♟xf3 ♟xc5 13 ♖b5+ (13 e3!?), when Kasparov-Korchnoi, World Championship Candidates Match (game 7), London 1983 went 13...♗d7 14 ♟c3 ♖xb5 15 ♟xb5 ♟e7 16 b4 ♟xb4 17 ♟xa7. Then Black's best is to keep his disadvantage to a minimum with 17...♞a8 18 ♟b5 ♞a5.

10...♗xf6 looks the safest. Korchnoi gives 11 ♟c3 ♟e7 12 e4 0-0 13 d5 ♟b6 14 ♗d3 exd5 15 exd5 ♞fd8 16 ♟d2 c4 17 ♟xc4 ♟xc4 18 ♖xc4 ♟xd5 19 ♟xd5 ♞xc4 20 ♟xf6+ ♟xf6 when the draw is imminent.

11 ♟c3

11 dxc5?! ♟xc5 12 ♖g4 ♖b6 is awkward for White as the b2-pawn is under fire.

11...b5 12 ♗d3 c4 13 ♖c2 b4 14 ♟e4 ♟b6 15 g4?!

This move is hard to justify and should land White in trouble if Black were to react accurately. 15 e3 f5 16 ♟ed2 c3 also gives Black a good game.

15...h5?!

Overlooking 15...♞g8! 16 h3 (16 g5 fxe5 17 ♟e5 ♟a4! and White is in a very bad way) 16...h5 17 gxh5 f5 with a decisive attack.

16 g5 fxe5?!

16...♟xe4 17 ♖xe4 fxe5 18 ♟e5 ♟g7! is preferable, after which the situation is far from clear.

17 ♟exg5 ♟g7

17...♟e7? runs into 18 ♟xf7! ♟xf7 19 ♟e5+ etc.

18 h4 ♟f6

18...♟xd4? 19 ♞ad1 ♟a4 20 b3 cxb3 21 ♖e4! gives White a strong attack (Inkiöv).

19 e4 ♟g5

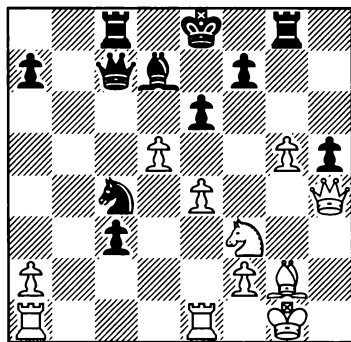
19...c3!? is a sound alternative, 20 bxc3 bxc3 21 a4 leaving both sides with much to play for.

20 hxg5 ♞g8 21 ♞fe1 ♟a4 22 ♖d2 c3 23 bxc3 bxc3 24 ♖f4 ♖c7

Black needs to be careful. 24...♟c4 25 ♞ac1 c2 26 d5 ♗d6 27 ♖f6 is double-edged.

25 ♖h4 ♟c4 26 d5

26 ♖xh5?! succeeds only in providing Black with a large helping of counterplay after 26...♖f4! (the h-pawn is practically worthless).

26...♟d7**27 dxe6?!**

27 e5! exd5 28 ♟d4! is stronger. After 28...♟e6 (28...♖c5 29 e6! puts Black's king in danger) 29 ♖xh5 ♖b6 30 ♟xe6 ♖xe6 31 ♟h3 ♖e7 32 ♟h1 White has a wonderful attack.

27...♟xe6 28 ♟d4 ♟g4 29 ♟f5 ♟e5 30 ♖g3 ♞d8?!

Black's play seems to be a little planless, an appropriate course being 30...♟f3! 31 ♞e3 c2 32 ♞c1 in order to generate counterplay. The most obvious move is then 32...♟d1, when the c-pawn is certainly a factor, but after 33 ♞b3! with the idea of 34 ♞b7! the situation remains a complete mess. A possible conclusion to the game is 33...♞g6 (protecting d6) 34 ♞b7 ♖xb7 35 ♖xe5+ ♟d8 36 ♖h8+ ♟c7 37 ♖e5+ with a draw by perpetual check.

31 ♞ac1 ♞d3

31...c2? 32 ♞xc2! is simply a terrible blunder, while after 31...h4 32 ♖xh4 ♞d2 33 ♟h6! ♞h8 34 ♖g3 Black is also in dire straits. Perhaps it is already too late to save the game.

32 ♖e3 ♗e2?!

32...♙xe3 33 ♖xe3 c2 34 f3! ♗xf5 35 exf5 ♗f8 36 f6 wins for White.

33 ♙xd3 ♗xd3 34 f4 h4

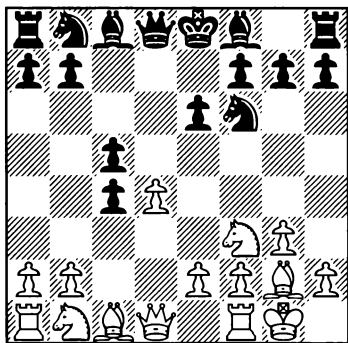
34...♖b6+ 35 ♖e3 ♗g4 36 ♖xb6 axb6 37 ♙xc3 and White wins.

35 ♖e3 ♗g4 36 ♖xd3 1-0

Black meets 6 0-0 with 6...cxd4

Game 77 Chetverik-Ivan Harkany 1996

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♗f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♗g2 c5 6 0-0



6...cxd4

Black has more colourful alternatives. Razuvayev-Feller, Poland 1988 continued 6...a6 7 dxc5 ♖xd1 8 ♙xd1 ♗xc5 9 ♗e5 ♗bd7 10 ♗xc4 ♙a7 11 ♗c3 with an edge for White. There followed 11...b5?! 12 ♗d6+, when Black could have minimised the damage caused by the weakening thrust of the b-pawn with 12...♗xd6 13 ♙xd6 ♗e7 14 ♙c6 ♗b8 15 ♙c5 ♗d7 16 ♗f4 ♗b7 17 a4, although this is nevertheless rather unpleasant. Instead after 12...♗e7? 13 ♗ce4 ♗xe4 14 ♗xe4 ♙c7 15 ♗d2! White was already winning.

6...♗d7 is more interesting for Black, e.g. 7 ♗a3 ♗c6 8 ♗xc4 ♗bd7 9 ♗f4 cxd4 10 ♗d6+ (10 ♗xd4!? might be an improvement)

10...♗xd6 11 ♗xd6 ♗xf3! 12 ♗xf3 ♖b6 13 ♗a3 0-0-0! as in Bogdanovsky-Smagin, Pilep 1992. Smagin gives 14 ♙c1+ ♗b8 15 ♙c4 ♗e5 16 ♗b4 ♗xf3+ 17 exf3 ♖c6 18 ♙xd4 ♗d5 as level.

7 ♗xd4

White has a decent alternative in 7 ♖xd4 ♖xd4 8 ♗xd4 a6 9 ♗d2 ♗c5 10 ♗c2 c3 11 bxc3 ♗bd7 12 ♗b3! ♗e7 13 ♙b1, when the open file is perfect compensation for the isolated pawns. The subsequent 13...♗d5 14 ♗d2 b5 15 ♗b4 ♗7b6 16 ♗a5 ♗d7 17 ♗xd5 exd5 18 c4! ♗f5 19 e4! ♗xe4 20 ♗xe4 dxe4 21 cxb5 leaves Black somewhat worse in view of the passed pawn and his slightly inferior development, while Balashov-A.Petrosian, Yerevan 1986 favoured White after 17...♗xd5 18 c4 bxc4 19 ♗xc4 ♗b5 20 ♙fc1 0-0 21 a4! ♗xc4 22 ♙xc4 ♙ac8 23 ♙bc1.

7...♗a6!?

7...♖b6 8 ♗c3 ♗d7 9 ♗e3! looks dangerous for Black, who should respond with 9...♗g4!? or 9...♗a6!? rather than follow the example of V.Mikhalevsky-Murey, Israel 1997, when the experienced GM went for the bait with 9...♗c5?! and ran into 10 b4! cxb3 11 ♙b1! ♗xd4 12 ♗xd4 ♖c7 13 ♙xb3 ♗c6 14 ♙a3!, the further 14...♗xg2?! 15 ♗b5 ♖d7 16 ♗d6+ ♗f8 17 ♗xg2 ♖c6+ 18 ♗g1 ♗a6 19 ♖xa6 bxa6 20 ♗xf6! gxf6 21 ♙b7 resulting in a decisive lead for White.

8 ♗a3!?

8 ♖a4+ ♗d7 9 ♖xc4 ♙c8 followed by ...♗c5 is no worse for Black.

8...♗xa3 9 bxa3 0-0 10 ♗b2 ♖b6 11 ♖c2 ♗d7

11...♗d8 12 ♗f3! and White has a strong position. Black needs to get his development going.

12 ♙ab1 ♖c7 13 ♗f3 ♙ac8

13...c3 14 ♗xc3!? ♙fc8 15 ♙fc1 ♗d5 looks strong but White has a counter with 16 ♗g5 ♗xc3 17 ♖xh7+ ♗f8 18 ♖h8+ ♗e7 19 ♖xg7 and Black is forced into 19...♗xe2+ 20 ♗f1 ♗xc1 21 ♖xf7+ ♗d6, when White has

no more than perpetual check – 22 ♖f4+
 ♙e7 23 ♖f7+ ♙d6 24 ♜e4+ ♙d5! 25 ♜d2+
 ♙d6 26 ♜e4+ ♙d5 and White cannot make
 progress.

14 e5 c5 **15** fd1 q4

Both the lines 15...♖fd8 16 ♖d4 and 15...♙c6 16 ♙xf6 gxf6 17 ♗c3 give White good compensation for the pawn on the kingside.

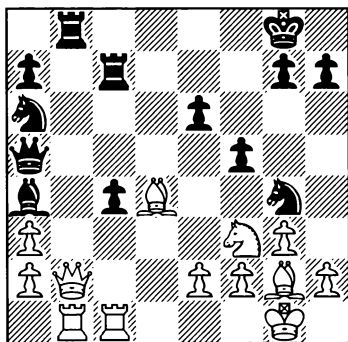
16 ♖d4 ♔a5 17 ♔e4

17 ♖c3! ♖a4 18 ♔c1 is a possible improvement.

17...f5?!

17...e5 is necessary. After 18 ♖xa7 the game can swing either way.

18 ♔xb7 ♖c7 19 ♔b2 ♙a4 20 ♖dc1 ♖b8



Allowing a nice queen sacrifice, but by now Black is already walking on thin ice. 20...h6 21 h3 ♖f6 22 ♕e5 illustrates White's complete control over the centre.

21 ♖xb8+! ♜xb8 22 ♖xb8+ ♔f7 23 ♜g5+ ♔e7 24 ♙c3 ♖a6 25 ♖g8 e5?

Black can still put up some resistance with 25...♖b6 26 ♖xg7+ ♘e8 27 ♖g8+ ♘e7, although White can look forward to a powerful attack after 28 e3.

26 ♖xg7+ ♔f6

26...♔d8 27 ♖a5! and White wins.

27 ♖xc7 ♔xq5 28 ♖xc4!

Now Black can no longer defend.

28...♙b5 29 ♖c7 ♜b6 30 ♙d2+ ♚h5 31
e3 h6 32 ♙b4 ♙a4 33 ♙d5 ♙e8 34 h3
♜f6 35 ♙f3+ ♚g5 36 ♜g7+ 1-0

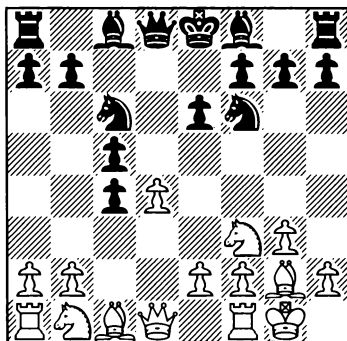
White plays 6 O-O c6 7 e5

Game 78

Ksieski-Enders

Bad Harzburg 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 f3 f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 g2 c5 6 0-0 c6



7  e5

This is probably the most ambitious choice. Indeed 7 dxc5 ♖xd1 8 ♜xd1 ♙xc5 appears insufficient for an advantage, e.g. 9 ♖bd2 c3 10 bxc3 0-0 11 ♖b3 ♙e7 12 ♖fd4 ♙d7 13 ♙g5 ♜ac8 14 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 15 ♖c5 ♖xd4 16 cxd4 ♙b5 with equality in Speelman-Van der Sterren, Yerevan 1996. 7 ♖a4 features in Games 81-83 below.

7...♘xe5

This is, of course, not forced. 7...♔d7, which is considered in the next two main games, should be the strongest alternative. 7...♟xd4??, on the other hand, spells disaster for Black due to 8 e3 ♟f5 9 ♖xd8+ ♕xd8 10 ♟xf7+ and White wins. 7...♞d5 8 ♟xc6 bxc6 9 dxc5 ♙xc5 10 ♖a4 ♗b6 11 ♞d2 favours White, e.g. 11...♙a6 12 ♟xc4 ♗b5 13 ♗xb5 cxb5 14 ♞e5 b4 15 ♞d1 ♙b7 16 ♞d2 ♙e7 17 ♞ac1 a5 18 e4 ♟f6 19 ♙g5 ♙d8 20 ♞c4 0-0 21 ♞d6 with a pleasant game for White in Savchenko-Galliamova, Rostov 1996.

8 dxe5 d5

Black cannot equalise here. 8...♘d7 9 f4 ♖b8 10 a4 ♙e7 11 ♘a3 b6 12 ♘xc4 ♙b7 13

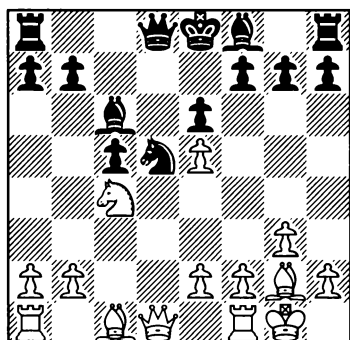
b3 ♖xg2 14 ♖xg2 ♚c7 15 ♖b2 ♚c6+ 16 ♖g1 0-0 17 ♚c2 ♚bd8 18 e4 was better for White in Lingnau-Klovans, Berlin 1996, and 8...♚xd1 9 ♚xd1 ♖d7 10 f4 ♚b8 11 a4 ♖e7 12 ♖a3 0-0 13 ♖xc4 is also very pleasant for White, who was successful in Hajtun-Gecsei, Budapest 1951: 13...b6 14 ♖d6 ♚d8 15 ♖e3 ♖xd6 16 ♚xd6 ♖b7 17 ♚ad1 ♖xg2 18 ♖xg2 ♚b7 19 f5 h6 20 g4 ♖f8 21 g5! exf5 22 gxh6 gxh6 23 ♚xh6 ♚db8 24 ♚xd7! and White won.

9 ♖a3

Another strong option is 9 ♚a4! ♖d7 10 ♚xc4, when Black needs to find an improvement on Vaulin-Koc, Koszalin 1997, which went 10...♖c6 11 ♖c3 ♚d7 12 ♚d1 b5 13 ♚g4 ♚b7 14 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 15 ♖xd5 exd5 16 e6 ♚d8 17 ♖g5 ♖e7 18 ♖xe7 ♚xe7 19 ♚xg7 and White was already close to winning.

9...♖d7

Black does not have time for 9...c3 10 bxc3 ♖xc3 11 ♚c2 ♖d5 12 ♚d1 ♖d7 13 ♖c4 which put the defender under too much pressure in Andersson-Guyot, France 1993, when 13...♚c8 14 ♖b2 ♖e7 15 ♖d6+ ♖xd6 16 exd6 0-0 17 ♖xd5 exd5 18 ♚xd5 left White with a clear advantage. However, Black's capitulation soon followed as 18...b6? met with immediate punishment in the form of 19 ♖xg7! ♖xg7 20 ♚g5+ ♖h8 21 ♚h5 etc. 10 ♖xc4 ♖c6



11 e4!

White should play with energy. After the quieter 11 b3 White achieved little in Raetsky-Enders, Forchtenberg 1997, when 11...♖b4 12 ♖b2 ♖xg2 13 ♖xg2 ♚d5+ 14 ♚xd5 exd5 15 ♖d6+ ♖xd6 16 exd6 ♖d7 17 ♖xg7 ♚hg8 18 ♖c3 ♖c6 saw the game drift into equality.

11...♖b6 12 ♖d6+ ♖xd6 13 exd6

This pawn can easily be underestimated. Karpov and Kramnik are known masters in exploiting such circumstances.

13...♖c4?!

A lesser evil is 13...0-0 14 ♖e3 ♖d7 15 ♚c2 with a clear advantage for White.

14 ♚c2!

Black will soon find that winning the pawn is not much fun.

14...♖xd6 15 ♚d1 ♚e7 16 ♖e3 b6 17 ♖xc5! bxc5 18 ♚xc5 ♚b7?!

18...♖b7 19 ♚xd6 is more accurate, although White still has a pawn for nothing.

19 ♚xd6 1-0

Black has had enough.

Game 79

Shipov-Volzhin

Hastings 1997/98

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 c5 6 0-0 ♖c6 7 ♖e5 ♖d7 8 ♖a3!

This has become the modern way to handle the position, taking over from continuations such as 8 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 9 ♖xc6+ bxc6 10 ♚a4, e.g. 10...cx4 (10...♚b6 11 dxc5 ♖xc5 12 ♚xc4 ♚d8 13 ♖d2 ♚b5 14 ♚xb5 cxb5 15 ♖b3 ♖b6 was even in Belichev-Mukhametov, Yalta 1995) 11 ♚xc6+ ♖d7 12 ♚xc4 ♖c5. Then 13 ♖d2 0-0 14 ♖e4 ♖b6 15 ♖g5 ♖e5 16 ♚b5 might look like Black is under pressure but after 16...♚d5! 17 ♚xd5 exd5 18 ♖d2 f6 19 ♖f4 ♖c4 20 a4 ♚fe8 it was actually the other way around in Pavlovic-Byrne, New York 1997. Salov-A.Sokolov, Sochi 1982 went 13 b4 ♖b6 14 ♖b2 ♚c8 15 ♚b3 0-0 16 ♖d2 ♖e5 17 ♚ad1 ♚f6 18 a4 a6 and Black was no worse.

Worth further investigation is 8 ♖xc4 cxd4 9 ♙f4 ♖d5 10 ♖d6+ ♙xd6 11 ♙xd6. Gelfand-Dokhoian, Sverdlovsk 1987 continued 11...♗b6 12 ♗c1 f6 13 ♖d2 ♙f7 14 ♖b3 ♖a5! 15 ♖xa5 ♗xa5 16 ♗c4 and White emerged with good play for the pawn, while 11...♖de7 12 ♖d2 0-0 13 ♗b3 ♙c8 14 ♙a3 e5 15 ♗ac1 ♗c7 16 ♖c4 ♗d8 17 ♙c5 ♙g4 18 ♗fe1 ♗d7 19 ♗a3 ♗ad8 20 b4 also resulted in compensation in Romanishin-A.Sokolov, Cannes 1998.

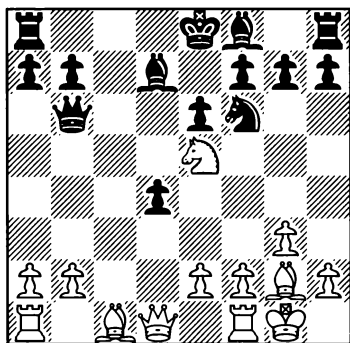
8...cxd4

Black can also try 8...♖d5!?, when 9 ♖axc4 seems harmless, e.g. 9...♖db4 10 ♖xc6 ♙xc6 11 ♙xc6+ ♖xc6 12 dxc5 ♙xc5 13 ♙f4 0-0 14 ♗xd8 ♗fxd8 15 ♗fd1 f6 16 ♙d6 ♙xd6 17 ♗xd6 ♙f7 18 ♗ad1 ♙e7 19 ♗xd8 ♗xd8 with a draw in Raetsky-A.Sokolov, Biel 1996. Instead White should consider 9 ♖xd7 ♗xd7 10 e4 ♖db4 11 d5!?

9 ♖axc4 ♖xe5

For 9...♙e7 see the next main game, which also covers Black's alternatives.

10 ♖xe5 ♗b6



11 ♙f4

Not surprisingly this is not White's only opportunity. In the event of 11 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 12 ♗a4 Black should avoid the risky 12...0-0-0?! 13 ♗d1 ♙e7 14 ♗xd4 ♙c5 15 ♗c4 ♙b8 16 ♙f1 e5, which was seen in Topalov-Morozevich, Madrid 1996. Now White could have played 17 ♙e3! f5 (17...♙xe3 18

♗b4! ♗f6 19 ♗xb7+ ♙c8 20 ♗c1+! and White wins) 18 ♗d1 ♙xe3 19 ♗b4 ♖c5 20 ♗xb6 ♖xa4 21 ♗xd8+ ♗xd8 22 ♗xb7+ ♙c8 23 fxe3 with a clear plus according to Morozevich. A more sober approach was essayed in Cvitan-Gyimesi, Baden 1999, when 12...♙c5 13 ♙f4 ♗d8 14 ♗ac1 0-0 15 b4 ♗xb4 16 ♗xb4 ♙xb4 17 ♙c7 ♗de8 18 ♙xb7 ♙e7 19 ♗b1 ♖b6 20 ♙xb6 axb6 21 ♗xb4 ♗xb7 22 ♗xd4 ended in a draw.

There is an interesting alternative in 11 b4!?, White making no secret of his quest for the initiative, e.g. 11...♗xb4?! 12 ♙f4 ♙a4 13 ♗c1 ♙e7 14 ♗b1 ♗c3 15 ♙xb7 ♗d8 16 ♖c6 ♙xc6 17 ♙xc6+ ♙f8 18 ♗xc3 dxc3 19 ♗fc1 and the endgame indeed looks like a grim ordeal for Black. Brodsky-Ulabin, Bydgoszcz 2001 went 11...♗d8 12 a3 ♙e7 13 ♙b2 ♗a6 14 ♙xd4 0-0 15 e3 ♙b5 16 ♗e1 ♙d6 17 a4 ♙xe5 18 axb5 ♗d6, when Ulabin gives 19 ♗xa7 ♗xb4 20 ♗xb7 ♙xd4 21 exd4 ♗xd4 22 ♗b1 ♖d5 23 b6 with a pull for White.

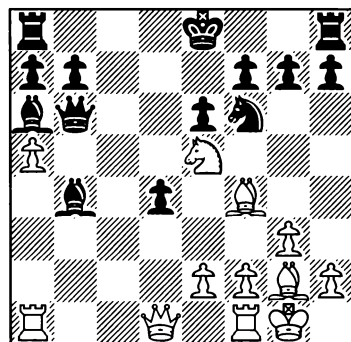
11...♙b5 12 a4

More challenging might be 12 b4!? ♗d8 13 a4 ♙c6 14 ♙xc6+! bxc6 15 ♗c1 ♙c8 16 b5! ♖d5 17 ♖xc6 ♖c3 18 ♗d3 ♖xa4 19 ♙e5 with play for the pawn in Tukmakov-A.Sokolov, Lenk 2001.

12...♙a6 13 b4!?

Nothing more than equality is achieved after 13 a5 ♗b5 14 ♗xd4 ♙c5 15 ♗c3 0-0.

13...♙xb4 14 a5



14... ♖b5!

After 14... ♖c5 15 ♙xb7! ♙xb7 16 ♖a4+ ♙f8 17 ♖ab1 White is given some attacking possibilities.

15 ♖b3 0-0

15... ♙c3 16 ♖xb5+ ♙xb5 17 ♙xb7 ♖b8 18 ♙c6+ ♙xc6 19 ♙xc6 ♖c8 20 ♖ab1! and White has good compensation for the pawn.

16 ♖ab1 g5 17 ♖xb4

In the case of 17 ♙d3 gxf4 18 ♙xb4 ♖ab8 White cannot fully justify the sacrifice of a pawn.

17... ♖xb4 18 ♖xb4 gxf4 19 ♙xb7 ♙xe2

Also fine is 19... ♖ab8 20 ♖fb1 ♙xe2 21 ♖xd4 with equality.

20 ♙xa8 ♙xf1 21 ♙b7

White should not lose his sense of reality. For example 21 ♙xf1 ♖xa8 22 gxf4 ♖d8 even allows Black to play for the win.

21... ♙e2 22 ♖xd4 fvg3 23 hvg3 ♙b5 24 ♖b4 a6

A last try?

25 ♖xb5!? axb5 26 a6 ♙d5 27 a7 ♙b6 28 ♙c6 f6 29 ♙e7+ ♙f7 30 ♙c8 ♖xc8 31 ♙xc8 b4 32 ♙f1 b3 33 ♙a6 ½-½

Game 80

Piket-Van Wely

Monte Carlo 1997

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♙f3 ♙f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 c5 6 0-0 ♙c6 7 ♙e5 ♙d7 8 ♙a3 cxd4 9 ♙axc4 ♙e7

This sound developing move is the most popular these days, but over time a number of alternatives have been tested. 9... ♙d5?! does not look sound, and after 10 ♙xc6 ♙xc6 11 ♖xd4 ♙b4 12 ♙xc6+ ♙xc6 13 ♖c3! Black has a difficult job bringing his pieces into the game. Kasparov-Andersson, Belgrade 1985 continued 13... f6 14 ♙e3 ♙e7 15 ♖fd1 ♖c7 16 ♖b3! g5 17 ♖ac1 ♖d8 18 ♖xd8+ ♙xd8 19 ♖xb7! and White was on his way to winning the game.

9... ♖c8 10 ♙f4 ♙d5 11 ♙xd7 ♙xf4 12 ♙xc6 bxc6 13 ♙xf8 ♙h3+ 14 ♙g2 ♖d5+

looks natural but 15 e4! ♖xc4 16 ♖c1 ♖b4 17 ♙xe6! fxe6 18 ♖h5+ clearly favours White according to Glek. Instead of the check on h3, Ljubojevic-Yusupov, Belfort 1988 went 13... ♖d5 14 gxf4 ♖xc4 15 ♖c1 ♖d5 16 ♖a4! g5 17 f5! exf5 18 ♖fd1 ♙xf8 19 ♖xd4 ♖e6 20 ♖c5 ♙g7 21 ♖a5 h6 22 ♖xf5 with a clear lead for White.

9... ♙c5 10 ♖b3 0-0 11 ♖xb7! does not work out for Black, as was witnessed in Kasparov-Deep Blue, Philadelphia (game 2) 1996: 11... ♙xe5 12 ♙xe5 ♖b8 13 ♖f3 ♙d6 (13... ♙d5 14 ♙g5! f6 15 ♖g4! gives White all the chances – Sulava) 14 ♙c6 ♙xc6 15 ♖xc6 e5 16 ♖b1! and White had the better chances. The computer went on to prove that positional decision making is not a strength, resulting in a clear advantage for White after 16... ♖b6?! 17 ♖a4 ♖b8 18 ♙g5 ♙e7 19 b4! ♙xb4 20 ♙xf6 gxf6 21 ♖d7!, when both f7 and h7 proved seriously weak. Black is advised to turn to the more circumspect 10... ♖c8. Rashkovsky-A.Sokolov, Cap d'Agde 1994 was harmless after 11 ♙f4 0-0 12 ♖ac1 ♙d5 13 ♙d3 ♙xf4 14 gxf4 ♙e7 15 ♙ce5 ♖b8 16 ♖c4 ♙f6! 17 ♙xc6 ♙xc6 18 ♖fc1, when the game should end in a draw after 18... ♖d7 19 ♙xc6 bxc6 20 ♖a4 ♖b6 21 ♖xc6 e5! 22 fxe5 ♖g4+ 23 ♙f1 ♖h3+ (Rashkovsky). Kharlov-A.Sokolov, St. Petersburg 1993 saw multiple exchanges: 13 ♙xd7 ♖xd7 14 ♙e5 ♙xe5 15 ♙xe5 ♙b6 16 ♖fd1 ♖ac8 17 ♖xc8 ♖xc8 18 ♙xd5 ♖xd5 19 ♖xd5 exd5 20 ♙xd4 ♙xd4 21 ♖xd4 ♖d8! 22 e4 ♙f8 23 exd5 ♙e7 24 ♙g2 ♙d6 25 ♙f3 ♖c8 26 ♖d2 ♖e8! and the rook endgame can be drawn but still requires a little effort.

10 ♖b3 ♖c8 11 ♙f4 0-0 12 ♖ac1 ♙d5 13 ♖fd1

White has more chance of an advantage with 13 ♙xc6!? ♙xc6 14 ♙e5, which was successful in Salov-Van Wely, Wijk aan Zee 1998 after 14... ♙f6 15 ♖fd1 ♙g5 16 f4 ♙e7 17 ♙xd4 ♖e8 18 ♖f1 ♙b5 19 e4.

13... ♙xf4

After 13... ♖d8 White has the tactical 14

♙xd5 exd5 15 ♘a5 ♘xa5 16 ♜xd5 ♙e6 17 ♜xa5 b6 18 ♜a4 ♜b7 19 ♘c6 with a slight plus.

14 gxf4 ♜b8 15 ♙e4 ♜c7 16 ♜f3

16 ♘a5 ♙d6 17 ♜h3 h6 18 ♙xc6 bxc6 19 ♘axc6 ♙xc6 20 ♜xc6 ♜e7 and Black holds his ground.

16...♙f6 17 e3!? g6 18 exd4 ♜fd8 19 ♙e3

If White is too optimistic and plays 19 d5?! Black should respond 19...exd5 20 ♙xd5 ♙e8 21 ♙xc6 ♙xc6 22 ♘xc6 ♜xd1+ 23 ♜xd1 bxc6 with play against both the b2- and f4-squares.

19...♙e8 20 ♘xc6

Not 20 d5? which runs into 20...♙xe5 21 fxe5 exd5 22 ♘xd5 ♜xe5 when Black nets a pawn.

20...bxc6 21 ♙xc6 ♜a5

In the case of 21...♙xc6 22 ♜xc6 ♜b7 White must push with 23 d5!? in order to keep the game flowing.

22 ♙xe8 ♙xe8 23 a3 ♜ed8 24 ♜e4 ♜b3 25 d5 exd5 26 ♘xd5 ♙xb2 27 ♜c7?!

Too optimistic. White should settle for the 'passive' 27 ♜b1 with the point that after 27...♙b5 28 ♘e7+ ♔g7 29 ♜xd8 ♜xd8 30 ♙xb2 ♙xb2 31 ♜e5+ f6 32 ♜xb2 Black is forced to take perpetual check.

27...♜xc7!

Black can resist anything – except temptation.

28 ♘xc7 ♜xd1+ 29 ♔g2 ♜b8

Black cannot win with 29...♙xa3?! because after 30 ♜e8+ ♙f8 White has 31 ♘e6! and the game is drawn after 31...♜b8! 32 ♜xb8 fxe6 33 ♜xa7 ♜d5, when Black will put the rook on f5 and erect a solid fortress. He would never defend the e-pawn – why should he?

30 ♜a4 ♜bd8?!

But here there is an improvement in 30...♜dd8 31 ♜xa7 ♙d4 with play against White's king. The text leads to a draw.

31 ♘b5 ♙1d7 32 ♘a7 ♙xa3 33 ♘c6 ♙f8 34 ♘xd8 ♜xd8 ½-½

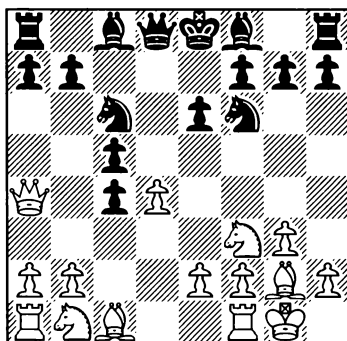
White plays 6 0-0 ♘c6 7 ♜a4

Game 81

H. Olafsson-Hjartarsson

Reykjavik 1984

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 c5 6 0-0 ♘c6 7 ♜a4



7...cxd4

The modern 7...♙d7 is considered in the next two games.

8 ♘xd4 ♜xd4 9 ♙xc6+ ♙d7

9...bxc6?! is best avoided, 10 ♜xc6+ ♜d7 11 ♜xa8 ♙c5 12 ♘c3 0-0 13 ♜d1 ♜c7 14 ♜f3 leaving Black with insufficient compensation for the exchange in Christiansen-Lhagva, Lucerne 1982. Indeed after 14...♙b7 15 ♙f4 ♜b6 16 e4 ♘xe4 17 ♘xe4 f5 18 b4! ♙d4 19 ♙c7 ♜xc7 20 ♜xd4 fxe4 21 ♜e2 White was in the driving seat.

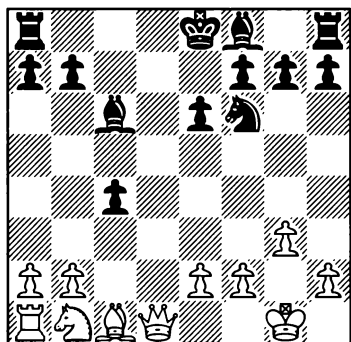
10 ♜d1

After 10 ♙xd7+ ♜xd7 11 ♜xc4 ♜c8 12 ♜b3 ♙c5 Black is doing fine, but 10 ♙e3!? looks good. In Gulko-Zsu.Polgar, Biel 1987 Black failed to solve her opening problems after 10...♙xc6 11 ♜xc6+ ♜d7 12 ♜xc4 ♙e7 13 ♘c3 0-0 14 ♜fd1 ♜c8 15 ♜b5 a6 16 ♜b6 ♙d8 17 ♜b4. Also possible is 10...♙xb2 11 ♙xd7+ ♘xd7 12 ♜d1 b5 13 ♜a6 when White has a strong initiative. However, Black also has two pawns, and after 13...♜d8 the situation is far from clear.

10...♜xd1+

10...♙xc6 11 ♖xc6+ bxc6 12 ♜xd4 ♙e7
13 ♜xc4 c5 14 ♙f4 0-0 15 ♘d2 ♘d7 16
♙b3 a5 17 ♜d1 ♙b6 18 ♜c2 left White with
the easier ending in Vladimirov-Ghaem
Maghami, Kelamabakham 2000.

11 ♖xd1 ♙xc6



12 ♘d2

White has two important alternatives. 12 ♙g5 seems only to give Black a tempo, but in fact White gets in f2-f3 for free. Nevertheless, there is no advantage: 12...♙e4 13 ♙e3 h5 14 f3 ♙f6 15 ♘d2 ♜d8 16 ♖c1 h4 17 ♙xc4 hxg3 18 hxg3 ♜d5! and Black was no worse in Mochalov-Sturua, Moscow 1979. The game continued 19 g4 ♙e7 20 ♙xa7 ♙xg4! 21 fxg4 ♜h1+! 22 ♙xh1 ♜h5+ 23 ♙g1 ♜h1+ 24 ♙f2 ♙h4+ 25 ♙e3 ♙g5+ 26 ♙d3 ♙xc1 27 ♜xc1 ♙xc1 and a draw was agreed.

12 ♖c2 demonstrates that Black cannot really hold on to the pawn. Polugaevsky-Andersson, Moscow 1981 went 12...♙e7 13 ♖xc4 0-0 14 ♙c3 ♜fd8 15 ♙e3 ♘d5 16 ♙xd5 ♙xd5 17 ♖g4 ♜dc8 18 ♙d4 ♙f8 19 e4 ♙c6 20 h4 ♜d8 21 ♙c3 ♜d3 22 h5 h6 23 ♜e1 ♜ad8 24 ♙h2 a6 with a slight plus for White. But Andersson has some affection for these passive positions, so he was probably not too uncomfortable here.

12...c3?!

This helps only White because it wastes a tempo and opens the b-file. However, Black anyway has difficulties equalising. In Kas-

parov-Andersson, Niksic 1983 White earned good chances of gaining the full point after 12...b5 13 a4 ♙e7 14 axb5 ♙xb5 15 ♙xc4 0-0 16 b3 ♜fd8 17 ♖c2 ♜dc8 18 ♙a3 ♙xa3 19 ♜xa3 h6 20 ♖c3 ♙xc4 21 bxc4 ♜c7 22 ♖d4 ♜ac8.

There is an interesting line in 12...h5!? 13 ♙xc4 h4 14 ♙f4, when White should be somewhat better. However, Black managed to do well in Vanheste-Blauert, Groningen 1989 after 14...♜d8 15 ♖b3 hxg3 16 ♙xg3 ♙e4 17 ♙e5 ♙xg3 18 ♖xg3 ♙d6 19 ♖xg7 ♙xe5 20 ♖xe5 ♙g8+ 21 ♙f1 ♙g2+ 22 ♙e1 ♙c6 with a draw by repetition.

13 bxc3 0-0-0 14 ♖b3 ♙c5 15 ♙f3 ♙e4

15...♙g4 16 ♙d4 ♙d5 17 ♖b5 ♙b6 18 a4 is excellent for White.

16 ♙d4 ♜xd4

Black essays an exchange sacrifice, but it is not enough. In the long-run the queen will reign. Unfortunately for Black 16...♙d5 17 ♖c2 e5 18 ♙e3! is unpleasant anyway according to H.Olafsson.

17 cxd4 ♙xd4 18 ♜b1 ♙xf2+

18...♙xf2? loses to 19 ♙e3.

19 ♙f1 h5

19...♜d8 20 ♖c2 ♙c5 21 ♜b3 ♜d5 22 ♙e3 and White is much better.

20 ♙f4

White also has 20 ♙e3 h4 21 g4 ♙g3 22 ♜c1! ♙xh2 23 ♖xc6+ bxc6 24 ♖a4 with a clear plus in Hjartarsson-Hardarson, Neskaupsstadur 1984.

20...g5?!

20...♜d8 21 ♜c1 ♙c5 is necessary, although White is still doing very well after 22 ♙e3.

21 ♙xg5 h4 22 gxh4 ♙xh4 23 ♖b2 f6 24 ♙xh4 ♙xh4 25 ♜c1 ♙d7

25...♙xh2 loses to 26 ♖xc6+! bxc6 27 ♖c2 and White will pick up all the enemy pawns.

26 ♖a3

Black is lost.

26...♙d6 27 ♖g3 ♜h5 28 ♜d1 ♙d5 29 ♖g7+ ♙c6 30 ♜c1+ ♙c4 31 ♖g4 ♜f5+ 32 ♙e1 b5 33 h4 e5 34 h5 ♜f4 35

♖g2+ ♜b6 36 h6 ♜e4 37 h7 ♜h4 38 h8 ♖1-0

Game 82
Portisch-Radulov
Buenos Aires 1978

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♟f3 ♟f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 c5 6 0-0 ♟c6 7 ♖a4 ♖d7

This looks like the most appropriate move, after which Black has good chances of equalising.

8 ♖xc4

White needs to play this as he achieves nothing after 8 dxc5 ♟a5! 9 ♖c2 ♖xc5 10 ♟e5 ♜c8 11 ♟c3 ♟c6 12 ♟xc4 0-0 13 ♜d1 ♖e7 14 ♖e3 ♖xe3 15 ♟xe3 ♜fd8 16 ♜d2 and a draw was rightly agreed in Razuvaev-A.Sokolov, Riga 1985. In Fominyh-Morozevich, Alushta 1993 Black was even better after 11 ♖g5 h6 12 ♖xf6 gxf6 13 ♟xd7 ♖xd7 14 ♟d2 ♖e7 15 ♟e4 ♖c7 16 f4 f5 17 ♖c3 ♜g8 18 ♟f2 ♖c5.

8...cxd4

This move lets White develop a bit too freely, and Black is under some pressure for a long time. 8...♜c8 9 dxc5 ♖a5 10 ♟bd2 ♖xc5 11 b3 ♖e7 12 ♖b2 ♖b6 13 ♖f4 0-0 14 ♟c4 ♖c7 15 ♜fd1 ♖xf4 16 gxf4 ♜fd8 17 ♟fe5 ♖e8 18 ♜xd8 ♟xd8 19 ♜d1 gave Black some problems to solve in Ftacnik-Unzicker, Germany 1995. These were minor, but problems all the same. The energetic 8...b5 is considered in the next game.

9 ♟xd4 ♜c8 10 ♟c3 ♟xd4

Korchnoi-Karpov, Candidates Match (game 17), Moscow 1974 also proved awkward for Black after 10...♖a5 11 ♜d1 ♖e7 12 ♟b3 ♖c7 13 ♟b5 (13 ♖f4! ♖e5 14 ♖g5 ♖e6 15 ♖a4 is interesting and looks a shade better for White) 13...♖b8 14 ♟c5 a6 15 ♟xd7 ♟xd7 16 ♟c3 ♟de5, when 17 ♖b3 0-0 18 ♖f4 favours White according to Botvinnik.

11 ♖xd4 ♖c5 12 ♖h4 ♖c6 13 ♜d1!

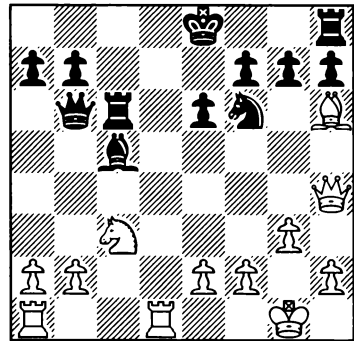
13 ♖g5 invites 13...♖d4! (the equaliser), when Karpov-Piket, Monaco (blindfold)

1998 continued 14 ♖xc6+ ♜xc6 15 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 16 ♖a4 0-0 17 ♜ad1 a6 18 ♜d7 b5 19 ♖e4 ♜fc8 20 e3 h6 21 ♜fd1 ♖b6 with a level game.

13...♖b6?

A tactical error that is punished severely. 13...♖a5 is the alternative. Benko-Peters, USA, 1979 continued 14 ♖xc6+ ♜xc6 15 ♖g5 ♖e7 16 ♟e4 ♖e5 17 ♟xf6+ ♖xf6 18 ♖xf6 gxf6 19 ♖b4 ♜b6 20 ♖a4+ ♟f8 21 ♜d2 and Black still had much work to do in order to feel more secure. 14 ♖h6 works less well here than in the main game for after 14...0-0 15 ♖xc6 ♜xc6 16 ♖xg7 Black has 16...♖xf2+! 17 ♟xf2 ♖xg7 18 ♜d3 ♜c5 with equality, as in Csom-Peters, Hastings 1978/79.

14 ♖xc6+ ♜xc6 15 ♖h6!



Breaking open Black's kingside.

15...gxf6

15...♖xf2+? 16 ♖g2 0-0 17 ♖xg7! gives White a winning attack. Alternatively 15...♖f8 16 ♜d2 e5 17 ♖e3 ♖a6 18 ♜ad1 ♖e7 19 ♖g5! 0-0 20 ♖xe5 won White a pawn in Ribli-Ljubojevic, Buenos Aires 1978. **16 ♖xf6 0-0 17 ♟e4 ♖b4 18 ♖e5 ♖e7 19 a3 ♖b6 20 ♜d7 ♖g5**

20...f6?! accelerates defeat, White winning with 21 ♖h5 ♖xb2 22 ♜xe7 ♖xa1+ 23 ♖g2 when Black is mated – 23...f5 24 ♖xh6 and ♖xh7 decides.

21 b3!

Accurate. After 21 ♟xg5 ♜c5 22 ♖e4

hxg5 23 ♖xb7 White is a pawn up, but no more.

21...♗xb3

After 21...f6 22 ♖b2 ♜d8 23 ♖xd8+ ♗xd8 24 h4 f5 25 hxg5 fxe4 26 gxh6 Black is in serious trouble.

22 ♖xg5 hxg5 23 ♗xg5+ ♖h8 24 ♜ad1 ♗c2 25 ♗f6+ ♖g8 26 ♜1d4 ♗g6

26...♜c4 27 ♗xf7! and Black is mated.

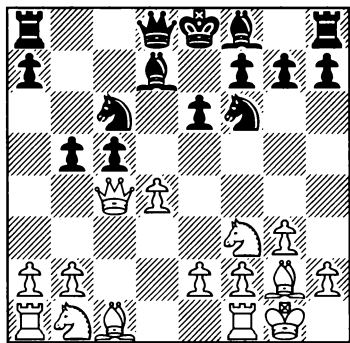
27 ♗f3! h5 28 ♖xb7 e5 29 ♜h4 ♜d8 30 ♗xh5 ♗xh5 31 ♖xh5 f6 32 ♖xa7 ♜d2 33 e3 ♜c1+ 34 ♖g2 ♜d1 35 ♜f5 1-0

Game 83

Korchnoi-Ivanchuk

Istanbul 2000

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 c5 6 0-0 ♖c6 7 ♗a4 ♙d7 8 ♗xc4 b5!?



The most energetic move.

9 ♗d3

Black should be advised against 9 ♗xb5? ♖xd4 10 ♖xd4! (10 ♗d3 ♙b5 clearly favours Black) 10...♙b5 11 ♖xb5 ♖d5 12 ♖1c3 a6 13 ♖xd5 axb5 14 ♖c3 b4 15 ♙c6+ ♖e7 16 ♖e4 ♜c8 and there was clearly not enough compensation for the queen in Hodgson-Karolyi, Kecskemet 1988.

9...♜c8

Completing queenside development and stepping off the long diagonal. With 9...c4 Black loses options: 10 ♗d1 ♜c8 11 ♖e5

♙d6 12 ♖xd7 ♗xd7 13 ♖c3 a6 14 d5 exd5 15 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 16 ♗xd5 ♗e6 17 ♜d1 ♙e5 18 a4 gave White a slight plus in Stefanova-Zhu Chen, Groningen 1999.

10 ♖c3

After this move Ivanchuk successfully tries for the initiative. It seems more natural to play 10 dxc5 ♙xc5 11 ♖c3, when Black has more than one path to follow. 11...0-0 12 ♙g5 (12 ♖xb5? ♖b4 13 ♗c4 ♙xf2+ and Black wins) 12...♖b4 13 ♙xf6 gxf6 14 ♗d2 ♙c6 15 ♗h6 ♜e8 16 ♜ad1 ♙f8 17 ♗h5 ♗e7 18 a3 ♙xf3 (18...♖d5 19 ♖d4) 19 ♙xf3 with a winning position for White in Anastasian-Kaidanov, Lucerne 1997.

11...♖b4 12 ♗d2!? ♗b6 (12...♖bd5 13 ♖xd5 ♖xd5 14 a3 0-0 15 b4 ♙b6 16 ♙b2 and White is better placed thanks to the co-ordination of his bishops) 13 ♖e5 ♜d8 14 a3 ♖c6 15 ♖d3 0-0 16 ♗g5 e5 17 ♖xc5 ♗xc5 18 ♗h4 favoured White (♙g5 is coming) in Vladimirov-De La Villa, Marchena 1990.

11...b4 puts the question to the knight. In Hansen-Van Der Sterren, Kerteminde 1991 White chose 12 ♖e4 ♖xe4 13 ♗xe4, when there followed 13...♖e7 (13...0-0 14 ♜d1 ♗e7 15 ♙g5 f6 16 ♙e3 gives White a little something as Black's queenside pawns are potentially weak) 14 ♖e5 ♙b5 15 ♙e3 0-0 16 ♜fd1 ♗b6 17 ♙xc5 ♜xc5 18 ♖d7 ♙xd7 19 ♜xd7 ♖d5 20 ♗h4 h6 and Black was no worse. After 21 ♜d1 ♜c2 22 ♙xd5 ♜xe2!? 23 ♗d4 exd5 24 ♖xa7 ♗xd4 25 ♜xd4 ♖xb2 the game was drawn. Khalifman-Dokhoian, Germany 1991 saw instead 12 ♖b5 0-0 13 ♖d6 ♖d4! 14 ♙f4 ♖d5 15 ♙e5 ♖xf3+ 16 ♙xf3 ♗g5 17 ♖c4 ♙b5 18 h4 ♗e7 19 b3 ♜fd8 and Black had been very successful in the opening. White has problems getting his pieces into play, and the queen is struggling to contribute.

10...cxd4

10...c4 11 ♗b1 (11 ♗d1! b4 12 ♖a4 ♗a5 results in an interesting position with chances for both sides) 11...b4 12 ♖e4 ♖d5 13 ♖eg5 h6 14 e4 ♖f6 15 ♖h3 ♙e7 16 ♜d1 ♗a5 was

unclear in Kozul-Bunazovic, Ljubljana 1993.

11 ♖xd4 ♖e5

Black presses for the win. After the simpler 11...♖xd4 12 ♜xd4 ♖c5 13 ♜d3 b4 the situation is comfortable, the subsequent 14 ♖e4 ♖xe4 15 ♖xe4 ♜b6 16 ♖f4 ♖b5 17 ♜f3 0-0 (17...f5!? is messy) 18 ♜ad1 ♖d4 19 ♖d2 e5 being fine for Black in Inkiov-Adamski, Tbilisi 1986.

12 ♜d1 b4

Black needs to maintain the high pace. After 12...♜b6 13 a4 b4 14 ♖e4 White might be a little bit better.

13 ♖e4 ♖d5

Black can equalise (again) with 13...♖xe4 14 ♖xe4 ♖e7 15 ♖f4 ♖c4 16 b3 ♖d6 17 ♖f3 0-0 etc.

14 ♖g5

Perhaps this is careless. After the more natural 14 ♖f4 ♖xf4 15 gxf4 ♖g6 16 e3 ♜b6 the position is level.

14...♖e7 15 ♖xd5?!

A decision that White will come to regret. After 15 e4 ♖b6 16 h4 h6 17 ♖gf3 ♖xf3+ 18 ♜xf3 ♖f6 19 ♖d1 ♖a4 20 ♖b3 ♜e7 Black is doing well. In the event of 15 ♖f5!? it is tempting to go for 15...♜xc1! 16 ♜xc1 ♖xg5, when 17 f4 ♜b6+ 18 ♖h1 ♖g4 19 fxg5 ♖ge3 20 ♜b3 ♖xf1 21 ♜xf1 0-0 seems fine for Black. Meanwhile there is 15...exf5 16 ♜xd5 ♖c5 17 ♖d4 0-0 18 ♖f4 ♖c6 19 ♖xe5 ♖xg2 20 ♖xg2 ♖d5 21 ♖f4 ♖xg5 22 ♜xf5 ♖e8 23 f4 ♖f6 24 ♖xf6 gxf6 25 ♜g4+ ♖h8 with compensation for the pawn according to Ivanchuk, and Black can also play the position in another fashion – with 23...f6!?, for example.

15...exd5 16 ♖gf3 ♖c4 17 ♜d3 0-0 18 ♖d1 ♖e8 19 ♖b1?!

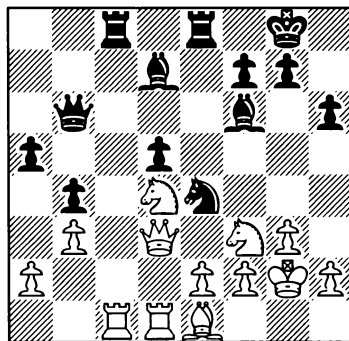
White should not tolerate the knight on c4: 19 b3 ♖d6 20 ♖e5 (20 a3 ♖e4 21 axb4 ♖xb4 22 ♜a7 ♖c3 23 ♜b1 ♖c5 clearly favours Black, 24 ♖a2 ♖xf3! 25 ♖xf3 ♖xf2+ 26 ♖g2 ♖c3 completely ruining White's structure) 20...♖e4 21 ♖xd7 ♜xd7 22 ♖b2 ♖f6 and White has good chances of main-

taining the balance.

19...♖f6 20 b3 ♖d6 21 ♖d2 ♜b6 22 ♖bc1 ♖e4

Black is better.

23 ♖e1 h6 24 ♖g2 a5



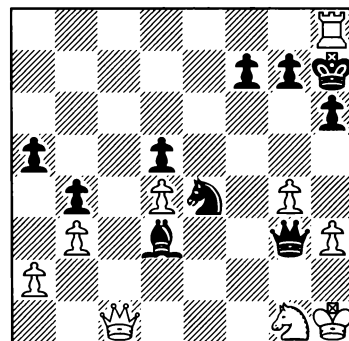
25 h3 ♖c5 26 ♖xc5 ♜xc5 27 e3 ♖c8 28 g4 ♜b6 29 ♖g1 ♖xd4 30 exd4

A better try is 30 ♜xd4 ♜xd4 31 ♜xd4 ♖e6, although the endgame is quite grim.

30...♖b5 31 ♜b1 ♜c6 32 ♖d2 ♜f6 33 ♖e3 ♖c3!

Eliminating the dark square defender.

34 ♜b2 ♖xe3! 35 fxe3 ♜h4 36 ♖d2 ♜g3+ 37 ♖h1 ♜xe3 38 ♖c2 ♖g3+ 39 ♖g2 ♖f1+ 40 ♖h2 ♖e4 41 ♜c1 ♜g3+ 42 ♖h1 ♖d3 43 ♖c8+ ♖h7 44 ♖h8+!?



44...♖g6!

44...♖xh8? 45 ♜c8+ allows White to escape with a draw.

45 ♜c6+ ♖f6 46 ♖e8 ♖h7 0-1

Summary

The position after 5...c5 6 0-0 ♖c6 7 ♗a4 cxd4 8 ♘xd4 ♗xd4 9 ♕xc6+ ♕d7 10 ♜xd1 ♗xd1+ 11 ♗xd1 ♕xc6 remains very important for the overall evaluation of the 5...c5 system. It used to be thought that Black has two plans of approximately equal value – to play for simplification in the hope of achieving a draw or to strive for an initiative on the kingside by advancing the h-pawn. Now it has been established that the aggressive approach fails. However, the ‘drawing’ fortress seems quite feasible, which partly undermines the reputation of 7 ♗a4. The positive contribution 7 ♗a4 received from Portisch-Radulov (Game 82) was only temporary as after 7...♕d7 8 ♗xc4 cxd4 9 ♘xd4 ♜c8 10 ♖c3 ♘xd4 11 ♗xd4 ♕c5 12 ♗h4 ♕c6 13 ♕d1 Black made an error with 13...♗b6?; 13...♗a5 steers the game towards equality.

In the 1990’s the following variation became fashionable for Black: 8...b5 9 ♗d3 ♜c8, when Korchnoi-Ivanchuk (Game 83) illustrates that 10 ♖c3 is harmless for Black. After 10 dxc5 ♕xc5 11 ♖c3 both 11...0-0 and 11...♖b4 are not quite satisfactorily for Black, but 11...b4 secures a level game after 12 ♖b5 and 12 ♖e4. Consequently 7 ♗a4 is no longer considered dangerous for Black. Therefore White’s attention has turned to 7 ♖e5. Now on 7...♕d7 White should not hurry with 8 ♖xc6 ♕xc6 9 ♕xc6 bxc6 10 ♗a4 because Black has time to get his game going despite the ruined pawn structure. Also not so popular these days is the complex continuation 8 ♖xc4 cxd4 9 ♕f4 ♕d5 10 ♖xd6 ♕xd6 11 ♕xd6. The main line is 8 ♖a3 cxd4 9 ♖axc4, when White has achieved a lead in development. Nevertheless the (extra) d4-pawn restricts White a little. In the modern line 9...♖xe5 10 ♖xe5 ♗b6 White must consider 11 ♕f4 ♕b5 12 b4 (Tukmakov) and 11 b4 (Brodsky), and in the case of 9...♕c5 10 ♗b3 0-0 he can probably grab the b7-pawn. Thus it is preferable for Black to play 10...♗c8 with chances of gradually equalising, as is demonstrated in Piket-Van Wely (Game 80).

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♕g2 c5 (D) 6 0-0

6 ♗a4+ ♕d7 7 ♗xc4 ♕c6 – *Game 76*

6...♖c6

6...cxd4 – *Game 77*

7 ♖e5

7 ♗a4

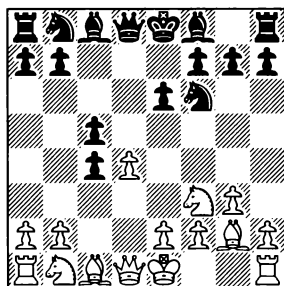
7...cxd4 – *Game 81*

7...♕d7 8 ♗xc4 (D); 8...cxd4 – *Game 82*; 8...b5 – *Game 83*

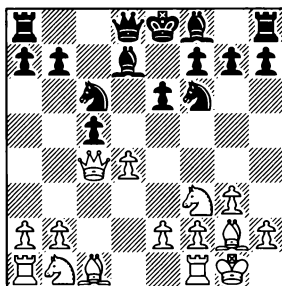
7...♕d7

7...♖xe5 – *Game 78*

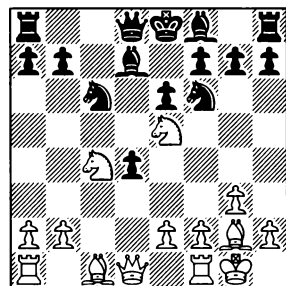
8 ♖a3 cxd4 9 ♖axc4 (D); 9...♖xe5 – *Game 79*; 9...♕e7 – *Game 80*



5...c5



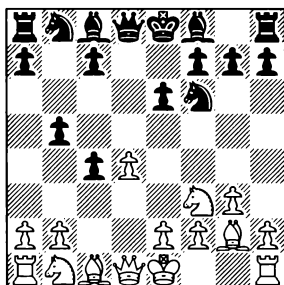
8 ♗xc4



9 ♖axc4

CHAPTER EIGHT

4...dxc4 5 ♖g2 b5



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 b5

This is a genuine gambit, Black immediately protecting his extra pawn despite it not yet being attacked. In return for the pawn White has a space advantage in the centre and a lead in development.

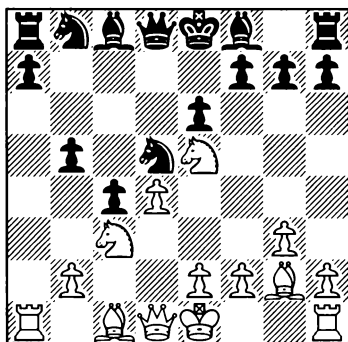
5...b5 has always been considered a very provocative continuation, being seldom seen in international practice. However, it is important to note that other systems often transpose to 5...b5 lines. For example if, in the 5...c6 variation, White plays 6 0-0, then the best answer is considered to be 6...b5 with a transposition to 5...b5. And 5...a6 and 5...b5 are also closely related – the only real difference being that 5...a6 is more flexible and allows Black to avoid the 5...b5 lines if he so desires.

After 5...b5 there are two main lines. The first is the tactical line introduced by Gulko – 6 a4 c6 7 axb5 cxb5 8 ♗e5 ♗d5 9 ♗c3 ♖b4 10 0-0 ♖xc3 11 e4! (Game 84). In the 1980's White achieved a number of brilliant victories with this system, mainly in Soviet tournaments. But the games somehow failed to follow standard, rational paths and did not feature precise defence and accurate calculation. Not surprisingly Black began to find ways in which the defence could be strengthened and prospects improved, prompting an

evaluation of the position as – at best – unclear. Thus in the struggle between the sword and the armour it would seem that the armour should triumph, and this forcing line has practically vanished from international practice. Now we are more likely to see the albeit less inventive 6 a4 c6 7 0-0 ♖b7 8 ♗e5 (Games 85 & 86), holding back the b1-knight, as in the 5...a6 lines.

Game 84 Balashov-Beliavsky Kiev 1986

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 b5 6 a4 c6 7 axb5 cxb5 8 ♗e5 ♗d5 9 ♗c3

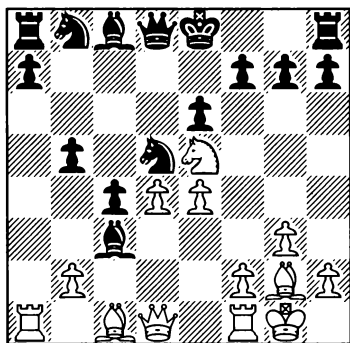


9...♙b4

9...♙b7?! is a dubious alternative as 10 ♖xb5 ♖c3 11 ♖xc3 ♙xg2 12 ♖g1 (Polovodin) might net Black the light-squared bishop but the price of time is a more important factor. White exerts pressure on the queenside and is clearly better.

9...f6 looks risky. Indeed Black was punished in Hackel-Rausch, Germany 1996, which continued 10 e4!? ♖xc3 11 ♖h5+ g6 12 ♖xg6 hxg6 13 ♖xh8 ♖xd4 14 ♙h6 ♖d7 15 0-0 f5?! 16 ♖g8 ♖xe4 17 ♖xe6+ ♖d8 18 ♖ad1 ♖c5 19 ♙xe4 fxe4 20 ♖d5 ♖b6 21 ♙g5+ ♖c7 22 ♙f4+ ♖d8 23 ♖e5 ♙b7 24 ♙g5+ and White won. An improvement is 15...♖e2+ 16 ♖h1 e5 17 ♙xf8 ♖xf8 18 ♖xf6 when Black has two minor pieces for a rook but White enjoys more activity and has the safer king.

10 0-0 ♙xc3 11 e4!



Gulko's contribution, which is preferable to 11 bxc3 ♖xc3 12 ♖d2 ♖d5 13 ♙a3 f6 with an edge for Black as White's knight is driven back and there are no tricks with ♖h5.

11...♙xb2!

The best of the candidate replies. 11...♙b4? is the worst in view of 12 exd5 exd5 13 ♖xf7! ♖xf7 14 ♖h5+ and White wins. 11...♖f4 doesn't look too convincing either, Gulko giving 12 ♙xf4 ♙xb2 13 ♖b1 ♙xd4 14 ♖xc4! bxc4 15 e5 etc.

11...♖e7 proved disastrous in Gulko-

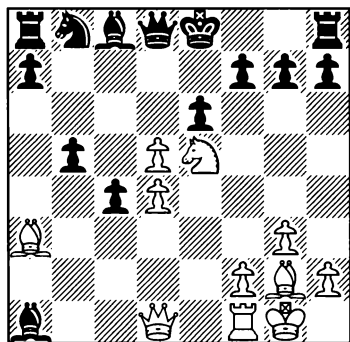
Mikhalchishin, Volgodonsk 1981, Black responding to 12 bxc3 with the poor 12...f6?, running into serious trouble after 13 ♖h5+! g6 14 ♖xg6! ♖xg6 15 e5 ♖c6 16 ♙xc6+ ♙d7 17 ♙xa8 ♖xa8 18 ♙h6 ♖f7 19 exf6. Of course this can be avoided with 12...0-0, but then 13 ♙a3 f6 14 ♖xc4! bxc4 15 e5 ♖d5 16 ♙xf8 ♖xf8 17 ♖a4 is pleasant only for White who, despite having a rook for two minor pieces, has the open files on the queenside with which to generate play.

In the event of 11...♖f6 12 bxc3 ♙b7 13 ♙a3 ♖c7 14 ♖e2 ♖bd7 15 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 16 d5 White has compensation for the pawn due to the dark-squared bishop.

12 exd5

The alternative is 12 ♙xb2 ♖e7 13 d5! 0-0 14 ♙a3, when 14...♖d7? 15 ♖xf7 ♖xf7 16 dxe6+ ♖xe6 17 ♖h5 g6 18 ♖xh7 ♖e5 19 ♖ad1 ♖d3 saw Black walking on thin ice in Polovodin-Zhelmin, Moscow 1983. In fact the game ended 20 ♙h3+ ♖e5 21 ♖g7+ ♖xe4 22 ♙g2+ ♖f5 23 ♙xe7 ♖e8 24 ♙h3+ ♖e4 25 ♖fe1+ ♖xe1 26 ♖d4+ and Black was mated. Instead of the faulty 14...♖d7?, Oll assessed the situation after 14...f6 15 d6 ♖ec6 16 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 17 d7 b4! 18 dxc8 ♖xc8 as unclear, thanks in no small part to Black's has three connected passed pawns.

12...♙xa1 13 ♙a3



13...a5

13...exd5?! is dangerous in view of 14 ♖h5, e.g. 14...g6 (14...♙e6 is punished by

Chernin's 15 ♖xf7! g6 16 ♜f3! ♜f8 17 ♜e1 ♖d7 18 ♜xe6, when White wins) 15 ♜f3 and White has a strong initiative, e.g. 15...f6 16 ♜e1! ♖e6 17 ♖h3! f5 18 ♖xg6 hxg6 19 ♜xe6+ ♖f7 20 ♖xf5 ♖xd4 21 ♖xg6+! and Black is crushed.

14 ♜g4

Also possible is 14 dxe6 ♖xe6 15 ♖xa8, when Kengis-Mejster, Toljatti 1985 continued 15...♖xd4? 16 ♖c6! ♖xf2+ 17 ♖xf2 ♜c7 18 ♖d6! ♜b6+ 19 ♜d4 ♜xd4+ 20 ♖xd4 b4 21 ♜a1! ♖d7 22 ♖f4 ♜c8 23 ♖b7! ♜d8 24 ♜xa5 ♖e8 25 ♖xe6 fxe6 26 ♜b5 and White won. Black's queenside pawns were inferior to White's active pieces. Dunnington gives 15...b4 16 ♜xa1 0-0 17 ♖c1 with attack, while 15...♜xd4 16 ♜xa1 ♜xa1 17 ♜xa1 b4 18 ♖c1 0-0 19 ♜xa5 ♜d8! is analysis by Kengis.

14...b4

After 14...g6!? 15 ♜f4 f6 16 ♜xa1 ♜a6 17 ♖g4 e5 18 dxe5 ♖xg4 19 ♜xg4 b4 20 ♖c1 c3 21 d6 (Oll) the situation is highly complex.

15 ♜xg7 ♜f8 16 ♜xa1 ♜a6

16...bxa3 17 dxe6 ♖xe6 18 ♖xa8 ♜xd4 19 ♜b1 ♖d7 20 ♖c6 and now Chernin-Yudasin, Sverdlovsk 1984 continued 20...♜d6? 21 ♖xd7+ ♖xd7 22 ♖xc4 ♜c5 23 ♜b8+ ♖c8 24 ♜xc8+ and White won. Black should play 20...a2! 21 ♖xd7+ ♖xd7!, sacrificing and relying on the dangerous a2-pawn. Then after 22 ♜b8+ ♖e7 23 ♜xf8+ ♖e6 24 ♜xf7+ ♖xe5 25 ♜e7+ ♖e6 26 ♜b5+ ♖e4 27 ♜xe6+ ♖d3 the battle rages on with chances for both sides.

17 ♖c1 exd5

17...f6 is also possible, Balashov giving 18 ♖xc4 ♜f7 19 ♜h6 exd5 20 ♖e3 ♖e6 21 ♖f3. White is the exchange down but has attacking prospects against Black's exposed king, while Black has two dangerous connected passed pawns.

18 ♖h6! ♜xh6?!

Better is 18...♜e7 19 ♜e1 ♖e6! 20 ♜xh7 ♖d7 21 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 22 ♖xd5 when White has clear compensation for the exchange in

this open position but Black's dangerous pawns contribute to an evaluation of unclear.

19 ♜xh6 ♖e6 20 ♜e1 ♜e7 21 ♖xc4

21 ♖xf7!? ♜xf7 22 ♜xe6+ ♖d7 23 ♜d6+ ♖c7 24 f4 and Black's slightly troubled king confers White the more pleasant game. Again Black's pawns are dangerous!

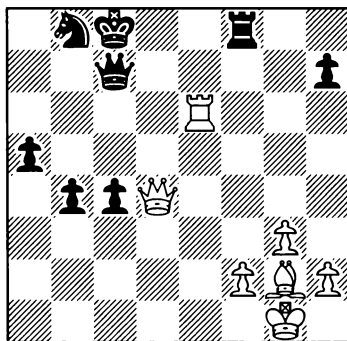
21...dxc4 22 d5 ♖d7 23 ♜e3!

White has a strong attack.

23...♜d6 24 ♜a7+ ♜c7 25 dxe6+ fxe6 26 ♜d4+ ♖c8?

Better is 26...♜d6 27 ♜g7+! ♜e7 28 ♜e5 but White still has a strong initiative.

27 ♜xe6



White is winning.

27...c3 28 ♖h3 ♖b7 29 ♜d5+ ♖a7

Or 29...♖c6 30 ♖g2 ♜c8 31 ♜xc6 ♜xc6 32 ♜b5+ and White wins.

30 ♖g2 ♖a6 31 ♜c6! 1-0

Game 85 Mochalov-Spirin Correspondence 1986

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 b5 6 a4 c6 7 0-0 ♖b7 8 ♖e5

After 8 ♖c3 b4 9 ♖b1 c5 10 ♖bd2 c3 11 bxc3 bxc3 12 ♖c4 cxd4 13 ♜xd4 ♜xd4 14 ♖xd4 ♖xg2 15 ♖xg2 ♖b4 Black had no problems in Grinshpun-Rabinovich, Tel Aviv 1997. Moiseenko-Kharlov, St. Petersburg 1998 took a different course: 8...a6 9 e4 ♖bd7 10 e5 ♖d5 11 ♖g5 ♖b6 12 ♜h5

♖d7 13 a5 ♜xc3 14 bxc3 ♜d5 15 ♙xd5 cxd5 16 ♜xh7 0-0-0 17 ♜xf8 ♚dxf8 with chances for both sides.

8...♜d5

Also possible is 8...♖b6 9 b3 cxb3 10 ♖xb3, offering the d4-pawn. In fact after 10...♖xd4 11 ♙b2 ♖b6 12 axb5 cxb5 13 ♙d4 ♖xd4 14 ♙xb7 ♖xa1 15 ♖xb5+ ♜bd7 16 ♜xd7 ♜xd7 17 ♙xa8 White has compensation for the pawn due to his lead in development.

Khalifman-Sveshnikov, Elista 1996 went 10...♜bd7 11 ♙e3! c5, prompting White to open up the centre with 12 ♜xd7 ♜xd7 13 d5!, when there followed 13...bxa4 14 ♖xa4 exd5 (14...♙xd5 15 ♜c3 ♙xg2 16 ♙xg2 ♖b7+ 17 ♙g1 ♚d8 18 ♚ab1 ♖c8 19 ♜b5! a6 20 ♜a7 ♖c7 21 ♚fd1! ♖xa7 22 ♖c6 ♖a8 23 ♚b7 ♖c8 24 ♚c7 is clearly better for White – Khalifman) 15 ♜c3 with an excellent game for White. After 15...d4 16 ♜d5 ♙xd5 17 ♙xd5 ♚d8 18 ♙f4 ♖f6 19 ♖b5 ♙d6 20 ♚a6 ♚b8 21 ♙b7! this had been translated to a decisive advantage.

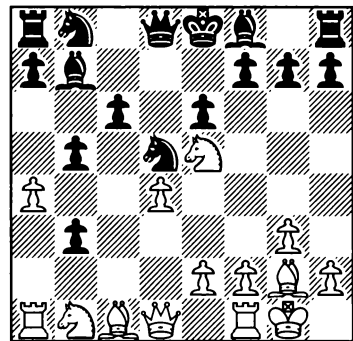
Finally there is 10...a6 11 ♚d1 ♜bd7 12 ♜c3 ♜xe5 13 dxe5 ♜d5 14 ♙xd5! exd5 15 axb5 axb5 as in Raetsky-Z.Varga, Zürich 2000, when White's development lead was balanced out by Black's consolidation in the centre. After 16 ♙e3 ♖d8? 17 ♙a7! ♖c7? 18 e4 b4 19 exd5! bxc3 20 d6 ♖d7 21 ♙c5! White stood better despite being a piece down. Black should play 16...♙c5 17 ♚xa8+ ♙xa8 18 ♚a1 ♙b7 19 ♜a4 bxa4 20 ♖xb6 ♙xb6 21 ♙xb6 ♙d7 22 ♚xa4 ♚a8 with equality.

9 b3

9 ♜c3 a6 transposes to 8...a6 9 ♜c3 ♜d5 9 e4 ♜f6 10 d5!? (10 ♜c3 leads to equality after 10...b4 11 ♜e2 c5) 10...cxd5 11 exd5 ♜xd5, when Raetsky-Sofrigin, Leukerbad 2002 continued 12 ♜c3! b4 13 ♜xd5 ♙xd5 14 ♙g5! ♙e7 (14...♖xg5 15 ♙xd5 ♖xe5 16 ♙xa8 ♖xb2 17 ♚c1 favours White) 15 ♙xe7 ♙xe7 16 ♖h5 g6 17 ♖h4+ f6 18 ♙xd5 exd5 19 ♙fe1! g5 20 ♖h6 and White had a devas-

tating attack: 20...fxe5 21 ♚xe5+ ♙f7 22 ♚f5+ and White won. In Vladimirov-Gedevanishvili, Daugavpils 1978 the queen-side saw all the action: 12 axb5 ♙e7 13 ♜xc4 0-0 14 ♜a5 ♖b6 15 ♜xb7 ♖xb7 16 ♜c3 ♚d8 17 ♖b3 ♜c6 18 ♜xd5 exd5 19 ♚d1 ♜b4 20 ♙d2 ♖xb5 21 ♙xb4 ♖xb4 22 ♖xb4 ♙xb4 23 ♙xd5 ♚ab8 24 ♚xa7 and in this opposite-coloured bishop ending White had good winning chances.

9...cxb3



10 ♖xb3

Also possible is 10 axb5 cxb5 11 ♖xb3 a6 12 e4 ♜f6 13 d5!, e.g. 13...exd5 14 exd5 ♙xd5 15 ♖e3 ♖e7 16 ♙xd5 ♜xd5 17 ♖e4 ♖e6 18 ♚d1 with comfortably enough for the two pawns. 13...♙c5! is interesting but appears inadequate in view of Agzamov's 14 dxe6 fxe6 15 ♖xe6+ ♖e7 16 ♖xe7+ ♙xe7 17 ♜c3 0-0, when White is slightly better because the centre pawns are more mobile than Black's a- and b-pawns.

10...a6 11 ♜c3 ♜d7 12 axb5

12 ♜xd5 exd5 13 e4 ♜xe5 14 exd5! cxd5! 15 dxe5 ♙c5 16 axb5 0-0 17 b6! with a slight advantage for White.

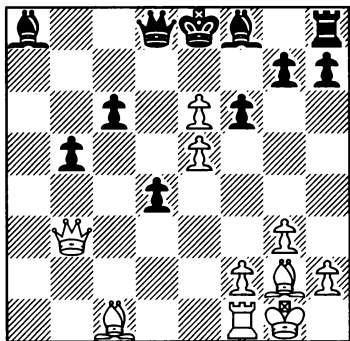
12...axb5 13 ♚xa8 ♙xa8 14 ♜xd5 exd5 15 e4 ♜xe5 16 dxe5 d4?!

16...dxe4 17 ♙xe4 ♙e7 18 ♚d1 gives White compensation by way of the usual development lead.

17 e6 f6

Mochalov gives 17...fxe6 18 ♖xe6+ ♖e7

19 ♖a2! ♖b7 20 e5! c5 21 ♖g5! ♖xg5 22 ♖xb7 with an excellent game for White.
18 e5!



18...fxe5

18...♖e7 19 exf6 ♖xf6 20 ♖a3 ♖e7? 21 ♖f3 ♖f8 22 ♖xc6+! is a nice little trick.

19 ♖e4! ♖e7

19...♖d6 20 ♖g5 ♖e7 21 ♖a1 gives White the initiative as Black has no time to castle: 21...♖b7 22 ♖a7 ♖xg5 23 ♖xb7 etc.

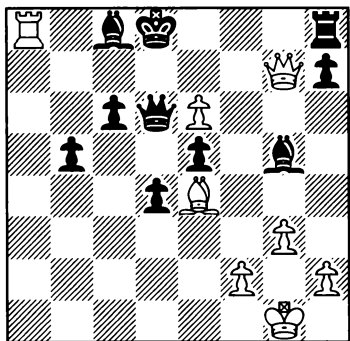
20 ♖f3 ♖d6

20...♖f6 21 ♖xc6+ ♖e7 22 ♖a3+ ♖xe6 23 ♖c1 and White is better. Black's king has seen better days.

21 ♖f7+ ♖d8 22 ♖g5! ♖b7 23 ♖a1 ♖c8

23...♖e8 24 ♖a7 ♖c7 25 ♖xe7+ ♖xe7 26 ♖xb7! ♖xf7 27 exf7 ♖d6 28 ♖xc6 and White wins.

24 ♖a8 ♖xg5 25 ♖xg7



25...♖e8 26 ♖xg5+ ♖c7

After 26...♖e7 27 ♖xe5 ♖xe6 28 ♖xe6 ♖xe6 29 ♖f5 White wins a piece and the game.

27 ♖g7+ ♖e7 28 ♖xe5+ ♖b6 29 ♖xd4+ ♖c7 30 ♖e5+ ♖b6 31 ♖b8+ 1-0

Game 86

Filippov-Pridorozhni

Ekaterinburg 1997

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 b5 6 a4 c6 7 0-0 ♖b7 8 ♖e5 a6 9 ♖c3

Also possible is 9 b3 cxb3 10 ♖b2. Then 10...♖b6 11 ♖xb3 ♖bd7 12 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 13 ♖d2 ♖e7 14 d5! saw White exploit his superior development after 14...cxd5 15 ♖xg7 ♖g8 in Tukmakov-Korchnoi, Leningrad 1973, Tukmakov giving 16 ♖h6!? ♖g6 17 ♖e3 ♖c5 18 ♖xc5 ♖xc5 19 ♖b2 as unclear due to Black's weak dark squares. Alternatively, Black sorted out his kingside in Orlov-Akopian, Minsk 1990, although after 10...♖e7 11 ♖xb3 0-0 12 ♖d2 ♖a7 13 ♖fe1 ♖e8 14 ♖ac1 a5 15 e4 ♖a6 16 axb5 ♖xb5 17 ♖e3 ♖a6 18 g4 White started an offensive in this sector, the subsequent 18...a4 19 g5 ♖fd7 20 ♖ec4 f6 21 gxf6 ♖xf6 22 e5 ♖g6 23 ♖h1 resulting in a balanced game.

9...♖d5

Black can try 9...♖b6, e.g. 10 e4 ♖bd7 11 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 12 d5 ♖c5 13 dxe6 fxe6 14 ♖h3 ♖f8 15 ♖h5+ g6 16 ♖h6 and White has considerable play for the pawn, although this is preferable for Black to Shabalov-Martynov, Moscow 1987, which went 12...cxd5 13 exd5 e5 14 axb5 axb5 15 ♖xa8+ ♖xa8 16 ♖e3 ♖c5 17 ♖g4 g6 18 ♖xc5 ♖xc5 19 ♖a1 ♖b7 20 ♖a5.

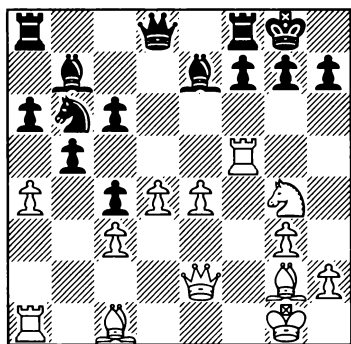
In Filippov-Akhmadeev, Kolontaevo 1994 Black opted for the quieter 10...♖e7 11 ♖e3 0-0 12 b3 cxb3 13 ♖xb3 ♖d8 (13...c5 is too early in view of 14 ♖c4! with an edge for White), inviting White to gradually build up his forces with 14 ♖fd1 ♖bd7 15 ♖d3 ♖e8 16 ♖ac1 ♖c8 17 h3 h6 18 g4 ♖a8 19 f4 etc.

10 e4

White concentrates on the centre. 10 ♖e4 ♘d7 11 ♙g5 f6 12 ♘xd7 ♗xd7 13 ♙d2 ♙e7 14 ♘c5 ♙xc5 15 dxc5 ♗e7 16 e4 ♘c7 17 ♙a5 e5 18 ♗d6 resulted in the usual dark square theme in Szabo-Shamkovich, Constanza 1969. 10 axb5 must also be investigated. Then 10...cxb5 transposes to 5...a6 6 0-0 b5 7 ♖e5 ♘d5 8 a4 c6 9 axb5 cxb5 10 ♘c3 ♙b7 (Chapter 5), which leaves 10...axb5 11 ♗xa8 ♙xa8 12 ♙xd5 cxd5 13 ♘xb5 as in Piket-Lputian, Montecatini Terme 2000. White wins back the pawn but now Black is able to smoothly bring his forces into the game, and Lputian secured equal chances: 13...♗a5 14 ♘c3 ♘c6 15 ♙f4 ♙b4 16 e4 0-0 17 ♗g4 h5 18 ♘xc6 ♙xc6 19 ♗xh5 ♙xc3 20 bxc3 ♗xc3 21 ♙e5 ♗d2 22 ♗d1 ♗h6 23 ♗xh6 gxh6.

10...♙xc3 11 bxc3 ♘d7 12 f4 ♙f6?!

12...♙e7 is appropriate, when 13 ♘xf7?! is dubious in view of 13...♙xf7 14 f5 e5! and Black keeps the position closed. G.Gross-M.Gurevich, Germany 1998 is a more useful model for White: 13 ♗g4 0-0 14 f5 ♘f6 15 ♗e2 exf5 16 ♗xf5 ♘d7 17 ♘g4 ♘b6



Now White found the dangerous looking 18 ♘h6+!?, both players having a fight on their hands after 18...gxh6 19 ♙xh6 ♙h8 20 e5 ♘d5.

13 f5 exf5 14 ♗xf5 ♙e7 15 ♗f3 c5

16 d5 0-0 17 ♙e3

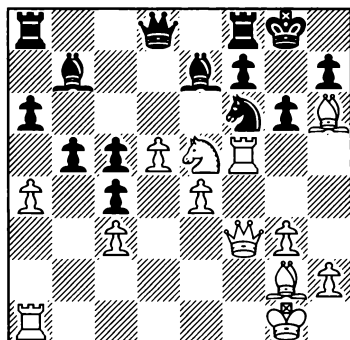
The forcing 17 ♘c6 ♙xc6 18 dxc6 prom-

ises White less than the game continuation.

17...g6?!

17...♗a5 18 ♙g5 h6?! 19 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 20 ♗xf6! gxg6 21 ♘g4 with good chances of success on the kingside.

18 ♙h6!!



A brilliant sacrifice!

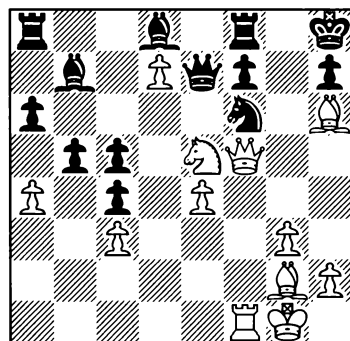
18...gxf5 19 ♗xf5 ♙h8 20 ♗f1!

White allows his forces full participation. Black is helpless.

20...♗e8

After 20...♗d6 21 ♗g5 ♘e8 22 ♙xf8 ♙xg5 23 ♘xf7+ Black avoids mate but not defeat.

21 d6 ♙d8 22 d7 ♗e7



23 ♗g5 ♘h5

23...♗g8 doesn't help Black 24 ♗xf6+ ♗xf6 25 ♗xf6 ♗g6 26 ♘xg6+ hxg6 27 ♗xf7. 24 ♗xh5 f6 25 ♙xf8 ♗xe5 26 ♗e8! ♙c6 27 ♙e7+ 1-0

Summary

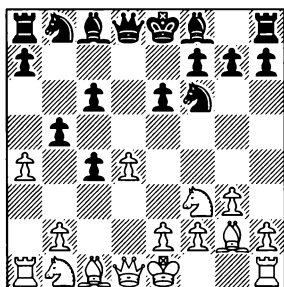
After 6 a4 c6 7 axb5 cxb5 8 ♖e5 ♘d5 9 ♖c3 ♙b4 10 0-0 ♙xc3 11 e4 it is difficult for White to achieve an advantage as Black is provided good counterplay by his queenside pawns. Consequently the line with 6 a4 c6 7 0-0 ♙b7 8 ♖e5 holds more potential for White. The problems with 8...♙b6 (such as reducing Black's influence over d5) were pointed out in Khalifman-Sveshnikov, while after 8...♘d5 White can successfully generate an with either 9 e4 or 9 b3. Perhaps Black should play 8...a6, when White has control over the centre, while 9 b3 is less effective – prompting the conclusion that there is no guarantee of an advantage.

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 b5 6 a4 c6 (1) 7 0-0

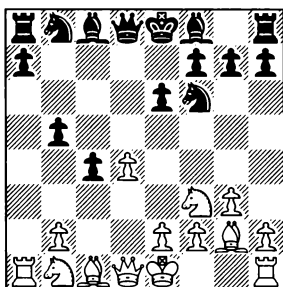
7 axb5 cxb5 (D) 8 ♖e5 ♘d5 – Game 84

7...♙b7 8 ♖e5 (D)

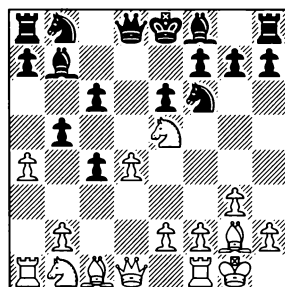
8...♘d5 – Game 85; 8...a6 – Game 86



6...c6



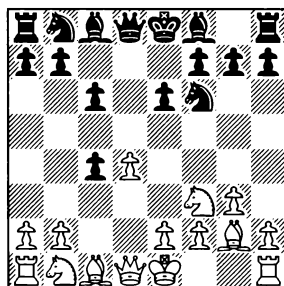
7...cxb5



8 ♖e5

CHAPTER NINE

4...dxc4 5 ♖g2 c6



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 c6

5...c6 is rarely seen. White can choose to head for the 5...b5 lines with 6 0-0 b5 7 a4 but there is also the more challenge with 6 ♘e5!?, which has a downside in that 6...♗b4+ can disrupt the first player's development. White can block the check with 7 ♘c3 with decent chances of achieving something concrete from the opening phase, or he can try the interesting gambit with 7 ♖d2, as seen in both games in this chapter. In the first game Black accepts the second pawn with 7...♙xd4 and faces a difficult task defending against White's threats (something in which he does not succeed). In the second game Black seeks to exploit the temporarily poor posting of the bishop on d2 with 7...♗e7, adopting a more positional approach.

Game 87

Chetverik-Burmakin

Nagykanizsa 1993

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 c6 6 ♘e5 ♗b4+ 7 ♖d2

Let us look at 7 ♘c3 ♘d5. Then 8 ♙c2? ♘xc3! 9 bxc3 ♙xd4! 10 ♗b2 ♗a5 11 ♘f3 ♙f6 12 ♘d2 0-0 13 ♘xc4 ♗c7 14 0-0 ♘d7

15 ♘d2 ♙g6 16 e4 e5 saw Black keep the pawn at no cost to himself in Castillo-Sadler, Linares 1995.

After 8 ♖d2 the ball is in Black's court. In Bondarevsky-Keres, Moscow 1947 White emerged with a slight edge after 8...♘b6 9 ♘e4 a5 10 e3 0-0 11 ♙c2 ♘d8 12 ♗xb4 axb4 13 ♘xc4 ♘xc4 14 ♙xc4 thanks to his easier piece play. This leaves 8...♗xc3 9 bxc3 b5 10 a4 when White's activity compensates fully for the pawn deficit. Tkachiev-Kazhgaleev, Cannes 1999 continued 10...f6 11 ♘f3 0-0 12 e4 ♘e7 13 ♗c1! a6 14 ♗a3 ♘d7 15 0-0 ♘b6 16 a5 ♘d7?! (16...♗a4?) 17 ♗h3 ♗f7 18 d5!? (18 e5!?) 18...exd5 19 exd5 ♘xd5, and now White could have played 20 ♗e6+! ♗xe6 21 ♘d4+ ♗f7 22 ♘xc6 ♘e5! 23 ♘xd8+ ♙xd8. Black has only two knights for the queen but the semi-closed position and the great outposts on d3 and d5 mean something, although White has the better chances.

7...♙xd4 8 ♗xb4 ♙xe5 9 ♗a3! b5

Forced. In the case of 9...♙xb2? 10 ♙b1 ♙e5 11 ♘xc4 White wins after ♘d6+, and 9...c5?! is not to be recommended in view of 10 ♘xc4 ♙c7 11 ♙d6! (Neistadt).

10 f4 ♙c7 11 ♘b5 cxb5 12 ♗xa8 ♗b7 13 ♗xb7 ♙xb7 14 0-0

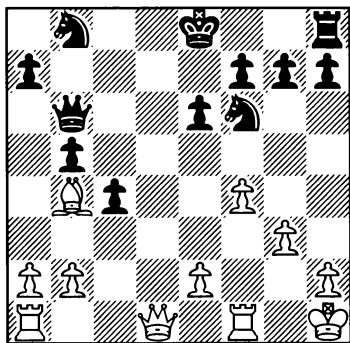
This is the most natural move. Another

try is 14 ♖f1!? ♖d5 15 ♖c5 ♖d7 16 ♖d4 f6, when Pankratov-Kharlov, Moscow 1998 saw 17 e4 ♖xc5 18 ♖xc5 ♖b6! 19 ♖xb6 ♖xb6 20 0-0-0 ♖e7 21 ♖d4 ♖c8 22 ♖fd1 with a very pleasant ending for White. At the moment only the d-file is open so it is difficult for White to break through. After a further opening up of the position the difference in strength between the rook and knight will show. Instead of 17 e4 White should consider castling long, as 17 0-0-0! ♖xc5 18 ♖xc5 f5 19 e4! fxe4 20 f5! creates a formidable attack against Black's stranded king.

14...♖b6+

In Shipov-Maljutin, Moscow 1991 Black's knights were busy after 14...♖c6 15 ♖c3 ♖e4 16 a4 (16 ♖xg7 ♖g8 17 ♖d4 h5 gives Black counterplay) 16...b4?! (16...♖xc3 17 bxc3 b4 18 cxb4 ♖xb4 19 e3 is a lesser evil) 17 ♖e1 0-0 18 ♖c2 ♖d6 19 ♖d1 ♖f5 20 ♖f2 but were nevertheless short of outposts, resulting in insufficient compensation for the exchange.

15 ♖h1



15...h5?!

Black should prefer 15...♖c6 16 ♖c3 ♖g4 17 ♖d6 ♖e3 18 ♖f3 (not 18 ♖fd1?? ♖b7, when White resigned in Pasmaan-Stean, Beer-Sheva 1978) 18...♖f5 19 ♖d2 b4 20 ♖e5 0-0 and White found his bishop stuck on e5 and his centre weakened, leaving the situation unclear.

16 ♖f3 ♖e4

After 16...♖c6 17 ♖c3 ♖e4 18 ♖xg7 ♖g8 19 ♖c3 ♖f2+ 20 ♖xf2 ♖xf2 21 ♖d6 Black restores the points score but the weakness of his dark squares spells serious trouble.

17 f5! ♖a6

17...♖h6 18 fxe6 ♖xe6 19 ♖f1 favours White.

18 fxe6?!

More clear-cut is 18 ♖c3 0-0 (18...♖f2+ 19 ♖xf2 ♖xf2 20 ♖xg7 ♖g8 21 ♖f6) 19 ♖d4 with a superior endgame for White.

18...♖xe6 19 a3

In the event of 19 ♖c3 Black can consider 19...h4!? because 19...0-0 20 ♖d4 ♖g6 21 ♖xa7 is preferable for White.

19...♖xb4 20 axb4 ♖g5 21 ♖f2

21 ♖xa7 ♖c6 is equal.

21...0-0 22 ♖d4 ♖c6+ 23 ♖g2 a6 .24 ♖d1

24 ♖h4!? is worth a look.

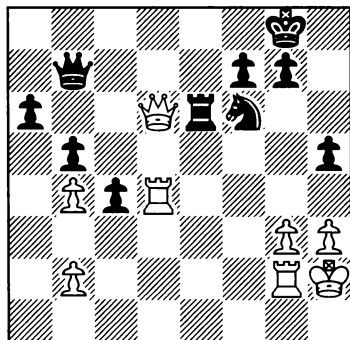
24...♖e4

Black's forces enjoy good co-ordination. The knight stands well on e4 and White has pawn weaknesses, thus affording Black compensation for the exchange.

25 ♖d7 ♖f6

Also good is 25...♖xd7 26 ♖xd7 ♖e8 but Black prefers to keep the queens on the board. This makes sense as the white king is susceptible to attack.

26 ♖d4 ♖e7 27 e3 ♖e8 28 ♖d7 ♖e5 29 ♖d5 ♖b8 30 ♖d4 ♖f6 31 ♖d6 ♖b7 32 h3 ♖xe3 33 ♖h2 ♖e6



34 ♖d8+?

34 ♖c5 minimises Black's lead to a slight advantage.

34...♗h7 35 ♖f8 ♖e1 36 ♖c5 ♖f3 37 ♖f4 ♖d1 38 g4?

This loses, but 38 ♖g1 ♖xg1 39 ♖xg1 ♖d2+ 40 ♖f2 ♖xb4 does not help White.

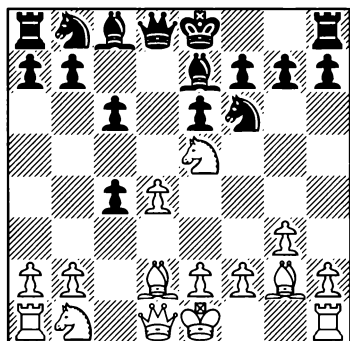
38...♗h1+ 39 ♖g3 ♖d3+ 0-1

Game 88

Stefanova-Kurajica

Benasque 1997

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 c6 6 ♖e5 ♖b4+ 7 ♖d2 ♖e7



8 ♖c3

White can also play 8 e3, when 8...c5!? 9 ♖a4+ ♖d7 10 ♖xc4 ♖c6 11 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 12 ♖xc6+ bxc6 13 dxc5 ♖d5 14 ♖xd5 cxd5 15 ♖c3 ♖xc5 16 ♖xf6 gxf6 brings about an approximately level ending and 11 0-0 offers White an edge.

After the text Black has tried 8...♖d5 9 ♖xc4 b5?!, but this proved good for White in Chetverik-Matras, Prague 2002 when the bishop landed on a5: 10 ♖a5 ♖b4+ 11 ♖xb4 ♖xb4 12 ♖e3 (12 ♖e5?! runs into 12...♖xd4! 13 ♖xd4 ♖c2+ 14 ♖d2 ♖xd4 – note that from e3 the knight protects c2) 12...♖b7 13 0-0 and White was in control of the vital c5-square. In order to avoid this

situation Black now elects to begin his queenside play by first pushing the a-pawn.

8...a5 9 a4?!

The natural looking 9 0-0 ♖d5 10 ♖xc4 b5 11 ♖e5 secures White a modest edge.

9...♖d5 10 ♖xc4 b5 11 axb5 cxb5 12 ♖e5

Again 12 ♖e3!? is an interesting move, e.g. 12...♖xe3 13 fxe3 ♖a6 with chances for both sides, or 12...♖b7 13 ♖d3 b4 14 ♖d2 0-0 with equality.

12...0-0 13 0-0 ♖b7 14 ♖b3

14 e4?! ♖f6! 15 ♖d3 b4 16 ♖d2 ♖a6 17 ♖c4 ♖c6! and Black wins material because d4 is under fire and there is the threat of ...♖e5! etc. 14 ♖d2 a4 is slightly better for Black.

14...b4 15 ♖d2 ♖c6 16 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 17 e4 ♖b6 18 ♖e3?!

Or 18 ♖c1 ♖b7 19 ♖e3 a4 and Black is making considerable progress on the queenside.

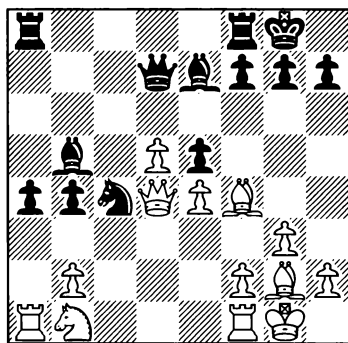
18...a4 19 ♖d3 ♖d7 20 d5?

The lesser evil is 20 ♖d1 ♖b5 21 ♖d2 ♖c4.

20...♖b5

Black wins material.

21 ♖d4 ♖c4 22 ♖f4 e5!



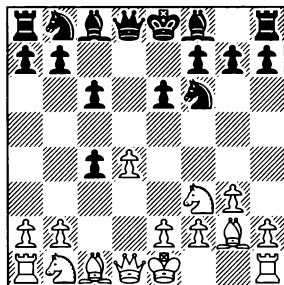
23 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 24 ♖xe5 ♖xf1 25 ♖xf1 ♖f6 26 ♖h5 ♖xb2 27 ♖a2 g6 28 ♖f3 ♖g7 0-1

Summary

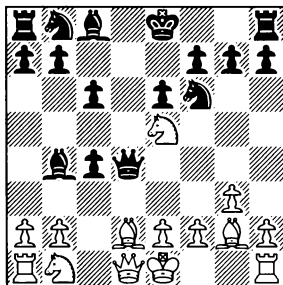
This line is a bit too obscure and lacks something in flexibility for today's top players. If White wants he can transpose to the sharp 5...b5 line with 6 0-0 b5 7 a4, while another option is a guaranteed advantage after 6 ♖e5 ♖b4+ 7 ♖d2. It is then very dangerous for Black to take the pawns in the centre, and White enjoys an enduring lead after 7...♙e7 8 ♖c3 followed by ♖xc4.

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 c6 (D) 6 ♖e5 ♖b4+ 7 ♖d2

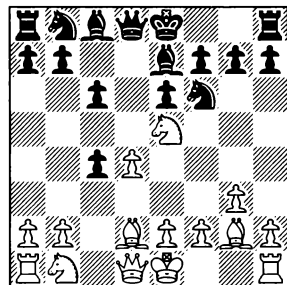
7...♙xd4 (D) – Game 87; 7...♙e7 (D) – Game 88



5...c6



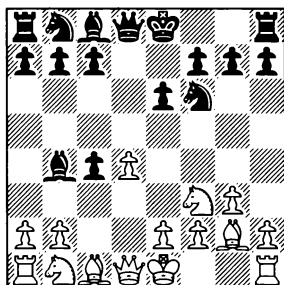
7...♙xd4



* 7...♙e7

CHAPTER TEN

4...dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♜b4+



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♜b4+

This check is designed to throw a (small) spanner in the works as far as White's co-ordination is concerned, as well as the defence of the d4-pawn. However, the idea is seen rather seldom with this particular move order.

The positions in this line can usually be compared to those of the Bogó-Indian Defence (1 d4 ♘f6 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♙b4+), while 6 ♘c3 0-0 7 0-0 transposes to the Nimzo-Indian Defence (1 d4 ♘f6 2 c4 e6 3 ♘c3 ♙b4 4 g3 0-0 5 ♘f3 d5 6 ♙g2 dxc4 7 0-0) – in this book these positions can be found via the move order 5...♘c6 6 0-0 in Chapter 6.

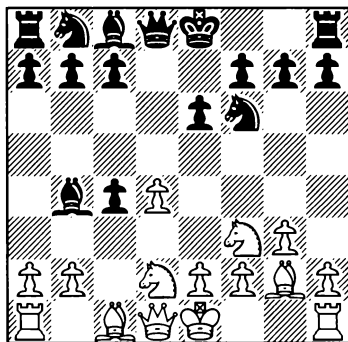
The continuations 6 ♘bd2 and 6 ♙d2 are of approximately level theoretical importance. The position after 6 ♘bd2 often arises through the move order 1 d4 ♘f6 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♙b4+ 4 ♘bd2 d5 5 g3 dxc4 6 ♙g2 when, in the case of 6...c3 7 bxc3 ♙xc3 8 ♙b1, White's pressure on the b- and c-files and his lead in development compensate for the pawn. Therefore we are more likely to see 6...♘c6 or 6...0-0, and these two options often overlap (Game 89).

In reply to 6 ♙d2 Black rarely trades bishops, and after 6...♙xd2+ 7 ♙xd2 Black struggles if he tries to hang on to the extra pawn

pawn with 7...b5?! thanks to 8 ♙g5 with a double attack. However, alternatives also leave Black passive and without counterplay, which explains why avoiding the exchange with 6...♙e7, 6...c5 and 6...a5 (Game 90) is preferable.

Game 89 Kozul-Ljubojevic Belgrade 1989

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♜b4+ 6 ♘bd2



6...0-0

After 6...c3 7 bxc3 ♙xc3 Black wins a pawn. Then 8 ♙b1 ♘e4 9 0-0 ♙xd2 10 ♙xd2 ♘xd2 11 ♙xd2 ♘d7 12 ♙fcl left

White with the usual 'development' compensation in Haba-Hübner, Germany 1993, which was soon unclear after 12...0-0 13 a4 a5 14 ♖c2 c6 15 e4 ♟f6 16 ♜d1.

Another option for Black is 6...♟c6 7 0-0 ♜xd2. Tukmakov-Lputian, Novosibirsk 1986 continued 8 ♜xd2 ♟xd4 9 ♟e5!? 0-0 10 ♜c1 c5 11 ♜xc4 ♟d7 12 ♟d3, White winning back the invested material with the better game, retaining his lead after 12...e5 13 ♟xc5 ♟xc5 14 ♜xc5 ♖e7 15 ♜b4 ♜g4 16 f3 ♜e6 17 e3 ♟c6 18 ♜a3 etc.

White can adopt a different set-up by recapturing with the queen, e.g. 8 ♖xd2 ♜b8 9 b3!? cxb3 10 ♜a3, when White is trying to keep Black's king stranded in the centre. This plan was used in Kozul-Vukovic, Banja Vrućica 1991 which went 10...♟e7 11 axb3 ♜d7 12 ♟e5 ♜b5 13 ♜fc1 a6 14 g4 0-0 15 g5 ♟e8 16 ♜c3 and White's kingside offensive was up and running. Instead of 8...♜b8 Black has 8...0-0 9 ♖c3 b5, when after 10 ♟e5 ♟xd4 11 ♜e1 ♜b8 12 e3 White hits the piece that defends against the fork on c6. Consequently Black should maintain the momentum by parting with the knight, although 12...c5 13 exd4 cxd4 14 ♖a3 anyway favours White.

7 0-0

Creating a genuine threat against c4 by lifting the pin. 7 ♖c2 is the alternative means to hit c4, when Black is not obliged to react. 7...b5 8 a4 bxa4 sees Black voluntarily weaken his pawn structure in return for piece play, Haba-Hübner, Germany 1991 continuing 9 0-0 ♜b7 10 ♟xc4 c5 11 ♜g5 ♟c6 12 dxc5 ♜xc5 13 ♖xa4 ♖e7 14 ♜ac1 ♜ac8 15 ♜e3 ♜xe3 when a draw was agreed, although White is slightly better in this position. Black can also play 7...c5 8 dxc5 c3 9 bxc3 ♜xc5 10 0-0 ♟c6 11 ♟b3 ♜e7 12 ♜d1 ♖c7 13 ♜f4 e5 14 ♜e3, this time White accepting a little structural damage in order to generate pressure on the queenside. This seemed to work in D.Gurevich-Tiviakov, New York 1998 after 14...♜g4 15 h3 ♜h5 16

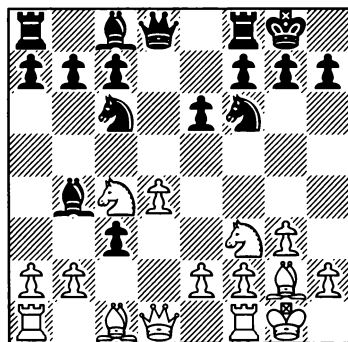
♟h4 ♜fd8 17 ♜xd8+ ♜xd8 18 ♜d1 with an edge for White.

A simple, albeit rather unambitious approach is to anticipate the coming capture on c4 and prepare a trade of queens with 7...♟c6 8 ♖xc4 ♖d5, although 9 0-0 ♜xd2 10 ♖xd5 exd5 11 ♜xd2 ♜g4 12 ♜fc1 ♜ac8 13 e3 ♟e4 14 ♜e1 resulted in White having the more comfortable game in D.Gurevich-Young, Reno 1992 thanks to the bishop pair. There followed 14...♜fe8 15 b4 ♟d6 16 a4 a6 17 ♜ab1 ♜f5 18 ♜b3 ♟a7 19 ♟e5 c6 20 g4 ♜e6 21 f3 f5 22 h3 ♜cd8 23 ♜h4 ♜a8 24 ♜g3 ♜ac8 25 ♜bc3 g6 26 ♜f1 and Black had failed to drum up worthy counterplay, being reduced to the unenviable policy of waiting to see how White chose to continue the battle.

7...c3

Raetsky-Gipslis, Senden 1998 went 7...b5 8 a4 c6 9 ♖c2 a5 10 b3 cxb3 11 ♟xb3 bxa4 12 ♜xa4 ♜a6 13 ♜g5 ♜b5 14 ♜a2 h6 15 ♜xf6 ♖xf6 16 ♟e5 ♜d8 17 ♜b1 a4 18 ♟c5 when, for the pawn, White had managed to generate a formidable initiative.

8 ♟c4 ♟c6



9 ♖d3

Quite different is 9 b3, White hoping to win the c3-pawn. Haba-Ostrowski, Czechia 1999 developed as follows: 9...♜b8 10 a3 ♜e7 11 ♖c2 b5 12 ♟ce5 ♜b7 13 ♟xc6 ♜xc6 14 ♖xc3 ♜e4 15 ♜b2 ♟d5 16 ♖c1 ♖c8 17 ♟e5 and White was ready to ad-

vance the e-pawn.

9...cxb2 10 ♖xb2 ♙e7 11 ♖ac1 a5 12 ♖b1

12 ♖d1 a4 13 e4 a3 14 ♙a1 ♙d7 15 ♖b1 ♖a4 16 d5 exd5 17 exd5 ♙a5 was the course of Raetsky-Rashkovsky, Cappelle la Grande 2000. Now White could have had chances for an advantage with 18 d6! ♖xc4 19 dxe7 ♖xe7 20 ♙g5 (20 ♖xc4 ♙xc4 21 ♙xf6 gxf6 22 ♖xb7 with compensation for the material) 20...g6 21 ♖xc4 ♙xc4 22 ♙xf6 ♖xf6 23 ♙xh7! ♙xh7 24 ♖xd7 etc.

12...a4 13 e4 a3 14 ♙a1 ♙b4 15 ♖fd1 ♖a4 16 ♙e3 c6 17 h4 h6 18 ♙f1 ♙d7

An interesting option is 18...b5!? 19 ♙e5 ♖b6 with chances for both sides.

19 ♙c4 b5 20 ♙b3 ♖a7 21 ♙e5

White has better in 21 ♙c3! ♙a6 22 ♙d2!, redeploying the bishop for an attack on the kingside, e.g. 22...♖b6 23 e5 ♙d5 24 ♙g4.

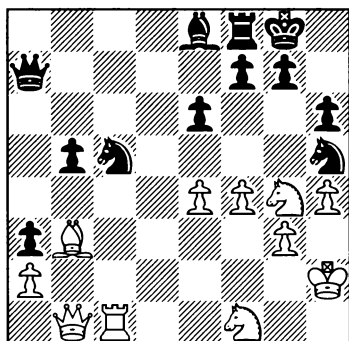
21...♙e8 22 f4?!

Dubious. The correct treatment is 22 ♙5g4 ♙xg4 23 ♙xg4 ♖b6 24 e5! (Kozul).

22...♙h5! 23 ♙f1

23 ♙g2 ♙xh4! helps Black.

23...♖b6 24 ♙h2 c5 25 dxc5 ♙xc5 26 ♖xc5 ♖xc5 27 ♙d4 ♖e7 28 ♖c1 ♙a6 29 ♙xa7 ♖xa7 30 ♙g4 ♙c5



31 ♙d1

Perhaps White might try 31 e5!? ♙c6 32 ♙d1, thus avoiding Black's next, which opens up the centre.

31...f5! 32 exf5 exf5 33 ♙e5 ♙e4 34

♖c2 ♖d4 35 ♙f3?

35 ♙xh5 ♙xh5 36 ♖xb5 ♖d1 is the lesser evil.

35...b4

Black has a decisive lead.

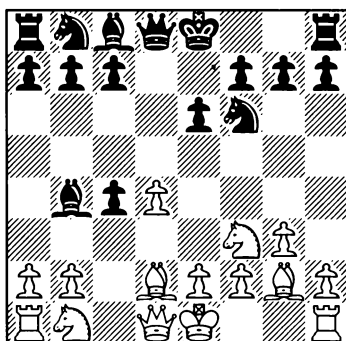
36 ♖b3+ ♙h7 37 ♙xe4 ♖xe4 38 ♖c7 ♙b5 39 ♙e3 ♙xf4 40 ♖c5

40 ♖e7 ♙a4! etc.

40...♖d8! 41 gxf4 ♖xf4+ 42 ♙h3 ♙f1+! 0-1

Game 90
Karpov-Piket
Monaco 1999

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♙f3 ♙f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♙b4+ 6 ♙d2



6...a5

Of course Black has other options. After 6...♙xd2+ 7 ♖xd2 a mistake is 7...b5!? in view of 8 ♖g5 with simultaneous threats against b5 and g7. Instead 7...0-0 8 ♙a3 ♙d7 9 ♙xc4 ♙c6 10 0-0 ♙bd7 11 ♖fc1 ♙d5 12 b4 left White in charge on the queenside in Portisch-P.Nikolic, Linares 1988.

6...♙e7 7 0-0 leads only to equality after 7...♙d7! 8 ♖c2 ♙c6 9 ♖xc4. Unander-Plato, Sweden 1995 saw the more combative 7 ♖c2 ♙d7 8 ♙e5!? ♙c6 9 ♖xc4 ♙xe5 10 dxe5 ♙d5 11 0-0 0-0 12 ♙c3 c6 13 a4 ♖b8 14 f4 a5 15 ♖d3 ♖c7 16 ♖ac1 and White enjoyed more space.

An interesting situation arises after 6...c5 7

♙xb4 cxb4 8 ♜e5 0-0 9 ♜xc4 ♜c6 10 e3, when Chetverik-Ziabari, Prague 2002 continued 10...e5!?, the point being that after 11 ♙xc6 bxc6 both 12 dxe5 ♙xd1+ 13 ♙xd1 ♜e4! 14 ♙e2 ♙a6 15 ♜c1 ♜ad8 and 12 ♜xe5 ♙h3 13 ♙f3 ♜c8 Black has compensation. Consequently White chose 11 d5, when the counter 11...b5! 12 dxc6 ♙xd1+ 13 ♙xd1 bxc4 14 ♜d2 c3 15 bxc3 bxc3 16 ♜c4 e4 17 ♙c2 ♙e6 18 ♙xc3 ♙d5 19 ♜a5 ♙xc6 would have led to equality.

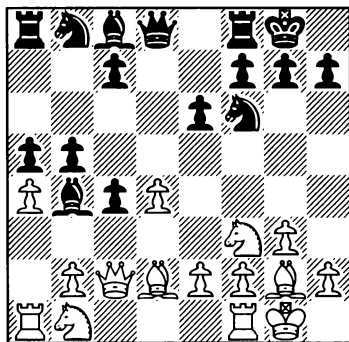
7 0-0 0-0

After 7...b5?! 8 a4 c6 9 axb5 ♙xd2 10 ♙xd2 cxb6 White again has 11 ♙g5 with the now familiar double threat against b5 and g7. Voloshin-Fiodorov, Polanica Zdroj 1997 saw 11...♜d5 12 ♙xg7 ♙f6 13 ♙xf6 ♜xf6 14 ♜e5 ♜d5 15 ♜c3 f6 16 ♜xd5 exd5 17 ♜f7! ♙e6 18 ♜d6+ ♙d7 19 ♜xb5.

8 ♙c2 b5?!

Babula-Jirovsky, Zlin 1997 witnessed another exchange of queens: 8...♜c6 9 ♙xc4 ♙d5 10 ♜c1 ♜d8 11 ♙xd5 exd5 12 ♙f4 ♙g4 13 e3 ♜d7 14 ♜c3 ♜h5 15 ♜b5 ♜xf4 16 gxf4 f6 17 a3 ♙f8 18 ♜e1 a4 19 ♙f1 ♜a5 20 ♙d3 g6 21 ♜c3 ♜a7 22 ♙c2 b5 23 ♜d3 and White's pull on the queenside was enough for an advantage.

9 a4



9...bxa4 10 ♜xa4

White has an interesting idea in picking up the a4-pawn with the knight, an approach

tried in Gulko-Makarychev, Moscow 1974, when 10 ♜c3! ♙b7 11 ♜xa4 ♙xd2 12 ♙xd2 ♜bd7 13 ♜fc1 ♜b6 14 ♜c5 ♜e4 15 ♙e1 ♜xc5 16 dxc5 ♜d5 17 ♜e5 c3 18 bxc3 f6 19 ♜cb1 favoured White. The advantage remained intact after the subsequent 19...♜a7 20 c6 ♙a8 21 ♜d7 ♜e8 22 c4 ♙xc6 23 ♜b8! ♙b7 24 ♜xb7! ♙xb7 25 ♜c6 ♙d6 26 cxd5 exd5 27 ♙xa5 ♜b2 28 ♙xd5+ ♙f8 29 e3, the two minor pieces being stronger than the rook (although Black can still fight on).

10...♙b7 11 ♙xb4 axb4 12 ♜xa8 ♙xa8 13 ♜bd2

13 ♙xc4 leads only to equality after 13...♙d5 14 ♙xb4 ♜c6 15 ♙c5 ♙xf3 16 ♙xf3 ♜xd4 17 ♜c3 ♜xf3+ 18 exf3.

13...c5

Black can clear the queenside with 13...c3 14 bxc3 bxc3 15 ♙xc3 ♜e4 16 ♜xe4 ♙xe4 17 ♜e5 ♙xg2 18 ♙xg2 ♙d5+ 19 ♙g1 (Piket), when White can claim a lead in view of his superior pawn structure.

14 dxc5 ♙a5 15 ♙xc4 ♙d5 16 ♙d4

16 ♙c2 ♜c8 17 e4 ♜xc5 18 ♙d3 gives White something to bite on.

16...♜d8 17 ♜c4 ♙xc4 18 ♙xc4 ♜c8 19 ♜d4?!

Better is 19 ♜d1 h6 (19...♜xc5?! 20 ♙xb4!) 20 h3 with a minimal advantage to White.

19...♜xc5 20 ♙d3 ♜c8 21 ♜d1 h6

21...♜d8 22 ♙c2 g6 23 e3 e5 is level.

22 h3 ♙a2 23 ♙b3 ♙xb3 24 ♜xb3 ♜fd7 25 f4 ♙f8 26 ♙e4 ♙e7

The king comes to the centre. Black has equal chances in this endgame.

27 ♜d4 f5 28 ♙d3 ♜c6 29 ♜c4 ♜b6 30 ♜c1 ♙d6 31 ♙f2 g5 32 e4

32 fxg5 hxg5 33 ♙b5 ♜e5 34 ♜xc8 ♜xc8 35 h4 with approximate equality.

32...gxf4 33 gxf4 fxe4 34 ♙xe4 ♜e7 35 ♜xc8 ♜exc8 36 ♜d4 ♜a4 37 b3 ♜c5 38 ♙c2 ♜e7 39 ♙f3 e5 40 ♜e2 exf4 41 ♜xf4 ♙e5 42 ♜d3+ ♜xd3 43 ♙xd3 ♜c6 ½-½

Summary

In the variation with 6 ♖bd2 ♘c6 Black usually exchanges on d2 and holds on to the gambit pawn. In return White enjoys better development and has definite compensation. After 6...0-0 White has a choice between taking direct aim at c4 with 7 ♖c2, with a slight edge, or seeking an initiative with 7 0-0, allowing Black to hang on to the material (after 7...b5 or 7...c3).

In reply to 6 ♗d2 all of 6...♗e7, 6...c5 and 6...a5 are reasonable for Black. Note that after 6...♗e7 7 0-0 Black can bring his other bishop (via d7) to c6 because 7...♗d7 8 ♘e5?! ♘c6 makes the bishop look misplaced on d2. White has a modest space advantage after 7 ♖c2 ♗d7 8 ♘e5.

In the variation with 6...c5 7 ♗xb4 cxb4 8 ♘e5 0-0 9 ♘xc4 ♘c6 10 e3 it was thought that 10...e5 was dubious due to 11 ♗xc6 bxc6 12 dxe5 ♖xd1 13 ♗xd1 ♘g4 14 ♖e1 (Bareev), but Black can certainly improve on 13...♘g4? with 13...♘e4, guaranteeing compensation for the pawn. Perhaps White should prefer 7 dxc5, with a slight lead in a standard Catalan position, rather than 7 ♗xb4.

After 6...a5 7 0-0 0-0 8 ♖c2 ♘c6 9 ♖xc4 ♗d6 we have a position which belongs in the line starting with 5...♘c6 6 ♖a4 ♗b4+ 7 ♗d2 ♗d6 8 ♖xc4 0-0 9 0-0 but with the additional ...a7-a5. The continuation 9 ♖xc4 ♖d5 differs from the well known variation in the Bogó-Indian Defence – namely 1 d4 ♘f6 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♗b4+ 4 ♗d2 a5 5 g3 d5 6 ♖c2 ♘c6 7 ♗g2 dxc4 8 ♖xc4 ♖d5 – in that neither player has castled in the Bogó. Here, apart from 10 ♖xd5 and 10 ♖d3, White has the additional possibility of 10 ♖c1 with a small but steady advantage.

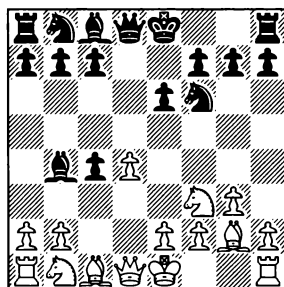
1 d4 d5 2 ♗c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♗g2 ♗b4+ (D)

6 ♘c3 0-0 7 0-0 ♘c6

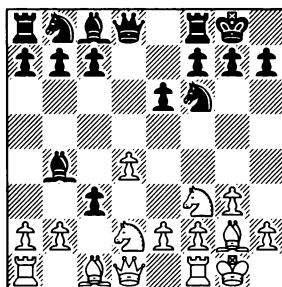
8 e3 ♖b8 – *Game 63* (Chapter 6); 8 ♖c2 ♖b8 – *Game 64* (Chapter 6)

6 ♖bd2 0-0 7 0-0 c3 (D) – *Game 89*

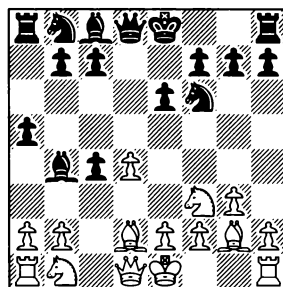
6 ♗d2 a5 (D) – *Game 90*



5...♗b4+



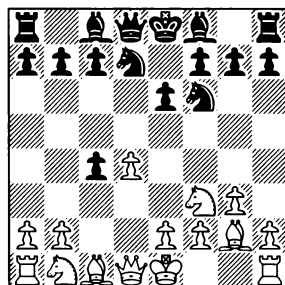
7...c3



6...a5

CHAPTER ELEVEN

4...dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♘bd7



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♘bd7

This natural posting of the knight is similar to Black's set-up in the Queen's Gambit Declined. Black addresses queenside development and prepares the liberating ...c7-c5 and ...e6-e5, but the system's peak in popularity has long gone. This is because White tends to find himself with an advantage and in little danger of facing counterplay from Black. Note that both 6 ♖a4 and 6 ♖c2 transpose to 5 ♖a4+ ♘bd7 in Chapter 3, so here we shall consider only the consequences of 6 0-0.

Then 6...♗e7 7 ♖c2 will again steer us to 5 ♖a4+, but White stands better after 7 ♘bd2 and 7 ♖fd2. 6...c5 is discussed in Game 91 and 6...♗b8 in Game 92.

Game 91 Vasilchenko-Meszaros Kecskemet 1991

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♘bd7 6 0-0 c5

Immediately contesting the centre. 6...♘b6 7 ♘bd2 c5 8 ♘xc4 transposes to 6...c5 7 ♘a3 ♘b6 8 ♘xc4 in the note to Black's 7th move below, but an alternative is 6...♗e7. Then 7 ♖c2 0-0 8 ♖xc4 transposes

to 5 ♖a4+ ♘bd7 6 ♖g2 ♗e7 7 ♖xc4 0-0 8 0-0 (Chapter 3).

7 ♖fd2 ♘b6 8 ♘xc4 ♘xc4 9 ♖a4+ ♘d7 10 ♖xc4 ♘b6 11 ♖d3 0-0 12 ♘c3 ♘d5 13 ♗d1 b6 14 e4 earns White the initiative. In Krasenkow-Hübner, Polanica Zdroj 1996 Black chose the inferior 14...♘b4?! 15 ♖b1 ♗b8 16 ♗f4 ♖g5 17 a3 ♘a6 18 ♗xg5 ♖xg5 19 b4 c5 20 f4 ♖h6 21 ♘b5 and found himself looking at a misplaced knight on a6. Hübner proposes an improvement in 14...♘xc3 15 bxc3 ♗b7 16 c4.

7 ♘bd2 also hits c4, A.Zaitsev-Hübner, Buesum 1969 continuing 7...♘b6 8 ♖c2 a6 9 a4 0-0 10 a5 ♘bd5 11 ♘xc4 b5 12 axb6 cxb6 13 ♖b3 ♗d7 14 ♖fe5 ♗b5 15 ♗d2 ♗e8 16 e4 ♖df6 17 ♗fd1 ♘d6 18 ♘xd6 ♗xd6 19 ♗g5 ♗c8 20 ♗f1! ♗xf1 21 ♗xf1 ♗e7 22 d5! with a nice attack for White. 7...b5 has been tried here, e.g. 8 a4 c6 9 axb5 cxb5 10 ♗e5 ♘xe5 11 ♗xa8 ♖xd4 12 ♖f3 ♘xf3+ 13 ♗xf3 ♖b6 14 b3 0-0 15 bxc4 bxc4 16 ♗e3 ♗c5 17 ♗xc5 ♖xc5 18 ♖a4 e5 19 ♗fc1 ♗e6 20 ♗b7 and White was in the driving seat in Ni Hua-Jakubowski, Oropesa 1999.

6...c6 supports the advance of the b-pawn, which soon saw action in Fine-Euwe, New York 1951 after 7 a4 b5 8 axb5 cxb5 9 ♘c3 ♖b6 10 b3 ♗b4 11 ♘a2 ♗e7 12 bxc4 bxc4 13 ♘d2 ♘d5 14 ♘xc4, when White stood

better thanks to his healthier pawns and queenside pressure. In Budnikov-Thesing, Germany 1992 Black sent his knight on a tour: 7...♘d5 8 e4 ♘b4 9 ♘a3 ♘d3 10 ♙g5 f6 11 ♘xc4 b5 12 axb5 cxb5 13 ♘a5 ♘xb2 14 ♚b3 ♘c4, and now after 15 ♙d2 ♘db6 16 ♚xb5+ ♘d7 17 ♚h5+ g6 18 ♚h4 ♙e7 19 ♙h6 White was in charge, in no small part thanks to Black's poor king.

7 ♘a3 a6

7...cxd4 8 ♘xc4 ♚c7 9 ♚xd4 b5 10 ♘ce5 ♙c5 11 ♚d3 looks nice for White, while Raetsky-Lechtynsky, Pardubice 1992 continued 7...♙e7 8 ♘xc4 0-0 9 ♙f4 ♘d5 10 ♙c1 ♘xf4 11 gxf4 ♚b8 12 dxc5 ♙xc5 13 ♚c2 ♘f6 14 ♚fd1 ♚e7 15 ♘fe5 ♘d5 16 e3 a6 17 a3, again with a queenside pull for White.

After 7...♘b6 8 ♙g5 Atalik gives 8...c3! 9 bxc3 cxd4 10 ♘b5 ♙d7 11 ♚b1! a6 12 ♘bxd4 h6 13 ♙xf6 gxf6 as unclear in view of the pawn weaknesses on both sides. Korchnoi-Miles, Rotterdam 1984 went 8 ♘xc4 ♘xc4 9 ♚a4+ ♙d7 10 ♚xc4 ♚b6 (10...b5 is a bit too early, as was demonstrated in Quinteros-Schweber, Buenos Aires 1998, which continued 11 ♚d3 c4 12 ♚c2 ♙c6 13 ♙g5 ♙e7 14 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 15 e4 ♙b7 16 ♙ad1 0-0 17 e5 ♙e7 18 ♘g5 ♙xg5 19 ♙xb7 ♚b8 20 ♙e4 g6 21 h4 ♙h6 22 d5 exd5 23 ♙xd5 ♚e7 24 ♚fe1 and Black was left to contend with e5-e6) 11 dxc5 ♙xc5 12 b4! ♚xb4 13 ♚xb4 ♙xb4 14 ♚b1 ♙d6 15 ♙d1 ♙e7 16 ♘g5 ♘d5. Korchnoi then gives 17 ♘xf7!? ♙xf7 18 ♚xb7 ♙e8 19 e4 ♙a4 (19...♙c6 20 ♚xg7 ♙e5?! 21 exd5 ♙a4 22 ♚g5! is excellent for White) 20 ♙d3 ♚c8 21 ♙b2 ♙c2 22 ♙d2 ♙b4 23 ♚xc2 ♚xc2 24 ♙xg7 ♘e3 25 fxe3 as a route to advantage for White.

8 dxc5 ♙xc5 9 ♘xc4 0-0

9...b5? runs into 10 ♘ce5 ♙b7 11 ♘xf7! ♙xf7 12 ♘g5+ ♙e7 13 ♙xb7 and White was close to winning in Raetsky-Andersen, Bad Ragaz 1994.

10 ♚c2 b5?!

10...♚e7 11 ♙g5 h6 12 ♙xf6 ♘xf6 13

♙ac1 with a slight advantage for White due to his lead in development.

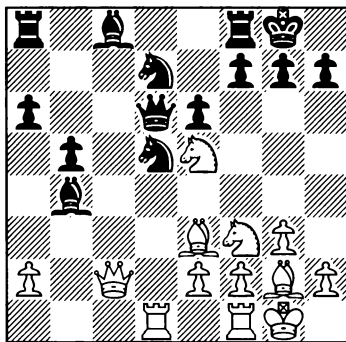
11 ♘ce5 ♚b6

Another try is 11...♚c7 12 ♙e3 ♙b6 (12...♙b7? 13 ♘xd7 ♘xd7 14 ♘g5 and White wins) 13 ♚xc7 ♙xc7 14 ♙ac1 with a considerable lead for White. Again Black has problems on the h1-a8 diagonal.

12 b4! ♙xb4 13 ♙e3 ♚d6 14 ♙ad1

14 ♘g5?! is tempting but Black pounces with 14...♘xe5 15 ♙xa8 ♘c4.

14...♘d5



15 ♘g5! f5

15...♘f6 16 ♘g4! and White wins at least a piece. 15...g6 is more stubborn, although White wins after 16 ♘exf7! ♚xf7 17 ♘xf7 ♙xf7 18 ♙f4 ♚c5 19 ♚xc5 ♘xc5 20 ♙xd5! etc.

16 ♘xe6! ♘xe3 17 fxe3 ♚xe5 18 ♘xf8 ♚xe3+ 19 ♙h1 1-0

Game 92

Kasparov-Korchnoi

Candidates Semi-final (9), London 1983

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♘bd7 6 0-0 ♚b8 7 a4 b6

Not Black's only configuration on the queenside. After 7...a6 8 a5 b5 9 axb6 cxb6 10 ♙f4 ♚b7 11 ♚xa6 ♘d5 12 ♘c3 Black played 12...♙e7?! in Tukmakov-O.Rodriguez, New York 1987, but following 13 ♘b5! 0-0 14 ♚c1 ♘xf4 15 gxf4 ♚b8 16 ♙a7 ♙b7 17

♖xc4 emerged a pawn down for nothing, his situation taking a turn for the worse after 17...♜f6 18 ♜e5 ♜d5 19 f5! ♖g5 20 ♜xf7! ♜xf7 21 fxe6 ♜f5 22 ♜xb7 ♜xb7 23 e4, when White won. Black can consider 12...♜xf4, when 13 gxf4 b5 14 ♜a8! ♜b6 15 ♜a5 favours White, the b5-pawn being weak and Black lagging behind in development. In Gulko-Shapiro, New York 1987 Black managed to use the b5-square (temporarily) for his own knight after 8...♜e4 9 ♖c2 ♜d6 10 ♜e5 ♜b5 11 ♜d1 ♜xe5 12 dxe5 ♖d7 13 ♖xc4 c5 14 ♜c3, when White collected the gambit pawn with a more active position. Indeed after 14...♖c7 15 ♜e4 ♖e7 16 ♖f4 0-0 17 ♜f6+! ♖xf6 18 exf6 e5 19 ♖e3 ♜d4 20 ♜xd4! exd4 21 ♖f4 White won material.

8 ♜fd2

8 ♜bd2 ♖a6 9 ♖c2 c3 10 bxc3 ♖xe2 11 ♜e1 ♖a6 was tried in Lutikov-Klovans, Vladivostok 1978, when White could have obtained the better chances after 12 c4! ♖e7 13 d5 ♜c5 14 ♜e5 ♖b7 15 dxe6 ♜xe6 16 ♖c6+ ♖xc6 (Neistadt gives 16...♖f8 17 ♜df3 with initiative) 17 ♜xc6 ♜d4 18 ♜xe7+! ♖xe7 19 ♜xd4 ♖e1+ 20 ♖g2, with two pieces for a rook.

8...e5

8...♖b7 9 ♖xb7 ♜xb7 10 ♜xc4 ♖e7 11 ♜c3 ♜d5 12 e4 ♜xc3 13 bxc3 ♜f6 14 ♖e2 is an edge for White, while 14 e5?! ♜d5 15 ♖g4 ♜xc3?! 16 ♖b2 h5 17 ♖xg7 ♜e2+ 18 ♖g2 ♖d5+ 19 f3 ♜f8 is unclear.

9 ♜xc4!

9 d5?! a5! 10 ♜c3 ♖a6 11 ♜b5 ♖xb5 12 axb5 ♖d6 13 ♜xc4 0-0 is equal.

9...exd4 10 ♖xd4 ♖c5 11 ♖d3 0-0 12 ♜c3 ♖b7 13 ♖xb7 ♜xb7 14 ♖f3!

14 ♖f4 ♖b4! 15 ♖f3 ♜c5 with only a small advantage for White.

14...♖a8 15 ♖f4 a6

15...♜bb8 16 ♖xa8 ♜xa8 17 ♜ad1 c6 18 e4 ♜f8 19 ♖c7 ♜e8 20 ♖d6 ♖xd6 21 ♜xd6 ♜e7 22 f4 favours White, whose proud knight is most unwelcome on d6.

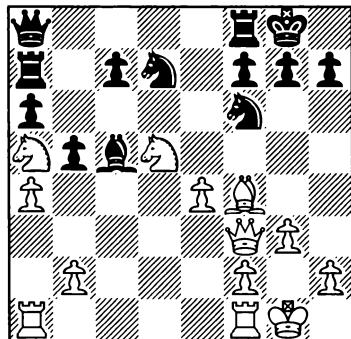
16 e4 ♜a7 17 ♜d5

Also possible is 17 ♖g2!? ♜e8 18 e5 ♖xf3+ 19 ♖xf3 ♜h5 20 ♜ad1 ♜xf4 21 gxf4 with a better endgame.

17...b5

17...♖c6 18 b3 ♜xd5 19 exd5 ♖f6 20 ♜ac1 is a lesser evil.

18 ♜a5!



18 ♜e5 forces too many exchanges and results in equality after 18...♜xe5 19 ♖xe5 ♜xd5 20 exd5 ♖d6 21 ♖d4 ♜b7 when, suddenly, Black is no longer cramped on the queenside.

18...bxa4?!

Far better is 18...♜e8! 19 ♜xc7 ♖xe4 20 ♖xe4 ♖xe4 21 axb5 axb5 22 ♜xb5 ♜a8 with chances to fight on despite White's extra pawn.

19 ♜fc1! ♖d4

Or 19...♖d6 20 ♜c6 ♖xf4 21 ♜xf4 ♜b7 22 e5 ♜e8 23 ♜xa4 with a decisive lead.

20 ♜xa4 ♖xb2?

Losing the exchange. After the more accurate 20...♜xd5 21 exd5 ♖xb2 22 ♜c2 ♖f6 23 ♖e3! ♜b6 24 ♖g4 White stays on top thanks to his attacking chances and Black's poor co-ordination.

21 ♜e7+! ♖h8 22 ♜c2 ♖e8

Or 22...♜e5 23 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 24 ♜ac6 ♖e8 25 ♜a5 ♖d6 26 e5 ♖xe7 27 ♜xa7 ♜d7 28 ♜c6 and White wins.

23 ♖xb2 ♖xe7 24 ♜c6 ♖c5 25 ♜xa7 ♖xa7 26 e5 ♜g8 27 ♖e3 ♖a8 28 ♖xa8 ♜xa8 29 f4 ♜e7 30 ♜d2 1-0

Summary

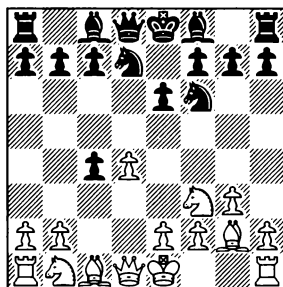
Practice shows that the 5...♟bd7 system is difficult for Black, which is why it is seldom seen on the tournament circuit these days. After 6...c5 7 ♞a3 (Game 91) 7...♟b6 our attention is drawn to the standard collection of the pawn with 8 ♟xc4! ♟xc4 9 ♜a4+ ♙d7 10 ♜xc4 (note that this is possible after 6...♟b6 7 ♟bd2 c5 8 ♟xc4). After 6...♞b8 7 a4 b6 (Game 92) Black's defensive task seems sufficiently difficult to prefer 7...a6 8 a5 ♟e4.

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♟f3 ♟f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♙g2 ♟bd7 (D)

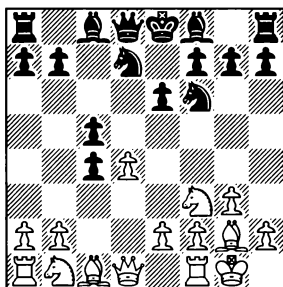
6 ♜a4 a6 7 ♜xc4 – Games 25 & 26 (Chapter 3)

6 0-0

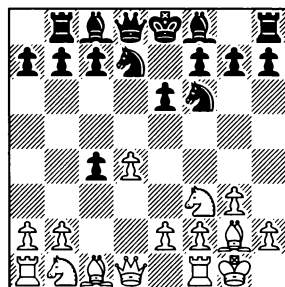
6...c5 (D) – Game 91; 6...♞b8 (D) – Game 92



5...♟bd7



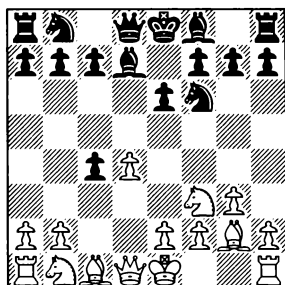
6...c5



6...♞b8

CHAPTER TWELVE

4...dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♗d7



1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♗f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♗g2 ♗d7

This is a logical attempt to provide the traditional 'problem' bishop with a good outpost, Black planning to place the piece on c6 in order to challenge the Catalan bishop. The point is that, compared to accommodating the bishop with ...b7-b6 or ...b7-b5, in this way Black avoids compromising the queenside structure and denies White targets in the form of weakened light squares.

5...♗d7 was reintroduced into modern practice by Korchnoi, notably in the 7th game of his match with Kasparov in London in 1983. Not surprisingly this provided a significant contribution to the theory of the line.

White can react in two ways, 6 ♖bd2 or 6 ♖c2, both with the intention of regaining the gambit pawn. We should note that the majority of variations after 6 ♖c2 have no independent value. Usually there is a transposition to 5 ♖a4+ ♗d7 6 ♖xc4 ♗c6 7 ♗g2, which was discussed in Chapter 3.

It makes sense to prevent the arrival of Black's bishop on c6. Consequently 6 ♗e5 is the main continuation, and the position after 6...♗c6 7 ♗xc6 ♗xc6 forms the tabia of the 5...♗d7 system. We then have a typical Catalan gambit situation where White's initiative

(initially in the centre) compensates for the pawn.

Game 93 Kozul-H.Olafsson *Wijk aan Zee 1991*

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♗f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♗g2 ♗d7 6 ♖bd2

6 ♖c2 ♗c6 transposes to 5 ♖a4+ ♗d7 6 ♖xc4 ♗c6, which leaves 6...c5. Then 7 ♖xc4 ♗c6 is familiar, while 7 0-0 ♗c6 8 ♖xc4 transposes to 5...c5 6 ♖a4+ ♗d7 in Chapter 7. Vaganian-Portisch, Saint John 1988 continued 7 ♗e5 ♗c6 8 ♗xc6 ♗xc6 9 ♗xc6+ bxc6 10 dxc5 ♗xc5 11 0-0 ♖d5 with the better structure for White, although Black was active. After 12 ♗c3 ♖h5 13 ♗g2 0-0 14 ♗a4 ♖d5+ 15 f3 ♗e7 16 ♖d1 ♖h5 17 ♖d4 ♗d5 18 ♖xc4 ♖fd8 19 a3 ♖ac8 20 b3 ♗f6 21 ♖b1 ♗b6 both sides had chances.

6...♗b4 7 ♖c2

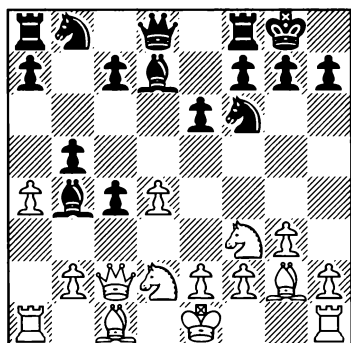
7 0-0 c3!? 8 bxc3 ♗xc3 9 ♖b1 0-0! favoured White in Sigulski-Yuferov, Naleczow 1984 after 10 ♗a3 ♖e8 11 ♖xb7 ♗c6 12 ♖b3 ♗xd4 13 ♖d3 e5 14 ♗xd4 exd4 15 ♗f3 ♖d5 16 ♖c2 ♖a5 17 ♗xd4 ♗xg2 18 ♗xg2 ♗bd7 19 ♗c6 ♖f5 20 ♖d2 but the immediate 9...♗c6 improves. Then 10 ♗a3 a5 11 ♖c2 ♗b4 12 ♗xb4 axb4 13 ♖xb4 0-0 re-

stores material equity with an unclear position.

7...b5

7...xd2+ 8 xd2 xc6 9 xc4 xd5 10 d3 c6 11 0-0 leaves White with the dark-squared bishop. However, 7...b5! looks best, when play has continued 8 0-0 c6 9 d1. One game went 9...a5 10 e4 0-0 11 e5 xd2 12 xd2 xd4 13 xc3 xb6 14 d2 c6 15 g5 h6 16 h4 xe5 17 xe5 d7 18 d4 c5 19 c3 and the bishop pair gave White compensation in Kozul-Liang Jinrong, Novi Sad 1990. In Sosonko-Korchnoi, Wijk aan Zee 1984 Black accepted the invitation to take on d4: 9...xd4 10 xd4 xd4 11 e4 xb6 12 e3 a6 13 d4 e7 14 xxf6 gxf6 (14...xf6 15 xf6+ gxf6 16 c3 e5 17 f3 e7 18 xb7 xb7 19 xb7 ab8 20 f3 with equality) 15 c3 e5 and White had the trademark Catalan activity in return for the material investment.

8 a4 0-0



9 0-0

White achieves an advantage after 9 axb5 xd2 10 0-0 c6 11 dxc4 in view of Black's somewhat weakened queenside.

9...c6 10 e4 xe4 11 xe4 bxa4 12 g5 g6?!

Black can try 12...f5 13 c2 e7 14 f3 a6 although it leaves White with a clear lead after 15 xc4 c7 16 e5.

13 h4 h5 14 g4! f6 15 gxh5! fxg5 16

gxg5 e8 17 e4! f5

17...gxh5 18 h1 h7 19 g1 and White wins.

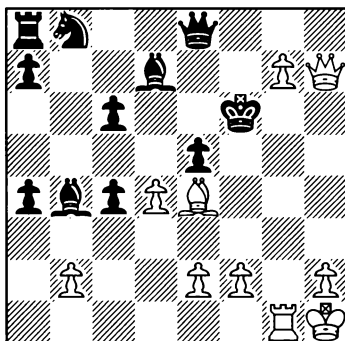
18 h1! e5 19 g1 xg5 20 hxg6

Also good is 20 xg5 e7 21 d2.

20...xg1+ 21 xg1 g7

21...e7 22 h7+ does not help Black.

22 h7+ ef6 23 g7



23...a6 24 g6+ xg6 25 xg6+ e7 26 dxe5 1-0

Game 94

Sulava-Farago

Vinkovci 1993

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 f3 f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 g2 d7 6 e5 c6 7 xc6 xc6 8 0-0

White elects to keep his Catalan bishop in play rather than surrender it with 8 xc6+ bxc6 9 a4 (9 0-0 c5 10 a4+ d7 11 xd7+ xd7 gives Black a good endgame) 9...d7 10 xc4 d5 11 xd5 cxd5 with a level ending.

Slightly different is the solid 8 e3 e5 9 xc6+ bxc6 10 a4 d5 11 0-0, e.g. 11...e7 12 c3 e6 13 dxe5 d7 14 f4 0-0 15 e4 c5+ 16 g2 d4 with Black's inferior structure no more significant than his healthy counterplay (White's king is a bit exposed here).

Another try is 8 a4, e.g. 8...b4+ 9 d2 xd2+ 10 xd2 0-0 11 xc6 bxc6 12 xc4

♚d5 13 0-0 ♜f8 14 ♚xd5 ♜xd5 15 ♜b3 a5 and a draw was agreed in Dorfman-Psakhis, Lvov 1984. Black's doubled c-pawns are weak and White has firm control of the c5-square, but Black is very active and has pressure both against d4 and down the b-file. Also possible is 8...♚d7 9 ♚xc4 ♜xd4 10 ♜xb7 ♜b8 11 ♖g2 ♖b4+ 12 ♜d2 0-0 13 e3 ♜f5 14 ♜c6!? ♚d6 15 a3 ♜g4 16 ♚c2, which was unclear in Wojtkiewicz-Timoshenko, Fredericksburg 1999.

8...♖e7

Black's 8...♜xd4?! in Gulko-Korchnoi, Amsterdam 1989 shouldn't be repeated. After 9 ♜xb7 ♜b8 10 ♖g2 ♜c5 11 ♜d2 c3 12 bxc3 ♜b5 13 ♚c2 0-0 14 a4 ♜xc3 15 ♚xc3 ♜d4 16 ♚a3 ♜xa1 17 ♚xa1 the rook was no match for White's bishops.

9 ♚a4

9 e3 has also been played, when Black must choose his next step carefully. Zsu.Polgar-A.Maric, Tilburg 1994 went 9...♚d7 10 ♚a4 ♜b4 11 ♚xd7+ ♜xd7 12 ♜d2 ♜b6 13 ♜xb7 ♜b8 14 ♜f3 c5 15 dxc5 ♜xc5 16 ♜e2 0-0 17 a3! ♜d3 18 b4! ♜e7 19 ♜xc4 ♜f6 20 ♚a2 ♜xc1 21 ♜xc1 ♜fc8 22 ♜ac2 ♜xc4 23 ♜xc4 ♜xc4 24 ♜xc4 with good winning chances for White. Krasenkov-Nei, Juvaskyla 1991 saw 9...♜d5 10 ♚e2 ♜b6 11 ♜d2 ♜a5 12 ♜e4 0-0 13 ♜c5 ♚c8 14 ♜d2 ♜c6 15 ♜ac1 ♜d8 16 ♜fd1 a5 17 b3 a4 18 b4 ♜a7 19 a3 ♜b8 20 b5 c6 21 ♜b1 cxb5 22 ♜xb5 and White had the initiative. Tratar-Wells, Bled 1995 featured Black's best response: 9...e5!? 10 ♜xc6+ bxc6 11 dxe5 ♚xd1 12 ♜xd1 ♜d7 13 f4 0-0-0 14 ♜d2 f6 15 e6 ♜b6 16 ♜c3 f5 17 e4 ♜c5+ 18 ♖g2 g6 19 a4 a6 and the situation can justifiably be evaluated as unclear.

9...0-0 10 ♜d1?!

A more solid approach is 10 e3 ♜b4 11 a3 ♜bd5 12 ♚xc4 c6 13 ♜d1 with a small but solid advantage for White due to his centre, extra space and bishop pair.

10...b5! 11 ♚xb5 ♜xd4 12 ♚a4

Forced (12 ♚xc4? ♜f3+).

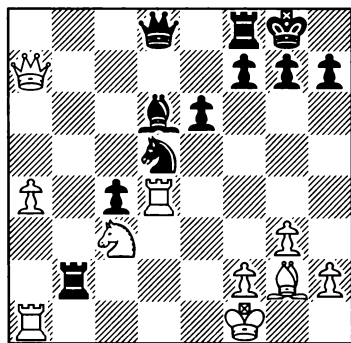
12...♜xe2+ 13 ♚f1 ♜d4 14 ♜e3

Not to be recommended is 14 ♜xa8?! ♚xa8 15 ♜xd4 ♚h1+ 16 ♚e2 ♚xc1 (Farago), when White will pay for his cramped queenside and exposed king.

14...c5 15 ♜c3?!

White should prefer 15 ♜a3 ♜b8 16 ♚xa7 ♜d5, e.g. 17 ♜xc4 (17 ♜xd4 cxd4 18 ♜xc4 ♜f6 is unclear – White has a dangerous queenside majority but Black has central control) 17...♜a8 18 ♚b7 ♜b8 and a draw was agreed in Raetsky-Sax, Munich 1994.

15...♜b8 16 ♚xa7 ♜xb2 17 ♜xd4 cxd4 18 ♜xd4 ♜d6 19 a4 ♜d5!



20 ♜d5

After 20 ♜d5 exd5 21 ♜xd5 ♚f6 Black again has the better prospects. The c-pawn is more dangerous than the a-pawn and it is easier for Black to create threats against his opponent's dark squares.

20...♜e5! 21 ♜dd1 ♜xc3 22 ♜xc4 ♚f6

Black has sacrificed his c-pawn but the attack is very strong.

23 ♜a2?

No better is 23 ♜ab1? ♜d4!, but White could try 23 ♜ac1 ♜a5 24 ♚d4 ♚xd4 25 ♜xd4 ♜b6 (25...♜xf2+ 26 ♚xf2 ♜b6 27 ♚e3 e5 28 ♚e4 ♜xd4 29 ♜b1 is less convincing – Black should keep as many pieces on the board as possible) 26 ♜f4 g5 27 ♜f3 ♜c8, when White's co-ordination is very poor but at least he can still fight.

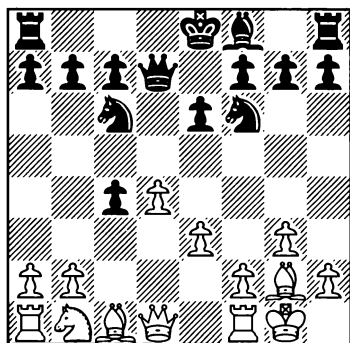
23...♚f3 0-1

Game 95

Beliaevsky-Karpov

Moscow 1988

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 f3 f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 g2 d7 6 e5 c6 7 xc6 xc6 8 0-0 d7 9 e3



9...b8

Black can try to hold on to the c4-pawn with 9... d5 10 e2 b6 11 d2 a5 . Slipak-Adla, Buenos Aires, 1990 continued 12 f3 d6 13 d2 c6 14 c3 e7 15 e4 c6 16 a4 0-0 17 a5 b8 18 xc4 and White regained the pawn with a much better game thanks to his space advantage – 18...a6 19 d2 a7 20 b4 b5 21 b2 a8 22 b3 fe8 23 h3 g6 24 f4 etc.

9...e5 10 e2 and now Hjartasson-Piket, Tilburg 1989 went 10...0-0 11 xc4 exd4 12 exd4 xd4 13 c3 (13 $\text{f4!?$ e6 14 e3 is interesting, with good play) 13... e6 14 a4 a6 15 xa6 bxa6 16 g5 e7 17 ac1 with White's compensation for the pawn coming in the shape of Black's damaged structure. The queens stayed on in Glavina-Toth, Mar del Plata 1990: 10...exd4 11 exd4+ e7 12 xc4 xd4 13 xb7 d8 14 g2 c5 15 d2 0-0 16 f3 f5 17 xd4 cxd4 18 f4 c5 19 ae1 fe8 20 xe8+ xe8 21 b4 b6 22 a4 and the queenside majority and bishop pair secured White an advantage.

10 e2 b5 11 b3 cxb3 12 axb3 b6 13 b2

13 xc6 xc6 14 xa7 releases much of the tension.

13...a6

13... b4 gave White a strong attack in Gleizerov-Cs.Horvath, Budapest 1989 after 14 d1 0-0 15 d5! exd5 16 xf6 gxf6 17 xd5 e6 18 h5 .

14 e4

14 d1 e7 15 c3 b4 16 e4 0-0 17 h3 (Petursson suggests 17 f4!?) 17... e8 18 a2 d7 19 c3 xa2 20 xa2 and White had the initiative in Petursson-S.Polgar, Aarhus 1993, eventually winning the game.

14...xd4!

The quieter 14... e7 presents White with an opportunity to strike an attacking stance with 15 d5 b4 16 h3 0-0 17 d1 .

15 xd4 xd4 16 xa6 xa6 17 xb5+ d7 18 xa6 e7 19 a8+ d8 20 f3

20 a4 d3 21 b4 0-0 22 d1 b6 23 xd3 xa4 24 c3 xc3 25 xc3 e7 leads to a level endgame.

20...d3 21 g2 e5 22 h5 0-0

Not 22...c6? 23 d1 xe4+ 24 g1 0-0 25 c3 and Black loses.

23 d1 e7 24 xf8+ xf8 25 xd3 xd3 26 e2 b4 27 f1 c2 28 c3 d4 29 d1 b4 30 a4 g5 31 b2 f6 32 d3 d2 33 g2 e7 34 f1 d6

Black is slightly better but is faced with the age-old problem of trying to find a way through the enemy defences.

35 f3 f5 36 g1 h6 37 b2 e7 38 c4 c1 39 e5 d2 40 c4 c1 41 e5 h5 42 exf5 exf5 43 g4 h4 44 gxf5 f6 45 d3 d2 46 g2 xf5 47 h3 f4 48 g2 e5 49 h3 d6 50 g2 e6 51 h3 f5 52 e2 f6 53 f2 d4 54 d1 f5 55 d3 e7 56 g2 f8 57 h3 d6 58 g2 e6 59 h3 f5 60 e2 e3 61 f4 gxf4 62 hx4 f5 63 e1 e5 64 g5 e7+ 65 g6 e4 66 f3+ d4 67 c6 ½-½

Summary

In reply to 5...♕d7 the continuation beginning with 6 ♖bd2 has been played by Catalan experts grandmasters Sosonko and Kozul. Nevertheless White fails to achieve an advantage here – with 6...♕b4 7 ♖c2 ♕b5! (as in Sosonko-Korchnoi) Black managed to retain the extra pawn, while it seems White is struggling to find sufficient compensation. Consequently ♖bd2 has left tournament practice at the highest level.

After 6 ♖e5 ♕c6 7 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 White achieves nothing from 8 ♖a4. Black can aim for simplifications and equal chances with 8...♕b4+ or play the more complex positions that occur after 8...♖d7. The positions after 8 e3 and 8 0-0 will often simply transpose but, after 8 e3, Black's 8...e5 is not bad, either. In the event of 8 0-0 ♕e7 the reputation of 9 ♖a4 was harmed by the game Sulava-Farago. However, after 9 ♖a4 0-0 White is not obliged to play 10 ♖d1! (there is 10 e3!?, for example) which, incidentally, was partly rehabilitated in Raetsky-Sax.

Finally, after the important 8 0-0 ♖d7 9 e3 ♖b8 10 ♖e2 b5 it would appear that White's initiative more than compensates the absence of a pawn.

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♖f3 ♖f6 4 g3 dxc4 5 ♖g2 ♕d7 (D) 6 ♖e5

6 ♖c2

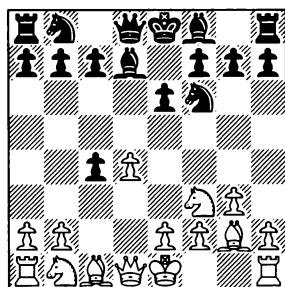
6...c5 7 0-0 ♕c6 8 ♖xc4 – *Game 76* (Chapter 7)

6...♕c6 7 ♖xc4 (D) – *Games 21 & 22* (Chapter 3)

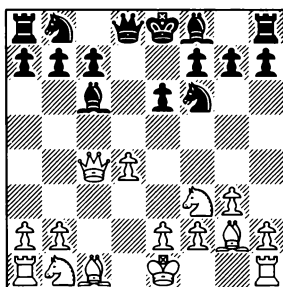
6 ♖bd2 – *Game 93*

6...♕c6 7 ♖xc6 ♖xc6 8 0-0 (D)

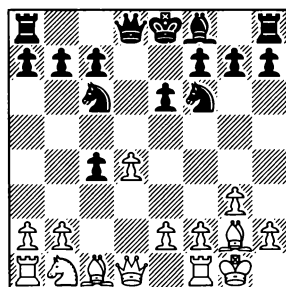
8...♕e7 – *Game 94*; 8...♖d7 – *Game 95*



5...♕d7



7 ♖xc4



8 0-0

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the catalan

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